NAMA / AKBARI TEXTS

مشرع الخصوص إلى معاني النصوص

Mashraʿ al-khuṣūṣ ilā maʿānī al-nuṣūṣ

ʿAlāʾ al-Dīn ʿAlī al-Mahāʾimī

With Ṣadr al-Dīn al-Qūnawī’s *al-Nuṣūṣ*

English translation
Complete source-based working edition

Commentary: printed pp.11–232
Qūnawī’s separate original: printed pp.235–267

11 November 2026 · Stage 13

About this edition

This volume contains the complete available Arabic text and a working English translation of al-Mahāʾimī's commentary in the 2008 Beirut printing, together with the separate text of Qūnawī's *al-Nuṣūṣ* appended to that printing. Coverage comprises 222 commentary pages and 33 appendix pages.

The source is the edition prepared by Aḥmad Farīd al-Mazīdī (Dār al-Kutub al-ʻIlmiyya, 2008), consulted through a print scan and an electronic transcription. Arabic source availability, translation review and manuscript collation are separate matters. This is a source-based working edition; it does not claim independent establishment of the medieval text from manuscripts.

Printed pages 113–114 are missing from the acquired scan. Their electronic text is included, with that limitation recorded. The final commentary sentence on p.232 breaks off in the printing itself. Its missing continuation is not invented. Qūnawī's separate ending on p.267 is retained as a separate text.

Modern editorial footnotes are excluded from the medieval running text. Editorial headings, English speaker labels and square-bracketed explanations belong to this reading edition. Quotations and reports are translated as the authors present them; their inclusion does not certify a report's authenticity. Difficult readings and necessary interpretation are marked where identified.

Source page numbers accompany every section. They are distinct from this PDF's pagination. Sentences may continue over a source page boundary. English choices vary with context; a single Arabic philosophical term need not have one mechanically fixed English equivalent.

At this checkpoint, 222 of 222 commentary pages have been reviewed against the available Arabic; 98 have documented print-image comparison. Review does not resolve every defective reading. In particular, the first passage on printed p.43 retains an explicitly marked synopsis of an unstable argument. Such passages are not certified as complete literal reconstructions.

Print scan: archive.org/details/machra3-khosous
Reader, exact review ledger and source notes: https://gnamma-research.github.io/booksite/texts/al-mahaimi/mashra-al-khusus/

The original medieval works are public-domain texts. The modern source's page layout and full editorial apparatus are not reproduced here.

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The PDF bookmark panel lists every source-page section. The online reader also provides Arabic and English search, cross-references and bookmarks.

Al-Mahāʾimī · commentary

Al-Mahāʾimī’s commentary

The quoted lemmata of Qūnawī are retained within al-Mahāʾimī’s explanation.

Printed p. 11

Author's invocation and preface

MSH-000 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

In the name of God, the All-Merciful, the Especially Merciful.

Glory and praise be Yours, O God! O You whose Being has illumined the heavens of the Names and Attributes and the earth of the entities of possible things! Within the niche of their nonexistence the lamp of Your manifestation has shone forth, gleaming from the glass of Your love, which is a brilliant star of Your witnessing. It is kindled from the blessed tree of Your lordship, which joins the undifferentiated to the differentiated, an olive-tree by virtue of its bringing into being and bringing to realization: neither eastern, such that it lays bare the dazzling splendours, nor western, such that it lets down the veils. The oil of Your beauty would almost shine by manifestation even if untouched by the fire of Your love that burns away coverings. Your Essence is light upon light. You guide whom You will among the beloved to Your light, and set forth similitudes for people so that they might find intimacy through You. You know all things. None is blind to You, despite Your utmost manifestness, save the one whom You know, in his own entity, to remain fixed in blindness.

And bless [**textually uncertain invocation: see apparatus**] him through the lamp of whose spirit the heavens of spirits and the earth of bodily forms were illuminated, before that lamp glimmered in the niche of his body and rose in the glass of his heart, a brilliant star through the self-disclosure of his Lord. It is kindled from the blessed tree of his soul, combining necessity and possibility; an olive-tree, [the transmitted expression connecting it] with the heavens and the fruits of the entities; neither eastern, among the disengaged things, nor western, among the suspended things. The oil of its prophethood would almost shine with perfections, even if the fire of spiritual discipline—which, when it touches it, occasions the manifestation of signs—

had not touched it. Thus it is light upon light. You guide whom You will among prophets and friends of God to Your light, and set forth similitudes for people so that, once the veils of confusion have been removed, they might know his rank in relation to You. You know all things. None is prevented from drawing upon his light save one whom You know to be infirm in receptivity.

To proceed: The least of the servants of the Most High, the Self-Sufficient, ʿAlī ibn Aḥmad ibn ʿAlī ibn Aḥmad—may God make him one of those blessed with eternal felicity—says: Since, by the agreement of people of insight and direct vision, and the consensus of those possessed of reason and eloquence, the human being is the quintessence of the worlds, intended for his own sake by the Lord of creatures among all existents, created in His image so as to know and love Him—that is, so as to be a locus of manifestation, at once comprehensively and distinctly, of His acts, attributes and Essence—everything in the other Presences is a preparation and preliminary to the perfections within the human being. He therefore must have [**defective wording in the source**], and must possess an aspiration that raises him towards the degrees that belong to him in the highest reaches; it must not abandon him, lest his aspiration pull him down below the rank of animals and inanimate things. This comes about when the heaven of his inwardness and the earth of his outwardness are illumined by the lamp of the intellect in actuality, from ...

Editorial note

This opening is an elaborate allusive rewriting of Qurʾān 24:35. The problematic phrases صلّ عليّ من, الزيتونة بالسماوات على ثمرات الأعيان, and فلا بد له إلا are also visible in the 2008 printed scan (printed p. 11; PDF page 12); they cannot simply be dismissed as errors introduced by the electronic transcription. They remain unresolved pending an independent witness. The wording ومتمهات is also uncertain; no conjectural Arabic restoration has been adopted. Here and below “entity” translates ʿayn without itself deciding whether the referent is a fixed entity, an extramental individual, or a particular determination. The former note accidentally duplicated the following Arabic and English paragraph; that duplicated material has been removed.

Printed p. 12

Intellect, unveiling, and the need for commentary

MSH-001 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... the fire of the Active Intellect, after the olive-tree of his thought has been purified by the oil of intuition (*ḥads*) of entanglement with estimation and imagination, and the niche of the material intellect and the glass of the dispositional intellect (*al-ʿaql al-malakī*) have been illuminated by the light of the acquired intellect from the higher realms. His sacred faculty then comes to a point at which its oil would almost shine with mysteries, even if no fire of instruction or discipline had touched it. This is the light of unveiling, from which the eye of certainty shines forth, unclouded by the

darkness of the doubts of philosophers and theologians. Their demonstrations do not disclose realities, as the two imams al-Ghazālī and al-Rāzī acknowledged—although they surpassed most people in both fields. This explains why the early authorities so strongly forbade these pursuits and admonished those who undertook to learn or teach them.

One might object: “Without discursive examination (*naẓar*), how could the pure be distinguished from the impure?”

We reply: Once attachments have been cut and impediments lifted, if this knowledge has become immediate and necessary (*ḍarūrī*)—and it is admissible that what had required examination should become such knowledge—then there is no dispute. Otherwise the criterion is the testimonies of the Book and the Sunna and the community’s consensus, followed by the guidance of a spiritual master known for uprightness of path and perfected insight.

Certainly, discursive examination can help resolve what perplexes the wayfarer concerning spiritual stations, by means of the acquired dispositions (*malakāt*) that this science has conferred. Now the *Nuṣūṣ* is among the works brought forth by the verifying master, exemplar of the elect, sovereign of the verifiers, refuge of subtle investigators, imam of the imams of the knowers among the Muhammadan heirs: Ṣadr al-Ḥaqq wa-l-Ḥaqīqa wa-l-Dīn, Muḥammad ibn Isḥāq ibn Muḥammad ibn Yūsuf al-Qūnawī—may God be pleased with him and cause him to be well pleased. It shines with the suns of this science, displays its blossoms, gathers the universal principles of its trees that bear every variety of sweetest fruit, and unveils the subtleties of the mysteries whose several lights he deposited in his concentrated expressions. Since I had seen no commentary on it whatsoever—much less one adequate to elucidating its words and meanings and doing justice to its intentions and construction—necessity and divine assistance compelled me to append a commentary that might benefit the hearts of its students in these pursuits. My inadequacy bars the door and keeps me from approaching: it is a hidden book whose untouched treasures are handled only by the purified, and whose mysteries are unveiled only by those brought near. Yet God’s all-embracing, munificent mercy preceded my inadequacy and plunged me into the sea of His generosity to bring forth its pearls and coral.

He inspired me to name it *The Watering Place of the Elect, Leading to the Meanings of the Texts* (*Mashraʿ al-khuṣūṣ ilā maʿānī al-nuṣūṣ*). I ask His immense grace and mighty bounty to adorn my pen by pouring upon it the pure water of correctness, so that the multitude of seekers may thirst for it, and to make it a light guiding me to a good return, that it might be a manifestation of His Names …

Editorial note

This paragraph establishes the relationship between rational inquiry, acquired intellectual habits, and unveiling. The author neither treats *naẓar* as self-sufficient nor denies it every auxiliary role; the two parts must be read together. The printed source does not demonstrate that no earlier commentary

existed—only that al-Mahāʾimī reports not having seen one. The 2008 print reads العقل الملكي. “Dispositional intellect” interprets this term in the technical sequence of material, dispositional, actual, and acquired intellects; it is not an Arabic emendation. The parallel interpretation of the glass in Q24:35 as العقل بالملكة is explicit in al-Ṭūsī’s commentary on Ibn Sīnā, as quoted in the Sharḥ al-Manẓūma. The earlier rendering “angelic” or “possessed” was misleading in this context.

Printed p. 13

The projected introduction

MSH-002 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... the Generous, the Bestower of Blessings, the Giver.

Let us begin with an introduction that will break the force of doubt concerning the question of divine unity (*tawḥīd*), the book’s highest objective. It will employ the evidence of the Book and Sunna, the sayings of imams regarded by most later scholars as authorities of sound judgment, rational demonstrations that people of intelligence readily accept, and the removal of most of the objections that have prevented the veiled from accepting this question.

It therefore has three chapters: the first, on transmitted proofs; the second, on rational proofs; and the third, on resolving objections. God is the patron of good deeds.

Printed p. 14

The nature of tawḥīd and its Qurʾānic evidence

MSH-003 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

[Introduction to the book, comprising three chapters.] Chapter One: Transmitted Proofs.

Know that *tawḥīd* is the judgment affirming unity of God Most High, upon which the majority of rational people agree. What distinguishes the verifiers, however, is their knowledge of the principle of this unity and the ground on which it is established for its subject: Being (*al-wujūd*) that encompasses everything. They derive this from the Noble Qurʾān, the sayings of His magnificent Prophet—God bless him and grant him peace—and the early authorities who are lamps upon the straight path, together with the inspiration and intuition [**reading uncertain: transmitted as *al-ḥadath***] bestowed upon them and thought assisted by the light of holiness when the soul is purified.

Among the Qurʾānic evidences are His words: “To God belong the east and the west; wherever you turn, there is the Face of God. God is All-Encompassing, All-Knowing” (2:115); “We shall show them Our signs on the horizons and in themselves until it becomes clear to them that He is the Real. Is it not enough that your Lord witnesses everything? Indeed, they doubt the meeting with their Lord; indeed, He encompasses all things” (41:53–54); “He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Hidden, and He knows all things” (57:3); “When My servants ask you concerning Me, I am near” (2:186); “We are nearer to him than the jugular vein” (50:16); “We are nearer to him than you are, but you do not see” (56:85); “He is with you wherever you are” (57:4); and “You did not throw when you threw; rather, God threw” (8:17).

And there are innumerable other noble verses. As for the Prophet’s sayings—God bless him and grant him peace—there is: “The truest expression uttered by the Arabs is Labīd’s verse: ‘Everything other than God is vain.’” And his saying: “When one of you rises for prayer, he is conversing intimately with his Lord. His Lord is between him and the direction of prayer; therefore let no one spit toward the direction in which he prays, but to his left or beneath his foot.”

Editorial note

Qurʾānic verses and reported sayings are sources cited **by** al-Mahāʾimī, not independent propositions whose precise metaphysical interpretation is already established. The editorial heading in brackets reflects the printed source; the bracket status of its subdivisions is not independently verified. The 2008 editor's numbered hadith footnotes are excluded from the translated authorial text. Printed p. 14 was visually checked: الحدث is present in the 2008 print, so the proposed sense “intuition” remains an interpretation of a suspect reading, not a verified correction to الحدس.

Printed p. 15

Prophetic reports and the authority of al-Ghazālī

MSH-004 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Also his report from God Most High: “My servant continues to draw near to Me through supererogatory deeds until I love him. When I love him, I become his hearing through which he hears, his sight through which he sees, his hand with which he grasps, and his foot with which he walks.” Also his saying: “God Most High will say on the Day of Resurrection: ‘O son of Adam, I was ill and you did not visit Me …’” and the remainder of the report. Also his saying: “Be gentle with yourselves. You are not calling upon one who is deaf or absent from you. You are calling upon One who sees and who is with you, and the One upon whom you call is nearer to each of you than the neck of his riding-beast.”

Al-Tirmidhī also related, in a long report: “By Him in whose hand is Muḥammad’s soul, if you lowered a rope down into the earth, it would descend upon God.” He then recited: “He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Hidden, and He knows all things.” There are other sound reports of this kind. The majority of scholars interpreted them figuratively to escape the difficulties they seem to raise. We shall remove those difficulties; hence those figurative interpretations will not be needed.

As for the sayings of the imams, one example is what the Proof of Islam, Abū Ḥāmid al-Ghazālī—may his spirit be sanctified—said in the third chapter of the Book of Recitation in the *Iḥyāʾ*: “Whoever knows the Real sees Him in everything, since everything is from Him, toward Him, through Him and for Him; He is the All in truth. Someone who does not see Him in all that he sees is as though he did not know Him.” He then said: “Pure tawḥīd is to see none but God in everything.”

In the *Book of Patience and Gratitude*, speaking about removing the veil from the reality of gratitude, he says: “Here there are two ways of seeing. The first is seeing through the eye of pure tawḥīd. This vision teaches you with certainty that He is the giver of thanks and the One thanked, the lover and the beloved. Such is the vision of one who knows that nothing in existence is other than He, that everything perishes except His Face, and that this holds true in every condition, from all eternity and for ever. The second perspective [the quotation is abridged here]: There is in existence only one existent and that which is brought into being (*mūjad*). The bringer-into-being is real, while the brought-into-being is vain considered in itself. The Existent subsists and sustains; the brought-into-being perishes and passes away. And since everything which …”

Editorial note

The 2008 printed page was visually checked. The first موجد after “one existent” is understood as the passive mūjad, “that which is brought into being,” in accordance with the argument and the cited Iḥyāʾ passage. In the following clause the Mashraʿ print has الموجد حق, rendered here as “the bringer-into-being is real”; the Iḥyāʾ transcription consulted reads الموجود حق, “the existent is real.” This source difference is recorded rather than silently changing the Arabic quotation. The Iḥyāʾ also supplies intervening clauses omitted in this condensed quotation, explaining the abrupt transition to the second perspective. This is a comparison with a digital text of the cited work, not manuscript collation. “Sound reports” reproduces al-Mahāʾimī’s classification; this project has not independently authenticated the report from al-Tirmidhī.

Printed p. 16

Multiple considerations and the fourth degree of tawḥīd

MSH-005 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… “upon [the earth] is passing away, so that only the Face of your Lord, possessed of majesty and generosity, remains.” He continues: “When the eye has been anointed with kohl that increases its light, its dimness diminishes. The greater its sight becomes, the more plainly it discovers the deficiency in whatever it had affirmed as other than God. If the traveller continues in this course, this reduction leads unceasingly towards effacement, until the vision of everything other than God is effaced. He then sees nothing but God and has attained the perfection of tawḥīd. Wherever he still perceives some deficiency in the existence of what is other than God, he has only entered its earliest stages.”

Again, in the *Book of Hope and Fear*, in the explanation of degrees of fear and their difference in strength and weakness, al-Ghazālī says: “If fear produces scrupulous restraint, it is higher. Its utmost degree is to produce the ranks of the utterly truthful: when the outward and inward are stripped of all that is other than God Most High, leaving within them no room for anything else.” Then, in the *Book of Tawḥīd and Trust*, concerning the reality of tawḥīd as the foundation of trust: “Tawḥīd has four degrees; it is divided into kernel, kernel of the kernel, shell, and shell of the shell.” He then says: “The fourth is that a person sees nothing in existence but One; this is the witnessing of the utterly truthful.”

He then says: “If you ask: How is it conceivable that someone should witness only One when he also witnesses heaven, earth and the other perceptible bodies, which are many? How can the many be one?” His answer is: “A thing can be many under one kind of witnessing and consideration (*mushāhada wa-iʿtibār*), and one under another kind of witnessing and consideration. Thus a human being is many insofar as one attends to the spirit, body, limbs, veins, bones and internal organs, yet under another consideration and in another witnessing that same human being is one. We say, ‘He is one human being’; in relation to humanity he is one.”

Then: “Likewise, everything in existence, Creator and creature alike, admits of numerous considerations and ways of witnessing. Under one consideration it is one; under other considerations it is many, with some of these exhibiting greater multiplicity than others.” He then invokes the Prophet’s approval of Labīd’s verse, followed by Sahl’s saying: “Poor man! He was when you were not, and He will be when you are not. Now that you have come to be, you say ‘I, I’. Be now as when you were not, for He is today just as He was.” Then, in the *Book of Love and Longing*, in explaining the cause of people’s limited comprehension of …

Editorial note

This is an early *direct textual witness* for the project's perspective register. The analogy does not establish by itself that the Creator and creatures constitute one substantial individual in the same sense that a human being is one. One must identify the precise unifying *iʿtibār*. The quotation must also be checked against the *Iḥyāʾ* to distinguish al-Ghazālī's original language from al-Mahāʾimī's selection.

Printed p. 17

Divine visibility concealed by its universality

MSH-006 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

"… knowing God Most High. Know that the most manifest and most conspicuous of existents is God Most High."

He continues: "There are two reasons why our intellects fail to comprehend something. One is its inherent concealment and obscurity—examples of which are readily found. The other is its extreme clarity. A bat sees at night but not by day, not because daylight is hidden or concealed, but because of its intense manifestness. Likewise our intellects are weak, while the beauty of the Divine Presence is at the very summit of brilliance and illumination, and of all-pervasiveness and inclusiveness. Not an atom in the dominion of the heavens and earth escapes His manifestation. Thus His manifestness becomes the cause of His hiddenness. Glory to Him who veils Himself by the radiance of His light and hides from insight and sight through His very manifestation. Do not be surprised that something should be hidden through being manifest: things are discerned by their opposites, whereas that whose existence encompasses all things so that it has no opposite is difficult to apprehend."

He continues: "God Most High is therefore the most manifest of all things, and through Him all things have become manifest. Were He subject to absence, disappearance or alteration, the heavens and earth would collapse and the visible and invisible dominions would become void; through this we could discern the difference between the two conditions. And were some things existent through Him and others through something besides Him, we could discern a difference in the evidence afforded by the two. Instead, the indication of Him is universally present in things in one consistent manner, and His existence endures through all conditions: the opposite is impossible. Hence His extreme manifestness produces concealment. This is why understanding is deficient. As for one whose inward vision has become strong and aspiration has not weakened, in his balanced condition he sees only God and knows none other; he knows that there is nothing in existence but God, that His acts are effects of His power and consequently dependent upon Him, and that nothing possesses existence in truth without Him. Existence belongs to the One Real, through whom all acts exist."

“Anyone in this condition looks upon no act without seeing the Agent within it, and is heedless of the act insofar as it is heaven, earth, animal, plant or tree.” He then says: “This is the true affirmer of divine unity, who sees only God. He does not even regard himself with respect to himself, but with respect to being God’s servant. Of such a one it is said that he has passed away in tawḥīd and passed away from himself. This is what is meant by the saying, ‘We existed through ourselves; then we passed away from ourselves and subsisted without an “us”.’” Then he quotes the lines: “You have become manifest, and are hidden from none / except a blind man who knows not the moon. / Yet You are hidden by what You have made manifest, veiled; / how could one know Him who has concealed Himself through the very thing seen?”

Editorial note

The assertion that the spiritually balanced person sees only God is expressly *situated in a mode of vision*. It should not immediately be converted into denial that created effects exist as dependent effects. The passage uses both idioms, *afʿāl* and *āthār al-qudra*. The punctuation لا نهد مت in the online Arabic appears to require لا نهد مت; no silent correction is incorporated.

Printed p. 18–19

Al-Rāzī on oneness, proximity, and the language of the Real

MSH-007 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

And there are other passages, explicit and otherwise. Among them is what the imam of scholars, Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī, says in his *Commentary on the Divine Names*, in the sixth section of the preliminary discussions, explaining the expression “I seek refuge from You in You”: “There are subtleties here. First, its meaning is that, if there were here anything besides You, I would seek refuge in it out of fear of You; but there is no one in existence but You, so I seek refuge from You only in You.”

Then, interpreting the pronoun “He” (*huwa*), he says: “The word ‘He’ is the portion of those brought near who go foremost, those possessed of souls at peace. For ‘He’ is a demonstrative indication, and indication specifies what is indicated on condition that nothing is present there except that single thing. If two things were present, indication alone would not suffice for specification. But there is no existent present in the minds and spirits of those brought near except the One who is Real through His own Essence. Know that the real is the existent, and the false is the nonexistent.”

Then: “Every possible thing, therefore, considered in itself, is vain and perishing. Hence God says, ‘Everything is perishing except His Face’ (28:88). In this sense the knowers say: ‘There is no existent in reality but God.’”

Then, in interpreting the Name “the Real” (*al-Ḥaqq*), while explaining al-Ḥallāj’s utterance “I am the Real,” he says: “We have shown by a luminous demonstration …”

“… that the only existent is the Real, exalted is He, and that everything besides Him is vain. This was a man in whose vision everything besides the Real had passed away; indeed, his own self had also passed from his view, leaving no existence in his vision other than God. At that moment he said, ‘I am the Real,’ as though the Real, exalted is He, caused this expression to pass over his tongue in the state of his total passing-away from himself and immersion in the light of God’s majesty.” He then quotes al-Ghazālī to explain why the Name *al-Ḥaqq* is especially frequent upon the tongues of Sufis: “They occupy the station of unveiling; one who occupies the station of unveiling sees God as real and whatever is other than Him as vain. The theologians, by contrast, occupy the station of inferring God’s existence from that which is other than God. It is therefore the Name ‘the Creator’ that predominates upon their tongues.”

Al-Rāzī then says, explaining the Divine Name *al-Walī* (“the Near Protector”): “To my mind, God’s nearness to the servant is greater than what the apparent sense of these verses indicates. This is because the quiddities of possible things cannot acquire the attribute of existence except through the Maker’s bringing them into existence. Accordingly, these quiddities are connected first to the Maker’s act of bringing-into-being, and only through that action do they acquire existence. Their proximity to the Maker’s bringing-into-being is therefore greater than their proximity to their own existence. There is something subtler yet: we have shown that the quiddities themselves become quiddities and realities only through the Maker’s forming and creating them. The Maker’s bringing these quiddities into being therefore precedes the realization of the quiddities, and the Maker is closer to them than they are to themselves.”

[Al-Mahāʾimī's own intervention begins:] “I say: Both arguments establish only their nearness to the *bringing-into-being* (*ījād*), which is a relation that has no existence, not to the Essence of the One who brings into being, exalted is He. Yet His nearness to things is not like the nearness of things to one another in time, place or rank. Rather, it is a nearness the intellect cannot apprehend by discursive thought unless illumined by the holy light.”

“Furthermore, even were the second argument sound, it would apply only to quiddities that exist, not to quiddities considered insofar as they admit either existence or nonexistence and are quiddities in themselves. How, then, could the Maker’s nearness to them be more complete than their nearness to themselves—or even, in the case of existing things, to their existence? This latter point he had mentioned in the first argument. Understand this well.”

Al-Rāzī then says in his explanation of the One and Unique, after repeating a subtlety mentioned in his treatment of “He”: “Know that the station of tawḥīd is a station too narrow for speech. For when you make a statement concerning it, there is a subject spoken about, something said of it, and the composite of the two—three, not one. The intellect knows it, but speech cannot reach it.”

Editorial note

Printed pp. 18–19 were visually checked. Al-Mahāʾimī's own intervention begins at وأقول: he argues that the preceding demonstrations establish proximity to ījād, described as a relation that has no existence, rather than to the divine Essence. The running text of p. 19 ends with فالعقل يعرف ولكن النطق لا يصل إليه. The words [مختصر الفتوحات المكية] وأطال في ذلك occur below the footnote rule and continue the modern editor's note from p. 18; they have been removed from the authorial Arabic and English. They do not attribute the preceding al-Rāzī paragraph to Ibn ʿArabī.

Printed p. 20

Earlier testimonies: Junayd, Ibn ʿAṭāʾ, and Shihāb al-Dīn al-Suhrawardī

MSH-008 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Junayd was asked about tawḥīd, and answered: "It is a meaning in which the traces [of created distinctness] fade away, established forms of knowledge become unsettled, and God is as He has always been." Then [al-Rāzī] says: "Ibn ʿAṭāʾ said that some people, in their tawḥīd, experience unveiling through acts: they see temporal things through God. Others experience an unveiling of Reality itself: their sensation of whatever is other than Him fades away. Such a person witnesses gathered unity, secret with secret, while his outward state remains characterized by differentiation." He then explains the Names First, Last, Manifest and Hidden by citing al-Ghazālī: "He is concealed only through the intensity of His manifestness and light; His veil is His light." This is what some verifiers mean in saying: "Glory to Him who hides from the intellects through His extreme manifestation and is veiled from them by the perfection of His light."

Then, interpreting His Name "Light": "Manifest light is that through which everything hidden appears. Hiddenness is nothing but nonexistence, and appearance nothing but existence. The Real—exalted is He—is existent and admits no nonexistence; hence He is a light admitting no darkness. Through the Real all things other than Him come to be; He is therefore the light of every darkness and the manifestation of every concealment. The Absolute Light is God; indeed, He is the Light of lights." There are many other passages of this kind.

Other testimonies include what the great shaykh Shihāb al-Dīn al-Suhrawardī says in *ʿAwārif al-maʿārif*, chapter eight: "The Sufi is purified of this remaining residue in both doing and refraining from acts for the sake of creatures; he sets creatures aside altogether and sees them with the eye of passing-away and disappearance. The forefront of divine unity shines for him, and he witnesses the secret of God's saying, 'Everything is perishing except His Face' (28:88)." Thus some, when overwhelmed by a spiritual state, said: "There is nothing in either world but God." In chapter twenty

he says: “As for inward passing-away (*fanāʾ bāṭin*), which is the effacement of the traces of existence at the flashing of the light of witnessing, it occurs in the self-disclosure of the Essence.”

Then, in chapter thirty: “At the beginning the Sufi negates creatures and sees things as proceeding from God, once the forefront of tawḥīd has appeared to him. But when he rises to the summit of tawḥīd, he thanks creatures after thanking the Real, and acknowledges that they possess an existence in acts of withholding and giving—after first seeing their Cause. Because of his breadth of knowledge and strength of realization, he affirms the intermediaries. Thus creatures do not veil the Real from him, as they do for ordinary Muslims, nor does the Real veil from him ...”

Editorial note

The second quoted Suhrawardī passage is of central importance: heightened spiritual realization **reinstates the awareness of mediating causes** rather than merely intensifying their phenomenological elimination. This is Suhrawardī as quoted by al-Mahāʾimī; direct collation of the *ʿAwārif* remains necessary. “Shihāb al-Dīn al-Suhrawardī” here is the author of the *ʿAwārif*, **not** the philosopher of illumination. The printed page confirms that the Sufi actively sets creatures aside and sees them under the aspect of passing-away. Word division and hamza were normalized in وعزلهم ... ورآهم. The scan also prints محور آثار الوجود; the English “effacement” understands the expected محو and remains a contextual interpretation of that suspect printed reading.

Printed p. 21

Returning from effacement to comprehensiveness

MSH-009 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

“... creatures, as they veil them from those at the stage of willing and from beginners. His thanks are directed to the Real, because He is the Benefactor, Giver and Causer; and he thanks creatures because they are intermediaries and causes.” Then, in chapter thirty-seven: “Some of those who prostrate are granted an unveiling by which they fold up, through their prostration, the carpet of cosmos and place, and their hearts roam through the expanse of unveiling and direct vision. They plunge beyond the identity of the enclosing heavens; the likenesses of the existents are effaced by the intensity of their witnessing, and they prostrate at the hem of the robe of Majesty.” He then says in chapter sixty-one: “The being of the Real so predominates over entities and worlds that he sees the cosmos through God, without attributing self-subsistence to the cosmos.”

Then again, in chapter sixty-one: “Their love and longing were a sign from the Real to them concerning the reality of tawḥīd, namely existence through God.” He also says: “When one who prostrates is made to taste prostration, he draws near, for by prostrating he folds up the carpet of the cosmos—what has been and what will be—and prostrates at the hem of the robe of Majesty, thereby drawing near.”

He goes on: “Some rise to the station of passing-away, while lights of certainty and witnessing embrace their inwardness, causing them to be absent from awareness of their own existence in their witnessing. This is a kind of essential self-disclosure given to the elect among those brought near. This station is a rank of arrival; beyond it lies the truth of certainty (*ḥaqq al-yaqīn*). There is, in this world, a [glimpse] of this proper to the elect [the printed wording is uncertain]: the diffusion of the light of witnessing through the servant in his entirety, so that his spirit, soul, heart and even bodily frame all share in it. This is one of the highest ranks of arrival.”

He also says: “One indication of passing-away is the report concerning ʿAbd Allāh ibn ʿUmar: A man greeted him as he circumambulated [the Kaʿba], but he did not return the greeting. The man complained to one of his companions, and Ibn ʿUmar said, ‘We were gazing upon God in that place.’” He then says: “But complete passing-away is that through which a command of the Real, exalted is He, so takes possession of a servant that the Real’s being predominates over the servant’s being.” There are many other such passages.

There are also the words of Abū al-Qāsim ʿAbd al-Karīm ibn Hawāzin al-Qushayrī, in his *Epistle*, when expounding the beliefs of this group. He quotes al-Naṣrābādhī: “You move between the attributes of action and the attributes of the Essence, and both are truly attributes. When He causes you to wander in the station of differentiation, He draws you near through the attributes of …”

Editorial note

The passage distinguishes: (i) cosmic dependence without independent subsistence; (ii) effacement of awareness, expressed through the metaphor of a folded-up cosmos; and (iii) the whole person’s participation in witnessing, including bodily existence. The cited passage also suggests that there can be a further grade beyond ordinary fanāʾ. The text of the reported account of Ibn ʿUmar must be separately assessed as a transmission, not presumed sound. Printed p. 21 confirms the suspect construction إطباق السماوات هوية دون فيهوى and the word امحورا. The latter should not be used to infer an additional grade of effacement: a parallel transmission in al-Yāfiʿī’s Nashr al-maḥāsin al-ghāliya (digital p. 27) reads لمح, a glimpse, of the higher certainty in this life. The English marks that comparative restoration in brackets; the Arabic has not been altered.

Printed p. 22

Al-Qushayrī on differentiation, gathering, and the terminology of finding

MSH-010 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

“… action, and when He brings you to the station of gathering (*jamʿ*), He draws you near through the attributes of His Essence.” Then al-Qushayrī says: “I saw in the handwriting of our master Abū ʿAlī al-Daqqāq that someone asked a Sufi: ‘Where is God?’ He replied, ‘May God be displeased with you! Do you seek a “where” alongside

the [Divine] Reality itself (*al-ʿayn*)?’” In the chapter explaining technical expressions, where he discusses induced ecstasy (*tawājud*), finding (*wajd*) and being/finding (*wujūd*), al-Junayd is cited as saying: “Knowledge of tawḥīd is distinct from its actual finding; and its actual finding is distinct from knowledge of it.”

Editorial note

Printed p. 22 contains **long numbered explanatory footnotes** after the authorial sentence. In particular a footnote says that the Real's *wujūd* in ecstatic realization differs according to the divine Names and cosmic receptivities in every breath. This is **not part of al-Mahāʾimī’s authorial text** on the evidence of the page’s explicit هامش (“footnote”) division. It must never be silently included among his own statements. A note about this useful *editorial witness* appears in `Textual_Apparatus.md`, not in the bilingual translation. The quotation “knowledge of tawḥīd …” requires collation with al-Qushayrī’s *Risāla*. The note’s historical reference to Textual_Apparatus.md is superseded by editorial/APPARATUS.md and the Stage 12 review. Modern footnote material remains outside the authorial text.

Printed p. 23

Gathering, gathering-of-gathering, and second differentiation

MSH-011 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Abū ʿAlī al-Daqqāq said: “Realization of being (*wujūd*) entails the servant’s complete absorption; he is like someone drowned in the sea.” Then al-Qushayrī says: “The person possessed of love alternates between sobriety (*ṣaḥw*) and effacement (*maḥw*). In sobriety he subsists through the Real; in effacement he passes away through the Real. These two states continue to succeed one another in him. When sobriety through the Real prevails, through Him he connects and through Him he speaks.” [Al-Mahāʾimī here invokes the prophetic report in which God says:] “Through Me he hears, and through Me he sees.”

On gathering and differentiation (*jamʿ wa-farq*), he says: “People differ in this matter in accordance with their diverse states and disparate degrees. The one who affirms his own self and creatures, but witnesses all of them as subsisting through the Real, has attained *gathering*. But the one who becomes absent from witnessing creatures, disengaged from self-attention and completely withdrawn from sensation, speaking under the overwhelming manifestation and sovereignty of Reality, has attained the *gathering of gathering* (*jamʿ al-jamʿ*). Differentiation is witnessing others as belonging to God; gathering is witnessing others through God; gathering-of-gathering is complete absorption and the passing-away of awareness of whatever is other than God under the overwhelming dominion of Reality. Beyond this there is a rare state called *second differentiation* (*al-farq al-thānī*): a person is restored to sobriety at the times of fulfilling the obligatory acts and performs them at their proper times. This is a return through God, not a return of a servant to himself through himself.”

On nearness he quotes the verse: “It was not asceticism that distracted me from them; rather / I found You witnessed in every place.”

Then he reports a statement of al-Junayd concerning tawḥīd, already quoted by al-Rāzī, and continues: “Abū Bakr al-Tilimsānī was asked: ‘What is tawḥīd?’ He said: ‘Tawḥīd, the one who affirms unity, and a One—those make three.’ Ruwaym said: ‘Tawḥīd is the effacement of human traces and the sole standing-forth of Divinity.’” [The subsequent statement, “the sign of the reality of tawḥīd …”, is **grammatically uncertain** in the transmitted Arabic.] Then he quotes again from [al-Junayd] what the imam had already reported of him. He continues: “Al-Junayd was asked about tawḥīd and said: ‘I heard …’”

Editorial note

The critical triplet on p. 23 is a *substantial empirical counterexample* to the blanket claim that the highest spiritual state always discards every distinction. **Second differentiation** is not simply the lowest *farq* regained, because its acts are performed “through God.” This passage is cited from al-Qushayrī and requires confirmation against a reliable edition of the *Risāla*. The textual boundaries on p. 23 are unusually compromised by footnote material and quotation marks; only the main text above is represented as authorial. Printed p. 23 was visually checked: the material beginning أوصاف البشرية and ending التعريفات (ص 324) is below the footnote rule and correctly excluded. The print has صاحب الود and فيه يصل; the digital Risāla consulted instead has صاحب الوجود and فيه يصول. These differences are recorded as comparisons with the cited source, without silently substituting its Arabic. The fragment علامة حقيقة التوحد القائم به واحدا is abbreviated or defective: the Risāla’s fuller wording attributes to Ibn ʿAṭāʾ a statement about forgetting tawḥīd so that its upholder is one.

Printed p. 24

Qushayrī's aphorisms and *Laṭāʾif al-ishārāt*

MSH-012 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

“… a singer saying: ‘My heart sang to me out of myself, and I sang as it sang; / and we were wherever they were, and they were wherever we were.’” Then [al-Qushayrī] says: “Dhū al-Nūn was asked: ‘By what did you know your Lord?’ He replied: ‘I knew my Lord through my Lord; had it not been for my Lord, I would not have known my Lord.’” Al-Shiblī said: “A knower has no notice of what is other than Him, nor does he utter the words of another.” Abū Yazīd was asked about the knower, and answered: “He sees nothing other than God in his sleep or wakefulness; he agrees with nothing other than God and looks towards nothing other than God.” Then, in the chapter on love, [al-Qushayrī] cites the saying: “The lover is effaced with respect to his attributes, and the Beloved is affirmed through His Essence.” There are many other such statements.

In his Qurʾānic commentary called *Laṭāʾif [al-ishārāt]*, concerning “When Moses sought water” (2:60), [al-Qushayrī] says: “The innermost hearts approach the watering-places of the realities by being snatched away from the cosmos and the things marked out within it.” Regarding “She is a cow not broken to work” (2:71), he says: “Just as God is their object of intention, so He is their object of witnessing and the One they find as existent; rather, their being is through God, and creatures [are effaced] from them through God.” On “He has forbidden you only carrion” (2:173): “God has forbidden innermost hearts to keep company with anything other than God—indeed, even to witness anything other than God.”

On “Righteousness is not that you turn [your faces]” (2:177): “Tawḥīd leaves no trace or imprint; it leaves no other, nor any *ghayr*—that is, alteration (*taghayyur*).” On “God—there is no deity but Him, the Living, the Self-Subsisting” (2:255): “One who realizes this expression sees not even the slightest affirmation as belonging to another, or proceeding from another.” Then: “His separation from everything for His sake becomes true, and his singleness endures by the existence of his exclusive devotion; he hears only from God and witnesses only through God.”

On “For the poor who have been constrained in God's way” (2:273): “However they look, they see the canopies of divine unity surrounding them.”

Editorial note

A number of phrases here have doubtful lexical integrity in the web transcription (notably *al-iḥtiṭāf*, *muṣāḥabatuhu*, and the pronouns in the 2:71 quotation). These are translated provisionally with the uncertainty disclosed; see apparatus. These are **al-Qushayrī's statements quoted by al-Mahāʾimī**, not the commentary's own running exegesis of the verses.

Printed p. 25

Hidden association, dependence, and the boundaries of spiritual language

MSH-013 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Then: “He does not recognize that they have even a single breath in company with creatures—and how could that be, when there are no creatures [before his witnessing]? To affirm what is not there would be an association of others with God in tawḥīd.” Again: “There remains in their innermost consciousness not an atom of affirmation of others.” Concerning “People of the Book, come to a common word” (3:64): “Just as nothing other than Him should be your object of worship, nothing other than Him should be your intended object or object of witnessing. This is to guard against association. You yourself are the first of the ‘others’ that you must not

witness.” On “He would not command you to take angels and prophets as lords” (3:80): “[Would] He command you to affirm creatures after granting them exclusive witnessing of the Real?”

And it is said: “Would He command you to contemplate forms and to attribute temporal origination to things like themselves, after the lights of tawḥīd have shone in your innermost consciousness and the suns of singling out [the One] have risen in your hearts?” On “Whoever holds fast to God” (3:101): “When the covering of differentiation is lifted from one's inward secret, one realizes that not an atom has otherness, for its cause is from Him.” On “Those who responded to God and the Messenger” (3:172): “Their response to the Real, truly understood, is because of His granting them existence.”

On “Worship God and associate nothing with Him” (4:36): “Open association (*shirk jalī*) is the belief that anything other than Him may be worshipped; hidden association (*shirk khafī*) is the observation of anything other than Him as existent. Tawḥīd is to know that all originated things come about through God and subsist through Him.” On “They call upon none but females besides Him” (4:117): “Iblīs is but one turned about within the grasp [of the Creator] according to the will of the Originator; if he possessed even an atom of actuality, he would be a partner in divinity.”

On “God does not call you to account for thoughtless words in your oaths” (5:89): “Who are you in the actuality of the situation, that you should put yourself forward? Is there any inhabitant of the dwelling, that one should speak of abandoning Him, or claim to realize union with or separation from Him? No; rather, He is God, the One, the All-Subduing.” On “Say: To whom belongs what is in the heavens and on the earth?” (6:12), he asks: “Is there anyone at all dwelling in the dwelling?”

Editorial note

The earlier English inserted “independent/independently” four times in the quotations, although the Arabic has no corresponding qualifier. Those insertions have been removed. Dependence may be part of an interpretation, especially in light of the following statement that temporal things subsist through God, but it must not be silently placed in the quoted wording. This remains al-Qushayrī’s language as transmitted by al-Mahāʾimī. The phrase فاستجابته الحق بالتحقيق لوجوده remains compressed and its English interpretation is provisional.

Printed p. 26

Qurʾānic allusions in the testimonies of al-Qushayrī and al-Sulamī

MSH-014 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

On “When night covered him” (Q 6:76), it is also said concerning his declaration “This is my Lord” while witnessing the star, sun and moon: he first contemplated effects and things other than God *through* God; then he saw things as belonging to God and coming from God; thereafter, in contemplating things other than God, he was effaced in God. Concerning “Those who believe and do not confound their faith with wrongdoing” (Q 6:82): “[Wrongdoing is], in reality, putting a thing in [other than] its place; its most grievous form is to suppose of temporal things that they were not and then came to be, for it is God who brings forth and God who makes [things] run their course. There is no god but God, and everything apart from God fell away.”

On “Had they associated others [with God], what they used to do would have come to nothing” (Q 6:88): “If they attended to an other, witnessed something apart from Us, or attributed any actuality of things coming to be to a power other than Ours in manifestation, the knowledge they had previously gained would have been impaired [source wording uncertain].” On “He is their Protector” (Q 6:127): “At their beginning they intend no other than Him; at their end they find no other than Him; and between the two they witness no other than Him.” Many more examples could be cited.

Among these testimonies is what the verifying shaykh Abū ʿAbd al-Raḥmān Muḥammad ibn al-Ḥusayn al-Sulamī of Nishapur says in his commentary called *al-Ḥaqāʾiq*: “It is said that the letter *bāʾ* in *bism* indicates that through God things appeared, through Him they vanished, through His self-disclosure beautiful things became beautiful, and through His concealment they became ugly and repellent.” Abū Saʿīd al-Kharrāz wrote to one of his brethren: “Can anyone estimate God except through God? Does anyone see God other than God? Has anyone known God, or can anyone know Him, except God? Before the servant and before creation, was there anything other than God? And is …” [The final question continues on p. 27.]

Editorial note

The scan of printed p. 26 correctly gives Q 6:82; the electronic 28 has been corrected to match it. The scan nevertheless lacks غير in the definition of wrongdoing. Al-Qushayrī’s Laṭāʾif on Q 6:82 reads والظلم ... وضع الشيء في غير موضعه; the English supplies the missing sense in brackets rather than turning the clause into a definition of justice. Source footnote 1 is modern editorial matter and remains excluded. The printed readings لتأسى, وسمحت, and ثم طالع الأغيار محو still require an independent witness.

Printed p. 27

Al-Sulamī on the disappearance of otherness

MSH-015 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… now in the heavens, the earth, and what lies between them apart from God? For they had not been [the construction here is uncertain]; they came to be through God and for God.” On “Repent to your Creator” (Q 2:54), al-Fārisī says: “Repentance is the effacement of humanity [in the sense of its independent self-assertion] through the affirmation of divinity.” On “Whoever rejects the false object of worship” (Q 2:256), it is said that *ṭāghūt* signifies everything other than God. In short, one who has not renounced everything cannot have sound faith in God [in the special sense being expounded].

On “God is the Protector of those who believe” (Q 2:257), Ibn ʿAṭāʾ says: “He effaces them from their attributes through His attribute, so their attributes are included beneath His attributes, just as their modes of being are included beneath His being, and their claims [yield] before His right.” On “To God belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on earth” (Q 2:284): “Whoever is occupied with these two is occupied with nothing to the neglect of everything.” On “Nothing is hidden from God” (Q 3:5), Jaʿfar says: “Do not let Him look upon you and find in your heart anything besides Him, lest He detest you.”

On “Do they seek a religion other than God's?” (Q 3:83), al-Wāsiṭī says: “Whoever clings to something other than oneness—or, rather, other than the One—is far from reality.” On “The Station of Abraham” (Q 3:97), al-Shiblī says: “Whoever witnesses there the Friend's station and the place is noble; one who witnesses there the station of the Real is nobler.” On “Be mindful of God with the mindfulness due to Him” (Q 3:102), Jaʿfar says: “Mindfulness is not to see in your heart anything besides Him.”

On “Some of you desired this world” (Q 3:152; the 2008 print and its transcription incorrectly give 3:102), al-Thawrī says: “Ordinary people wear the garment of servanthood, the elect wear the garment of lordship, so that they cease to attend to servanthood; the people of purity have been drawn by the Real and effaced from themselves.” On “Let those who are stingy not suppose …” (Q 3:180), Ibn ʿAṭāʾ says: “Whoever looks to another on the path of the Real is deprived of the Real's gifts and the brilliant lights of proximity.” On “In the creation of the heavens and earth” (Q 3:190), [the quotation continues on p. 28].

Editorial note

Q 3:152 corrects a wrong number already visible in the 2008 print; the Arabic retains that printed number. The opening clause إذ لم يكونوا بالله is also present in the scan and is textually uncertain. The earlier “through themselves” has been removed because it has no Arabic equivalent. The spiritual imagery remains a report attributed to the earlier speakers, not independent authentication of their sayings.

Printed p. 28

Degrees of witnessing, taṣarruf and self-disclosure

MSH-016 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Someone said: “The elect do not contemplate the cosmos and events except while witnessing signs; they do not witness signs except while witnessing the Real. Whoever witnesses the Real does not mingle with the taste of temporal occurrence. How could temporal occurrence affect one for whom temporal occurrence is other than [what ordinary people mean by] temporal occurrence?” On “Worship God, and associate nothing with Him” (Q 4:36), Ibn ʿAṭāʾ says: “Association is to behold another than Him, or to behold harm and benefit as coming from another than Him.” On “God does not forgive that partners should be associated with Him” (Q 4:48), al-Wāsiṭī says that [its esoteric demand] is that one's innermost consciousness should behold nothing but God.

On “Whoever obeys the Messenger has obeyed God” (Q 4:80), it is said: “Obedience to the Messenger is obedience to the Real, because of his effacement from his own attributes and subsistence through the attributes of the Real, his disappearance from his own traces and his subsistence through the Real outwardly and inwardly. Through obedience to him and remembrance of him the servant reaches the Real; by disobeying him he is cut off from Him.”

On “When You took me to Yourself” (Q 5:117), Abū Bakr al-Fārisī says: “Wherever the unifier turns his gaze, it is the Real that he contemplates. If he were to remain in the Fire forever, he would not seek relief, because beholding the Real, its impact upon him, his rescue and his ruin are [for him] but one [object of regard]. The vision of exclusive oneness has obliterated every veil, so that speaker and one addressed are one; the Real is addressing Himself through Himself.” On “When night covered him, he saw a star” (Q 6:76), al-Wāsiṭī says: “In his secret he looks to the Real, not to the star.”

On “It is He who brought you forth from a single soul; then there is a dwelling-place …” (Q 6:98), al-Wāsiṭī says: “The lights of the Essence rest within it forever.” On “If you obey most of those on earth” (Q 6:116), it is said: “Whoever looks to anything other than the Real is disappointed and goes astray.” On “His Lord spoke to him” (Q 7:143): “He requested sight of Him when he returned to his own reality, and saw God in every object seen and contemplated.” On “When his Lord disclosed Himself” (Q

7:143), al-Wāsiṭī says: “What reached creatures of His attributes and descriptions was according to their measures, not the totality of the attributes, just as the self-disclosure was not through the totality of the Essence.”

Editorial note

The wording «وطئه» in the al-Fārisī quotation is uncertain; “its impact upon him” is provisional. The final claim explicitly distinguishes the measure of the receiver from exhaustive disclosure of the divine Essence; the passage is transmitted from al-Wāsiṭī, not yet al-Mahāʾimī’s independent metaphysical proof.

Printed p. 29

Existence and existentiation under two perspectives

MSH-017 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

On “You did not kill them …” (Q 8:17), someone says: “You did not cast, but you cast with the arrow of gathering, so He hid you from yourself. You cast, yet [He displaced] the throwers from you [uncertain wording]: the immediate act is yours, while reality belongs to Us when We do not make a separation.” On “Nor do you perform an act without Our being witnesses over you” (Q 10:61), someone says: “Whoever witnesses His witnessing of him is thereby cut off from contemplating all others.” On “Ask your Lord's forgiveness” (Q 11:3), Yūsuf says: “The great ones ask forgiveness for seeing anything at all besides the Real.”

On “To God belongs the unseen of the heavens and earth, and to Him the entire affair returns” (Q 11:123), al-Nahrajūrī says: “None gains access to it except the trustworthy.” Then: “They are those in whom nothing is left for themselves, who retain no claims on their own behalf; so they existed without [their own] being and witnessed without [their own] witnessing.” And: “They are neither themselves nor not themselves: they are themselves insofar as existence (*min ḥayth al-wujūd*) is considered, but not themselves insofar as the bringing-into-existence (*min ḥayth al-ījād*) is considered.” And: “They have been taken beyond the bounds of separation to the very reality of gathering, so that they are gathered in the very reality of the gathering of gatherings.”

On “She indeed desired him” (Q 12:24), Ibn ʿAṭāʾ says: “Zulaykhā contrived to display herself to Joseph, but God veiled her from him by the highest proof and the manifest Real, so that at that moment he witnessed nothing but the Real.” On “Is He who stands over every soul …” (Q 13:33), al-Junayd says: “Through God things stood, through Him they perished, through His self-disclosure beauties became beautiful, and through His concealment they became ugly and repellent.” On “Worship your

Lord until certainty comes to you” (Q 15:99), al-Wāsiṭī says: “You then realize that you sense nothing but the Real, see nothing but the Real, and converse with nothing but the Real.”

Editorial note

The contrast between *min ḥayth al-wujūd* and *min ḥayth al-ījād* is explicit. Its first speaker here is al-Nahrajūrī as transmitted through al-Sulamī. Treat it as a register distinction in reported language, not proof that the terms denote different independently existing objects. The longer story about Joseph in footnote 1 is editorial and omitted.

Printed p. 30

Moses, fanāʾ, and the measure of revelation

MSH-018 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

On “When he came to it, he was called: O Moses! Truly I am your Lord” (Q 20:11–12), Moses was asked: “How did you know that the call was the call of the Real?” He replied: “It effaced me and encompassed me; every hair upon me became an addressee of a call coming from every direction, as though each hair expressed an answer. When the lights of awe enveloped me and the lights of might and dominion surrounded me, I knew that no one could speak of himself using those two successive expressions except the Real.”

He said: “That was the place of effacement, and I said: ‘You! You have never ceased to be; Moses has no standing with You and no boldness to speak, unless You preserve him through Your abiding and characterize him with Your attributes; then You are both the one addressing and the one addressed.’” He [the quoted speaker] said: “‘No one carries My speech but I, and none answers Me but I. I am speaker and one spoken to; you are a shadowy figure in between, serving as the place of address.’” On “He found God with him” (Q 24:39), Ibn ʿAṭāʾ says: “Creatures found nothing but the Real.”

On “We shall show them Our signs on the horizons” (Q 41:53), al-Khaṭmī says: “A servant continues to rise from one state to another until he reaches elevated and lofty states, and sees God sustaining things, which vanish in the witnessing of the Real. He becomes certain that when the eternal is compared with the temporally originated, the latter retains no effect [in that regard], however great its worth and importance.”

This is the meaning of “Our signs on the horizons and within themselves, until it becomes clear to them that He is the Real” (Q 41:53): first contemplating the cosmos while witnessing the Real, then contemplating the Real while being effaced from the cosmos, when the many attributes become one attribute and one witnesses nothing

but the pure Real. Abū ʿUthmān was asked about someone who speaks of *the witnessed one* [*al-shāhid*, reading/context uncertain]. He answered: “I do not reject the assertion of someone who witnesses all things as one thing.”

Editorial note

The source's report about Moses is an esoteric transmitted narrative, not a verified prophetic ḥadīth. The printed editor cites Ibn ʿAjība in footnote 1; this is excluded from al-Mahāʾimī’s main text. The subject of *fanāʾ* must be kept distinct from a claim of hypostatic fusion.

Printed p. 31

The lights of creation and the collapse of separate agency

MSH-019 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Wāsiṭī said: “He manifested Himself in every thing by what He displayed through it, and His displaying things is His manifestation through them. Examine them closely and you will find none but God. This is why the Prophet, peace be upon him, said: ‘The truest saying spoken by Labīd is: Everything apart from God is vain.’” On “Surely to God all affairs return” (Q 42:53; the source identifies Q 42:3, apparently in error), he says: “For everything's beginning is from Him and its end goes back to Him; what is from Him and for Him is, in the present instant, through Him.” On “We are nearer to him” (Q 50:16), ʿĀmir ibn Qays expressed the realization when he said: “I have never looked at a thing without seeing God nearer to me than that thing.”

On “He is the First and the Last, the Outward and the Inward” (Q 57:3), Jaʿfar al-Ṣādiq said: “These meanings fell away, and He alone remained.” From al-Shiblī: “Things fall away because He is First, Last, Outward and Inward.” There are many similar places. Another authority is the accomplished and verifying shaykh Abū Ṭālib al-Makkī, who says in *Qūt al-qulūb*, in the discussion of the ascetic and the excellence of renunciation: “We have related from Ibn ʿAbbās on the words ‘all of it from Him’ (Q 45:13): ‘In every letter is one of His names, exalted is He; thus the name of every thing is identical with His name, just as the act of every entity is identical with His act.’”

Elsewhere he relates that a knower was asked: “Does a friend of God grieve for anything other than God?” He answered: “Does he see anything other than God, that he might grieve for it?” In his explanation of the station of unification, he describes the conditions of those who trust in God as the friend turns to his protecting Lord and sees Him in everything. Then: “When his witnessing is perfected and he fulfills the duty of bearing witness, that witnessing—by the vision of God's self-subsistence—renders invisible the existence of creatures *alongside* God. He does not see them apart from Him. The divine self-subsistence stands before him … when the heart is entirely free to behold the King. This belongs to the eye of certainty, beyond his

[discursive] knowledge, because the manifest Real is First and Last, just as …” [Continued on p. 32. The middle of the Arabic period is defective or severely compressed.]

Editorial note

The verse «ألا إلى الله تصير الأمور» is Q 42:53, not 42:3. «وجود الخلقية مع الله» explicitly contains the preposition *maʿa*; it speaks of the apparent “alongside” in witnessing, not simply created dependence. The long Abū Ṭālib al-Makkī passage has a corrupt clause (قام له القيومية بنصبه من الملك…) needing independent comparison with *Qūt al-qulūb*.

Printed p. 32

Causes, intermediaries, and differing scriptural attributions

MSH-020 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… He is the Outward and the Inward. Then he says: “When certain of our shaykhs were asked about trust in God, they answered from the very reality of the matter: ‘It is to be with the Real as though you had never been, for the Real is now as He always was.’” Then: “Poor soul! He existed when you were not; He will exist when you will not. When today you came to be, you said, ‘I, I!’ Be now, in your present existence, as though you were not, for He is today as He was.”

Then, concerning the affirmation of causes and intermediaries: “The one who trusts in God sees nothing but God, His attribute, His act, and His command. His act is outward, His attribute inward; God is the Outward and the Inward. His command is the inscribed trace, and God is the One who commands and inscribes.” Then: “God has brought causes into appearance and established Himself [as the true agent] within them. Thus He says, ‘Say: the Angel of Death will take you’ (Q 32:11); then He sets that [mediating attribution] aside and makes Himself manifest: ‘God takes souls’ (Q 39:42). Likewise, in a differentiated account He says, ‘They took the devils as protectors’ (Q 7:30), while under the aspect of unification He says, ‘We made the devils protectors’ (Q 7:27). In the ambiguous [verses] (*mutashābih*) He says, ‘The Sāmirī led them astray’ (Q 20:85); in the decisive [verses] (*muḥkam*), ‘It is nothing but Your trial; You lead astray by it whomever You will and guide whomever You will’ (Q 7:155).” Then: “It is likewise related of God, blessed and exalted: ‘I am My own proof; no proof points to Me more surely than I.’”

Then, in a further account of the one who trusts in God and of guidance and clarification, a knower says: “When you see all things as though they were one thing, from one mine and with one eye, you will be shown what you had never seen before, hear what you had never heard, and understand what people had not understood.” In discussing love and its possessors, [Abū Ṭālib] continues: “Love … [source syntactically uncertain] until love of God becomes the servant's love in relation to

everything. Then he loves God truly just as he believes in Him truly, through the vision of certainty that makes his vision [of God] prevail over his vision of creatures: he witnesses Him in everything and is one through Him without anything else, for He has disclosed Himself …” [Final wording of the passage remains defective.]

Then: “None uttered unification but the One; none uttered ‘God’ but God.” Next he says: “You have been inward …” [and so forth]. In speaking of the fears of lovers and their stations of fear, he cites: “You became manifest to him whom You had effaced, after his effacement; / so he was without a being of his own, because You were he.” The following verse, he says, had been recited before it [see p. 33].

Editorial note

The pair 32:11 / 39:42 gives explicitly differentiated versus comprehensive attribution of a single act, not a straightforward claim that angels are unreal. «أثبت نفسه فيها» is not to be silently reinterpreted as a spatial indwelling. An earlier reading quoted «تقلّب محبة» is textually uncertain.

Printed p. 33

Divine proximity and the beginning of al-Anṣārī’s testimonies

MSH-021 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

“You have been hidden, yet are hidden from no one / except a blind man who cannot recognize the moon.” Then he says: “You have become manifest, hidden from no one / except a blind man who cannot recognize the moon. / You have remained hidden and have not disclosed [Yourself], being veiled [wording uncertain]; / how can he be known who was veiled by the very means of knowing? / I became the strangest thing I encountered in my striving, / for I myself am a veil that tries to discover the news.” [The poem's subject shifts and the wording of its second and third lines calls for collation.]

Then: “He is the seer and what is seen, the hearer and what is heard; He is the witness and the witnessed, the finder and what is found.” As a lover says: “Neither within the heart nor in what the eye beholds / is there any vacant space for anything but the Beloved. / He is my illness, my health, my cure; / through Him life is sweet so long as I live.”

Then, explaining the pillars of Islam and the obligation of divine unity: “It is the heart's conviction that God, exalted is He, is one—not as a unit in a number.” Farther on: “He is Last in His Firstness and First in His Lastness; His names, attributes and lights are neither created nor separate from Him. He is before everything, behind everything, above everything, with everything, and closer to everything than the thing is to itself; yet He is not a locus in which things inhere, nor are things loci in which He inheres.” There are further statements of this kind.

Al-Mahāʾimī adds: “I say: What al-Wāḥidī and al-Baghawī relate from Wahb ibn Munabbih is fitting here: ‘A call came from the tree: “O Moses!” He answered quickly without knowing who had called him. He said: “I hear Your voice but do not see Your place. Where are You?” He answered: “I am above you, with you, before you, behind you, and nearer to you than your own self.” Moses knew that such a thing befitted none but God, mighty and glorious, and became certain of Him.’” Among the testimonies is also that of the Shaykh of Islam Abū Ismāʿīl ʿAbd Allāh al-Anṣārī in *Manāzil al-sāʾirīn*: “The station of repentance is not complete until one arrives at repentance from whatever is below the Real [reading supported by the cited Manāzil], then has perceived the defect in that repentance, then repented of perceiving that defect. The flight of the elect of the elect is first from what is beneath the Real to the Real, then from witnessing the flight to the Real, and finally from flight itself to the Real.” In the chapter on spiritual audition, the audition of the elect consists of three … [continued on p. 34].

Editorial note

The words after «وأقول» are al-Mahāʾimī’s direct editorial intervention; his account of Wahb ibn Munabbih is a cited report and has not been established as authentic ḥadīth. The insistence on no literal *ḥulūl* (God as substrate and creatures as divine substrate) is explicit in the cited *Qūt* formulation. The scan confirms the problematic printed من in بالانتهاء من التوبة. The cited Manāzil wording is بالانتهاء إلى التوبة مما دون الحق: reaching repentance from what is other than the Real. The English now follows that marked source-supported reading rather than saying that repentance ceases. The Arabic has not been silently emended. The poem’s uncertain wording is also confirmed in print.

Printed p. 34

Differentiated spiritual stations in al-Anṣārī

MSH-022 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… matters: “to witness the intended Object in every affair, to stand upon the ultimate end in every whisper, and to be delivered from taking pleasure in differentiation.” The audition of the elect of the elect is “an audition that washes impediments away from unveiling, joins everlasting duration with eternity without beginning, and returns endings to the First.” In the chapter on watchfulness (*murāqaba*), the third degree is “to be watchful of pre-eternity by contemplating the very reality of precedence, welcoming the knowledge of divine unity; to watch for the manifestation of the signs of pre-eternity upon [the allusions / intimations] of post-eternity; and to be free of the bond of watchfulness. One's watchfulness binds one by the trace of one's self; once that trace is annihilated, the bond disappears; the attachment itself is the bond.” In the chapter on gratitude, the third degree is that “the servant witnesses none but the Giver of blessings.”

Then: “When he witnesses the Giver of blessings as his Worshipped One, he regards the gift as great; when he witnesses Him in love, he finds hardship sweet; when he witnesses Him in exclusive unification, he no longer witnesses either blessing or hardship as coming from Him.” In the chapter on direct witnessing, the third degree is “a witnessing of gathering which draws one into the very reality of gathering, possessing soundness of arrival and riding the sea of being.” In the chapter on subsistence: “Subsistence is the subsistence of what has eternally been Real, through the obliteration and dismissal of what never existed [in its own right]”—that is, the subsistence of the Real once what was not existent is dismissed, until it is obliterated through annihilation in Him.

In the chapter on gathering (*jamʿ*): “Gathering is that which casts down differentiation, severs pointing and indication, and departs from water and clay, after a firm establishment, freedom from changes of spiritual coloration and release from witnessing duality, [together with] removal of the feeling of equilibrium and even of witnessing its own witnessing.” As for *the gathering of being* (*jamʿ al-wujūd*), it is “the dissolution of the utmost limit of connection into the very reality of being, in complete realization”; *the gathering of the entity* (*jamʿ al-ʿayn*) is “the dissolution into the Essence of the Real of everything that indication could encompass.” Gathering is the utmost reach of the travellers' stations, and the brink of the sea of divine unity.

In the chapter on divine unity: “The expression to which those who indicate point—casting off temporal origination and affirming beginninglessness—is the pivot around which indication turns on this path; yet it is itself a defect that must be cast aside.” Then: “Divine unity is beyond whatever any originated thing indicates, any occasion undertakes, or any cause bears.” Shaykh al-Anṣārī said: “Long ago I answered a questioner about the unity professed by the Sufis with these three rhyming verses: ‘No one has ever unified the One; / for whoever unifies Him thereby denies Him. / The unification voiced by one who speaks of His qualities / is a borrowed thing annulled by the One. / His unification is His own unifying of Himself; / the description given by one who describes Him is a departure [from the truth].’”

Editorial note

The language of “no one unifies the One” is an argument against regarding the servant as the *originating source* of divine unity. It must not be conflated with denial that the servant makes a true confession of tawḥīd. Several terms in the audition and gathering passage look corrupt, including «إيحائين» and «التنافي من إحساس الاعتدال»; translate provisionally pending a direct *Manāzil* collation.

Printed p. 35

Al-Kalābādhī: how opposed descriptions can designate a single state

MSH-023 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

There are other such passages. Another authority is Shaykh Abū Bakr al-Kalābādhī of Bukhara, who says in *al-Taʿarruf*, in the discussion of knowledge: “They agree that God, exalted and majestic, is the sole proof of God.” He then quotes al-Thawrī, Ibn ʿAṭāʾ and al-Junayd, and relates from Muḥammad ibn Wāsiʿ: “I never saw a thing without seeing God in it.” Another says: “I never saw a thing without seeing God before it.” From al-Junayd: “He is both knower and known.” This means that insofar as you are yourself, you do not know Him; rather, you have known Him insofar as He is He.

Then, in the discussion of contact or connection (*ittiṣāl*), he relates from Ibn ʿUmar: “We used to behold God together in that place”—meaning, as [the author] explains, during the circumambulation. This belongs to the discussion of self-disclosure and concealment.

Then, in the discussion of annihilation (*fanāʾ*) and subsistence (*baqāʾ*): “Some have regarded all these states as a single state despite the difference in their expressions, and have made annihilation subsistence and gathering separation; likewise absence and witnessing, intoxication and sobriety [the transcription reads *shukr*, ‘gratitude’, rather than *sukr*, ‘intoxication’, requiring collation]. This is because one who is annihilated subsists in what belongs to the Real and is annihilated from what belongs to himself. Again, he is gathered because he witnesses only the Real; yet the gathered person is separate because he witnesses neither himself nor creation. He subsists because he remains with the Real, is gathered through Him, and annihilated from all else and separated from them. He is absent and intoxicated because discernment has disappeared from him. The disappearance of discernment means what we have said concerning pains and pleasures; or else things become united for him, so he does not witness contrariety, since the Real directs him only according to what accords with Him. Discernment distinguishes one thing from another, but when things become one thing, discernment falls away.”

Then, in the discussion of divine unity: “The servant’s share from the Real is the finding of the Real (*wujūd al-Ḥaqq*); he is held captive within it [reading *maʾsūr*], with neither advance nor retreat.” Then, describing the knower: al-Ḥasan ibn ʿAlī, may God be pleased with them both, was asked: “When does a knower witness the Real?” He said: “When the Witness appears, the witnesses vanish, the senses depart, and even sincerity fades away.” The annihilation of the witnesses means that your regard for creatures disappears insofar as harm, benefit, blame and praise are concerned. The departure of the senses is the meaning of His saying, “Through Me he speaks and

through Me he sees …” [and so forth]. There are many similar places. And there is what the learned verifier Sayyid Shams al-Dīn al-Samarqandī says in the conclusion to his commentary … [continued on p. 36].

Editorial note

The 2008 scan confirms الشكر, والثاني, and ما سور. The cited Taʿarruf has السكر, والمفارق, and مأسور in the corresponding passages. “Captive” and the servant as subject are now made explicit in English, with the comparative reading marked; the Arabic is unchanged. The Taʿarruf identifies the final speaker more fully as al-Ḥasan ibn ʿAlī ibn Yazdānyār, whereas the Mashraʿ abbreviates the name and adds a blessing. That discrepancy prevents confidently identifying the speaker as the Prophet’s grandson. These are digital cited-source comparisons, not manuscript variants.

Printed p. 36

Al-Samarqandī and al-Bayḍāwī on dependence and ascent

MSH-024 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… on his *Ṣaḥāʾif*: “The conditions of people fall into three classes: occupation with the Real to the exclusion of anything else; occupation with the Real along with something else; and occupation with something else to the exclusion of the Real.” Then: “For the people of the path and of realization, the second is [a subtle form of] association; the third is unbelief; the first yields complete felicity and genuine joy in this world and the next: ‘Whoever rejects false objects of worship and believes in God has grasped the firmest handhold that never breaks’ (Q 2:256).”

Among these also is the learned verifier, Judge Nāṣir al-Dīn al-Bayḍāwī. In *Anwār al-tanzīl*, on “Wherever you turn, there is the Face of God” (Q 2:115), he glosses: “That is, His Essence is there.” Then: “By His encompassing of things God is All-Embracing, All-Knowing.” On “The Face of your Lord shall remain” (Q 55:27): “If you examined the directions or aspects of existents and considered their existence, you would find all of them perishing in themselves apart from the Face of God, that is, the aspect turned toward Him.”

In his commentary on *al-Maṣābīḥ*, in the section on remembrance, concerning the divine saying reported by the Prophet, peace be upon him, “My servant continues to approach Me through supererogatory acts …”: “A servant continues drawing near to God through many kinds of obedience and spiritual discipline, rising from one station to another, higher station, until God, exalted is He, loves him. He then immerses him in contemplation of the precinct of His holiness, so that he never attends to anything without attending to his Lord. Whenever he turns toward someone turning and someone turned toward, a captor and captive, maker and made, agent and patient, he

sees God. This is the last degree of the travellers and the first degree of those who have arrived. Under *this consideration*, therefore, God becomes his hearing and his sight.”

Then, in the chapter on God's names, explaining the name “God”: “Every possible thing has no existence [of its own]; rather its existence is from the aspect (*jiha*) through which it faces the Necessary, exalted is He.” This is indicated by the words “Everything except God is vain.” In explaining the names “the Creator, the Originator, the Fashioner”: “He ascends from the created to the Creator and passes from contemplation of the product to contemplation of its Maker, until he reaches the point that whenever he looks at anything he finds God with it.”

Editorial note

The phrase «بهذا الاعتبار» is decisive: the hadith description is being explained *under this consideration*, tied to the aspirant’s attainment. The phrase “the thing has no existence” is immediately followed by the qualifier that its being is from the aspect by which it faces the Necessary; it should not be decontextualized as a denial of all created actuality. The al-Samarqandī quotation is a separate, reported triad and cannot simply be turned into a binding Sunni legal classification of those who notice created causes.

Printed p. 37

Neither indwelling nor crude separateness

MSH-025 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

In explaining the name “the Preserver” (*al-Ḥafīẓ*): “The share of the knower, in particular, is to [guard] his inwardness from looking to others, and his outwardness from acting as wrongdoers act.” On “the Real” (*al-Ḥaqq*): “The servant's share is to see God as real, and everything else as unreal *in itself*, yet real through His bringing it into being and originating it.” On “the Light”: “That which is manifest in itself and renders other things manifest. There is no doubt that when being is set in opposition to nonbeing, manifestation belongs to being and hiddenness to nonbeing. Since the Creator, exalted is He, exists through Himself, free of the darkness of nonbeing and even the possibility of its overtaking Him, whereas the being of all other things flows forth from His being, it is correct to apply the name ‘Light’ to Him.” Similar examples occur elsewhere.

Another authority is the learned verifier Sharaf al-Dīn al-Ṭībī. After citing the account from Wahb which we transmitted from al-Wāḥidī and al-Baghawī, he writes: “This does not require corporeality, nor does [such] nearness.” He also cited, at those places in his commentary on *al-Mishkāt*, the other material which we related from the judge. Concerning the names of God and the most distinctive way to enumerate them, he says that one should “fill the heart with God, attend to none besides Him, and hope

in or fear none besides Him in whatever one does or leaves undone, for He is the unshakably Real while everything else is vain. God says: ‘Everything perishes but His Face’” (Q 28:88).

Explaining the name “the All-Seeing,” he relates from Sahl, who said: “For so many years I have addressed none but the Real, exalted is He, while people have thought I was speaking to them.” Someone versified the same meaning: “They thought I had long been addressing them, / while You were the One I intended through my words to them.” This is the attribute of gathering (*jamʿ*) to which the people of the path have referred. In explaining the names “the One, the Unique,” he says: “The servant's share is to plunge into the ocean depths of unity and become absorbed therein, until from beginningless eternity to endless eternity he sees none but the One, the Unique.”

Another is the learned verifier Sirāj al-Dīn, author of *Kashf al-Kashshāf*, who writes in his preface: “Praise belongs to God, who illumined the entities with the light of being and made them mirrors of His attributes, and chose from among them the human species because it comprehends the secret of the worlds, thereby perfecting the places in which His Essence appears.” On “There is the Face of God” (Q 2:115), he says that it prepares the way for the denial of divine offspring, because He to whom all directions belong is exalted beyond them; consequently no entity bounded by a direction can resemble Him, whereas offspring is of the same kind as its parent … [continues on p. 38].

Editorial note

The al-Bayḍāwī passage states both «باطلا في ذاته» and «حقّا بإيجاده واختراعه», expressly indicating one judgement under the thing’s own aspect and another under divine production. Both clauses are crucial. The Ṭībī passage expressly rejects a corporealist reading of divine closeness. The precise identification of *Kashf al-Kashshāf* and its authorship should be checked. “Guard” in the first sentence is a contextual restoration under the divine name al-Ḥafīẓ; the supplied Arabic يعرف is preserved. It should not be treated as a verified alternative reading.

Printed p. 38

Completion of twelve transmitted authorities and epistemic reticence

MSH-026 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… necessarily. On “Is it not enough that your Lord is witness over every thing?” (Q 41:53), he says: “Whoever witnesses Him witnesses everything.” On “The Outward and the Inward” (Q 57:3), He is “Outward through His being, for all existents are manifest through His manifestation, and Inward through His innermost reality.” There are many similar places.

Al-Mahāʾimī resumes his own synthesis: These twelve leading authorities agreed in accepting these [truths], and in the words of some there are explicit transmissions from these great figures: al-Ḥasan ibn ʿAlī, Ibn ʿAbbās, Ibn ʿUmar, Jaʿfar, Abū Fāris, Yūsuf ibn al-Ḥusayn, ʿĀmir ibn Qays, al-Wāsiṭī, Abū Bakr al-Fārisī, al-Nahrajūrī, Abū ʿUthmān al-Ḥīrī, al-Qāsim, Muḥammad ibn Wāsiʿ, Ibn ʿAṭāʾ, Ruwaym, al-Kharrāz, al-Naṣrābādhī and Abū ʿAlī al-Daqqāq; and there are implicit references to others.

Shaykh Abū Ṭālib al-Makkī and al-Ghazālī also transmit from Ibn ʿAbbās: “If I explained this verse—‘God it is who created seven heavens and of the earth their like’ (Q 65:12)—you would stone me.”

Al-Ghazālī, in *Minhāj al-ʿābidīn*, transmits from Imām Zayn al-ʿĀbidīn: “I conceal the jewels of my knowledge, / lest an ignorant person see the truth and bring ruin upon us. / Abū Ḥasan was before me in this, / and entrusted [it] to al-Ḥusayn, while before him [the reading is corrupt]. / O many a jewel of knowledge which, if I revealed it, / people would say, ‘You are one who worships idols!’ / Ignorant men would deem it lawful to spill my blood, / thinking the ugliest of their actions beautiful.” Al-Bukhārī also relates from Abū Hurayra: “I preserved two vessels of knowledge from the Messenger of God, peace be upon him. One I disseminated; as for the other, if I disseminated it, this throat of mine would be cut.” Reflect upon this collection of testimonies and you will, God willing, receive guidance.

Editorial note

The printed poetry has unstable wording, especially «للمَتاء» and the second verse. Do not assign its attribution to Zayn al-ʿĀbidīn with historical certainty before checking its transmission. The Abū Hurayra report is a distinct ḥadīth, not proof that the earlier poems share its authority. This page ends chapter 1; chapter 2 starts p. 39.

Printed p. 39

Why rational demonstrations are offered after transmitted testimony

MSH-027 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Chapter Two: Rational demonstrations for the existence of the Necessary Existent. Know that most of the knowers have confined themselves to proofs furnished by unveiling—that is, immediate, inwardly experienced certainties—for the removal of darkening veils. They proceed through spiritual striving, which precedes guidance in the divine saying, “Those who strive in Us, We shall surely guide them to Our ways” (Q 29:69), through Godfearingness—“Fear God, and God teaches you” (Q 2:282)—and through complete turning towards God. They have not set out discursive premises, because these can plunge their practitioners into blameworthy perplexity through the generation of darkening doubts, except for someone whom God protects

by a holy faculty and angelic dispositions supporting the faculty of immediate intuition. But ordinary people have gone to extremes in denouncing these knowers. They allege that the latter, following arbitrary spiritual struggles, categorically reject every judgement—rational, sensory, innate and instinctive—and that the cause is a deeply ingrained disturbance of temperament affecting the seats of the psychic faculties, the consumption of healthy bodily materials giving rise to imaginative obsessions, the predominance of black bile, and the mastery of madness and melancholy. Such an accusation exposes its proponents to hidden associationism and to the fear of an evil end, as al-Ghazālī relates from certain knowers; a Prophetic report, meanwhile, indicates that these people possess honour through God. Therefore it becomes necessary to set forth the [rational] premises and dispel the doubts that entrap the critics, in the hope that they will cease their denial—or be transformed into people who see.

We say that there are two questions here: first, the actuality of unrestricted existence (*al-wujūd al-muṭlaq*); second, its being necessary through itself. **First question.** Know that the actuality of existence is more evident to thought than the actuality of sensible light is to sight. Yet its very intensity of manifestation has made things seem the opposite of what they are. In the same way, because sunlight reaches the extreme of radiance, some people have imagined that nothing lies beyond colours; but sunset necessarily brings out the distinction between places of shadow and illumination. Existence, the light of lights, is not like this: it remains constantly present with things in one and the same manner. Hence many highly skilled speculative thinkers deny its extramental actuality, claiming that nothing exists outside the mind except quiddities and that existence itself is only a second intelligible or purely mental consideration. This results from the likeness between the furthest limit and the starting point: actuality is impossible beyond the former and impossible short of the latter. These two impossibilities are alike in their [relation to] actuality, though different in the relations intended. It is therefore necessary to expose the source of the confusion.

Editorial note

The final contrast of two impossibilities («الامتناعان») is obscure in this transcription. “More evident to thought” renders the recorded «عن الأفكار» provisionally; a printed witness must be consulted. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/39?lang=ar

Printed p. 40

Existence is not a merely mental consideration: objections and replies

MSH-028 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

We say: there is no doubt that every quiddity which exists possesses actuality unrestrictedly considered. This actuality is either identical with the quiddity, a part of it, or something additional. In either of the first two cases it is evident that actuality cannot be a merely conceptual affair. If it is additional, the determinate actuality must have something by which it subsists, since a description cannot subsist through itself. It must subsist either through unrestricted actuality or through determinate actuality; the second alternative is plainly untenable, so the first is established. That by which something actual subsists has an even stronger claim to be actual. If the restriction is merely conceptual, the actual reality is what is unrestricted. If the attribution of actuality to quiddity is denied, extramental existence would be identical to existence in the mind—for mental existence would be even more liable to be called conceptual.

Moreover, were actuality merely conceptual, everything—including the person making the conceptual consideration—would be merely conceptual; yet its reality is grasped immediately, and denying it is obstinate disputation. **Objection:** If every quiddity possesses an actuality, then its relation to that actuality must itself be actual, and another actual relation must link them, producing an infinite regress. **Reply:** If the relation does not itself exist [in the stipulated manner], the answer is evident; if it does, the second relation is precisely actuality's belonging to the quiddity. **Objection:** If actuality is affirmed as belonging to it, it is a nonsubsistent attribute; otherwise [its attribution] would be postponed until after the quiddity's own establishment, and it could not be established of it. It would furthermore be a quality whose subject precedes it and is more general than it; thus actuality would inhere in that subject and depend upon it.

Reply: Not everything which is not a substance is thereby an accident, whereas quality is an accident. Nor does ‘subsisting’ invariably mean ‘depending’; substantial form, for example, does not depend on prime matter [in the sense intended by the argument]. **Objection:** The actuality of a newly originated thing that is now nonexistent is not present. Otherwise actuality would obtain when the thing had none. When it later comes to be we say that its actuality has arisen after not existing; consequently actuality as such was absent. **Reply:** [The quiddity] is not actual, but actuality is actual through itself; the proposed consequence deprives a thing of itself. What comes about after not having been there is the conjunction [of actuality with the quiddity]. **Objection:** The quiddity's actuality is already established; if unrestricted actuality also existed, there would be a duplication in what exists, an idle obtaining of what is already obtained.

Reply: If the quiddity's actuality means its distinctness, it is clear that actuality is one. If its [actual] existents are intended, they belong to the quiddity by existence, while existence belongs to itself through itself. In any case repetition would concern one and the same matter, whereas two considerations are at issue here. **Objection:** It is predicable under both considerations, while it cannot be a genuine particular [under each]. **Reply:** [The transcribed wording here is syntactically insecure: the answer contrasts what is extramental with a merely imagined common predicate.] **Objection:** If actuality were real it would multiply what is one, since the actuality of a thing in itself differs from its actuality in a place, a time, or a state.

Editorial note

At least two readings are defective: «الضد وصف» may not be the intended noun, and the last objection and reply around «جزئيات جزئيات الحقيقي» are corrupt. The source text is preserved rather than silently normalised. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/40?lang=ar

Printed p. 41

Relations do not multiply reality; first proof of necessary existence

MSH-029 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Reply: We deny [that its own actuality multiplies it]; it is only the relations which multiply. **Objection:** If existence is determinate by itself, it would be confined to one, whereas multiplicity is witnessed. Moreover what is universal cannot become a real particular outside the mind simply by adjoining it to a universal quiddity. It is like the other conceptual universals: its extramental realization would require the addition either of determination or of something necessarily connected with determination. But determination is conceptual, being the joining of an individuating feature; that joining is mental, since an extramental thing could not be added, *outside the mind*, to a universal quiddity which exists in the mind. The same holds for its necessary concomitant: something merely conceptual cannot be a necessary consequence of something real, for otherwise the real thing could not exist without that conceptual consideration, whereas real things obtain without the person making the consideration.

Reply: Existence is determinate through itself; plurality belongs to quiddities, and their particularization is either through themselves on condition of their being qualified by existence or through extrinsic causes. Even were existence not determinate through itself, their extramental existence could be a determinate nature, or a nature considered apart from the alternatives universal and particular; it need not be determination itself, nor its concomitant. **Second question: the ways of**

proving intrinsic necessity. First way: Existence—shared in meaning by every existent—does not intrinsically admit nonexistence; therefore the unrestricted and all-encompassing reality of existence is necessary.

That such a common meaning is present is self-evident, even if we conceive it only under an aspect or through thought. Yet its extreme clarity has led to confusion, and it has been taken to be identical with quiddities. Notice that the conviction that there is existence remains even when our convictions concerning particular specifications pass away. **Objection:** The belief that one particular thing exists disappears when the existence of another is affirmed; where, then, does the common element remain? **Reply:** We discover that what remains the object of our conviction is the meaning of existence—even if no word had ever been coined for it. **Objection:** Belief in a thing's existence does not cease if one believes it to be existence itself, then a substance, then an accident. [The connecting wording at فلا is unclear.] Existence would thus itself have existence, prompting an infinite regress.

Reply: Existence is in reality identical with itself; it differs from it only by conceptual consideration. Once that consideration is removed the regress stops. That existence is additional in one case does not entail that it must be additional in another. **Objection:** Then it would be shared between itself and something other than itself. **Reply:** The difference established solely through consideration drops away. Moreover, existence is divided into necessary and possible, and what receives that division is common to both. **Objection:** The sharing might be merely verbal; and one may divide a [given] world into 'possible' or 'necessary' while what receives the division is its quiddity itself.

Editorial note

Do not read the common meaning of existence alone as an independent proof of one numerical extramental subject; the author adds ontological premises. The last objector wording is insecure.
Online page: https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/41?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: Review against the supplied Arabic corrects the direction of implication at لا الاعتباري يلزم الحقيقي and retains the explicit لا يزول in the following objection. The connecting wording at فلا remains uncertain; no Arabic restoration has been made.

Printed p. 42

Further replies on common existence and nonexistence

MSH-030 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Reply: It is a rational division, which does not depend upon our affirming both alternatives as actual: if a thing's existence proceeds from itself it is necessary; if from another, it is possible. To deny the explanatory distinction on the supposition that existence is identical with the thing—because one allegedly cannot say that a

particular identity, if it entails itself through itself, is necessary, while otherwise it is possible—is sheer obstinacy: the statement is necessarily intelligible. An unrestricted quiddity is divided only by adding a dividing feature. If existence is added to it, existence must remain with each opposing member of the division; the continued presence of existence is precisely the common element. This sharing entails a common existence and is not undone by appeal to quiddity or individuality, since those notions too possess their unrestricted meanings. Further, anything is either existent or nonexistent. Nonexistence is general, and so must its opposite be; otherwise the exhaustive alternatives would be a general and a particular.

Objection: What is negated is only a particular identity, and the exhaustive distinction is between its being and its removal. **Reply:** Ordinary understanding takes the expression universally. One should not object that, if this general negation obtains among other identities, contradictories would be joined; if not, it would be impossible to affirm the negation of anything besides that identity. For although it is [the wording علما here is uncertain] with respect to the identities, it has no actuality simply as such, but only through certain relations. These doubts have also been confronted with alleged proofs that existence is identical with quiddities. One such proof says: if existence were additional, quiddities as such would be nonexistent, so the existent would be qualified by the nonexistent.

Reply: Quiddities considered in themselves are characterised by neither existence nor nonexistence. These are joined to them as blackness or whiteness may be joined to a body. **Another objection:** Every positive attribute of a thing presupposes that thing's own establishment. Quiddities would therefore possess existence before their existence; that existence would precede itself, producing an infinite regress. **Reply:** That principle of presupposition applies to a positive attribute which is *other than existence*. **Another objection:** If existence were additional, it would itself require existence. **Reply:** A thing's being established as itself is not something additional to it. That nonexistence cannot befall existence is likewise self-evident; the preceding argument serves to bring this out. Nonexistence would either befall existence as an accident—in which case one contradictory would be qualified by its opposite—or else existence would turn into a different nature. Both are necessarily impossible.

Objection: The intended meaning is only that existence might cease. **Reply:** Such cessation cannot even be possible, because an impossibility cannot be possible. **Objection:** It is not impossible for one of two contradictories to qualify the other; what is impossible is to predicate the one of the other, rather than of a subject outside both which can receive either. **Reply:** [The syntax of this rebuttal is unstable in the transcription.] The impossibility of a contradictory's being predicated of itself in the proposed manner is still more evident: for example, if blackness cannot be predicated of the very subject considered as the recipient of blackness, then predicating it of blackness itself would be still more problematic. At any rate, denying the impossibility of one contradictory’s being qualified by the other is mere obstinacy.

Editorial note

Several clauses, particularly the final dialectic about subject and blackness, are transmitted in doubtful syntax and need photographic verification. The translation follows the visible argumentative direction without claiming textual certainty. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/42?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: The expression علما بحسب الهويات and the black/blackness example remain textually difficult. The present review has not checked a page image and does not emend either. The final rebuttal explicitly denies the possibility of one contradictory being qualified by the other; the earlier English accidentally reversed this claim.

Printed p. 43

Real unity, names, and the possible objection from a specially necessary nature

MSH-031 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Objection: Sharing entails universality, which is incompatible with real existence because a universal cannot exist outside the mind; it also entails multiple instances, which contradict divine oneness. **Reply:** What the term is predicated of is not a collection of independently existing instances. Rather the whole is one, necessary through itself, while plurality occurs through possible attributes additional to the Essence. Sharing is considered with respect to its relations to quiddities, and multiplicity with respect to its appearance within them. Thus it is not universal in the manner alleged, since all things are necessarily actual through it. Nor is it a particular marked by a merely conceptual limitation, such as being disengaged from quiddity: otherwise, when that limitation ceased to be considered, existence itself would become susceptible to nonexistence. Neither can a positive restriction qualify it: if like a form, it would render the Necessary composite; if like a posited [restriction; the transmitted word is الفرض], it would not be a necessary concomitant of the very nature of existence. The ensuing argument about a restriction's relation to its subject is compressed and textually uncertain, but its point is to reject a distinct real delimitation that would require another principle or an infinite regress.

Objection: Unrestricted existence could be immune to nonexistence only if it were the very essence of a determinate existent. But that is false: the unrestricted can be predicated of what is determinate, whereas one self-subsistent essence cannot be predicated of another. Necessary reality is therefore a special nature necessarily accompanied by unrestricted existence. **Reply:** Such a nature cannot be made intelligible. If it has instances in the mind, and one instance exists while the others are impossible, despite all being [conceptually] possible, the necessity of the former and impossibility of the latter must come from something extrinsic; for what belongs to something through itself is not eliminated by what comes from another. If the nature has no such instances and differs from unrestricted existence, it cannot itself

be existent, lest it become a composite with existence. If it is a quiddity, necessary existence would subsist in it and thus depend on something other than itself. That quiddity would have to be the agent producing this existence—otherwise the Necessary's existence would come from another.

It would also have to be the cause of its own existence and so precede itself in existence. Moreover, if such a quiddity could act to actualize itself, it could supposedly act to actualize the world without itself existing: before possessing existence it could cause its own inherence in the First Intellect and then the Intellect's existence, and similarly all subordinate things, without ever itself acquiring existence. Thus the proof of a necessary Creator would be undermined. It would also become admissible that the quiddity of every thing causes its own existence without the Necessary exerting any effect upon it. If simple, the argument would be that, just as the simple divine quiddity allegedly entails its own existence, so does every simple quiddity. If composite, the quiddity of the part, the form, and their composite arrangement could cause that arrangement, yielding the quiddity of the whole; this in turn could cause its own existence or that of its parts ...

Editorial note

The final paragraph continues on p.44. The compressed middle portion of the first reply is flagged; a translation must not silently smooth the corrupted source into a demonstrative syllogism. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/43?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: The first pair still gives an explicitly signalled synopsis of the highly compressed final restriction/regress argument rather than a secure clause-by-clause translation. In particular الفرض has not been silently changed to العرض or الفصل. This passage requires further source verification.

Printed p. 44

Rejecting the specially necessary nature and intrinsic existential gradation

MSH-032 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... when that combination is stipulated, and the composite then becomes a cause of its own existence or of the existence of its parts. The nonexistence of temporally originated things would result from the absence of the conditions and preparatory factors required for their existence. Proofs of a Necessary Existent would thereby collapse. [On the alternative] that the alleged necessary nature is a merely intelligible thing which cannot possess existence, the Necessary itself would depend upon an intelligible item, while that item would be both receiver and agent, the cause of existence without being required to exist. The principle of extramental existence would then be something mental incapable of extramental actuality. How could that be a Necessary Existent inseparably connected with existence? But if the nature held

to entail existence does not differ from the reality of unrestricted existence, one must either deny that possible existences entail unrestricted existence as they fail to entail necessary existence, or require particular existences to entail unrestricted existence despite possible quiddities' failure to entail the Necessary.

Objection: It is denied that this is absurd: it is the very doctrine being maintained. **Reply:** Its impossibility has been shown. Two entirely alike things cannot be united while one inheres in the other and stands to it as a necessary concomitant without any distinguishing ground, when the hypothesis expressly denies a difference. Our doctrine is not that possibles possess independent actuality. The reality that is actual is one, with additional attributes. **Objection:** Your argument presupposes an ungraded reality. Might not possibles entail the unrestricted by a reality different from that of the Necessary, while the two share the property in question? [The reading «ملكك تشكيل» is corrupt.]

Reply: Existence, whatever differences are alleged in its manifestations, does not admit nonexistence, as already established. Were another [independent existence] actual there would be multiple Necessary Existents, something the proponent of gradation wholly rejects. Arguments for gradation from priority, precedence, greater completeness and greater nobility presuppose the alleged nature that necessarily accompanies existence; but such properties accrue to existence only in relation to quiddities—for example, through having fewer or more intermediaries. Against the posited necessarily accompanying nature we add that it differs from the notion of every determination, for determination requires a subject, which conflicts with intrinsic necessity. Such a nature would therefore have possible instances: it is a universal in the mind, and if one instance obtained while the others were impossible, this would have to be through another. If the alleged inseparability is denied because the nature is unrestricted or the restriction is merely supposed, the conclusion follows if it does not depend on a subject.

Editorial note

The clause «ملكك تشكيل» and several further inflections in the final dialectic are visibly defective. The text unequivocally distinguishes priority and perfection relative to quiddities from gradation of existence considered in itself; the rest awaits collation. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/44?lang=ar

Printed p. 45

What are the alleged individuals of unrestricted existence?

MSH-033 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… [of] a subject. **Objection:** If this argument is sound, the Necessary cannot be identical with unrestricted existence. For if unrestricted existence has instances in the mind while their combined actuality is impossible, the actuality of one and impossibility of another must arise from something other than themselves. Alternatively, if particular existences differ from unrestricted existence, existence is predicated of them and of the unrestricted only equivocally, contradicting the clear and established common meaning; if they do not differ, possible things would be necessary through themselves. **Reply:** [The transmitted clause هي بالحقيقة نفي للوجوب الواجب is unclear and does not support a secure translation.] It is the quiddities of possible things that are characterised by possibility. Unrestricted existence is not other than the Necessary, for otherwise it would not subsist through itself and be distinguished by itself, but [would be distinguished] only by necessity. **Objection:** Nonetheless, it is self-evident that possibles, like the Necessary, are instances of unrestricted existence.

Reply: An appeal to self-evidence is inadmissible at the very point under dispute. Moreover, by ‘possible’ one might intend the subject to which some determination or attribute belongs, without taking the attribute together with its subject. In that case [the subject considered as existence] is the Necessary. Or one may intend the attribute or determination itself abstracted from the subject; then it is not an independent instance of the unrestricted Necessary: what does not exist through itself, or whose whole cannot so exist, is not an instance of what exists through itself. For a composite of intrinsically necessary existence and something else, or the resulting whole, cannot possess existence through itself. What exists only derivatively does not possess actuality through itself, because a constituent cannot itself possess the stipulated intrinsic actuality. Hence supposed mental instances each existing through themselves are impossible, and no such thing is an instance of the self-existent. Or, finally, the subject may be considered under its description as bearing those attributes. In that case the whole exists: one in essence but multiple through attributes which are possible and additional to the Essence. There is, strictly speaking, no self-subsisting essence other than one existence; unrestricted existence has no mental instances differing by necessity, possibility and impossibility.

Objection: What is impossible outside the mind has a mental existence which is, like the Necessary, an instance of unrestricted existence. There must therefore be mutually incompatible instances within the unrestricted. **Reply:** Mental and extramental existence are, in reality, one; their difference is through conceptual consideration. What is necessary through itself is impossible only *in relation to* the quiddity of an impossibility. Intelligible meanings are attached to extramental

existence only at some of its degrees. **Objection:** Such meanings occur only in intelligible discourse that indicates them; how could their existence be identical with extramental existence? **Reply:** The restriction to the intelligible concerns the derivative ‘being-existent’ of the meanings that have existence. Our subject is existence through itself, which bears such meanings. Furthermore, if by the subject of these considerations we mean ...

Editorial note

The author distinguishes conceptual mental identity from a purported plurality of self-subsisting existences. The final sentence continues on p.46. The transcription contains anomalous syntax at «أو شيء منها» and «معروض هذه الاعتبارات». **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/45?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: The opening reply contains the anomalous phrase هي بالحقيقة نفي للوجوب الواجب. Its earlier English reconstruction has been withdrawn; the supplied Arabic remains unchanged pending source verification.

Printed p. 46

Completion of first proof; second through fifth ways

MSH-034 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... apart from taking those considerations together with it, it is the Necessary through itself; if an attribute alone is meant, it is not one of the [Necessary's] independent instances; and if their combination is meant, the whole is not necessary through itself. What is impossible outside the mind cannot therefore count among the instances of unrestricted existence; what is possible returns to the existence [through which it is manifested]. **Objection:** If unrestricted existence is identical with intrinsic necessity, the latter restricts it. **Reply:** That is a conceptual judgement which does not remove real unrestrictedness. **Objection:** But it was said that unrestricted existence does not accept even privative restrictions. **Reply:** The first claim concerns what must belong to it as unrestricted, which excludes every restriction; the second concerns what necessarily follows in thought. Reflect on this distinction. The posited nature said to entail existence is also refuted thus: either its reality is intrinsically necessary or existence is an intrinsic necessary concomitant. But existence, considered as additional to a simple nature, is not entailed by that nature through itself, because it lies outside the nature's concept and that concept can be understood without it. Without regard to anything external, it has an equal relation to existence and nonexistence, so it is intrinsically possible and cannot entail existence intrinsically.

Second way: If existence were not necessary in itself, it would be possible and would require for its actuality a cause preceding it in existence. The existence of the Necessary would then itself be possible. Or existence would be divided into necessary

and possible, but a subject of division has no extramental actuality except through its subdivisions; meanwhile the subdivisions of existence cannot themselves be actual except through existence. This produces a circle.

Third way: The nature of existence is found in the Necessary. If it were other than the Necessary, the Necessary's existence would depend upon another. If it is identical with the Necessary and unrestricted, unrestricted existence is necessary. If it is particular, unrestricted existence is present with it. Should unrestricted existence be necessary, the point is proved. If not, the particular would depend, through its dependence, upon a cause; and even if the particular is claimed necessary, its condition would not be necessary in itself, so the particular composed through it would not be intrinsically necessary either. **Fourth way:** Existence has no reality additional to itself, since otherwise the reality could be conceived without existence, which is necessarily absurd. Existence is therefore necessary; otherwise it could be stripped of itself. **Objection:** It might cease while [its reality] remains. **Reply:** The disappearance of realities would entail [the transmitted word قبلها, “before them,” is unclear here]. Moreover, the proposed view entails the possible disappearance of the Necessary’s reality.

Fifth way: Everything needs existence in order to be actual. If existence itself needed another existence, the latter would [ultimately] need the Necessary. **Objection:** The unrestricted cannot be restricted by either need or the absence of need, and as a universal it requires instances. **Reply:** Dependence upon a particular entails dependence upon the unrestricted; and being without restriction by need would hold only if existence were divisible in the posited sense, which is denied. We deny both that existence is universal and that every universal requires individuals. Rather, possible natures require …

Editorial note

Source p46 has an unstable transition in the fifth argument. Final sentence continues p.47. One should distinguish “existence is necessary through itself” as metaphysical conclusion from the conceptual fact that its own existence cannot be added to it. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/46?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: The fourth proof contains the doubtful phrase ارتفاع الحقائق يستلزم قبلها. The inherited English supplied a presupposition-of-prior-existence argument; the revised English marks the source uncertainty instead. The fifth proof’s opening remains unstable as already recorded.

Printed p. 47

Sixth and seventh arguments; opening two objections

MSH-035 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… individuating features for their manifestation in the sensible world, and species-forming differentiations for their appearance at the level of meanings—not for their own actuality as such. **Sixth way:** If unrestricted existence were not necessary, some particular existence would have to be. If the particular differed in reality from unrestricted existence, calling both ‘existence’ would be equivocal, contrary to what is evident. If it did not differ, Necessary Existents would be multiplied, because the unrestricted would have individuals identical with what is necessary and all such individuals would accordingly be necessary. This would also absurdly make the divine cause of things unrelated to them, contrary to the causal correspondence accepted by the majority and evidenced by induction, make it apprehend a universal above which there is no further universal although it is itself but one branch of the unrestricted reality it cannot encompass, make the naturally posterior a cause of the naturally prior, and place it under every general predicate.

Seventh way: We know immediately that existence, in which existent things participate, is a single extramental reality whose nature is identical with those existents mentally and externally; they are multiplied and distinguished only by particularising relations and considerations. It is therefore more appropriate to regard the unrestricted as that which is real, while its determinations are intelligible meanings taken from relations and considerations. The Real is pure existence, not mixed with anything other than itself: there is no composition, plurality, attribute, or delineation in it. Understand this; God is the Bestower.

Chapter Three: Removing doubts. There are several objections. **First:** If unrestricted existence is determinate through itself, mutually incompatible attributes cannot inhere in it; for a numerically single thing cannot possess contradictory characteristics. Otherwise its determination would be by means of those attributes—since it cannot be determined through another—and the Necessary would multiply according to the distinct individuals bearing those attributes. **Reply:** It is determined through itself, and there is no contradiction in its entailing one thing intrinsically and another in conjunction with an additional consideration. **Second:** If unrestricted existence does not subsist independently, it cannot be necessary in itself. But if it does subsist independently, either it brings about the inherence of something incompatible with what is already present, so the opposite of an existing thing would always appear, or it entails its contrary so both would be united in everything. **Reply:** Its independent subsistence does not prevent what is incompatible with something at one level of its manifestation, or its entailing a different thing only at another level.

Editorial note

The seventh proof expressly makes «الإضافات والاعتبارات المخصصة» the differentiating principle: the philosophical relation between these considered distinctions and actual manifested differences remains a central question. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/47?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: The final reply to the second objection is compressed in the supplied Arabic. The English conveys its contrast between levels, but its detailed syntax remains to be verified against the print or another witness.

Printed p. 48

How different manifestations can belong to unrestricted reality

MSH-036 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Third objection: Unrestricted existence is supposed to receive opposites. It would then need preparatory conditions external to itself, for if its receptivity for them came entirely from itself, there would be an intrinsic difference in its very reality. **Reply:** It may be disposed for one thing through itself and for another through a mediating factor without an intrinsic difference; besides, these preparatory conditions are attributes distinct from it. **Fourth:** If necessary, it must be one, yet it is the locus of attributes; a simple reality would consequently be both recipient and agent in relation to the same item, which the philosophers reject. **Reply:** That is impossible only when the two roles are asserted under one and the same aspect. Distinct aspects do not impair simplicity if one of the aspects is privative, such as a determination constituted by relation, and the object received is likewise privative. It may therefore receive through its determination and act through its reality, or conversely. Indeed, a privative item may in a certain manner both act and receive under one aspect, as when an attribute of something entails its being qualified as that thing’s attribute and receives that qualification.

Fifth: If the Necessary were unrestricted, it would cause all things. But what is one simply as one cannot produce both something and what contradicts it. Each thing would thus require another cause, bringing multiple causes to bear upon the same particular effect. Were the Necessary a particular reality instead, it could be qualified by an attribute that entails one thing and, in conjunction with something further, another. **Reply:** It is possible for different states to arise in relation to unrestricted existence without restricting it: together with one state it causes one thing, and together with another it causes something else. **Sixth:** If the unrestricted were necessary, it would be one; yet it is confessedly shared among temporal things. It would therefore either be identical with them, qualified by them, or an attribute of them—all manifestly impossible.

Reply: Its being shared among them means its appearing within their quiddities, without being joined to them or separated from them. For in themselves they are nonexistent; they become illuminated through it and are characterised by intelligible relations between themselves and it. The impossible claim would be that unrestricted existence is qualified by temporal existents [as independent positive realities]. Relations are privative matters, particularly when one of the two terms is itself privative. It remains pure existence, unmixed with anything, with no plurality in any respect. Rather, plurality lies in a configuration illuminated by it. It is ‘all’ in the sense that the all would be nothing without it, while “Nothing is like unto Him; He is the All-Hearing, the All-Seeing” (Q 42:11). **Seventh:** Existence is an accident of the Necessary and cannot be the Necessary itself, for several reasons. First: if it is not additional, it is either included [as a constituent], making the Necessary composite, or identical. In the second alternative, if it is not shared [the previous demonstrations are contradicted]; if shared, the divine disengagement from other things is an accidental attribute, caused either by the essence of existence, in which case possibles would accompany it, or by something else, in which case it needs an extrinsic principle. Furthermore ...

Editorial note

The claim about relations as privative is central, but the visible syntax «اتصافه بالحوادث الموجودة النسب أمور عدمية» is broken and requires checking before a definitive rendering. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/48?lang=ar

Printed p. 49

Closing objections and transition to Qūnawī

MSH-037 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... if the essence entails detachment, this is contradicted by possibles; if it entails no detachment, it violates the hypothesis; and if it entails neither, every cause must be extrinsic. One cannot answer that detachment is privative and therefore requires only the absence of a cause, for an absence relative to something would presuppose the absence of the cause of conjunction; that cause would differ from the Necessary, bringing back dependence upon another. **Reply:** Sharing here means that multiple attributes are related to existence and considered together with it, so that it manifests through genera, species and individuals. There is no multiplication within existence itself, and therefore no intrinsic participation of several separate realities. Moreover, [on the present construal] the cause of disengagement is the Essence, on condition that it is not qualified by those attributes. We may indeed say that its essence entails neither [the disputed restriction nor its negation] while its inwardness entails disengagement and its outwardness entails relation. It has no need of another because it is itself the Inward and the Outward. We deny that a privative detachment

needs an absence of a cause: needing the absence of a cause would be a positive relation, not established by something wholly without actuality. Even if conceded, relative nonexistence pertains to existence and so is not other than existence itself in a way that would require another; besides, the supposed dependence would belong to detachment itself, not the Essence that is disengaged.

Second argument of the seventh objection: If the unrestricted were the origin of possibles, either existence alone is the source—then every existent, sharing in existence, would be the origin of everything, even itself and its causes—or the source is existence together with disengagement. In that case a privation would be included in the first principle of actuality, and the proof of a Creator would collapse, since a possible existence, or its conjunction with a privative condition, might be the agent. Nor can one simply say that disengagement is a condition of efficacy: every existence would remain a universal source, even if its effects failed to follow for want of the condition. **Reply:** We accept the first alternative in the sense that existence is one, not that every thing is independently the source of every other thing or of itself. Disengagement is the relevant condition. The alleged absurdity would follow only if a possible being exercised that independent efficacy; but the condition's obtaining in possible things is impossible, and it is no surprise that supposing something impossible should yield a further impossibility.

Third: Necessity is a relation requiring two terms. **Reply:** A distinction through conceptual consideration is sufficient, as in the case of someone knowing himself. **Fourth:** Existence is a specific nature, whose necessary properties cannot differ. **Reply:** This presupposes a multiplicity of instances; differences can instead arise when existence is considered with other attributes. There are additional difficulties to be discussed in their proper places, God willing. Now it is time to begin the principal aims. God alone grants success and assistance in hardship.

Editorial note

This closes the three preliminary chapters; the Qūnawī commentary proper begins with the proem on p.50. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/49?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: The clause علة تجرد الذات بشرط عدم اتصافه لها is construed as making the Essence the cause of disengagement on the stated condition. Its compressed syntax remains uncertain; this construal has not been verified against a page image.

Printed p. 50

Qūnawī’s invocation: praise, the divine Name, and the signs within its letters

MSH-038 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

[Qūnawī, opening lemma] “Praise belongs to God, who—exalted and glorified is He—has made manifest, through the resting-places of spiritual aspirations, the ranks of knowledge of certainty, its absence, its eye, and its reality, together with their degrees.” [The sequence «وعدمه» is transmitted as “and its absence”; its relation to the surrounding enumeration is suspect and requires a second witness.]

[Al-Mahāʾimī’s explanation] On “Praise belongs to God”: praise consists in magnifying an essence by reason of the beautiful qualities it possesses. *Allāh* is a proper name for the Essence of the Necessary Existent insofar as the existence of the world is connected with it. The sign for the unrestricted Essence is the letter *hā’*, since it is a pronoun pointing to what is absent. In Arabic writing its form encloses, and its articulation begins from deep within the chest before traversing the various points of articulation; hence it encompasses the distinctive properties of the other letters, just as the unseen of the Essence encompasses the degrees of determinations. Yet no written form belongs to that Essence insofar as it is unrestricted, transcending every judgement and every name and representation; this symbolism concerns it only under the relation of unrestrictedness. The word *Allāh* deserves to be qualified by attributes because it unites in comprehensive oneness all the divine attributes—life, knowledge, power, will, speech, hearing and sight—whereas other Names indicate particular meanings.

The hamza in the Name alludes to the first determination; the concealed, faint *alif* to the hiddenness of the breath or self determined through it [the reading *nafs* requires verification]; the first *lām* to the domain of dominion (*mulk*), and the second to the invisible kingdom (*malakūt*).

Assimilation of the letters signifies the inclusion of the inward kingdom within outward dominion. The separation of the *alif* indicates the severance of commensurability between the unrestricted and the restricted precisely under their respective aspects of unrestrictedness and restriction [the transmitted syntax breaks off]. The *alif* audible but unwritten after them points to [an obscure relation between] the self-discloser, its own level, and the encompassing of individual entities, by which the divine is related to what receives divinity. The *hā’* signifies the essential unseen and the inflectional vowels the qualifications and judgements. The definite article in *al-ḥamd* denotes totality, while the prefixed *lām* in *li-llāh* denotes exclusive belonging: all kinds of praise belong to Him. These kinds are four. [The first is] the Real’s praise of Himself: magnifying the Essence for its complete unrestrictedness beyond relations and determinations; magnifying His first determination as [the transmitted متبع الكمالات is uncertain]; magnifying Him through His knowledge encompassing all

objects of knowledge and the necessary effective realities; and [magnifying] manifest existence through its expansion over created things. [This describes the first kind; the remaining kinds follow below.]

[The second is] the Real’s praise of creatures, since they are vestments of His light; [the third is] creatures’ praise of Him, since He is distinguished by intrinsic necessity. This includes praise by the world of meanings—that is, the fixed entities—as His intelligible affairs and determinations of the divine Names; praise by the world of spirits through transcendence, unity and luminosity; praise by the imaginal world as the bodies of self-disclosures and the moulds of spirits and meanings; praise by the bodily world through its realities and meanings and their spiritual splendour; and praise by the human world, which declares Him free from defects and describes Him with the perfections that truly belong to Him, in the most … [sentence continues on p.51].

Editorial note

The received lemma has «وعدمه» (“and its absence”), anomalous alongside ʿilm/ʿayn/ḥaqq al-yaqīn. Preserve it without emendation. The fourth paragraph contains severe syntactic damage. All bracketed lemmas are Qūnawī, not al-Mahāʾimī. Arabic p.50 ends mid-sentence; no material from p.51 silently moved backwards. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/50?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: The four kinds of praise run across pp.50–51; the descriptions of the Essence, first determination, knowledge and manifest existence are subdivisions of the first kind, the Real’s praise of Himself. The supplied wording متبع الكمالات is retained as uncertain, not silently read as a different word.

Printed p. 51

Comprehensive praise and the methods of certainty

MSH-039 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… perfect manner. [The fourth kind,] creatures’ praise, means magnifying the one praised on account of virtues particular to that one; it is a share in the perfection of the Real's praise of Himself, insofar as manifest existence, appearing through all and in all, is identical with the all under that consideration. There is a praise comprehending all these praises, called the “praise of praise,” which subsists through the Real. The Perfect Human magnifies the Real either in the oneness gathering all meanings, because this complete human appears in the divine form, or in respect of his differentiated constitution. Each of his realities—spirit, heart, soul, body and all the corresponding qualities and judgements—recognises the Real through the divine Name upon which it depends, speaking in the language of its own reality, rank, preparedness and comprehensive oneness, with inexhaustibly many expressions of praise.

[Qūnawī, repeated lemma] “He made manifest through the resting-places of aspirations the ranks and degrees of the knowledge, eye and reality of certainty [and the transmitted anomalous ‘absence’].” **[Commentary]** Here *abāna*, “made manifest,” means making something immediately and necessarily known. To explain this, one must first distinguish four groups seeking the realities of things: Illuminationist philosophers, who seek them through unveiling and direct vision but not on the rule of Islam; Peripatetic philosophers, who seek them by definitions and demonstrations on that same footing; theologians, who seek them through those rational methods while following the rule of Islam; and Sufis, who seek them by unveiling and direct vision while following that rule.

Unveiling here means acquiring firm, certain conviction through freeing the soul from bodily attachments and blameworthy qualities and directing oneself wholly towards God. Following the rule of Islam means conformity with revealed books and prophetic reports, without forcing upon them interpretations that are not required.

Objection: Discursive reasoning must assist inspiration in order to distinguish it from satanic suggestion and the soul's internal speech. Inspiration is not subject to human control, and purification requires struggles to which the bodily constitution rarely proves equal. Assurance is attained only through discursive reasoning. If the outcome of purification is not immediately necessary knowledge, then it depends upon a state whose loss entails losing some of the knowledge; in this sense it is inferential. If no such dependency is found, the result may be no more reliable than unexamined imitation, and people holding false doctrines also experience such convictions; a discriminator is indispensable. **Reply:** The discriminator is agreement with the Book, Sunna and consensus of the community. It thereby excludes the experience of those holding false doctrines.

Even if inspiration is not subject to human power, it is promised by God: “Those who strive in Us, We shall surely guide them to Our ways” (Q 29:69). When purification follows the practice of genuine investigators it does not damage a person's constitution but rather makes it more balanced; moreover, even discursive examination requires purification to remove the doubts and perplexities … [continued p.52].

Editorial note

The section distinguishes a claimed source of knowledge (kashf) from its normative testing (scripture and communal consensus). The categorical claims about philosophers and theologians are the author’s own fourfold taxonomy, not an editorial conclusion. Qūnawī’s repeated opening lemma remains separately labelled. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/51?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: The fourth praise item is introduced simply as حمد الخلق in the supplied text; its object is not explicitly given. The revised English therefore leaves “the one praised” general instead of silently identifying that object as God.

Printed p. 52

The case for inspiration and its compatibility with rational examination

MSH-040 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… which arise within it. The criterion is what the knower has actually attained as immediate certainty, even when it previously required discursive investigation. No serious investigator disputes that inferential knowledge may become immediately evident. Nor does the assistance of discursive reasoning undermine our position; how much less can one dismiss inspiration, whose consequences God has promised to those who struggle in His cause? How could it be false when He says, “O believers, if you are mindful of God, He will grant you a criterion for distinction” (Q 8:29)?

They explain this criterion as a light by which truth is distinguished from falsehood. The same is indicated by “Is one whose breast God has opened to Islam, so that he is upon a light from his Lord …?” (Q 39:22); “In that are signs for those who discern” (Q 15:75); “We have made clear the signs for people who have certainty” (Q 2:118; the source gives Q 45:4); and the statement concerning signs in what God has created in the heavens and earth for people who are mindful of Him (Q 10:6).

He also cites, “This is an exposition for humankind, guidance and an admonition to the mindful” (Q 3:138), and “Whoever is mindful of God, He will appoint for him a way out and provide for him from where he did not reckon” (Q 65:2–3). These verses are interpreted as promising an escape from doubts and difficulties, a knowledge not obtained by study, and insight not obtained by trial. A prophetic report is then cited: “Whoever acts according to what he knows, God causes him to inherit knowledge of what he did not know and gives him success in acting until he merits entry to Paradise; whoever fails to act upon his knowledge is made to forget what he knew and fails to act until he merits the Fire.” [This translation records the attribution in the source, not an independent authentication of the report.]

Another report is cited: “Among my community are people who receive inner address and are spoken to, and ʿUmar is one of them.” He also cites: “Be mindful of the believer's discernment, for he looks by the light of God.” Evidence validating discursive reasoning does not contradict such inspiration: both paths are sound according to those who investigate thoroughly. However … [continued p.53].

Editorial note

Publisher’s modern footnotes on hadith sources are excluded from the Arabic author layer; independent isnād analysis remains undone. The Q 45:4 quotation looks mismatched to its citation and is explicitly flagged. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/52?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: Reference correction: قد بينا الآيات لقوم يوقنون is Qurʾān 2:118, verified against the Arabic verse at https://quran.com/2/118 on 11 November 2026. The source's [4 :الجاثية] remains unchanged in the Arabic transcription; the English reference identifies the actual verse.

Printed p. 53

Why method requires purification; what spiritual aspiration means

MSH-041 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Anyone who holds that moral training, illumination and purification have no relevance to instruction and rational study has entered into the very substance of passion and fantasy. Vices dominate him and virtues are denied him; he relies solely on books by imitators of the philosophers and polemical theologians, squanders his life in corrupt imaginings and empty suppositions amid overwhelming doubts, and the light of his heart fades as his inward sight is blinded by accumulating darkness and false beliefs. Ignorance and irresolution increase, leaving him bewildered, without knowing where to turn, and exposed to divine displeasure.

On Qūnawī's phrase "He made manifest ... through aspirations": *himma* comes from *hamma*, an impulse toward an intention, but authorities differ over its technical sense. The author of the *Manāzil* defines it as a movement of the soul wholly possessed by its object, such that its possessor cannot restrain or turn away from it. He lacks the power to hold back or wait, being overcome by the force of aspiration. Ibn ʿArabī, in his technical vocabulary, states that when a passing thought becomes established in the soul it is called will (*irāda*); when it returns a third time it is called aspiration (*himma*), and a fourth time resolve (*ʿazm*). [The details of this numerical sequence are left as the received text and await independent comparison.]

When one turns toward action the passing impulse to act is called intention (*qaṣd*), and the commencement of action is striving (*saʿy*). Another view defines aspiration as the psychic impetus that seeks perfection. Some direct their ambition toward worldly matters, others toward the perfections of the next life, while others direct their aspiration to God, in God, or to what is with God. Their difference in degree reflects their shares from God and the sublimity of aspiration's objects, including [unveiling?; the transmitted word is الكف], witnessing, and ranks such as prophecy, sainthood and vicegerency. Yet another definition is a single-minded gathering in the presence of a divine Name that calls forth the intended effect without wavering toward another, so that the Name effects what is sought on condition of concentrated aspirations.

The first definition best suits the present discussion, but it has several divisions. In the beginnings, aspiration is bound to obedience and fidelity to repentance; in the gateways, the heart attaches itself to abiding bliss, turns from what perishes, and pursues its goal without slackening. In transactions or practices, it impels upright

action, sustained vigilance and firm trust in God through reliance and surrender. In ethical formation it devotes itself entirely to attaining felicity and perfection; among the foundations, aspiration draws its possessor toward the Real through the power of certainty ... [continued p.54].

Editorial note

Names and quotations from the Manāzil and Ibn ʿArabī are attributed as quotations, not automatically adopted as definitions valid at every station. The source includes a modern editor’s bibliographical footnote, excluded here. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/53?lang=ar

Printed p. 54

Aspiration, inward repose and certainty

MSH-042 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... and by the spirit of intimacy which prevents weariness on the journey and deviation of intention. In the valleys, aspiration is the total turning to the Real, with a disdain for reliance upon the soul's own gains, compensations and mediating means—works, hope, and trust in such things. In the spiritual states, many concerns become a single concern through the sovereignty of love. In the realms of sainthood, aspiration rises above attributes and passes beyond descriptive features towards the Essence. At the endings, there is no aspiration except to act effectively through the Real’s own efficacy throughout all possible things. What is intended here is aspiration at the level of the valleys and what lies above them.

The definition is most strictly appropriate to these higher ranks; its application to earlier stages is analogical, particularly before the decisive opening. It is also possible that ‘aspiration’ here refers to the third type in the last definition. The second and fourth meanings [in the enumeration] concern exerting an effect [the transmitted phrase الغي في is unclear]. Its *resting* means the tranquillity of the hearts in which these aspirations are found, as the hearts are qualified by the light of faith and by conformity of their attainments to the Book and the Sunna. This repose comes through remembrance of God, which puts an end to intrusive imaginings, allowing the light of remembrance to become established: “Surely, in the remembrance of God do hearts find rest” (Q 13:28). He is the Necessary Existent, beyond whom there is nothing; He is pure Light before which no darkness remains. Complete turning strengthens the person's participation in the aspect of the Real until it overcomes the person, just as a piece of iron adjoining fire takes on the fire's effects. This is possible only through the love latent in the servant, which emerges only by avoiding its opposites—that is, by Godfearingness. Thus He has disclosed through the resting places of aspiration the ranks of the knowledge, eye, and reality of certainty.

According to Shaykh Muḥyī al-Dīn in his *Epistle on Certainty*, certainty is a station between knowledge and tranquillity. Its etymology is connected with water settling in a hollow, or with the fastening by which a vessel is secured. Certainty is knowledge established in the heart so firmly that it does not disappear even as the knower moves from one position to another. If it disappears, faith is lost and doubt succeeds it; doubt is a species of associationism or denial. When something of that kind was suggested about Abraham, and he was asked “Have you not believed?”, our Prophet said, “We have more right to doubt than Abraham,” [thereby] affirming Abraham's certainty. It is evident that Abraham already had certainty; what he sought was tranquillity, which is granted by direct seeing ...

Editorial note

The analogies of fire and iron do not by themselves establish identity or indwelling. The lexical derivations and the quotation attributed to Ibn ʿArabī require checking against his treatise. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/54?lang=ar

Printed p. 55

Different definitions of the three certainties

MSH-043 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

For this reason he said, “But so that my heart may be at rest” (Q 2:260). Doubts are afflictions superadded to certainty, and it is therefore legitimate to seek reassurance. He also said that knowledge must rest upon certainty; [the clause regarding knowledge and repose is corrupt]. Authorities have differed in defining the knowledge, eye and reality of certainty.

In the technical definitions it is said: the *knowledge of certainty* (*ʿilm al-yaqīn*) is what demonstration yields; its *eye* (*ʿayn al-yaqīn*) is what witnessing yields; its *reality* (*ḥaqq al-yaqīn*) is what is obtained from knowing the reality made visible through that witnessing. A similar definition says: knowledge of certainty arises through examination and inference; the eye of certainty through unveiling and the reception of a gift; and the reality of certainty through realization and separation from the contamination of clay upon the arrival of the herald of union.

The author of the *Manāzil* says: knowledge of certainty consists in accepting what has become manifest of the Real, accepting what is unseen on the Real's authority, and standing by what is upheld through the Real. The eye of certainty involves passing beyond inference to direct apprehension, beyond report to sight, and piercing the veil of discursive knowledge through witnessing. The reality of certainty is the dawn breaking upon unveiling, then release from the effort of certainty, and finally extinction in the Truly Certain Real. In the *ʿAwārif*, Fāris says that the reality of

certainty is what the knowledge of certainty points towards, while the eye of certainty is the servant's realization of it as he witnesses the entities with direct vision, just as one beholds visible things directly, and is able to speak truthfully of the unseen.

Another says: knowledge of certainty is the state of gnosis; the eye of certainty is the state of gathering (*jamʿ*); and the reality of certainty is the gathering of gathering expressed in the language of unity. Yet another counts five things—name, description, knowledge, eye, and reality. Name and description pertain to the common people, knowledge of certainty to the saints, its eye to the elect among the saints, its reality to the prophets, and the reality of the reality of certainty (*ḥaqīqat ḥaqq al-yaqīn*) to our Prophet alone, peace be upon him. The first definition is closest to the present discussion. The ranks of the knowledge of certainty vary: it may arise from theoretical demonstrations after extensive disputation or from a little effort, from obvious inward evidences, from accepted teachings of realized spiritual masters in varying degrees, or from the words of the Book and the Sunna. Knowledge received merely from outward scholars, by contrast, is imitation rather than direct knowledge.

Editorial note

The claimed hierarchy of knowers is a reported alternative, not an assertion that every tradition makes identical epistemic divisions. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/55?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: Source comparison, not an adopted emendation: the online text of al-Suhrawardī's ʿAwārif al-maʿārif, chapter 62 (https://ibnalarabi.com/books/awarif.php?id=65; consulted 11 November 2026), attributes the first definition to Fāris, but introduces the subsequent realization/witnessing sentence under al-Junayd. It reads المرئيات / الغيوب at the place where this commentary's transcription has المرائي / العيون, and has حال التفرقة where the next pair here reads حال المعرفة. These differences require checking the printed witnesses and quotation boundaries; the commentary's Arabic and its stated attributions have not been silently replaced. The comparison supports removing the inherited English's unsupported mirror imagery.

Printed p. 56

The three certainties across ontological and cognitive levels

MSH-044 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

As for the ranks of the eye of certainty, it may be received from the imaginal world, from terrestrial or celestial spirits, from the higher intellects and souls, or from divine eternal knowledge. As for the ranks of the reality of certainty, a person may realize it through the acts of the Real, through His attributes, through extinction in His Essence, or through abiding by it.

The degrees of the knowledge of certainty likewise vary. It may lack both stillness and tranquillity, possess both, or possess one without the other. It may be established by proofs to which weak objections can still be raised without undermining the

conclusion—though the knower becomes perplexed when trying to respond to them because language is inadequate. Or it may rest on proofs admitting no such objection, on a single demonstration, or on several mutually reinforcing demonstrations. One may know only by a demonstration *that* something is so (*burhān innī*) or also by a demonstration *why* it is so (*burhān limmī*).

The eye of certainty may also be without stillness or tranquillity, or with both. It may occur by unveiling (*mukāshafa*), witnessing (*mushāhada*), or immediate beholding (*muʿāyana*). Unveiling is the witnessing of entities and their states in the very Reality of the Real; it is genuine realization through contemplating the divine self-disclosures. [The source's additional differentiation between contemplating names, Essence and attributes is grammatically corrupt.] Witnessing is vision of the Essence after the veil has been lifted absolutely. Immediate beholding is the Real’s beholding His own Essence through His own Essence, without ambiguity and without taking account of the imperfection of variegation (*talwīn*).

The reality of certainty may be through the extinction of the soul alone, or the heart along with it, or the spirit along with them while the secret remains, or while the hidden secret remains, or through none of them remaining [the division is insecure], or through the abiding of all these—not by their own existence but by the true Existence and the light overflowing from it. Each of these has further degrees which this brief work cannot enumerate. **Qūnawī says:** “And He made clear, through the cessation of the seekers' agitation upon reaching the utmost reach of their souls, their differing degrees in the abodes of knowledge of Him and in His acts of drawing them near.” To make clear (*īḍāḥ*) is to bring from hiddenness into manifestation, just as to disclose (*ibāna*) is to bring from ignorance requiring investigation into immediate knowledge. The first is more comprehensive, for a kind of hiddenness may remain even in immediate knowledge as long as unrest persists. Repose is the cessation of movement; at the beginnings agitation is the soul's movement towards ...

Editorial note

Editorial footnote on *ʿālam al-mithāl* has been excluded from authorial text. The extra sentence in the source on the degrees of witnessing contains errors and must be collated. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/56?lang=ar

Stage 13 review: In the definition of muʿāyana, عيان الحق بذاته ذاته makes the Real the beholder and His Essence the object: the revised English preserves that grammar. The intervening distinction of names, Essence and attributes remains explicitly unresolved in the supplied transcription.

Printed p. 57

Agitation of the seeker, soul and the four journeys

MSH-045 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… the promised attainment and weariness with all else in existence. At the gateways agitation constricts one’s disposition, makes creatures distasteful to its possessor, and makes death seem desirable. In practical dealings, it is estrangement from all but the Real, intimacy with unity and withdrawal from creatures. At the level of character it is being stripped of sight [the transmitted البصر is uncertain here] and capacity because of the longing and need one experiences for the Real. At the roots it is restless flight towards the goal from anything that hinders or turns the wayfarer back. In the valleys agitation overcomes discursive intellect and other burdens [reading unclear]; in the states it is longing that moves a person and removes patience. In sainthood it purifies the present moment and clears away attributes. In the realities it abolishes conventional forms and residues and is not satisfied with gifts and chosen privileges; at the endings it leaves nothing untouched and annihilates every entity and trace. The present passage principally concerns what occurs in the spiritual states. The seeker is the one journeying towards the Real through disconnection from everything else. Arrival means reaching the goal; here “at the time” (*ḥāl*) denotes the time coinciding with that arrival.

Shaʾw means distance or range. The *nafs* here is the subtle, vapour-like substance bearing the faculties of life, sensation, motion and will; philosophers call it the animal spirit. It mediates between the heart—here the rational soul—and the body. It may be the commanding soul, inclined towards bodily nature, commanding sensory pleasure and desire and drawing the heart downwards; it then becomes the dwelling place of evil and the origin of blameworthy traits and actions. Or it may be the self-reproaching soul, illuminated to some extent by the heart's light and awakened from the sleep of heedlessness. It begins correcting itself, oscillating between lordly and creaturely orientations. When its dark native tendency results in wrongdoing, the light of divine warning overtakes it, so that it reproaches itself and repents. Or it may be the soul at peace, progressively illuminated by the heart, shedding its blameworthy attributes and taking on praiseworthy character. It turns entirely towards the heart and follows it into the holy world, leaving impurity behind.

The attainment of the furthest range of the soul comes with the completion of its journeys after it finds tranquillity. The end of the first journey, *to God*, is the removal of the veils of multiplicity from the face of unity. The end of the second, *in God*, is the removal of the veils from the aspects of inward, intelligible multiplicity. The end of the third, [towards] the unicity of the Essence, is liberation from the two opposed restrictions, outward and inward, through arrival at the unicity of the very gathering. The end of the fourth journey, *from God to creatures in* …

Editorial note

The identification of nafs with a subtle animal spirit is a context-specific psychological usage. The journey-counting and names must be compared with later formulations rather than harmonised silently. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/57?lang=ar

Printed p. 58

Two senses of gnosis and diverse capacities of knowers

MSH-046 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… the station of uprightness is the oneness of gathering and differentiation (*jamʿ wa-farq*). It comes through witnessing the inclusion of the Real in creation and the fading of creation in the Real, until the one reality is seen in the forms of multiplicity and the multiple forms in the reality of unity. *Maʿrifa*, gnosis or recognition, is used in two senses. First, knowledge of what is inward inferred from an outward indication—for example, recognising someone's inward character from a visible mark. God says to the Prophet: “You would recognise them by their marks, and you will certainly recognise them through their manner of speech” (Q 47:30).

Second, recognition is knowledge of something witnessed which was already familiar: seeing again a person whom one saw long ago and saying, “I recognised him after so many years.” The object recognised is differentiated according to the ranks of existence, which [the source says] are six, but then names: the rank of the unitive Essence (*aḥadiyya*); the rank of the divine Presence of unicity with distinct names (*wāḥidiyya*); the rank of abstract meanings; the rank of spirits; the imaginal world; the witnessed world; and the rank of the all-comprehensive existent, the Perfect Human. Every one of these admits of very many subdivisions.

Seekers differ greatly in their degrees of recognition. For some knowers the only way is to infer His attribute from His act, His name from His attribute, and His Essence from His name: “Such people are called from a distant place” (Q 41:44). Others are borne by eternal solicitude into the sanctuary of witnessing. They then witness the One whom they knew through the preceding witnessing signalled by “Am I not your Lord?” (Q 7:172), and know His names and attributes through Him—reversing the first knower's path. The gulf between them is vast. The first knows Him while absent from direct witnessing, rather like a sleeper who sees an image that fails to correspond to reality; the second witnesses Him directly like a waking person who sees something real as it is.

The Real is one in Essence, attributes, names and acts. Whatever essence, attribute, name or act is attributed to other than Him receives such attribution figuratively: in reality these are reflections of the lights of the self-disclosures of the Essence, eternal attributes, divine names and acts in the loci of cosmic manifestation. Nothing of these

belongs literally to a locus as the forms reflected in a mirror do not truly belong to the mirror. Hearing and sight, wherever predicated, belong in their reality to God: “He is the All-Hearing, the All-Seeing” (Q 42:11). The Real's making manifest the mystery of His Essence, attributes and acts did not follow upon any previous hiddenness from Himself. It was so that He might subsequently disclose Himself by the name the Outward, just as He had first disclosed Himself by the name the Inward; then ...

Editorial note

IMPORTANT: the source expressly says «وهي ستة» (six), but lists seven ranks. Do not emend without examining other witnesses. This is also crucial evidence for different registers of knower and known.
Online page: https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/58?lang=ar

Printed p. 59

Higher attainment, the person of the Perfect Human, and divine names

MSH-047 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Indeed no manifestation of His acts appears without His also becoming veiled through it. This arises from the perfection of His craft and the profundity of His wisdom. By ‘name’ one does not mean a verbal expression but what that expression signifies—the Essence qualified by an attribute. This is the sense in which the scholars say, “The name is the named.” Differences among those brought near Him take several forms. A knower may acquire certain divine attributes within the limits of human capacity; he may be effaced *in* them or *by* them, witness the attributes or witness the Essence, be effaced in it and abide through it. He may occupy the station of realization, whose distinction [from the preceding condition] will be explained later. He may become a *badal*, a *watad*, an imām or pole (*quṭb*), a solitary one (*fard*), or another of the ranks whose details cannot be given here. Their differences at the end of the soul's journey are indicated by the saying attributed to the Prophet, “Whoever knows himself knows his Lord.” The soul is fully known only at the end of its range and its journeys, when its veils of light and darkness disappear and realities become disclosed, for it then becomes a perfectly polished mirror facing the higher principles in which all sciences and realities are inscribed. Reflect and you will receive guidance, God willing.

Qūnawī says: “He distinguished His elect from among creatures by setting no ultimate aim for them other than His Essence, beyond all His worlds and the Presences of His names and attributes.” Distinction (*tamyīz*) is a description removing ambiguity; here it means particular election. The elect are those who have passed through the spiritual abodes until they reached God. They then journey *in*

God, *through God*, and *from God*. Beneath them are the intermediate travellers who have crossed most of the abodes, and below these the beginners who have not traversed most of them. The first are called the forerunners; the second, those who follow a middle course; the third, aspirants. The term creation ...

Editorial note

The long note explaining realization and seeing God through His names on p59 is an editorial footnote and remains outside the authorial translation. The formula “He who knows himself...” requires separate hadith verification. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/59?lang=ar

Printed p. 60

The world as manifestation and several non-identical taxonomies of realms and Names

MSH-048 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... creation is the visible form of existence as it appears through possible quiddities. An end is that toward which movement tends and at which it ceases. An essence is the fundamental principle through which a thing is what it is. There are differing descriptions of the *world*. According to one, it is the “second shadow”: existence manifest in the forms of possible things. Because that existence appears in their determinations it is called “what is other” (*siwā*) and “the other” (*ghayr*) when considered in its relation to possibilities, which nevertheless remain established in their own nonexistence. The world is its form, while it is the world's identity and spirit. Determinations are the effects or determinations of the Name the Manifest, through which the Hidden becomes disclosed. In this classification the world is divided into the *jabarūt*, the realm of divine Names and Attributes ...

... the realm of Command, namely the spirits, which exist by the command of the Real without matter or temporal duration; this is also termed the *malakūt* and the unseen; and the realm of Creation, namely bodies existing with matter and duration, also called *mulk* and the witnessed domain. Another definition takes *ʿālam* as that by which something is known, so that every existent is a world; the world is then divided into the unseen and the witnessed. The unseen is subdivided into originated things hidden from the senses, the *malakūt* identified with eternal attributes, and the *jabarūt* identified with the eternal Essence; the witnessed domain is divided into the imaginal, bodily and human worlds. Yet another account uses “world” as a designation for every existent and divides it into the world of the Essence in its nonnumerical oneness ...

... the world of Divinity, the Presence of the One; the world of immaterial spirits; the imaginal world; the *malakūt*, here understood as spiritual powers; the *mulk*, corporeal realities; and the all-comprehensive cosmos, the human being. The divine

Name is the Essence together with an attribute, while an attribute is a meaning subsisting in the Essence; the two terms may sometimes be used interchangeably. Considered from the intimacy and awe occasioned by contemplating them, the Names divide into those of beauty (*jamāl*), such as the Gentle, and those of majesty (*jalāl*), such as the Overpowering. These are expressed through the two Hands. In another classification the Names are essential, indicating no meanings additional to and going beyond the Essence, as *Allāh*, Existent and Pre-eternal; attributive, indicating an additional meaning that does not pass over to another, as Living, Knowing and Willing ...

... or Names of act, indicating additional meanings extending to others, such as Creator, Provider and Shaper. Alternatively, “essential” may denote attributes in which the Essence is sufficient unto itself, such as Living, Knowing, Willing, Powerful, Hearing, Seeing ... [continued p.61].

Editorial note

The page deliberately supplies *multiple* classifications of the realms: jabarūt, malakūt and ʿālam al-amr do not retain an identical denotation across them. This is evidence for contextual technical meanings, not permission to conflate them. Opening sentence continues p.59 and last sentence p.61. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/60?lang=ar

Printed p. 61

The primordial Names and the highest object of divine knowledge and aspiration

MSH-049 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... Speaking. On another usage, essential Names are those whose existence does not depend on the existence of something else, although their intelligibility may depend upon a consideration of another—such as the Knowing. These are called the first Names, the Keys of the Unseen and the leaders of the Names. Attributes may then be divided into those of complete encompassing scope and those without it. The first are the seven leading attributes, despite relations of conditional priority among them: knowledge presupposes life, power both of those, will the three, and the remaining attributes the four. They are roots of all others, even though some of the others encompass very many things.

[Qūnawī, lemma] “Rather, He made the utmost extent of their aspirations the noblest object of His essential knowledge and the highest objects of His will, until the end of their willing and the furthest target of their aim was what He wills through His Essence for His Essence, under the loftiest aspects of His primordial affairs and His most elevated determinations.”

[Al-Mahāʾimī's exposition] Eternal knowledge consists in the Real's being present to Himself, in Himself and for Himself, while the realities of everything other than Him are present within His knowledge. It consequently has objects, the noblest being His Essence, necessary through itself and comprehensive of all. Eternal will concerns the disclosure of what lies in the Unseen into the witnessed world according to the preparedness of the realities of manifestation; its highest object is the appearance of the Essence in the comprehensive locus. These things can only be attained through elevated aspiration. Thus, in knowledge of certainty, the limit of their aspiration is the noblest object of essential knowledge; in the eye of certainty, its highest willing; and in the reality of certainty, their original desire becomes that which He wills through Himself for Himself, after they have traversed the stations. Qūnawī's successive restrictions exclude what is willed indirectly through the prerequisites and completions of the Perfect Locus, and what is willed merely for the sake of knowing Him while retaining one's separate self-awareness. The “essential affairs” (*shuʾūn dhātiyya*) are the consideration of the imprints of realities in the Essence under the Presence of *aḥadiyya*; these become the fixed entities at the level of *wāḥidiyya*. The relation is like a tree with branches, leaves, flowers and fruit contained in a seed: the realities subsist undifferentiatedly in *aḥadiyya*, then appear in differentiated form within divine knowledge in *wāḥidiyya*. The fixed entities are the realities of possibilities in God's knowledge. Corresponding to these affairs are self-disclosures at the rank of *wāḥidiyya*, the divine Names and Attributes. Some affairs are primordial, others derivative; the former can receive the Real's appearance through His Essence together with the whole of His Attributes, both comprehensively and distinctly.

Although this [primordial reality or affair] is intelligible and does not enter into [extramental] existence, it nevertheless has its determination and effect in everything possessing concrete existence … [continued p.62].

Editorial note

Central ontological distinction: the fixed entities are in divine knowledge, and their realities are *not* asserted to become independently existent just because they have effects. “Essential affairs” in aḥadiyya and “fixed entities” in wāḥidiyya are related but not automatically identical from every perspective. The final «وهي» is grammatically ambiguous. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/61?lang=ar

Printed p. 62

The first and second determinations; aḥadiyya, wāḥidiyya, and the two kinds of multiplicity

MSH-050 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… existence. For this reason it has the rank of primacy, insofar as it is sought by the Essence. The kind of knowledge intended by the creation of the world in the reported saying “I was a hidden treasure and loved to be known” is obtained only through a locus such as this, for it includes every self-disclosure; no one fully knows what is absent from his own constitution. The loftiest of the determinations is the first determination, in which the Essence discloses Itself to Itself under the attribute of oneness (*wāḥida*), where manifestation and hiddenness are in equilibrium. Because this determination is receptive to both, it is a locus for *aḥadiyya* and *wāḥidiyya*: the two are related, and their relation is displayed through that intervening unity. [The report “hidden treasure” is cited as a received saying, not verified as a prophetic ḥadīth.]

There are two considerations of the Essence: first, the negation of multiplicity and relations, under which It is named *Aḥad*; second, the consideration of these [relations], under which It is named *Wāḥid*. The first self-disclosure encompasses essential and nominal perfection in comprehensive, undifferentiated fashion. Complete differentiation of particulars requires the distinctness of realities, for which there is no room in the first disclosure owing to the preponderance of unity. Essential perfection entails absolute self-sufficiency: the eternal comprehension of everything that is capable of differentiation to eternity in one all-inclusive witnessing, without dependence upon its differentiated unfolding.

What is sought here, then, is the perfection of the Names, conditioned by the world in its differentiated aspect and by Adam as a comprehensive presence arising after that differentiation. The Essence demands this perfection insofar as It is qualified by Names and Attributes. Detailed differentiation is a further perfection that requires the Real to become distinguished and some rule of otherness to obtain—even if only as a relation. Neither is possible under *aḥadiyya* considered as such. Another determination is therefore required, in which divine, cosmic and human realities, and all that can be differentiated, become distinct: the **second determination and second self-disclosure**. Since it appears from the first determination in that determination's form, it comprises unity, multiplicity, an intermediary and a differentiating limit, just as the first includes unity and the two aspects *aḥadiyya* and *wāḥidiyya*. Its unity is called the outward face of existence, and its multiplicity the outward face of knowledge. Necessity accompanies the first, possibility the second. Manifest existence possesses true unity through the pervasion of *aḥadiyya* and relational plurality through the pervasion of *wāḥidiyya*; the outward face of knowledge has the reverse arrangement. Multiplicity in knowledge concerns the fixed

entities of possibilities, while multiplicity of existence is the origin of the divine Names and Attributes. Existential unity encompasses primordial affairs; the unity of knowledge is the Presence of meanings and the sea of possibility. [This passage contains compressed antecedents and should be collated before its subdivisions are treated as a definitive taxonomy.]

Qūnawī's phrase “under the loftiest aspects of His primordial affairs and His highest determinations” thus indicates that no one can aspire to what lies beyond that rank. He will explicitly state this later in the text. Understand, and God is the Inspirer.

Editorial note

The central philosophical issue is the distinction between the **first taʿayyun** in which essential unity dominates and **second taʿayyun** where distinctions within divine knowledge appear. The report “I was a hidden treasure” requires independent hadith evaluation. The obscure final list is translated provisionally with no invented variants. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/62?lang=ar

Printed p. 63

Certainty, phenomenal self-effacement, and why divine “pervasion” is not indwelling

MSH-051 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī says: “Thus He, exalted is He, is the very reality of their certain knowledge, its eye and its truth throughout the ranks of His essential knowledge, related first to Himself and then to His objects of knowledge, while they are effaced in Him as regards themselves, yet their ruling remains and pervades all His existents and Presences.” **Al-Mahāʾimī explains:** Because the utmost reach of their aspirations is the noblest object of His knowledge, He is the reality of their knowledge of certainty. Because it is the highest object of His will, He is the reality of the eye of their certainty. When what they will coincides with what He wills through His Essence, He is the reality of the reality of their certainty.

Here is the explanation. When their knowledge attains the noblest objects of eternal knowledge, they know the unity of all things in existence. They consequently know that their certain knowledge, considered in its existence, is the very true Existence. Yet at this rank their individual selves and their knowing still veil them. When knowledge becomes direct seeing, the veil of knowledge is lifted and they perceive that the eye of their certainty is true Existence itself. When direct seeing becomes realization through the Real and the spectator is effaced, they realize that He, **in respect of existence**, is the very reality of their certainty. **This is not said under the consideration of His unrestrictedness**: considered so, He is independent of

the worlds and remains beyond the veil [of their knowledge]. Rather it is said under the distinct ranks of His essential knowledge, which, although essential, admits of ranks according as it relates first to the Essence and then to objects known.

This knowledge, relating to the Essence without the veil of the spectator's knowledge or individual self, is the reality of certainty attained by the elect. They attain it through self-effacement in Him, **not** by becoming nonexistent as spirit, soul or body, but by ceasing to apprehend these things under their own aspect. They apprehend them instead as shadows of the Real and lights manifest through His light. Hence their *rulings* remain even while their independent existence is effaced from awareness. Since these rulings remain, they continue to be knowers who have realized the reality of certainty. He is likewise the reality of their certainty insofar as He pervades all His existents and Presences, among which the reality of their certainty is included, as it belongs to the domain of knowledge.

Know that this pervasion (*sarāyān*) is **not** the pervasion of indwelling (*ḥulūl*). Indwelling would be like that of an accident in a substance; but God is no accident of anything, since accidents exist through Him—how could He be one of them? Nor is it like a form's inherence in matter: He is the form of nothing, for forms exist through Him and matter through their forms—how could He be identical with either? Nor is it an occupant's presence in a place, from which He is transcendent, since He encompasses the whole: how could a place encompass Him? Rather His pervasion is like the passage of sunlight through glass, without anything moving ...

Editorial note

DECISIVE PASSAGE: “not under His unrestrictedness”; “not that they become nonexistent as spirit, soul or body”; “not the pervasion of indwelling.” These are separate epistemological and ontological qualifications, not optional ornaments. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/63?lang=ar

Printed p. 64

Coloured glass, the descent of manifestation, and the status of fixed entities

MSH-052 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... from the sun to the glass, as might be imagined. Rather the effect arises through the glass facing the sun: the light takes on the apparent colour of the glass, although sunlight itself has no colour. By the pervasion of the Presences he means manifestation at the first determination and in the subsequent ranks of eternal relations.

The learned Ṣadr al-Dīn says in the *Epistle on Unity*: “Then it”—that is, the unrestricted Identity—“required manifestation from the limit of the unseen to the limit of witnessing, and the realization of those attributes and determinations as distinguishable in the entities in actuality; it knows them distinctly and brought about the world of spirits, namely intellects and souls. The manifestation of existence there is more complete than in the world of meanings; then came the imaginal world and the world of bodies. In this world the manifestation of existence was completed, for the self-disclosure of existence attained completeness with the bringing into being of the first body which delimits the directions, the Throne, the station of establishment in divine discourse.”

Objection: To say that [the absolute Identity] requires manifestation and that possibility exists as something able to receive its effect is impossible. If possibility is actual, it is either in existence, and hence necessary, or in a quiddity, which is nonexistent, known or unknown, even impossible; there is no third alternative. **Reply:** Rather, its subject and correlate is “certainty” [اليقين, as printed; the reading and intended sense are uncertain]. We deny that quiddities are unable to receive existence. If they are conjoined with existence, they necessarily become existent, and such conjunction is indeed actual. There are determinations whose natural subject is extramental existence, others whose natural subject is intelligible existence, and still others whose natural subject is unrestricted existence, as in the fixed entities. Nevertheless, these are not existent by an existence which is their own essence or an intrinsic constituent of them. The following printed wording is unstable: “Otherwise it would follow from quiddity as such being neither unknown nor known; for the existent does not become caused and unknown.” [No independent witness has resolved this sentence.] Whenever a quiddity becomes existent by conjunction with existence, its being-existent depends on its conjunction with existence, which is other than the quiddity.

One must not argue: if existence is necessary, everything that exists must be necessary. We reject the inference: existence is necessary precisely because it is actual through itself, unlike that which exists derivatively (*bi-l-ʿaraḍ*). The latter's being-existent is a conceptual attribution; for this reason negative attributes and privative accidents may also be predicated of it. Whoever regards …

Editorial note

The first line closes the p63 solar analogy. Distinguish al-Mahāʾimī’s report of the epistle from his response to an objection; the modern editor’s gloss on huwiyya is excluded. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/64?lang=ar

Printed p. 65

Manifestation, not creation of existence: a reply to objections

MSH-053 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… unrestricted existence to be a purely conceptual consideration may have failed to distinguish it from this derivative attribution of being-existent. The two are confused in his reasoning, so that the reality which is actual through itself and forms the source of all other real things is made into a mere mental consideration. Recognise the distinction.

Objection: There is no coherent sense in which manifestation can be affirmed. If it means existence itself, the claim would be that existence causes itself to exist, although it is necessary and cannot be subject to such causal production. If it means existence restricted by a particular qualification, neither of its two constituents can be made or affected: existence is necessary, while the other constituent is a quiddity that cannot in itself receive existence. Nor can the whole receive existence, for the whole depends upon its constituents; if it cannot receive existence it cannot receive the additional attribution of existence either, since an accident's existence follows its subject. One cannot reply that intellectual existence receives extramental existence: it receives neither extramental nor intellectual existence anew, for that would be obtaining what was already present. Nor do the remaining particular limitations enter into consideration within unrestricted existence, so they cannot necessitate extramental or mental existence, nor can unrestricted existence necessitate them. The same applies to any conceptual whole made up of restrictions and the restricted subject. And if ‘manifestation’ refers merely to a quiddity, relation or attribution, these cannot receive existence; the point needs no further explanation.

Reply: What we mean by manifestation is that the unrestricted becomes determinate through some determination. As you already know, **the correlate of possibility is the determination**, not existence considered in itself. **Objection:** The bodily world is furthest from the fountainhead of existence and nearest to sheer possibility. How, then, could existence be manifested in it more completely and perfectly? The reverse would seem more appropriate.

Reply: Perhaps the intention is that a reality which can be apprehended comprehensively, understood distinctly, imagined, estimated and sensed by the outward senses manifests more properties and effects of existence than one accessible only to some of these modes. The individual reality (*inniyya*) manifest at the final rank is plainly accessible through all these modes of cognition, unlike the individual realities operating at higher ranks. **Objection:** If the perfection of the lowest rank consists in being open to all these modes of apprehension, so should the Perfect Human be; yet you describe him as having been effaced from them. **Reply:**

The Perfect Human achieves perfection only by acquiring the stable capacities (*malakāt*) corresponding to all these modes of cognition at their proper ranks. Sensory apprehension is not …

Editorial note

This page explicitly defines appearance as «صيرورة المطلق متعينا بشيء من التعينات» and says possibility pertains to the determination; these statements are more precise than generic “emanation.” **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/65?lang=ar

Printed p. 66

The embodied Perfect Human, persistence of faculties, and mediation

MSH-054 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… nor the restrictions that naturally accompany it an obstacle to the remaining kinds of apprehension, most of which are attained through acquisition and free choice. Acquisition cannot take place without sensory apprehension. How, then, could sense perception in itself bar the other modes? It obstructs them only insofar as it draws the novice towards sensible things considered as ends in themselves; during the first stages effacement is necessary. **At the stage of abiding (*baqāʾ*), however, sense perception is no obstacle.**

One should not object: if these modes of apprehension are perfections, death would diminish them, whereas what is sought by the Necessary Essence is the manifestation of perfections and removal of defects; why, then, do perfected people die? We reply that death completes their perfection, for perfected souls remain capable after death of everything they were capable of before, including sensory apprehension. Establishing this fully would require more explanation than this brief work can contain. This concludes the substance of the learned author's discussion.

Qūnawī says: “May God bless the one who has realized Him from the aspect of the most perfect witnessing and the most complete, noblest and most comprehensive knowledge, while constantly present with Him in all his stations, states, ranks and modes of being.”

Since, under the divine customary ordering, the agent's efficacy upon a recipient requires a proportion or affinity between them, and the utterly transcendent Real cannot be directly proportioned to creation in its radical dependence, a mediator possessing both disengagement and connection is needed: he receives overflowing grace through the former aspect and conveys it through the latter. According to the realized masters, our Prophet most perfectly combines both. Qūnawī therefore seeks blessing through the most complete means, the invocation of blessings (*ṣalāt*), which

is a relation joining the invoker and the one invoked. From God it is mercy, generosity and forgiveness; from creatures it is prayer and humble submission. The related roots ‘connection’, ‘bond’, ‘joining’, ‘warmth’ and ‘strength’ evoke the common idea of coming together and drawing near. The goal is that the Real appoint him as vicegerent so that he becomes one who follows the Real in manifesting His form, and that he be connected with the essential and nominal self-disclosures particular to divine election. Human reality is thereby linked to the five Presences from which it arises. The first is the Presence of his reality, corresponding to his fixed entity in divine knowledge. The second is his spirit—that is, the Breath of the All-Merciful determined through that fixed entity so as to give it relief from the constriction of its nonexistence. The third is his bodily form and individual person.

Editorial note

Very important: fanāʾ and baqāʾ affect the availability/obstructiveness of sensory cognition differently; this is not a metaphysical assertion that sensory reality disappears. The “five presences” enumeration continues onto p.67. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/66?lang=ar

Printed p. 67

The five Presences, comprehensive witnessing and the Muhammadan station

MSH-055 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

The fourth is the reality of the heart, a unitive comprehensiveness joining spiritual and natural aspects. The fifth is his intellect, the faculty by which he retains and understands realities, bears sciences and wisdoms, and distinguishes them. Every human being is under a divine obligation to reconnect these realities to the Real in the principles from which they originate; the five daily prayers are linked to this mystery.

Divine mercy relates to each thing according to its receptivity. For sinners it consists in forgiveness and what follows from it, including entry into the Garden. For the obedient it includes the Garden, divine satisfaction and encounter. For knowers of unity it also includes the outpouring of certain knowledge and true gnoses. For realized, perfected and perfecting prophets and saints it includes essential and attributive self-disclosures and the highest ranks of the gardens with respect to acts, attributes and Essence. By the aspect of the Essence I mean what constitutes the First Principle's joy in His Essence and essential perfections. The mercy directed towards the Prophet's heart is therefore the highest of essential and nominal self-disclosures, due to his perfected receptivity and powerful longing. Its overflow comes from the all-comprehensive divine name, the source of all lights. Angels are loci of

names serving the Greatest Name, and a servant follows his master; hence the Prophet receives the overflow of all names, and their manifested loci collectively seek forgiveness for him. The prayers of believers for him express an intrinsic [reciprocity or recompense—reading «مجازة» uncertain] required by their fixed entities and primordial receptivities. As he was the mediator of their perfections and of their existence in knowledge and actuality—of quiddity as well as existence—so he mediates their perfections.

The one who realizes the divine names, having been made a locus of their manifestation by God, [effaces: the Arabic verb is corrupt] the delineations of his own traits and attributes. The one who merely adopts the traits (*mutakhalliq*), by contrast, acquires the virtues and praiseworthy qualities through effort and discipline, avoiding vice and blameworthy conduct; he possesses their effects from the divine names. Witnessing means seeing the Real through the Real. Witnessing the differentiated within the comprehensive is seeing multiplicity in the unitive Essence; witnessing the comprehensive within the differentiated is seeing unicity in multiplicity. **The most perfect witnessing unites both.** Perfection consists in the most complete manifestation of divine comprehensiveness and cosmic realities. The more completely someone manifests the totality of divine attributes and names, the more perfect he is; lacking any of them, he is correspondingly deficient and further from the station of divine vicegerency. The witnessing is called perfect in consideration of the perfection of the witness. This witnessing is gnosis. The Shaykh says: “The knower is one to whom the Lord shows Himself, whereupon the spiritual states manifest in him”; and gnosis …

Editorial note

The corrupted word «[يمحوظ]» is preserved as recorded and translated only cautiously. This page explicitly defines the two reciprocal kinds of witnessing and a higher comprehensive mode. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/67?lang=ar

Printed p. 68

Comprehensive Muhammadan knowing and the universal name

MSH-056 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… his state: this is the eye of certainty. Qūnawī next explains that he is realized through the most complete knowledge, because he has access to eternal knowledge. It is called the noblest because nobility here consists in the absence or reduction of intermediaries; this indicates that no mediator stands between the Prophet's knowledge and eternal knowledge. It is called the most comprehensive because it encompasses limitless objects of knowledge. It is not called the most perfect because, considered as knowledge, it is one reality among divine realities, unlike his

witnessing, which is comprehensive in all of its realities. Witnessing is not called the noblest because it embraces what is mediated and what is unmediated. This witnessing and knowledge are inseparable from him, with his constant presence with his Lord; visions and self-disclosures follow continuously without a gap in which he becomes wholly occupied with another. The ‘stations’ are the five divine Presences; ‘states’ are the alterations of self-disclosure; ‘ranks’ are their order according to degrees of elevation and the sequence of mediations under the divine customary order; and ‘modes of being’ are renewed self-disclosures in all these at successive instants. Understand.

Qūnawī says: “Our master Muḥammad, his family, the elect of his community and his brethren who have obtained from God his fullest inheritance, comprising his sciences, states and stations.” ‘Master’ signifies one who has command. The Prophet said, “I am the master of the children of Adam, and there is no boasting.” That is, he is charged with the management of their affairs, yet he does not boast of this insofar as it belongs to his created aspect. Rather, he glories in the One who created him over them, since this concerns the aspect of his realities. Each divine name has a form in knowledge called a quiddity or fixed entity, and a form outside the mind called a locus of manifestation. The names are the lords of those loci. **The Muhammadan Reality** is the form of the Essence together with all the names; it is the image of the all-comprehensive name from which the overflow reaches all other names. This reality governs the intelligible form by means of the Lord who manifests in it, the Lord of lords, and thus has unrestricted lordship [by derivation and vicegerency]. It is in this sense that the Prophet said, “I was specially given the Opening of the Book and the final verses of al-Baqara.” The Opening begins, “Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds” (Q 1:2), gathering the worlds of bodies and spirits. Such lordship belongs to his *reality*, not to his humanity as such; considered in his humanity he is a servant under lordship, and …

Editorial note

The contrast between “Muhammadan Reality” and the Prophet’s creaturely human aspect is stated expressly; do not present delegated lordship as independent divinity. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/68?lang=ar

Printed p. 69

The family of the Prophet: physical, religious and spiritual kinship

MSH-057 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... this lordship cannot be conceived without giving everything its due and bestowing all that the world requires. It possesses the names through which it acts in the world according to the world's receptivities. Yet because this reality embraces two aspects, divine and servantly, it possesses that authority not originally but by derivation: this is vicegerency. The name ‘Muḥammad’ comes from the root of praise in an intensive form. His reality—that is, his essence at the first determination, or together with all attributes, or as the form of the all-comprehensive name, or the Greatest Spirit, or true unity—embraces both the arc of *aḥadiyya* and the arc of *wāḥidiyya* in a comprehensive gathering of praises. God brings forth the one who praises and the one praised, and all divine and cosmic beauties and praises are gathered in the reality of Muḥammad, peace be upon him, while the Muhammadan Reality also supports their distinct and detailed praises.

Āl, family, refers to the Prophet's kin, to whom his affairs and inheritances of knowledge, spiritual states and stations pass. They are of several kinds, for he has an elemental bodily form, a religious and legal form, a luminous spiritual form, and an inward, heart-centred spiritual reality. Whoever participates fully in the bodily and religious forms and is genuinely connected to the luminous and inward realities is a vicegerent and imam standing in his place, such as the Mahdī, peace be upon him. Whoever participates in the last three is an inheritor of his knowledge, rank and spiritual state: such people are successors and trustees even if not genealogically noble. Someone related only through bodily descent may nevertheless possess some measure of spiritual meaning and character and thus belong to the sayyids and sharifs. Even when a descendant is far removed from spiritual and intellectual inheritance and outwardly violates the law, that kinship should not be despised: he may yet be among those who eventually return to primordial purity.

Another explanation divides kinship into form alone, meaning alone, or both. Whoever combines both is a successor and imam standing in the Prophet's place, as were the great prophets before him and the perfected saints after him. Whoever possesses inward spiritual kinship alone—like the believer of Pharaoh's household or the man of Yā Sīn—is his spiritual child, having been prepared to receive his meaning. Hence the Prophet is reported to have said to Salmān, “Salmān is one of us, the People of the House.” One whose kinship is formal alone may possess it by descent, as the sayyids do, or by religion, as do outwardly learned jurists, scholars, the righteous, worshippers and other believers. The most complete kinship embraces all these, followed in order by inward kinship, religious formal kinship, and bodily descent.

Editorial note

The scheme of Muhammadan kinship is not to be substituted for positive legal rules of genealogy or inherited political authority. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/69?lang=ar

Printed p. 70

The Muhammadan heirs, unveiling, and singular disclosures

MSH-058 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

The community to whom he—peace be upon him—was sent consists, insofar as they answer him, of the community of response and acceptance of the summons, though the summons was originally universal. It is the former community that is intended, since the latter, as such, contains no elect. These are those whose souls have been purified of vices and whose hearts of their turbidity; God has purified them of their own existence [and attributes] through His existence and attributes. [The printed phrase وأوصى فهم is corrupt; “and attributes” is a contextual conjecture, not an independently attested reading.] He then mentions what follows from such purity: receiving the most complete inheritance, indicated by the Prophet's saying: “The learned are heirs of the prophets. The prophets leave neither dinar nor dirham; they bequeath only knowledge, and whoever takes it has taken an abundant portion.”

By saying “an abundant portion” he indicates that this is not knowledge acquired by formal study, since the abundant portion and the coolness of certainty are not obtained through it. Rather, it is knowledge bestowed directly from God (*ʿilm ladunnī*), obtained through the light of unveiling when the breast opens to knowledge of certainty, the eye of certainty, and the reality of certainty. This is why he says “embracing his sciences”: the real, universal sciences that entail their principles. States and stations are divine self-disclosures: insofar as they change and do not remain fixed they are states, and when they become firmly established they are stations. There is considerable disagreement here, which is not the place to pursue.

He [Qūnawī] said, may God be pleased with him: “[Together with their actual realization of the results of their distinctive shares, which distinguish them from those [shares] distinguished by the properties of intermediaries, the fruits of following, and the effects of connections.]”

That is, they inherit his fullest inheritance while realizing the consequences of their particular shares. A “result” is what arises from another thing as its offspring; specialists in rational inquiry reserve the term for what follows intrinsically from a proof. Here it means the knowledges, states, and stations consequent upon their distinctive shares. The plural *ḥuẓūẓ* means allotted portions, and here a disclosure particular to each according to his particular receptivity. “Particular” is what is found in one and not in others. If this exclusion extends to all others, the particularity is

absolute, and the effusion is a disclosure whose genus, species, or attribute may otherwise be found elsewhere [the syntax of this clause is uncertain]. The restriction is needed because disclosures never recur numerically as the same individual disclosure, as the base text says. He distinguishes the particular shares from those set apart by the qualities of intermediaries. An intermediary conveys an agent's effect to a receptive patient; its own characteristics colour the effect, giving it properties it would not otherwise have. Such intermediary-specific shares are found in the recipient only through that intermediary. Likewise, they are distinguished from the shares—[sentence continues on p. 71].

Editorial note

The printed page ends mid-sentence; Qūnawī's words occur in brackets. The modern editor's hadith footnote is not copied as authorial prose. The printed reading «وأوصى فهم» appears corrupt; supplied bracketed English here is conjectural, not a textual emendation. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/70?lang=ar

Printed p. 71

Types of mediation and the universal form of time

MSH-059 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

—distinguished by the fruits of following. Following (*tabʿiyya*) means imitating [the exemplar] in belief, actions, and states; its fruits are the inherited knowledges that arise from this. These fruits have shares of knowledge and states other than the absolutely particular shares, although they belong especially to those who follow the exemplar. He next mentions something more general, "and the effects of connections": that is, shares distinguished by the effects of relations between agent and recipient, other than the intermediaries and their effects. These connections have their particular effects and shares, different from distinctively personal shares, and present in any recipient capable of receiving an effect from the real Agent. Understand.

He [Qūnawī] said, may God be pleased with him: "[A blessing whose efficacy continues, whose fruitfulness endures as long as time, considered both in its universal reality and in the forms of its detailed effects, expressed as its years, months, days, and hours.]"

That is, he asks blessings upon the Prophet and the elect of his community—blessings fruitful in their efficacy, which is perfection. Even though perfection has been attained by them, it has infinitely many degrees; thus he adds "continually yielding fruit," meaning the unceasing effusion of perfection upon those characterized by it through their mediation. He compares this to time's continuity in two respects: its universal reality and its particular forms. A thing's *ḥaqīqa* is that whereby it is what it

is in external reality; its *māhiyya* is what it is without qualification; its *huwiyya* is that whereby it is individuated. A universal is a conception capable of being shared by many. According to Aristotle, time's reality is the measure of the motion of the outermost sphere.

According to al-Ashʿarī, [time is] a changing occurrence by which another changing occurrence is measured; the full question belongs to kalām and philosophy. As for the aspect of the forms of its effects, this refers to loci of manifestation in which the effects of temporal reality become detailed. “Detailing” separates things which, when gathered, can be described as one. The forms persist by succeeding one another. Thus he asks that blessings and their fruits continue like those forms, so that unending disclosures follow upon one another in travelling in God, through God, and from God. He then explains the forms of the effects of temporal reality by the words “expressed by its years ...”

—and so on. The year is measured by the sun's proper motion through its zodiacal signs or by twelve such movements of the moon; a month by the sun's movement through one sign or by the moon's passage through all signs; a day by the sun's being above the horizon; and an hour by one twenty-fourth part of the motion of— [continues p. 72].

Editorial note

The phrase «وهي الحقيقة المطلقة...» is part of modern editor’s numbered footnote on the printed p. 71 and is not included in the translation. The passage supplies explicit separate definitions of ḥaqīqa, māhiyya and huwiyya (not synonyms). **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/71?lang=ar

Printed p. 72

First naṣṣ: the Absolute as the subject of metaphysical knowledge

MSH-060 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

—the outermost sphere. He mentions temporal forms to draw attention to the form of eternal, everlasting existence and its division into universal and particular aspects, the affair being as decreed. The term *dahr* (time, age) has also been applied to God in the sound hadith, “Do not revile Time, for I am Time: I turn the night and day”; or it may allude to the detailed aspects of the single effusion in its origin; or to the fact that, although prophetic perfection is comprehensive, it has particulars dependent on supplication. Understand.

First Text. He [Qūnawī] said, may God be pleased with him: “[A noble text, the first of the texts, which must be placed first.]”

Lexically, *naṣṣ* denotes what is pure or unalloyed. Here it means something specifically belonging to the tasting of the most perfect and all-comprehensive station, corresponding to what God knows at the highest, most complete and most perfect degree of His knowledge, as the Shaykh explains later in the third subdivision of the first three texts. It is so named because it admits of no explanation or figurative reinterpretation in any manner [the assertion of indefeasibility is Qūnawī's characterization as explained here, not our editorial standard]. Its nobility belongs to the nobility of its object: the Absolute, which comprehends all while having no need of any. It is first because it investigates the first consideration—intrinsic absoluteness. It necessarily comes first because it treats the subject of this science: unrestricted existence. Among the preliminaries of a science is distinguishing its subject in an essentially complete way, for the questions built upon it concern the predication of essential concomitants of that subject, its kinds, their essential concomitants, or their kinds. He does not explicitly define the science as inquiry into the states of existence as existence, and as it appears in loci of manifestation and other respects. Definition would provide a mental distinction, but he considers sufficient the distinction in reality supplied by the difference of subjects. Nor does he state its end separately, since it is plain from the subject: the most universal and exalted of things. Inquiry into it is inquiry into every existent through unveiling and certainty, and the resulting supreme felicity and highest rank, with no limit, are readily understood.

He [Qūnawī] said, may God be pleased with him: “[Know that the Real, considered in His intrinsic absoluteness, cannot properly be subjected to a judgement, known through an attribute, or assigned any relation whatsoever—neither unity, nor necessity of existence, nor principiality, nor the requirement of bringing-into-existence, nor an effect's issuing forth, nor the relation of knowledge on His part to Himself or anything other than Himself. For all of these entail determination—[continues on p. 73].”

Editorial note

Naṣṣ 1 opens on this printed page. The last bracketed lemma of Qūnawī continues onto the next. Modern hadith-reference footnote excluded. The word “before” in later discussion denotes the order of consideration, not proven temporal succession. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/72?lang=ar

Printed p. 73

The Absolute, nonpredication, and the apparent self-referential paradox

MSH-061 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

“—and restriction. There is no doubt that conceiving any determination requires that non-determination precede it. Thus all that we have enumerated is incompatible with absoluteness.” [End of Qūnawī’s sentence begun p. 72.]

Lexically, *al-Ḥaqq* means the established or real. Unrestricted existence is called thus because it is established through itself, while everything else is established through it. Existence is established from every aspect, whereas what is other than it is not established in virtue of its own essence but only through another. To prohibit predication of it insofar as it possesses intrinsic absoluteness, even though it is the subject of all predications, is to say that the latter apply by reason of its many and different determinations and other aspects; “consideration is given to determination in absoluteness,” as the print reads. [The context appears to require a negation, but no independent witness has been collated.] The qualifier “intrinsic” distinguishes this from the freedom of the first determination from the [differentiated] names: insofar as it is the first determination, it admits predications of unity, determination, knowledge of the essence, and necessity of existence.

An objection: “You have judged of it that no judgement can be made about it—is that not a contradiction? And you judge that it is unrestricted and describe it as absolute.”

We reply: what is intended is that this determined reality, considered before its determination, cannot then be subjected to that judgement. When it becomes determined and knowledge is related to it, one judges that it was not subject to judgement at that prior consideration, nor restricted or qualified. More fundamentally, the prohibition of judgement means that it cannot be bound by the judgement: the assertion and its opposite stand on an equal footing relative to it. A judgement is the relating of one thing to another. Definition by attributes is a descriptive (*rasmī*) definition, through which the Real may now be known, whereas a true essential definition is impossible in His case forever, beginninglessly and endlessly. “Attribute” here includes both affirmative and negative predicates; this kind of definition is impossible in the intrinsic respect because it is itself a form of judgement. Likewise, the assignment of a relation is precluded because a relation is a kind of identifying attribute. Unity here is not opposed to multiplicity but calls attention to negating the multiplicity wrongly imagined in Him. It cannot be attributed in that intrinsic respect because it is relational. The necessity of existence means that existence is from His essence—indeed, is His very essence—but assigning even this as a predicate invokes a relation based upon unity. “Principiality” means being the source of things: a relation based upon necessary existence. The requiring

of existentiation is His manifestation of things in the mode of choice; the issuing forth of an effect is a wider expression, since it could also apply in a necessitarian mode. Both are relations consequent upon principiality.

He then mentions the one matter whose exclusion entails the exclusion of all the others: no relation of His knowledge to Himself or to another may be predicated insofar as He is considered absolutely unrestricted; the other descriptions depend on this relation. This emphatically does **not** mean that ignorance came first—God is infinitely exalted above that—but only that knowledge cannot be considered *together with this consideration of absoluteness*, just as these other matters cannot be taken together with it, despite being eternally necessary to the Real under their appropriate considerations. He then explains the whole by what explains their primary basis—[continued p. 74].

Editorial note

Key philosophical objection and response. “Before determination” is explicitly a mode of consideration, not temporal prior ignorance. Arabic «أولا موصوفا» and «العلم حاصل» in related pages need collation with Āshtiyānī 1421 edition. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/73?lang=ar

Printed p. 74

An absoluteness beyond the binary of absolute and conditioned

MSH-062 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

—and of its consequences: each description entails specification and restriction. For what is not specified, how could a determinate judgement be asserted, a determinate attribute assigned, or a determinate relation added? He next gives the reason for considering absoluteness: the conception of any determination necessarily presupposes non-determination. Judgements, descriptive definitions, and attributed relations therefore conflict with the absoluteness conceived prior to determination. Every determination is a restriction that comes after [its basis in the order of consideration], and what precedes all determinations is nothing other than non-determination. Understand.

He [Qūnawī] said, may God be pleased with him: “[Rather, to conceive the Real's absoluteness it must be conceived as a negative attribute, not as an absoluteness whose opposite is restriction. It is freedom from the familiar unity and multiplicity, and from confinement to either absoluteness or restriction, or their combination, or transcendence of them all. Thus all these may properly be asserted of Him while He transcends them all. Ascribing all these and other things to Him, or negating them of

Him, stands equally: neither side has priority over the other.]” The ordinary absoluteness opposed to restriction is itself one of the qualified judgements dependent upon determination.

Thus, he says, to conceive this absoluteness one must conceive it negatively: that He is not bound by anything, not that He possesses the ordinary absoluteness opposed to restriction. The term is used because He is free from the commonly known unity and multiplicity. From the standpoint of absoluteness He is not restricted by either; it is His degrees and determinations that are so qualified. Likewise He is free from confinement to absoluteness and determination, though these pertain in their different respects to His degrees and determinations. Nor is He confined to their conjunction—unity, multiplicity, absoluteness and restriction—even though all are present relative to those degrees. Hence ascribing any of these to Him, or ascribing other predicates—transcendence and likeness, unseen and witnessed—or denying them, are equally possible without one pole prevailing. Were one pole to prevail in this unrestricted regard, He would become conditioned by it, and a subordinate pole would not stand on the same footing. Priority among predicates obtains only according to ranks dependent upon determinations; these have no force where intrinsic absoluteness is the consideration. Understand: this is a place where the feet easily slip.

Editorial note

Critical nuance: this is neither ordinary “unrestricted as opposed to restricted” nor a positive determination called “the Absolute.” Modern editor’s gloss at note 1 and reference to his own separate book at note 2 deliberately omitted; not al-Mahāʾimī. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/74?lang=ar

Printed p. 75

First determination as intrinsic knowledge-relation, not real division

MSH-063 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

He [Qūnawī] said, may God be pleased with him: “[Once this becomes clear, it is known that attributing unity to the Real, or principiality, influence, the act of bringing-into-existence, and the like, is valid only when related to the Real under the consideration of determination.]”

In other words, since no relation has priority over another under intrinsic absoluteness, any preference among relations arises only with respect to His determination. Unity and principiality pertain to the first determination; influence—orientation toward making or annihilating—and the action of producing existence pertain to the second determination and those after it. Each is a relation and must

therefore have relata. Absoluteness is a negative consideration. The intended point is that conceiving these relations depends on considering determination; it does not deny that, in the determinate respects, they are eternally true of the Real. Understand.

He [Qūnawī] said, may God be pleased with him: “[The first of the determinations that can be intellectually apprehended is the intrinsic relation of knowledge, but only insofar as it is distinct from the Essence by a relational distinction, not by a real one.]”

Since relations presuppose determinations and relations have an order, determinations too must be ordered. The first determination that can be conceived is the knowledge-relation, that is, what becomes manifest through the relation of knowledge. Thus he treats knowledge as a relation, for the attributes do not subsist there as differentiated realities. He says “that can be intellectually apprehended” because the first determination in actuality is the relation of life, life being a condition of knowledge, though it is not conceived until after knowledge is conceived. He says “intrinsic” to distinguish this from the later relation of knowledge associated with the divine names, and from His knowledge of other things and the fixed entities. He qualifies the distinction by saying “insofar as”: knowledge is present in absoluteness, but because it is not differentiated there at all it does not yield determination. The distinction is relational, because real differentiation belongs only to the determination of *wāḥidiyya*, not to *aḥadiyya*, the first determination. Thus this relation in the first determination is identical in reality but other under a particular consideration.

He [Qūnawī] said, may God be pleased with him: “[Through the intrinsic knowledge-relation, the Real's unity, necessary existence, and principiality become intelligible—especially insofar as His knowledge of Himself is within Himself, His very knowledge of Himself is the cause of His knowledge of everything, things are determinations of His universal and detailed cognitions, quiddities are cognitions, and these cognitions are intellectually generated one from another.]” Since ascribing relations to the Real depends on determination, conceiving the intrinsic relations depends on the first determination. “Through the intrinsic knowledge-relation” means the Essence's knowledge of Itself through Itself in Itself, together with a distinction made in consideration.

Editorial note

The original explicitly separates (i) actual relation of life from (ii) first intellectually conceived relation of knowledge; (iii) relational distinction of aḥadiyya from (iv) real differentiation assigned to wāḥidiyya. “Real” in last contrast is al-Mahāʾimī’s usage and needs careful analysis before ontological extrapolation. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/75?lang=ar

Printed p. 76

The ordering of essential relations through self-knowledge

MSH-064 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

He [Qūnawī] said: “[The unity of the Real becomes intelligible].” This unity is an essential relation considered as the negation of multiplicity from Him intrinsically; it can [not] be considered in the unqualified Essence, which holds good with [descriptions of] unity and multiplicity. The same applies to His necessity of existence: this is a relation, the Essence of existence requiring [existence], considered with a distinction only in thought, as mentioned before. It is [not] considered in unrestricted absoluteness, which also encompasses the possible things. The same applies to His principiality, since that is a relation between Him and what He brings forth and cannot be considered in unrestricted absoluteness, which encompasses what is brought forth. These relations appear under the first determination. Before knowledge [in the order of apprehension] none can be understood: if He did not know His essence, how would its unity be judged? Without knowledge of unity, how would necessity be judged, given the impossibility of multiple necessary beings? Without knowledge of necessity, how would principiality toward multiplicity be known? And without knowledge of necessity, how could He be known as both the origin and the end of events? More specifically, conceiving each of these depends upon the intrinsic knowledge-relation, insofar as His knowledge of Himself within Himself adds nothing to His essence; through it He knows His unity. Without this, unity from every aspect would not be intelligible, since otherwise Essence and attribute would constitute a multiplicity. Similarly, the necessity of existence depends—[continued p. 77].

Reading note: The first two negative statements above require contextual supplementation: the 2008 print reads والاعتبار لها, without an explicit negative. The third parallel statement explicitly reads ولا اعتبار لها. The bracketed negatives follow that parallel and the argument, not a separately collated witness.

Editorial note

This printed page contains a lengthy modern editor footnote (beginning “قال الشيخ صدر الدين القونوي...”) quoting Miftāḥ al-ghayb and polemicizing against critics. It is not part of al-Mahāʾimī’s running text and is expressly excluded. Arabic «(يتعقل وحدة الحق)» is cited by al-Mahāʾimī as a lemma from Qūnawī. Do not cite the footnote as primary testimony without separately verifying its quotation. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/76?lang=ar

Printed p. 77

Fixed entities as cognitions, without temporal emergence of divine knowledge

MSH-065 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

—upon unity. Besides, the Necessary must be perfect, and there is no perfection if knowledge is superadded [to the Essence], since one might then conceive it apart from Him. Principiality depends upon both. Furthermore, if His self-knowledge were an addition to His Essence, so that it were conceivable for Him not to know Himself, it would also be conceivable for Him not to know His own principiality.

Again, His very knowledge of Himself is the cause of His knowledge of everything. Unity, necessity, and principiality belong among the things known, and they are among His nearer concomitants: if He knows distant concomitants through His self-knowledge, He all the more knows the nearer ones. Alternatively, His self-knowledge is the cause of His knowledge of everything because it embraces His own *shuʾūn* (essential aspects), which are the realities of the fixed entities and hence of things. For things are determinations of His universal and detailed cognitions. Unity is a determination of His universal cognition of the Essence insofar as its comprehension of those aspects is not differentiated; this belongs to the first determination. Necessary existence is a determination of His universal cognition of the Essence insofar as the affairs of possible things included within it are not differentiated. Principiality is a determination of His universal cognition insofar as He is first, with no differentiation of what comes afterward within it. Detailed cognitions, however, are not conceived in that rank. Things are described as determinations of His cognitions because they do not possess independent existence; rather, existence is effused from His light upon their fixed entities, which are His cognitions, and He is qualified in respect of His manifestation in and through them, becoming determinate by them. The fixed entities are intelligible matters, nothing beyond that. Moreover, quiddities are cognitions. If unity, necessity, and principiality are existent matters they must have quiddities and cannot precede the first intrinsic cognition; otherwise they are cognitions pure and simple. Quiddities are described as cognitions because in external existent things there is nothing extraneous to existence, although we know with certainty that things are distinguishable and diverse, while existence is shared. Their distinction is therefore through quiddity. These cognitions can further be considered as arising intellectually one from another: unity arises from cognizing the Essence; necessity from cognizing the Essence and unity; and principiality from cognizing all three. They are cognitions, and their ordering arises because the later among these is a necessary concomitant of the earlier. Conceiving that upon which something depends entails conceiving its consequent; accordingly the cognition of the consequent arises from that of its prerequisite.

Therefore he [Qūnawī] said, may God be pleased with him: “[Not in the sense that they newly occur in the Real's cognition—God Most High is exalted above anything unbefitting Him—but rather the cognition of some is posterior in rank to the cognition of others. All are beginningless and everlasting cognitions, abiding in one mode; they are intelligible within knowledge, which relates to them according to what their realities require.]”

Editorial note

This is a decisive distinction between cognitive/rank succession and chronological production of divine intellections. The printed Arabic has forms «منتشية» and «تعقلات» that require collation; all have been retained in the source layer. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/77?lang=ar

Printed p. 78

Eternal cognition, temporal relations, and the differentiated within the undifferentiated

MSH-066 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Lest the foregoing suggest that the cognition that “arises” is newly produced because it comes later than that from which it arises, he removes the misunderstanding: “arising” here does not mean temporal origination, which is impossible in the Real's Essence and inseparable attributes, knowledge among them. “For abstraction is a relation, as explained in philosophy.” [The function of this printed/transcribed clause in the argument is uncertain.] What appears as origination in attributes connected with His name *the Manifest* is, in respect of existence, appearance following hiddenness; in respect of the fixed entities, it is described as being preceded by nonexistence. Posteriority in cognition is therefore only posterior **in rank**, by way of natural priority: the later requires the earlier, yet the earlier is not thereby the efficient cause of the later. Divine attributes are not caused by anything, for efficient causation concerns originated things. All these cognitions are eternal and everlasting in one invariant mode; ignorance of none of them came first. Their realities possess a natural order, however, and knowledge relates to each according to its reality. This is why we say God's knowledge of temporal events is eternal, although it relates to them as they are: He knows the past as past, the present as present, and the future as future, without any alteration in His knowledge. What changes is the relation between knowledge and its object, a relation that has no existence; therefore allowing for such a consideration in divine knowledge poses no difficulty. Understand.

He [Qūnawī] said, may God be pleased with him: “[What their realities entail is of two kinds. The first is their being cognized insofar as their multiplicity is absorbed in the Real's unity: the cognition of the differentiated within the undifferentiated. It is like a

knowing intellect's discerning, with the eye of knowledge, what one seed potentially contains of branches, leaves, and fruit, and in each individual fruit what was contained in the first seed, and so on without end.]”

Since knowledge relates to realities according to their requirements, they are sometimes apprehended together in one mode and sometimes as ordered. Their requirements have two modalities, since the unitary Essence and the realities each mirror the other. The first, in which the Essence mirrors the realities and they remain in one mode within It, is their cognition insofar as their multiplicity is absorbed in the unity of the Real: they do not appear in It as really distinguished, although they are present potentially. Their articulation is by consideration in relation to what will come afterward. This is the witnessing of the differentiated within the undifferentiated, in which the whole is contained within that perfection. But the perfection that embraces those realities is not complete [in the respect of manifestation] until existence becomes manifest in them and to them. The fixed entities, considered as such, remain nonexistent and never become manifest as fixed entities; nevertheless the Real beholds them by witnessing in knowledge, not by concrete witnessing (*shuhūd ʿaynī*). The names demand both perfections. Hence multiplicity here is by consideration, while unity is real—just as a seed includes the tree, its fruit, and the seeds within its fruit. The seed's unity is like the reality, and the multiplicity within it exists by consideration. Only—[sentence continues on p. 79].

Editorial note

A major research datum: at p78 the fixed entities «معدومة لا تظهر من حيث هي أبدا وأزلا» (“nonexistent and never manifest as such”), but this alone does not establish which *possible entities* never have manifested effects; do not overgeneralize. The p78 clause «وسمة هي معدومة» is syntactically suspect in the transcription, and the translation of its antecedent is contextual and provisional. The passage continues p79. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/78?lang=ar

Printed p. 79

Reciprocal intelligibility: multiplicity in unity and unity in multiplicity

MSH-067 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… the one who truly knows it sees the multiplicity within it; his knowledge does not change when the multiplicity comes to exist actually outside the mind. No perfection previously absent is thereby added to knowledge. Rather, the very same perfection acquires the attribute of external manifestation, so that the perfection proper to external existence may be obtained. The knower receives no increment beyond what was known at first; nevertheless, because his knowledge is realized externally, his knowledge must also relate to it as such so as to correspond to the eternal knowledge. Understand.

Qūnawī: “The other mode is to conceive the rulings of unity group after group. Each group is conceived with the quiddities it contains, which are the forms of those multiple intellections by which the one existence is made to appear multiple. This is the reverse of the first absorption mentioned: there multiplicity was absorbed in unity; here unity is absorbed in multiplicity. Know this.”

The other mode required by the realities is that the realities themselves become mirrors of the Real. Their intelligible ordering then appears, because the judgements or descriptions of the one existence are conceived insofar as it appears in these realities, although those descriptions also belonged to it in hiddenness. These judgements are conceived group by group according to natural order, even though the whole collection can be conceived at once when considered simply as divine determinations. Their order follows the order of their externally manifested quiddities. Each group is conceived together with its quiddities, which are the forms of those intellections: loci for judgements first conceived all at once and then considered repeatedly through many manifestations. Al-Mahāʾimī specifies *external* quiddities because mental quiddities have no such sequential order of apprehension except insofar as they represent external things with an ordered manifestation.

These forms, namely external quiddities, are genuinely multiple outside the mind. They make the one existence appearing within them numerically multiple *with respect to its appearances*, not as it is in itself, because those forms are many mirrors of it and its reflected forms multiply with their multiplicity. The “absorption of unity”—its hiddenness within determinate realities—is the reverse of the first absorption, in which the multiplicity of realities is absorbed in existence. This is the witnessing of the comprehensive in the detailed. There is order in this witnessing according to the times at which existence appears in each locus. Multiplicity and temporal order belong intrinsically to the external quiddities, and to mental quiddities insofar as they are capable of external realization. Unity belongs to the Real with respect to what is in the Real. Understand.

Editorial note

Precise claim: real multiplicity of exterior quiddities/manifestations without intrinsic multiplication of unqualified existence. This is not an unrestricted denial of objective diversity. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/79?lang=ar

Printed p. 80

Text Two: three modes of intrinsic demand/effusion

MSH-068 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Second text. Qūnawī: “Among the texts: know that the Real, insofar as it is unrestricted and all-encompassing, is not named by a name, assigned a judgement, or determined by a description or defining mark. Ascribing demand [*iqtiḍā’*] to it has no greater priority than ascribing non-demand, for a demand conceived or denied at that level is itself a determinate judgement and a restricted qualification.”

Having completed the discussion of unrestrictedness that is not opposed to restriction and is not confined to either member of that pair, to their conjunction, or to separateness from them, Qūnawī turns to unrestrictedness *as opposed to* restriction. This second kind of unrestrictedness is considered only before the first determination; the former kind, beyond the opposition of unrestrictedness and restriction, can be considered both before and after it. It is still characterized through the concepts of unrestrictedness and universality, as indicated by “its comprehensiveness.” Yet it cannot be given any special name, or else it would cease to be unrestricted; nor may a special judgement be attributed, such as saying that it demands fixed entities or names or does not demand them, because either exclusive description opposes its universality.

Nor is the Real determined here by an attribute such as knowledge or by a distinguishing mark such as existence or life. Therefore the ascription of an intelligibly determinate demand for names or entities is no more appropriate than that of its denial. The qualification “intelligibly conceived” matters: these possibilities are contained within the first meaning of unrestrictedness and differ from it only under a consideration. What cannot apply at the present standpoint is *demand or non-demand conceived as a distinct judgement*, not a denial that the actuality corresponding to it may be found at another rank. Thus either affirmed demand or its denial would count as a determinate judgement.

One can express it as “demanding” or “not demanding” and describe the Essence as possessing or lacking a demand; but then the particular unrestrictedness opposed to restriction would no longer remain. Demand cannot be conceived as such under the exclusion just discussed, though determination comes in an order related to it. Rather, intelligible demand depends on the scientific or knowledge-determination, and that first knowledge-determination is not brought about as a consequence of the demand: it is already embraced within unrestrictedness in its primary sense. Understand.

Qūnawī: “Know further that, although demand is intrinsic, it has three ranks. At the first rank it depends on neither a condition nor a necessitating factor producing its determination. At the second its determination depends on one condition only. At the

third the manifestation of its effects depends on conditions, causes and mediators.” Al-Mahāʾimī begins to explain that neither the attribution of demand nor non-demand has priority in essential unrestrictedness … [the transmitted wording here appears repetitive and needs collation].

Editorial note

A fresh numbered text begins p80. Online transcription’s end “نسبة اللا اقتضاء … أولى من نسبة اللا اقتضاء” repeats itself and likely contains a copy error; preserve and flag. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/80?lang=ar

Printed p. 81

Effusion without mediation, one mediation, and many conditions

MSH-069 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… but both relations are included in the Essence according to unrestrictedness in the first sense. Demand is one in essence, insofar as it is effusion without differentiation at the unrestricted level; yet its effects differ as it descends to what receives the effusion. It may arrive without mediation, through one mediator, or through many. An intermediary may be a condition or a cause. A “condition” is something that does not itself participate in bringing into existence but on which the effect depends; a “cause” in this context is a necessitating factor that does not itself exercise effective agency. Consequently, as demand and effusion descend from essential unrestrictedness they have three ranks whose rulings differ. At the first rank the relation to the recipient does not depend upon a conditioning factor or one that causes its determination, even if it depends on a genuinely effective source among the divine names and lordly names, since there is no preference within the absolutely unrestricted Essence, which needs none of the worlds. At the second rank, the *determination* of demand, though not the demand in its origin, depends on one condition alone. A cause is not specified here, since treating it as a cause would also require absence of an impediment and thus multiply mediations. At the third rank, once a determination has been established in one of the earlier ranks, the manifestation of its rulings depends on further conditions, causes and intermediaries, such as natures, corporeal forces and other things. All these classes are included to accommodate endlessly many subordinate degrees; not every effect requires all the enumerated factors. He intends to classify the rest of the ranks.

Qūnawī: “The ruling of the first demand is the essential effusion, not through a necessitating factor, nor can it be conceived in opposition to a recipient or the recipient's preparedness. The ruling of the second demand is dependence on a single existential condition, namely the First Intellect, which mediates between the Real and

those possible things that are decreed to exist until the Day of Resurrection. At the third rank, manifestation of the effect and ruling of demand depends upon diverse conditions, as is the case with other existents.”

This specifies the kinds and determinations of effusion. The first demand produces an essential effusion, expressly contrasted with a name-conditioned effusion, which necessarily works according to the reception and preparedness of fixed entities because the divine names are relations to those entities. Essential effusion does not occur through any necessitating created cause and is not conceived in relation to a pre-existing recipient and its preparedness: recipient and preparedness are themselves established through this effusion. If it depended on them, a vicious circle would follow.

Editorial note

Distinguish the condition (sharṭ), necessitating cause (sabab/mūjib), truly effecting source, and preparedness (istiʿdād); note that “First Intellect” is Qūnawī’s text as quoted. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/81?lang=ar

Printed p. 82

The Most Holy Effusion and nonexistence of unrealized possibilities

MSH-070 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Hence the first effusion does not act through a condition. This is the domain of divine choice, power equally related to the two alternatives, and will selecting one. The recipient is the fixed entity (*ʿayn thābita*); preparedness (*istiʿdād*) is its readiness to receive. This effusion is called the **Most Holy Effusion (*al-fayḍ al-aqdas*)**. The second demand yields an effusion depending on one condition, since two or more would belong to the third rank. This condition must be positive: the absence of mediation is already found at the first rank, and is not counted as another mediator. Absence of an impediment, by contrast, may be considered alongside a cause, but only where an impediment has been posited; in that case its absence is a qualified negation functioning like a positive condition, whereas otherwise it is simple non-being. The one positive condition is the First Intellect. Divine names are non-subsisting relations, and existence is the Essence considered with those relations; because they do not really differ from the Essence they are not counted as separate mediators. Other beings, being subordinate to the First Intellect, entail plurality of intermediaries. The Intellect is called a condition, not a cause, because counting it as a cause would also require the condition that no impediment be present. It mediates between the Real and the possible things whose existence has been decreed. Of the higher existents it is the most perfect, fully actual in all respects and bearing the

fewest aspects of possibility, and therefore nearest the Real. The limitation to possibles *decreed to exist* is deliberate: a possible thing that remains non-existent and has not emerged from knowledge into external being requires no mediator of its existence, precisely because it has no such existence.

The effects resulting from the second demand include the Second Intellect and Universal Soul. As for the third rank of demand, the wording is varied to clarify concisely what was meant above: the effect's appearance depends on numerous “conditions,” that is, factors of many kinds, including conditions, causes and other mediators. The word “conditions” is used broadly for whatever an effect depends upon, as in the case of the Third Intellect, the second soul, and the celestial spheres. Understand.

Qūnawī: “I do not mean by this that there are three demands differing in their realities. Rather there is one demand with three ranks, and through the aspect of each rank an effect or effects appear and become determined. Understand.” Al-Mahāʾimī forestalls the inference that there are diverse demands within the Essence itself: this would conflict with the principle, to be discussed, that one does not demand more than one from the same aspect. Accordingly, it is one demand …

Editorial note

This passage is central for unmanifest fixed possibilities: it asserts the non-existent possible does not require a mediation *in external existence* because it has not emerged into the external realm. It does NOT yet establish intrinsic impossibility of manifestation. The transcription «وأما غير العقل الأول ظن» appears corrupt; no emendation made. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/82?lang=ar

Printed p. 83

The single effusion and Text Three on knowledge as one reality with many relations

MSH-071 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… in its reality, but it differs according to its ranks, like the originating principle. It has three ranks: one at its own abiding station and two in its descent; at each rank a particular effect or several effects are manifested and determined. At the first there is the First Intellect; at the others, the effects already discussed. Qūnawī says both “appear” and “become determined” because the effects are concealed within the Essence and as yet indistinguishable; through manifestation they become distinguishable and determinate.

The universal effusion is general existence (*al-wujūd al-ʿāmm*). Al-Mahāʾimī suggests that this subtle approach can reconcile philosophers, who hold that only one proceeds from the One, with theologians, who assign all things directly to God without mediation; hence Qūnawī's admonition, “Understand.” Alternatively, one may say that the effusion is one but becomes manifold with ranks, while causes do not produce effects; they only mark out their times. God knows best.

Third text. Qūnawī: “One of the divine texts is that intrinsic, unitary knowledge is attributed multiplicity in respect of its relation to known things. Those things are apprehended only in respect of its determinations and relations.”

Having finished unrestrictedness considered as opposed to restriction, al-Mahāʾimī says Qūnawī begins the first delimitation, that of knowledge, because knowledge is the first relation. He calls this a divine text insofar as knowledge is the origin of divine names; the names together with the Essence constitute the Presence of divinity. Knowledge is termed “unitary” because it is one in the Presence of *aḥadiyya*, and “intrinsic” because it is not distinct from the Essence.

Its further ruling is that multiplicity is attributed to unitary knowledge insofar as it relates to many known things, namely the fixed entities, the realities of possibilities. In the same way, multiplicity is attributed to unrestricted, one existence by considering its appearance in numerous loci, and to demand or effusion in relation to distinct recipients, even though these remain one at their source. Intrinsic knowledge is one and encompasses everything just as the Essence encompasses it. But considered solely in relation to the Essence, it is undifferentiated or comprehensive. The many things known are apprehended in detail only through knowledge's determinations by those things, that is, through its relations to them.

Hence the fixed entities are called “forms of knowledge” and “unmade.” It would be wrong to imagine that many forms are engraved into knowledge considered as a single intrinsic reality; rather, they are imprinted under the consideration of its many determinations, arising from its relations to the entities. Those determinations are mirrors for the fixed entities. **Qūnawī:** “Its relation to each known thing follows the known thing in the condition it has in itself, whether the known thing is simple or composite, temporal or spatial, or neither temporal nor spatial, temporally bounded …”

Editorial note

The grammar of “three ranks … and two” on opening of page is unclear; report, do not “correct” to a unified cosmological model. In this section the unitary knowledge is intrinsic; pluriformity belongs to its relations. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/83?lang=ar

Printed p. 84

Immutable knowledge and changing relations; a general rule for judging

MSH-072 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): “… in receptivity and limited in its ruling and attribute, or not temporally limited and infinite in the respects we have mentioned. Know this.”

This clarifies the universality of knowledge and its encompassing everything, although no new coming-to-be or change occurs within its original unity, even when such changes occur in its relations. Knowledge's relation to each known thing follows that thing. Each known thing proceeds from the one knowledge considered in its unity; nevertheless, because knowledge's determinations concern those things, each determination follows the nature of what determines it. Thus the *relation* takes on the character of the object, while the intrinsic knowledge, which underlies the relation, stays as it is. Such characters include simplicity or composition, temporality or atemporality, spatiality or non-spatiality, eternity or its absence.

The example of a simple, temporal, spatial and bounded object is a spoken letter of the alphabet; of a simple object outside such conditions, the intellects and souls; of a composite temporal-spatial object, things generated in the sublunary world; of a composite not situated in time and space, the sphere delimiting directions [according to the author's cosmology]. Knowledge's relations receive the characteristics without intrinsic knowledge receiving them. For example, someone knows that Zayd performs an action at a specified time. Beforehand he knows that Zayd *will* do it, and at the time knows he *is* doing it. A new temporal relation appears with Zayd's action, while the knowledge that Zayd acts at that time remains one and unchanged. Similarly, a composite is known as one in its totality, but in detailed consideration its intelligibility may require prior apprehension of the parts. Understand: this is a place at which both philosophers and speculative theologians easily stumble, which is why Qūnawī says “Know this.”

Qūnawī: “Among the further deductions from the texts just mentioned is that every judgement issued by a judging agent concerning what is judged follows the condition of the judge at the very moment of judging, and follows the condition of what is judged at the time the judge judges it.” This shows that what arises from unrestrictedness is an unrestricted effusion: if the unrestrictedness is not opposed to restriction, the effusion is likewise so; otherwise it stands in opposition to restriction. Since the known thing determines the relation of knowledge, that relation follows its object. The statement is therefore a deduction from all three earlier texts.

It is also a deduction in another sense. From the first text Qūnawī had derived the intelligibility of unity, necessary existence and principiality; from the second, demands differing according to ranks; and from the third, the correspondence of knowledge's relations to the known things. He now gives a general rule suitable for all three: the judgement of every ...

Editorial note

Retain grammatical difference between intrinsic knowledge (unchanged) and its changing relation (relational, not separately subsistent). The text breaks mid-sentence on p84. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/84?lang=ar

Printed p. 85

Judgements vary with the states of judge and recipient

MSH-073 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... judging agent, whether eternal or originated, upon what is judged, whether immaterially originated or material, follows the state of the judge, for the effect must be proportionate to the agent. It is the *state*, rather than the Essence regarded solely as Essence, that is here considered, because without qualification effects stand in an equivalent relation to the Essence. The judge's state at the moment of judging is specified, since states before and after that moment are not then operative and have no such effect. The judgement also follows the state of what is judged, since the object must be capable of receiving that judgement. Again, the relevant state is its state *at the time of judgement*, since earlier and later states are not then operative. This resembles the logicians' principle that a conclusion must correspond to its two premises.

Qūnawī: “If what is judged is of a kind whose states change, the rulings of the judge concerning it will vary with each state, differing as it becomes clothed in those states. If, however, what is judged is of a kind whose state remains on a single course, the judge's ruling remains fixed according to the first relation that determined the judgement and its requirement. What remains depends also on the judge's state at the time of judgement: whether the judge is such that it changes according to its states, or such that it remains fixed while the states change. The way a judge's ruling follows these factors therefore falls under the respective present alternatives, covering all ranks of every judging agent and every object judged. No judgement or thing judged falls outside what I have described.”

Since a judgement depends on the respective states of judge and object at the time of judging, if the object passes from one condition to another, the sorts of ruling multiply. For each new condition there is a specific judgement, differing by genus,

class and other characteristics according to the object's changing situation, whether the judging agent itself remains fixed or changes. A changing agent is exemplified by an artisan in his various arts and works.

A fixed agent is exemplified by the divine names and the angels in relation to the world of generation and corruption. The judgement of a fixed agent can cease to apply to an object when the latter undergoes a change, at which point another agent comes to govern it. Hence the operations of different names and angels are associated with their appropriate times. If, on the other hand, the object naturally remains in one condition, the first judgement remains fixed according to the original relation of the judge to it. So long as the object retains that condition, the relation remains, and because the relation determines the ruling, the determinate ruling continues as well.

Editorial note

This page applies the judge/recipient rule to changes in finite agents and objects. Beware of attributing temporal change directly to the divine Essence. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/85?lang=ar

Printed p. 86

Four combinations of change and fixity; Text Four on the inseparability of knowledge from existence

MSH-074 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

A further point remains: the relation of the judge's ruling also depends on the judge's state. If the judge itself is fixed, its ruling over a stable object does not vary, as in the Real's ruling over the intellects, which are therefore fully actual eternally and perpetually [in the metaphysical account being expounded]. Where states vary, as with souls affected by many intellects, the intellects’ rulings over those souls differ even though the intellects remain fixed; hence the effusion bestowed on the souls varies. The implied answer to Qūnawī's conditional “if the judge …” is “the ruling remains fixed in one fashion”; the answer to the alternative clause is “its states become multiple.”

The statement “therefore …” sums up the preceding analysis and is meant to be exhaustive. Judgements arise from four combinations: both judge and judged remaining fixed; both changing; the judge fixed while what is judged changes; or the reverse. Qūnawī states this exhaustively because one might suppose that, even if judge and object are fixed, their judgement changes through different intermediaries. The reply is that in such a case the proximate “judge” is considered as the composite of the original agent and the mediating factor; considered without that qualification, the first agent remains judge over all. Understand.

Fourth text. Qūnawī: “Among the deductions from the texts previously mentioned is that knowledge follows existence, in the sense that wherever existence is found knowledge is found without separation.” This follows from the first text, which established that the initial relation arising from the unseen of unrestrictedness is knowledge; and from the second, which established that the First Intellect, also called the Greatest Spirit, is the intermediary between ...

Editorial note

The extended text in footnote 1 identifying the First Intellect, Supreme Pen, and Muhammadan Spirit is NOT part of al-Mahāʾimī’s main paragraph and is deliberately excluded. The Qūnawī passage begins p.86. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/86?lang=ar

Printed p. 87

All existence entails knowledge; differences of manifestation and preparedness

MSH-075 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... the Real and all existents. The third text showed that knowledge's determinations correspond to the determinations of known things. It follows that knowledge accompanies existence: since the first determination is the most comprehensive, its concomitants extend through the more particular determinations, because whatever necessarily accompanies the general also accompanies each particular falling under it, and a concomitant of a concomitant is likewise necessary. The mediation of the Intellect is grounded in spiritual affinity, for an agent and recipient must share a relevant affinity; hence the Intellect pours forth upon every spirit according to that spirit's preparedness.

Spirit is immaterial; and, as philosophy demonstrates in this account, every immaterial reality is knowing. Knowledge must relate to the known thing, which is existence itself in reality, though it is other under a certain consideration. Accordingly, the Real knows, through one knowledge, its Essence, its attributes and infinitely many things.

Thus knowledge is a concomitant of existence with equal extension. The phrase “follows” means inseparable accompaniment. All things therefore, in the sense intended here, know God, hear His command and obey Him, as illustrated by transmitted accounts of stones and earth bearing witness to the call to prayer. The verse “There is nothing but celebrates His praise, but you do not understand their glorification” (Q 17:44) is accordingly taken in its literal, not merely figurative, sense. “You do not understand” addresses those veiled from this fact, whether believers or unbelievers.

Another argument is that existents are not without immaterial powers, and every immaterial thing knows. Powers are principles of effects, and whatever acts must know that through which it acts. God says, “Does He who created not know? He is the Subtle, the All-Aware” (Q 67:14). Hence even human limbs are aware, in their fashion, of what they do and of what the heart directs toward them, although they have neither speech nor imagination. Understand.

Qūnawī: “The variation of knowledge follows the variation in how fully or deficiently a quiddity receives existence. Where existence is received more perfectly, knowledge is more perfect; knowledge is diminished in proportion to deficient reception and the predominance of the rulings of possibility over those of necessity, the reverse of what we mentioned first. Know this.” Al-Mahāʾimī supplies an objection: if knowledge invariably accompanies existence, one might expect it to be required by existence itself, whose essential requirement cannot vary with accidents. Why, then, do some things display complete knowledge, others partial knowledge, and yet others seemingly none at all—even some human beings …

Reading note: The clause about the heart is printed وبما يليها القلب; “what the heart directs toward them” renders the apparent connection, but the verb remains uncertain. The logical argument earlier on the page also prints الأعمى where the context requires الأعم, “the more general.”

Editorial note

Fourth text attributes universal knowing to existence and its different manifestations, not necessarily to conscious thought. The existential/epistemic register must be checked before comparison with panpsychism or graded consciousness. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/87?lang=ar

Printed p. 88

Degrees of cognitive manifestation and opening of Text Five

MSH-076 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… may remain ignorant of his Lord. The answer is that although knowledge accompanies existence according to a single rule—as is shown, on this account, by the governance of the bodies of the ignorant through their spirits in much the same manner as in perfected persons—the *manifestation* of knowledge varies with the manner in which existence discloses itself to particular quiddities. Each quiddity receives knowledge in the measure in which it becomes a locus of existence. Since knowledge follows existence, wherever existence manifests in the fullest fashion knowledge likewise manifests fully, and wherever its manifestation is restricted or deficient the accompanying knowledge appears deficiently as well.

Thus no knowledge ordinarily appears in inanimate things, even though, considered with respect to unrestricted existence, complete knowledge is present in their existence; this is why, according to transmitted reports, such things have spoken in the presence of perfected prophets and saints. Such saints' vision is chiefly directed to unrestricted existence within them, so that the inner, spiritual realm of the things is disclosed to them, unlike those who attend only to existence's restriction by the things' particular forms, especially those who restrict their attention to quiddity and even identify that with existence itself.

Qūnawī next indicates why knowledge is not outwardly apparent in certain things: the rulings of possibility, whose basis is nonexistence, dominate in them, and the knowledge accompanying existence is not manifest where the opposing limitation prevails. Thus spiritual powers are less manifest among minerals, greater in plants, greater still in animals, and most comprehensive in human beings. Insofar as these powers are immaterial, the rulings of necessity, a quality associated with existence, prevail within them. The greater their manifestation, the greater the outward display of knowledge, in proportion to the predominance of the rulings of necessity over those of possibility. This is the “reverse of what we mentioned first.”

His final instruction to “know this” also challenges the common claim that universal knowledge belongs exclusively to human beings and angels. Al-Mahāʾimī argues that the absence of a demonstration establishing cognition in other things is no demonstration of its absence; indeed, the restriction is contrary to the scriptural texts and to phenomena said to have been shown to prophets and saints. Moreover, the structures made by some animals, such as bees and spiders, astonish even expert geometers. How, then, can knowledge be categorically denied to them? God knows best.

Fifth text. Qūnawī: “Among the further deductions from the established texts mentioned earlier …” Al-Mahāʾimī explains that this is a deduction from the first text insofar as unrestrictedness indicated negatively is not itself directly knowable, and from the second insofar as one can come to know the disclosed truths through knowledge of the names and fixed entities lying behind them, and from …

Editorial note

This page concludes Qūnawī’s Text 4 and opens Text 5 mid-sentence; the next stage must resume on p.89 without dropping the continuation. “Necessity” refers to rulings predominating in powers, not independent necessary existence of created entities. **Online page:** https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/9637/88?lang=ar

Printed p. 89

Text Five: the criterion of the comprehensive station

MSH-P089 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

[Continuation from p. 88.] ... the third text, in respect of the ultimate scope of that relation.

Qūnawī: “Although I have indicated something of this in certain places in my books, within another matter and in its idiom, nevertheless, since I have devoted this book specifically to the *nuṣūṣ* belonging to the distinctive tastes of the station of perfection —not to the more general discourse of restricted tastes experienced by possessors of particular stations, which derive primarily from the presence of one divine name or attribute, the place of origin and spring of that particular taste—I must isolate and distinguish what pertains to the taste of the most perfect, most comprehensive station. This concerns a proposition's being established and corresponding to what God knows at the highest, fullest and most perfect degree of His knowledge, not merely its being established relative to one station rather than another or under one condition, time, or state rather than others.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Qūnawī says that he has already made oblique allusions to the subject in other works, though normally he avoids repetition even within his own books, much less in comparison with other people's books. Those allusions came in the context and language of a different experiential insight, so repeating the matter here is not unqualified repetition. Still, because the same topic has been mentioned in some way, he needs a reason to return to it. His reason is the special nature of these *nuṣūṣ*: they concern tastes appropriate to perfection in its particular and comprehensive sense, not simply to perfection in the broad sense.

Tastes ascribed to perfection in its general sense are those that, in their primary attribution, are restricted to the presence of a particular divine name or attribute, which is the source of the particular taste.

A *taste* is what is apprehended through immediate experience (*wijdān*). The qualification “primarily” is necessary because a taste also has a relation to the Essence, insofar as the names themselves depend upon and are embraced by it. Perfection is a relational designation: it may be absolute, as at the special station of perfection, or relative to a particular thing, as in its general station. Qūnawī accordingly separates the *nuṣūṣ* from other forms of knowledge. They belong to the most complete experiential station, understood as the comprehensive union of comprehensivenesses (*jamʿ al-jamʿ*), and make claims whose validity is not restricted to one determinate viewpoint ...

Editorial note

The source page ends mid-sentence, continued on printed p. 90. Note transcription has odd grammar «الحضرة اسم».

Printed p. 90

Text Five: cognition and what lies beyond its object

MSH-P090 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… to every form of unrestrictedness and every kind of experiential taste, so as to correspond to what God knows at the highest level of divine knowledge—essential knowledge, which is the fullest because it embraces the Essence and its affairs, and most perfect because it unites undifferentiated comprehension with detailed articulation. These are the matters I have discussed elsewhere under another consideration. I have not included knowledge whose verification is proper to one perspective rather than another, to one taste rather than another.

Nor have I included what holds at one station of the same person but not at another, or in one of his times and states rather than another: these are tastes corresponding to divine knowledge under some determinations but not others and rooted in one particular attribute or name. Perfect taste has three conditions: it rests on the Essence, corresponds to the highest knowledge, and is true with regard to all. A taste lacking any one of these conditions is incomplete. Understand.

Qūnawī: “Having laid down this universal introduction, we say concerning the text we intend to clarify: any object of knowledge apprehended by a person through consideration, unveiling, sensation or imagination, either together or separately—if his consideration, unveiling, sensory or imaginal apprehension does not go beyond the thing itself, after its essential constituents and universal concomitants are known—has not been fully apprehended as it deserves, nor known with genuine knowledge.” **Al-Mahāʾimī:** This is a suitable introduction because the most perfect station requires correspondence to the highest, fullest and most perfect degree of God's knowledge.

The divine knowledge has this character because it encompasses both the essential constituents and necessary concomitants of things, and what lies behind them, ascending as far as the first determination. This comprehension has been attained by him. [The antecedent of له in this compressed sentence is not explicit; the source does not state an exclusivity claim.]

The expression “any known thing” includes things that exist and things that do not. Human beings are singled out as apprehenders because in them all cognitive faculties come together; they also apprehend through themselves. By “consideration” the author means discursive reasoning and intellectual definitions; by “unveiling,” the holy faculty called inner sight, direct experience or contact with the higher assembly

of intellects, celestial souls and other immaterial beings; by “sensation,” the outer senses; and by “imagination,” one of the inner senses. These can operate jointly—two or more with respect to the same object, such as reasoning and unveiling concerning the unseen, or sensing and imagining concerning outward ...

Editorial note

Page ends mid-enumeration; continued on 91. Copy-text has «معلم» for «معلوم» in quotation; leave original and mark uncertain.

Printed p. 91

Text Five: complete knowledge, the fixed entities, and the unknowable Essence

MSH-P091 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... things, or by considering, sensing, and imagining intermediate objects such as geometrical figures. These faculties can also work individually: there are disclosures not grasped by discursive intellect, imagined things not sensed—such as a sea of mercury—and intellectual objects not reached through unveiling, such as the conjunction of contradictories. The latter is an intellectual object which unveiling can only represent through an analogy: first one imagines combining things that can coexist, then imagines opposites and transfers the pattern of combination to them. If the perceiver stops at any of these modes without apprehending what lies beyond their object, even after grasping all its essential elements (yielding a complete definition) and the universal concomitants applying across individuals and conditions (yielding a complete description), the apprehension is incomplete.

Necessary concomitants are specified because other accidents, and merely particular concomitants, do not furnish an adequate definition. The prior knowledge of essentials and concomitants is a prerequisite because it establishes knowledge in its elementary form; the perfection of that knowledge lies beyond it. An image of what is known may be impressed upon the knower, but complete apprehension requires knowing the thing's origin, end, properties and general accidents so as to correspond with what God knows at the highest level. Full knowledge also requires the knowledge of its constituent parts and states, and of the parts and states of those in turn, reaching ultimately the fixed entities and their principles. Apprehension is broader than full knowledge, for it applies to outward things where the latter's complete correspondence is absent. Understand.

Qūnawī: “It makes no difference whether what one apprehends is the world in its meanings and spirits, or in its forms and accidents, or whether it is the Real. When the true nature of the matter and the form of every known thing's determination

within the Real's knowledge are disclosed, one finds it so. Unless one's knowledge of the Real reaches His unrestrictedness and the pure unity of His true Essence—which no name determines, no attribute or judgement or description contains, and which cannot be circumscribed by witnessing, intellectual conception or any determinate thing—one does not know that there is no goal beyond God, that encompassing Him in knowledge or witnessing is impossible, and that beyond the absolutely Real Existence there is only imagined nonexistence. There is, moreover, another way, loftier, more complete and more unveiling, to know why one cannot know God in the way He knows Himself. By God's grace we have known it by taste and witnessing. But its explanation and inscription are forbidden; the utmost expression concerning it is …”

Editorial note

The wording «الجمع بين النقيضين» is reported as an intellectual thought-object, not as an ontologically possible conjunction.

Printed p. 92

Text Five: knowing the limits of knowing

MSH-P092 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… the hint just mentioned.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Complete knowledge is equally dependent on apprehending what lies beyond the object, whether the object is the cosmos or the Real. With respect to the world, its meanings are its realities and fixed entities, which cannot be properly understood apart from divine knowledge. Its spirits cannot be thoroughly known without the divine names that assume their forms. Its imaginal and sensible forms are images of spirits; and accidents attaching to any of these are not understood fully without knowing what underlies them, even if they can be defined or described.

With respect to the Real, His first determination cannot be known without knowledge of unrestrictedness. Yet at that point the consummation of knowledge is the recognition of one's inability to know Him. One knows that inability only by recognizing that beyond Him there is absolute nonexistence. No complete definition by genus and difference applies, since nothing stands above Him; nor can He be described through distinctive properties, which require determination.

Qūnawī's reference to disclosure of the “true nature” of a matter and the form of each known thing's determination in divine knowledge means that things are known only through what lies beyond them. But encompassing everything beyond them is impossible. The greatest determination that can be known is the first; yet even its complete comprehension is impossible without knowledge of the absolute, pure unity

of the Essence, the source of unity-in-itself (*aḥadiyya*) and oneness (*wāḥidiyya*). No name determines it; indeed, no attribute does, still less a name, which in conception is compounded of attribute and Essence. No judgement does, still less an attribute arising through a judgement; no defining description does, still less a judgement dependent upon conceiving it. It is not circumscribed as an object of witnessing so as to be apprehended through inner vision, nor as an intelligible object so as to be apprehended by intellect, nor is it confined within any determinate thing. Cognition can only enter where there is a determination of some kind. Without reaching this limit one does not know that no goal lies beyond God. One does not even approach the incapacity which is the limit of knowledge, still less knowledge itself; nor does one know that encompassing Him through knowledge and witnessing is impossible.

He next explains the impossibility of such encompassing knowledge by saying that beyond the true, unrestricted existence …

Editorial note

Page breaks during the argument; «العلم» and «المعرفة» are here deliberately contrasted.

Printed p. 93

Text Five: the name as qibla of a station

MSH-P093 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… there is only imagined nonexistence. Nonexistence as conceived is itself an object in the mind and thus not outside existence considered absolutely. Beyond absolute existence there is only a merely imagined “thing,” not a real object of intellection. Hence even if one could conceive the absolute in some elementary way, one could not adequately conceive its unrestrictedness; nor what an adequate understanding of it would presuppose. It follows that nothing can be known in complete perfection because knowing every thing requires knowing the Real, and knowing the Real requires knowing His unrestrictedness. Ibn ʿArabī accordingly says [verse]: “I do not know the reality of any thing; how could I know it when You are within it?” This argument establishes why one cannot know God as He knows Himself: divine knowing is not the impression of a representation of the known requiring further knowledge of its background, but His own reality being present to Him. This latter claim calls for philosophical demonstration.

The printed commentary next attributes to “Shaykh Ibn ʿArabī” the saying that there is another, unveiled way of knowing this impossibility, which may not be written down. [The wording also occurs in the Qūnawī lemma on p91; the printed attribution is retained rather than silently reassigned.] The previous words provide only a hint. Al-Mahāʾimī tentatively suggests that what we know of the Real is always His outward

aspect, never the Reality as He knows it, which is present to none but Him. Describing this without qualification could wrongly suggest that God Himself knows only an outward surface. Since outwardness and inwardness are relative to *us*, that limitation does not apply to God. God knows best.

Qūnawī: “This remains so even if the taste, knowledge acquired by its possessor, and witnessing rest on the presence of a divine name that constitutes the *qibla* of that station, and the end of his knowledge of the Real is reached there—especially insofar as the name is identical with the Named, as we have explained elsewhere. But these are relative ends. Beginnings and ends are markers of relative perfections; the matter is otherwise with respect to true perfection. God alludes to this in speaking to the most perfect of His servants: ‘And to your Lord is the final end’ [Q 53:42].”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This judgement—that the Real, and indeed anything, cannot be known with full knowledge—applies even when taste, meaning immediate experience; the knowledge attained by its possessor, meaning direct knowledge (*ʿilm ʿaynī*); and witnessing, meaning the eye of certainty thereby attained, are referred, together with the resulting station, to the presence of a name among the divine names. He considers this attribution … [continued on p. 94]. [The printed opening phrase أن الحق بلا شيء من الأشياء is corrupt; the rendering follows the universal claim explicitly stated earlier on this page.]

Editorial note

The line «حضرة الأمم» is suspicious in the online text, likely an OCR/transcription defect. The Ibn ʿArabī verse should be collated before quotation in an edition.

Printed p. 94

Text Five: station-relative attainment is not absolute knowledge

MSH-P094 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… to the presence of the name: the Essence as unrestricted cannot be an object of knowledge. He further qualifies the name as one of the divine names, because the names of the Essence, insofar as they are not other than It, likewise cannot be objects of knowledge. The Prophet alludes to this with ‘or what You have reserved for Yourself in the knowledge of the unseen with You.’ The names of lordship cannot be the final goal of the perfected, owing to the many intermediaries involved.

His expression ‘which’ stands in apposition to ‘name’. It indicates that the perfected cannot encompass all the names, since each is associated with a particular name that is his Lord: when he turns to it, he receives an answer. It is therefore the Greatest Name in his case. Accordingly, the Greatest Name varies according to persons, except

for the perfected: they receive many self-disclosures from the names and are answered through many names, without being restricted to one name rather than another.

The special name becomes the orientation of a given station; no other name discloses itself to its possessor except insofar as it falls under the scope of that name. His limit of knowing the Real is thus a limit of knowing the Essence *as disclosed through this name*. This is especially so under the consideration that the name is the Named: Essence and names coincide in reference while differing in their concepts. Knowledge of the name therefore entails knowledge of the Essence under the name's qualification.

He then qualifies his statement to set the preceding issue right: the knowledge and witnessing arising from a tasting grounded in particular divine presences of the names are endpoints relative to the lower knowledge and witnessing arising from a tasting grounded in the names of lordship and what lies below them. They are not an absolute endpoint. The unrestricted Essence has no endpoint; how, then, could knowledge of It have one? Nor does It have a beginning: beginnings and endpoints attach neither to It nor to Its unrestricted perfection. Rather, they mark relative perfections. A beginning indicates the origination of a perfection in relation to what follows, and an endpoint in relation to what precedes. How could knowledge of that which has neither beginning nor end have either? Thus one who has a beginning, though no end, cannot encompass knowledge of It.

Thus “the matter is otherwise” at the level of true, unrestricted perfection: only one whose knowledge has neither beginning nor end could encompass it. Every other knower has both and so cannot do so …

Editorial note

The numbered hadith-source marker (1) and modern source footnote have been excluded from the authorial text.

Stage 13 review: Review against the supplied Arabic: the second paragraph uses الكمل both in the initial limitation and in its later exception. No hierarchy of two differently perfected groups has been supplied to resolve this tension. The fourth paragraph concludes من له بداية ولا نهاية (‘one who has a beginning and no end’), while the following paragraph speaks of beginning and end; the distinction or possible textual fault requires verification against witnesses.

Printed p. 95

Text Five: the Muhammadan terminus and incomprehensibility

MSH-P095 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… even the most perfect of His servants, peace be upon him. God indicates this by the verse “And to your Lord is the final end” [Q 53:42]. The limit of the Prophet's knowledge of his Lord is, then, the Reality under the aspect described, not unrestrictedness as such, for unrestrictedness as such has no locus of manifestation. The encompassing Greatest Name constitutes the utmost limit of his knowledge. Understand.

Qūnawī: “God has placed another subtle, hidden point in the verse. He did not say ‘To your Lord is *your* end,’ but indicated that his end within the total range of lordship is the end of ends; beyond it lie only further detailed degrees of greater perfection, which never reach a limit or terminus.” **Al-Mahāʾimī:** The verse does not imply that the Prophet's knowledge is deficient merely because it is related to a special divine name. Rather, that name is the furthest goal that can be reached in knowledge; he is consequently the most perfect of knowers.

The verse does not say “your end” and thus leave open another terminus for someone else. It identifies his terminus within universal lordship as the utmost terminus of all divine and lordly names. Beyond his specific lordship lie only particular refinements of still greater perfection which God alone knows. The Prophet's invocation “or what You have reserved for Yourself in the knowledge of Your unseen” alludes to those details. Since they have no finite end, none but God can encompass them; nonetheless, they belong to the particular perfections of the lordship proper to the Prophet. Through his Lord he possesses unrestricted perfection in the relevant sense and occupies the end of perfections and kinds of knowledge.

Qūnawī: “The Prophet also indicated this in one of his intimate invocations: ‘I seek refuge in Your good pleasure from Your displeasure, in Your pardon from Your punishment; I seek refuge in You from You. I cannot enumerate praise of You: You are as You have praised Yourself.’ That is: I cannot attain all that is in You. Thus he combines the indication of the impossibility of encompassing with the fact that he has attained the highest limit of knowing the Real. It is as though this prayer comments on the verse just mentioned, namely …”

Editorial note

Excluded modern hadith references. Text ends mid-Qūnawī quotation, continued on p96.

Printed p. 96

Text Five: fanāʾ and baqāʾ in the Muhammadan supplication

MSH-P096 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… ‘And to your Lord is the final end’ [Q 53:42]. The Prophetic traditions contain many further indications of what we have said: whoever follows them attentively, after grasping our point, will find it plain.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: In one of his intimate invocations, the Prophet indicated what we have said: that he does not encompass the reality of knowledge, despite reaching its end of ends. He said, ‘I seek refuge in Your good pleasure from Your displeasure,’ in view of the unity of the acts, which are effects of these [attributes]. This follows the method of a demonstration of the reason why, inferring the effect from its agent. He then said, ‘I seek refuge in You from You,’ in view of the unity of the Essence, by the method of witnessing.

He then says, ‘I cannot enumerate praise of You’—[understood as] effacement in the unrestricted Essence, while indicating his lack of knowledge of It. He then says, ‘You are as You have praised Yourself’; thus he subsists through Him and through His attributes, … enraptured by Him, not through his own essence [the wording around عال، والها is uncertain].

Since the purpose of citing the prayer is to show the absence of encompassing knowledge together with attainment of the end of ends, Qūnawī explains ‘I cannot enumerate praise of You’ as ‘I cannot attain all that is in You’ in respect of unrestrictedness. Even if I subsist through You, my subsistence is not through Your unrestrictedness, but through Your determination together with its attributes. The Prophet thus combines an indication that encompassing the unrestricted Essence—even what lies below It—is impossible, since proper apprehension depends upon You [the transmitted connective wording is uncertain], with an indication that his knowledge of the Real has reached the end of ends, where he subsists through Him. Subsistence is the highest station: there neither the Real veils creation nor creation veils the Real. This differs from the station of effacement, which veils creation, and from ‘bringing-into-being’ (al-takwīn), which veils the Real [the received term requires verification].

The prayer thus resembles a commentary on the verse because the terminus of the Prophet's knowledge pertains to the Lord proper to him: he subsists through that Lord while acknowledging the impossibility of exhaustive praise. It is only *like* a commentary, because the verse by itself does not explicitly assert subsistence, nor necessarily the actual possession of the terminus. A terminus does not determine the thing terminated, unless one construes the verse as excluding what comes after it, since humanity appears capable of infinitely many further knowledges. The author

repeats the verse to avoid making his argument seem to be an explanation of another verse, such as Q 20:110 (“They do not encompass Him in knowledge”) or Q 37:180 (“Glory be to your Lord, the Lord of might …”) …

Editorial note

Modern editor’s two numbered hadith-reference notes on p.96 omitted.

Stage 13 review: Review against the supplied Arabic, without a new scan check: بالغناء is rendered as an understood reference to fanāʾ from its context, but the Arabic remains unchanged. The wording عال، والها, the connective لتوقفها عليك, and the received term التكوين remain uncertain. In particular, التكوين has not been silently changed into التلوين or paraphrased as concentration on created things.

Printed p. 97

Text Five: the Heights and the station of overview

MSH-P097 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… beyond what they ascribe [Q 37:180]. These verses show only that God cannot be encompassed; unlike the text under discussion, they do not indicate the Prophet's attainment of the end of ends in knowledge. Qūnawī mentions many indications in Prophetic reports but does not enumerate them. Most, al-Mahāʾimī suggests, appear in prayers; these should be followed up.

Qūnawī: “This station and taste have several tongues, which express them in different formulas. One of their Qurʾānic names is the [Station of] the Heights (*al-Aʿrāf*), whose men, God says, recognize everyone by their marks. This is a property of overseeing the outer boundaries, achieved by carrying knowledge of things to the point where one can survey what lies beyond them.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The point just established is that perfected prophets and saints have an endpoint in knowledge, a comprehensive experiential station. That one station is spoken of in various idioms, each expressing one aspect or taste of it. Among Qurʾānic designations is *al-Aʿrāf*, treated here as a proper designation and not merely the familiar common noun. Commentators disagree whether its inhabitants are perfect or imperfect: they have variously said prophets, angels, martyrs or the just of the Resurrection.

Other identifications include jurists and scholars; people whose deeds fall short, who are held between Paradise and the Fire until God permits them to enter Paradise; and people whose good and bad deeds are equal. The next identification is corrupt in the supplied text (بطارت خفائرهم إلى آخر الناس). Another corrupt phrase concerns fathers' approval without mothers' approval, or the reverse. Further suggestions are the children of polytheists, those who act for show, and people of the interval between prophetic missions who did not change their religion [the transition that follows is

corrupt]. The chosen interpretation is supported by God's saying that its men recognize everyone by their marks. They are called ‘men’, understood here as the perfected, and their recognition of everyone by their marks is a distinctive property of surveying the extremities of every group. This can occur only at the utmost reach of knowledge: knowledge of the things whose extremities one surveys must reach the point that affords an outlook upon what lies beyond them, so that those things are properly known to the extent of one's capacity.

The pronoun in “They have not entered it, though they long [to]” [Q 7:46] refers, in his interpretation, to the people of ...

Editorial note

The enumeration of tafsīr views is visibly corrupt in the online transcription; check a printed image. Do not treat it as an exact critical reading.

Stage 13 review: The supplied Arabic in the list of interpretations of the Heights contains uninterpretable phrases. The English marks these instead of inventing meanings for بطارت خفائرهم or attributing divine approval to one parent from an unstable text. This review does not establish their printed readings.

Printed p. 98

Text Five: maṭlaʿ and mawqif across prophetic and wayfaring registers

MSH-P098 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... Paradise. According to this reading, the people of the Heights greet them before they enter, while they are still in a state of anticipation. The words “when their eyes are turned” [Q 7:47] refer to the eyes of those destined for Paradise, before entry, and “Enter Paradise” [Q 7:49] is the speech of the people of the Heights to them after confronting the prominent people of the Fire. Other interpretations are not discussed because they lie outside the present purpose.

Qūnawī: “In the station of prophecy its tongue and name are the *maṭlaʿ*—the point of rising or outlook. As is reported of the Mother of the Book and, indeed, the mystery of each Qurʾānic verse, it has an outward face, an inward face, a limit and an outlook, extending to seven inward meanings, or according to another report to seventy. I have indicated this in my commentary on the Fātiḥa; consult it there.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The prophetic designation for this capacity to survey and disclose the higher reaches of meaning is *maṭlaʿ*: that from which the levels beneath become visible. Every verse, like the Fātiḥa, has an outward dimension accessible through language, syntax and circumstance of revelation, an inward meaning grasped by those who know realities, and a boundary: outwardly, the limits of what was

transmitted from the forebears, and inwardly, the operative principles of interpretation. The *maṭlaʿ* grants insight into the subtle indications of reality; some later writers confine it to witnessing the speaker.

A saying attributed to Jaʿfar al-Ṣādiq states that God discloses Himself to His creatures in every verse, though they are unable to endure it. Another account understands the *maṭlaʿ* as witnessing the Real in each thing under an attribute appropriate to its manifestation. The intended sense, however, is broader and more consistent with the treatise. The outlook reaches seven or, in another report, seventy inward degrees. Qūnawī points to his Fātiḥa commentary for an explanation, but al-Mahāʾimī says he could not find it to reproduce it here. **Qūnawī:** “Among the people of God its tongue and name are the *mawqif*, the halting-point that marks the end of one station and looks out upon the next.”

Editorial note

The prophetic narration about seven/seventy depths should be independently examined; editorial hadith footnote not reproduced.

Printed p. 99

Text Five: the barzakh as a station-dependent technical designation

MSH-P099 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: For seekers who turn away from everything other than God, the technical designation is *mawqif*, the position at the end of a past station and with a view toward a future one. This terminology especially belongs to travellers because its meaning changes with their changing stations; it does not apply in precisely the same way to those who have reached a comprehensiveness embracing all stations. Qūnawī places “name” before “tongue” here, but reversed the order in the prophetic register to convey that prophetic expressions disclose their meanings most directly: each such tongue has the force of a designation.

Seekers, by contrast, often place little weight on terminology; some of their utterances function as precise names and others do not. The word *mawqif* functions as a designation even though its particular reference varies from station to station. Because it is not an absolutely fixed name, Qūnawī adds “its tongue.” **Qūnawī:** “In the taste of the station of perfection, relative to any two stations, its name and tongue are the *barzakh* joining them; and relative to the special station of perfection it is the *barzakh of barzakhs*.” This is a formulation of the same taste under the all-embracing station of arrival and comprehension.

He says here ‘within the taste of the station of perfection’ to indicate that this expression signifies it directly. It has two relations: one between any two stations among those below the absolutely highest; the other concerns [the absolutely highest] and what lies only one degree below it.

Under the first relation it is the *barzakh* joining two stations: the intermediate boundary that both separates and combines, like the line between shadow and sunlight. Those who have attained perfection are not halted at a fixed stopping-point, which is why this is not simply called *mawqif*. Under the second relation the highest encompassing boundary is the *barzakh of barzakhs*, higher than all the lesser intermediaries. Some also use *barzakh* for the presence of *wāḥidiyya* and the first determination as the origin of the intermediary realities, calling it the first, greatest or most comprehensive *barzakh*.

Editorial note

The online edition contains an extended note at the end of p99 and beginning of p100 on different uses of barzakh. Its authorship is unclear in transcription; do not silently treat note as al-Mahāʾimī.

Printed p. 100

Text Six: nondetermination, identity and true unity

MSH-P100 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Text Six. Qūnawī: “A noble text whose attainment is difficult.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Having treated the outermost reach of what knowledge can relate to, Qūnawī now considers what can and cannot be apprehended. Even analogies for this theme are difficult: spiritual taste and witnessing can disclose a matter through an image corresponding to it in one respect but not in another, and even the relevant aspect of correspondence—and sometimes the very analogy—is difficult to apprehend.

Qūnawī: “The unseen of the Real's Identity (*ghayb huwiyyat al-Ḥaqq*) alludes to His unrestrictedness under the consideration of nondetermination.” **Al-Mahāʾimī:** The unseen aspect of that Identity which cannot be apprehended points to unrestrictedness in the negative sense: unrestrictedness insofar as there is no determination, not the determination of being “unrestricted” as opposed to “restricted.” That latter, qualified notion can be apprehended.

Qūnawī says ‘the unseen of the Real's Identity’ because the Identity itself can be apprehended within determinations. He says ‘allusion’ because no expression signifies it directly: expression presupposes apprehension—or, more precisely, a

linguistic convention that itself depends on apprehension. ‘Unseen’ is not a name for it that would constrain it by hiddenness; the word is introduced only to indicate that it cannot be apprehended.

Qūnawī: ‘His true unity, which effaces all considerations, names, attributes, relations and associations, consists in the Real's intellection of Himself and His apprehension of Himself insofar as He is determined. Although this determinate intellection and apprehension immediately follows the unrestrictedness indicated, in relation to the Real's determination within the intellection of every ...’

Editorial note

The first lines of printed p100 are the continuation of a modern note on barzakhs from p99; they are excluded from the authorial text and documented separately.

Printed p. 101

Text Six: the first determination and the distinction between ontological and conceptual priority

MSH-P101 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... conceiver, in every self-disclosure, it is an unrestricted determination and the most encompassing of determinations. It is the witnessing of the perfected; it is the essential self-disclosure, and to it belongs the highest station of unification.’

Al-Mahāʾimī: True divine unity has no plurality whatsoever. It effaces even conceptual considerations, and a fortiori the names, attributes, relations and connections, since each implies multiplicity. This does not entail the abolition of attributes altogether but their inclusion within the unity without distinguishing them from the Essence so qualified. It is the Real's intellection of Himself before the distinctions among act of knowing, knower and known are made. These distinctions arise through His intellection of Himself and therefore are conceptually posterior to it. It is the Real’s intellection of Himself in respect of determination as intelligible, not determination by individuation; the latter would stand much farther from unrestrictedness. Attribute-distinction presupposes attribute-intellection, which in turn presupposes intellection of the Essence; here the Essence alone is apprehended.

This intellection is true unity: the intellection itself is not intellected alongside it, let alone a knower and something known. This differs from unity considered together with the attributes, which contains a plurality of considerations. This intellection is qualified as being ‘in respect of determination’, because in respect of unrestrictedness unity has no priority over multiplicity.

He then indicates that this is the first determination: ‘This intellection’—that is, self-intellection—‘and determinate apprehension, although it immediately follows the indicated unrestrictedness’, meaning unrestrictedness in the negative sense, would properly be qualified by unrestrictedness in ordinary usage and would thus not be a determination [in that respect]. Yet it combines both: determination in relation to what precedes it, and unrestrictedness in relation to what lies beneath it. Relative to the Real's determination in the intellection of every conceiver, whether the Real or creation, in every self-disclosure, in a locus of manifestation or otherwise, it is an unrestricted determination. In combining both it gathers the determinations [the connective wording here is uncertain], and it is that to which knowledge of Him relates. Hence it is the essential self-disclosure that falls upon the Muhammadan Reality directly, and upon others through an intermediary. It cannot disclose itself in loci of manifestation: if it shines upon them, it burns them up. It appears only to His Essence in His Essence; none sees Him thus except one who has been effaced in Him and subsists through Him. To it belongs the highest station of unification, essential unification above that of attributes and intellect. Unification cannot be considered in what lies above it, since the attribution of unity has no priority there at all. Understand.

Qūnawī: “The Real's principiality (*mabdaʾiyya*) follows this determination. Principiality is the origin of considerations and the source of relations and connections, whether manifest in existence or hidden in the domain of intellections and minds.”

Editorial note

The long bracket in the online transcription is not always consistently divided between Qūnawī and commentary; check collation. Preserve this passage as the source presents it.

Stage 13 review: The first-determination discussion distinguishes negative unrestrictedness from unrestrictedness in ordinary usage. The supplied connective فهو من حيث الجمع بينهما أو جمع التعينات is unstable; the translation preserves its general contrast without claiming an established restoration. No independent print comparison was made in this review.

Printed p. 102

Text Six: second determination, necessary existence, and principiality

MSH-P102 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: The Real's being the principle of things follows the first determination: it cannot precede it, for before it all relations stand alike; nor can it simply be identical with it, for principiality is a distinct consideration requiring its own foundation.

Principiality is the origin of every consideration, since consideration presupposes some subject in which its distinctions are made. No such consideration arises prior to principiality in the account under discussion. It is therefore the wellspring of relations and connections, both those that manifest through existence's association with fixed entities and those remaining hidden in higher intellections and minds. In this way the Real is the source and terminal point of the whole series of external and mental existents: He has no other, outwardly or inwardly, first or last.

Qūnawī: “That of which one says ‘unrestricted, one, necessary existence’ is existence determined in the divine, essential relation of knowledge. The Real is called the Principle by investigators under this relation, not under another. Understand and reflect: in this text I have included for you the principle of all principles of divine knowledge. God is the guide.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The Real described as “unrestricted existence” is not the unseen of the Identity, namely unrestrictedness in the negative sense, since that is not named or restricted even by the predicate unrestricted. The same holds for calling It one or necessarily existent: those qualifications are not asserted in the aspect of sheer nondetermination. They apply when existence is determined by the divine relation of knowledge to the Essence in its detailed inclusion of names and attributes. This is the *second determination*, the degree of divinity (*ulūhiyya*) and the presence of oneness (*waḥda*), and is not identical to the first determination.

At the first determination, the Essence was known simply as itself, not yet as unrestricted existence or its opposite, as one rather than many, or as necessary. These further attributes arise in the intellection of the first determination. The Real is properly called Principle under the divine, essential cognitive relation, not under the nondifferentiating first determination or the later relation of lordship. The objection that the first determination should be the principle of the second is rejected, because the divine names are not distinguished there; hence principiality had not …

Editorial note

Explicit evidence that “unrestricted, one, necessary existence” has a specific second-determination register. P102 transcription contains «العملية» where «العلمية» may be intended; no silent emendation.

Printed p. 103

Texts Six to Eight: transition from determinations to ascent and manifestation

MSH-P103 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… appeared. It first appears at the second determination. Under another aspect even negatively unrestricted Reality is the origin of all. That is why Qūnawī says “Understand.” By “Reflect” and “I have included the principle of principles,” he draws attention to the hidden Identity, true unity as first determination, principiality as second determination, the emergence of names, attributes and considerations, their manifest and hidden relations, and the sense in which one speaks of unrestricted, one, necessary existence. These are foundational questions of the science of spiritual realization; understanding them facilitates the detailed investigations.

Text Seven. Qūnawī: “Every traveller who follows any path—provided he wins some felicity from God—has the Real as his final end. Such a traveller possesses an ascension (*miʿrāj*), and his journey is an ascent (*ʿurūj*). Understand.” **Al-Mahāʾimī:** Any traveller who follows one of the paths of the masters uprightly, and receives a felicity through disclosures of beauty, gentleness and the related names, has the Real as his end.

Such a traveller ascends away from his acts, attributes or selfhood. Ascending beyond acts brings realization of the unity of acts; ascending beyond attributes brings unity of attributes; ascending beyond the self brings essential unity. The journey is therefore a movement beyond the multiplicity entailing hidden associationism toward the light of unification. The final end is the Real, as veils are removed from His lights. Qūnawī adds “Understand” because, from another perspective, all paths ultimately return to the Real as well, though not all have the same qualification of felicity.

Text Eight. Qūnawī: ‘A noble, universal text containing clear mysteries.’ **Al-Mahāʾimī:** Having stated in the preceding text that the traveller who receives some felicity from the Real must have the Real as his final end, he now explains the cause of that felicity and its details. The mysteries discussed here are the kinds of self-disclosure in loci of manifestation, the human being as the complete locus calling for these kinds of disclosure, what follows from each self-disclosure, and that temporally originated things are not other than the Real, since He has not exerted an effect upon their realities or upon …

Editorial note

The phrase «أن الحوادث ليست غير الحق» must be read in the limited sense explicitly given by the following causal analysis; no simple numerical-identity conclusion follows.

Printed p. 104

Text Eight: the criterion of causal efficacy and essential reality

MSH-P104 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… their existences, but upon the relations of existence to the realities or their forms. Thus their multiplicity and temporal origination do not impair unification or the necessity of unrestricted existence. He also explains the effect of each upon the other, and other matters that will appear at the end of the commentary on this text. These are the great mysteries whose worth is known only to God and His people.

Qūnawī: “Know that anything described as exercising influence upon one or several things is not so described with complete propriety unless it affects the reality of the thing *insofar as it is that thing*, without conceiving the addition of some further qualification to the reality said to exercise influence or any external condition whatsoever.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This lays the groundwork for explaining why differentiated mirrors do not change the underlying reality of what appears in them. Such mirrors are therefore called causes in a figurative or qualified, not absolutely proper, sense. Strictly speaking no thing affects another thing's underlying reality in a way that could overturn unification. Even divine “influence” on things is an influence in one respect rather than in every possible respect, much less can creatures affect one another's essences without qualification. When ordinary speech calls a simple substance under several aspects, or a composite thing, an “agent,” the term can only be fully literal if the agent operates upon the affected thing's own reality considered without addition. If only an accident is affected, the language is transferred from the accident to its bearer. If the cause acts only under an added qualification, the whole qualified complex is operative, and naming a part the agent is taking a part for the whole. If an external condition is required, the purported agent is insufficient in itself, and the real explanatory unit includes the condition. Calling one element alone the cause is again an abbreviated usage.

An added qualification is singled out because it attaches to a reality only once that reality has already been constituted, and so cannot account for the very constitution of that reality. An external condition differs in the manner of its requirement. Qūnawī says “the reality described as influencing,” not simply “the influencer,” because influence is here attributed according to conventional speech rather than already granted in the stringent sense being examined.

Editorial note

Important distinction: effect on essence versus on an accident, mode, relational appearance, or externally conditioned complex. No extra-mental causation doctrine should be inferred before the subsequent qualifications.

Stage 13 review: In the final paragraph the supplied wording وإنما يعتبر انضمام القيد بالأثر (‘the addition of a qualification to the effect is considered …’) is difficult in relation to the surrounding argument. A missing negation must not be supplied without a witness; the Arabic remains unchanged.

Printed p. 105

Text Eight: causal qualification and the mirror argument

MSH-P105 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

The expression “whatever the external condition may be” prevents the objection that a condition necessarily accompanying its cause should be counted as part of the cause's essence. That inference is mistaken: even an inseparable exterior condition is not identical with the reality considered in itself. A condition merely posited in the mind, on the other hand, does not alter the objective efficacy of the agent, which operates whether or not we form the consideration. Understand.

Qūnawī: “I added these restrictions because effects are attributed to things according to their ranks or considerations concomitant with their realities, and because it is widely asserted, by theoretical thinkers and many people of spiritual taste, that every mirror, whether spiritual or sensible, has an effect upon what is reflected in it, since it returns the form of what is reflected and its image appears there according to the mirror's nature.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The conditions laid down above are intended to question ordinary causal attributions: fire is said to burn according to its rank; the First Intellect is said to produce another intellect under the aspect of necessity, a body under the aspect of possibility, and the Universal Soul through its self-knowledge. But rank, aspect and associated consideration are qualifications or conditions, so these examples do not establish an unqualified influence on a reality in itself. Qūnawī is also responding to theoretical philosophers and theologians; he specifies theoretical *reason* because that word can also be used for inner spiritual sight.

Many possessors of experiential knowledge similarly say that any mirror has a real effect on what it reflects: either a spiritual mirror, such as the fixed entities with respect to existence, or a sensible mirror, such as polished metal and water. They argue that the reflecting medium changes the appearance—straight or curved, diminished or enlarged—of the thing's form, and infer a genuine effect on the reflected reality from an effect on its representation. The pronouns in the passage specify the mirror rather than “mirrorhood” as what is alleged to act. Qūnawī will deny that alteration in the image is alteration in the thing itself.

Hence most theoreticians say that existence has become multiple through the essences and has become conditioned by these loci of manifestation after its unrestrictedness. They do not recognize that this is an effect upon the form of what is reflected, not upon its reality …

Editorial note

A complex First Intellect example is difficult in source wording; verify against the printed witness before using it as evidence for Avicennian emanation.

Printed p. 106

Text Eight: the mirror does not contain the Reality

MSH-P106 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —and form is an accident. The multiplicity and changes of accidents do not entail multiplicity or change in the essence. Moreover, the form belongs not to the essence but to its manifestation in these mirrors: it accrues to what has no essence other than the essence of the one whose form is impressed in these mirrors by facing them. He indicates this as follows.

Qūnawī: “That [the mirror exercises influence] is correct in one respect, not absolutely. Influence upon the reflected thing would only be genuine if the mirror changed its reality *as such*—which does not happen. Influence is attributed to the mirror only in the perception of someone who does not know the reality of the thing and has encountered it solely in the mirror. The mirror is not the locus of the reflected thing's reality, but of its image and certain appearances. Appearance is a relation attributed to the thing insofar as its form appears in the mirror; it is not the thing's own reality.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The claim of influence is figuratively legitimate with respect to the image attributed to its original, but false if taken as an unconditional change in the original essence. The mirror affects a likeness, which is attributed to the thing; the reality does not inhere in that likeness, although the likeness figuratively shares the reality’s name. A spectator who has seen the thing only through its reflection may infer that the original has been affected. The analogous spiritual error occurs when someone who witnesses a divine appearance in the mirror of the heart supposes that the reality of the Real has disclosed itself in that heart and imagines that what he sees is the Real. This is an error, not something realized in external reality or knowledge, except insofar as the veiled person’s apprehension is known through eternal or originated knowledge. In that respect it occurs in existence, which is the Real, like other errors.

The mirror never houses the original reality, and this is especially clear where the Real is concerned: His reality is too exalted to be disclosed or directed toward another, as established in the sciences and agreed by the great masters of unveiling. What appears is an image or similitude; likeness does not share the essential

constitution of its source, any more than a painted person on a wall possesses the essence of a living, rational human. Moreover no particular image in a heart can encompass divine disclosures, which are inexhaustible.

The mirror thus houses an image representing one appearance. But a difficulty arises: perfected masters speak of reaching the unity of all-unity, subsisting through the Real and witnessing Him. Yet what appeared to their hearts was all they witnessed.

Editorial note

The polemic against identifying one's limited apprehension with the Real belongs to al-Mahāʾimī's exposition; it is not an endorsement of literal incarnation.

English revised against print: corrected the initial claim that the image has no essence other than its original, removed the unsupported claim that the witness declares himself God, restored eternal or originated knowledge, and moved the objection's final clause to p.107. Actual printed p.106 checked; the entire Arabic body is present.

Printed p. 107

Text Eight: essential self-disclosure beyond the mirror

MSH-P107 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —if it were not His very reality, they could not say this. He answers that this language has a figurative aspect. "The thing has appeared in the mirror" refers to its image or manifestation, not to the essence itself having entered the mirror. Appearance is an attributed relation, not the original reality. An effect on that relation is not an effect on the Essence. We should not say the Real has become restricted by these loci; rather, **His appearances are qualified through them, not His Reality**.

Qūnawī: "When I say 'certain appearances,' I mean to indicate that there are distinctive essential self-disclosures (*tajalliyāt dhātiyya ikhtiṣāṣiyya*) which occur neither within a locus nor a mirror nor according to a specified rank. Whoever apprehends the Real by these disclosures witnesses the Reality *outside the mirror*, as It is, not according to a locus, rank, particular name, attribute or state, or any such qualification. Such a person knows by taste that the mirror has no effect on the Reality."

Al-Mahāʾimī: The qualified "some" implies disclosures beyond the mirrors of fixed entities, exterior beings and mental forms. These are not merely the Essence appearing to Itself within Itself; prophets and select saints also receive special essential disclosures that do not occur within created loci, fixed entities or a particular rank. Otherwise they would not be purely essential. The objection arises: how can the Essence be disclosed without a rank?

The objection continues: it has already been said that negative absoluteness cannot be apprehended. We answer: what is apprehended here is the Essence without restriction to a rank, although it has descended to ranks. It was not apprehended before descent; otherwise, how could negative absoluteness be ascribed to it? What is intended here, moreover, is before descent to created beings, their entities, and the names connected with them. One who apprehends the Real through these disclosures witnesses the reality of the original—the one whose form can be impressed in a mirror—outside the mirror, as a reality, not as present in a locus or rank.

To forestall the notion of an imaginal appearance still conditioned by a subtle mirror, Qūnawī rules out not only a specified name, attribute or spiritual state, but all such relations and additions. At that moment all are effaced in the Real.

Editorial note

Textually central to the question of how a knower can have unmediated essential disclosure without claiming conceptual comprehension of the absolute.

English revised against scan, especially the omitted negative-absoluteness objection and answer. The old rendering introduced a subsequent descent and effacement merely from attention; the source's stronger wording is restored. The opening continues p.106.

Printed p. 108

Text Eight: al-tajalliyāt al-dhātiyya al-barqiyya

MSH-P108 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: The distinctive essential disclosure outside the mirror shows by taste that the mirror exerts no influence on the Reality. If a mirror were responsible for appearance *as appearance*, every appearance would have to depend upon a mirror; but an appearance without any such mirror is possible. Mirrors therefore condition only some appearances and their accompanying qualities. If they do not alter even appearance considered in itself, still less can they alter the Reality of the one appearing.

Qūnawī: "Our master, the Imam—may God sanctify his spirit—used to call these disclosures 'lightning-like essential disclosures' (*al-tajalliyāt al-dhātiyya al-barqiyya*). At that time I did not know why he gave them that name or what he meant." He adds that they occur only for one emptied entirely of every attribute, state and ruling, whether deriving from the necessary order of divine names or the contingent order. This emptiness is absolute, corresponding to the unrestrictedness of the Real. Yet the disclosure does not remain longer than one breath, which is why it is compared to lightning.

Al-Mahāʾimī identifies Qūnawī's master as Muḥyī al-Dīn Ibn ʿArabī, the foremost practitioner of this knowledge. The “lightning” here is not merely the fleeting illumination sometimes experienced at the beginnings of unveiling: those initial flashes are disclosures through divine names, not the distinctive essential disclosure beyond all mirrors. There the Essence is with the names, but the names are not external to the Essence.

Qūnawī: “When I heard my master I did not understand the cause or meaning of calling them ‘essential’ and ‘lightning-like’.” The apparent difficulty was that “essential” had been taken as an appearance of the Essence in loci, whereas lightning-like disclosures were associated with the beginnings of the way. Why should the latter qualify the former?

Qūnawī learned the answer when the disclosure was actually granted to him. He repeats both adjectives to prevent the misconception that every divine disclosure requires complete emptiness. Disclosures of the Essence through particular names may demand emptiness from some conditions, not all. These special essential disclosures, by contrast, require complete emptiness from the states, attributes and laws of the necessary named and contingent cosmic orders, for each would serve as a veil blocking disclosure without a locus.

Qūnawī: “This emptiness is absolute.” **Al-Mahāʾimī:** That is, emptiness of self, heart, spirit, secret, and the more hidden, and of all attributes and states. It does not differ from the absoluteness of the Real—not in the negative sense [the print’s particle is unstable], but in the—

Editorial note

Do not collapse “brief” into “subjective only”: p109 expressly explains finite duration through human comprehensiveness. The source line «وما كنت أعرف يوم سماعي...» appears as bracketed dialogue with interpretative intrusion; mark collation priority.

English checked against scan and revised in two places: restored that the names are not external to the Essence, and rendered emptiness of the enumerated faculties without adding attachment. The printed إلا بالمعنى السلبي before بل بالمعنى [continued المقابل للتقييد on p.109] is unstable; the English flags the contextual interpretation. Quotation boundaries in this edition are unreliable; speaker labels remain editorial.

Printed p. 109

Text Eight: why lightning-like essential disclosure cannot endure

MSH-P109 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… opposed to restriction, not to an actual annihilation of the faculties. “Emptiness” does not mean that self, heart, spirit, secrets, qualities and states cease to exist in reality; it means they are not attended to and do not constitute obstacles. Similarly the Real's unrestrictedness does not mean an absence of attributes, which are eternally and necessarily His. Qūnawī then forestalls the assumption that perfect receptivity would cause this disclosure to continue indefinitely: “It does not remain beyond one breath; therefore it is likened to lightning.” This contrasts with some introductory illuminations which, despite beginning as flashes, may develop into a stable state.

Qūnawī: “The reason for its lack of permanence is the ruling of the comprehensive nature of human reality (*jamʿiyyat al-ḥaqīqa al-insāniyya*). Just as this comprehensiveness does not require its continuity, so too, if human comprehensiveness did not contain the emptiness and unrestrictedness that summon these disclosures, it would not comprehensively embrace every attribute and state. Its comprehensive character both establishes this disclosure and negates its permanence.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The author does not spell out explicitly why the disclosure cannot remain for two successive breaths, but it follows from what he says. Human comprehensiveness entails the possession and actualization of diverse states and attributes. When the knower is emptied for this special self-disclosure, those capacities do not cease to exist: they are temporarily unused. If this one mode persisted, the other aspects would remain unactualized; human comprehensiveness would then function as though it were not comprehensive. An objection arises: if the human being is created to be an all-embracing locus, why should an experience that temporarily suspends these capacities ever arise?

Qūnawī's answer is that comprehensiveness prevents the disclosure's indefinite continuation, not its occurrence. If humanity lacked even the possibility of this highest experience, it would fail to include the very greatest possible disclosure and would therefore be incomplete. His formulation underlines the sovereign comprehensiveness of the human constitution: what it does not in any way require cannot belong to its full manifestation. Hence “the judgement of comprehensiveness affirms it and denies its permanence.”

The emptying and unrestrictedness that attract this distinctive disclosure resemble the unrestrictedness of the Essence. The other side of comprehensiveness, however, requires the disclosure of the Essence together with …

Editorial note

Strong authorial evidence: absence of attention, not nonexistence of faculties; temporal briefness grounded in jamʿiyya. P109 ends with sentence continued p110.

All authorial body and English compared with printed p.109. No material English change required. The explanation explicitly distinguishes absence of attention from real annihilation of the faculties and preserves the objection concerning comprehensiveness. Arabic footer-free body is complete.

Printed p. 110

Text Eight: enduring effects of a momentary disclosure

MSH-P110 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… attributes. Here, although the Essence remains qualified by all of them, it is not veiled by them for a subtle instant, then is veiled by the robe of majesty. The principle that comprehensiveness establishes the disclosure but negates its permanence also implies that the several capacities need not be simultaneously active. Their successive activation is enough, especially given the renewal of creation at every instant. The comprehensive character need not be an actual aggregation of all states in a single instant; the potential for them is significant.

Qūnawī: “When God granted me this disclosure I found that it produced extraordinary effects both within me and outwardly. Among them is that, although it does not last for two breaths, it leaves in its locus attributes and knowledges which only God can enumerate.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The passage testifies to the concrete fruits of a disclosure actually received and known through immediate spiritual experience, here treated as stronger than outer sensation and discursive thought for the question at hand. Qūnawī acknowledges the divine gift in the spirit of “Speak of your Lord's blessing” [Q 93:11]. He indicates a subtle point: through spiritual experience it is as though he witnesses it now and it is with him. The extraordinary rulings are those of necessity, extraordinary in relation to the world of origination. These rulings are the lights of the disclosure upon his purified spirit: they remain upon the heart and make it spiritual, upon the soul and make it tranquil and qualified by divine character traits, and upon the body and make it obedient to God’s commands. These are some of the consequences he has in mind when he speaks of unusual effects in his inward and outward constitution.

More particularly, although the disclosure itself does not stay even for two breaths, the heart as its locus retains innumerable divine attributes and unacquired knowledges related to the Essence. During the event their manifestation was so dominant that differentiated attributes did not veil it. When its exceptional dominance ceases, the traces can continue to appear through attributes, which can coexist with

the return of ordinary modes. Connection to the highest source of knowledge exceeds what is gained by contact with the intellects or celestial rational souls; the knowledges and attributes thus left behind cannot be enumerated except by the One whose knowledge has no limit. Understand.

Qūnawī: “On the very night when I wrote this arrival [of knowledge], I came to know that one who has not tasted this witnessing is not a fitting receptacle …”

Editorial note

Separate duration of disclosure from duration of resulting states or sciences. Note «ساعة لطيفة» versus «نفس واحد» and new-creation analogy.

Compared with scan. English restores the presentness of spiritual witnessing and the specified rulings of necessity, omitted from the earlier paraphrase; also restores the Essence as the subject of veiling. Arabic body boundary complete.

Printed p. 111

Text Eight: the prophetic inheritance and language of “nothing with Him”

MSH-P111 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… for inheritance [from prophecy], nor has he understood the secret of the saying ‘I have with God a time in which none but my Lord can contain me’; nor the secret of ‘God was, and nothing was with Him’; nor the secret of God's words ‘Our command is but one, like the blink of an eye’ [Q 54:50]; nor the principiality of existentiation outside any existent time.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Qūnawī reports further, extremely rare effects of this distinctive self-disclosure, learned by him on the night of composition. Someone who has not tasted the lightning-like essential witnessing—who has not apprehended it in direct spiritual experience, indicating that the same reality is not reached by other means—does not, in the strict sense intended here, qualify for the **distinctively prophetic inheritance**. The particular inheritance of the prophets is this supreme self-disclosure; lower grades may also be received by ordinary saints.

The realities of knowledge are not disclosed as they are without this disclosure, since other sources are deficient in comparison. It is therefore not a prophetic inheritance, but an inheritance of saints or philosophers who have connected with the intellects and souls.

Without tasting this witnessing, one does not grasp the inner secret of the report “I have with God a time in which none but my Lord can contain me.” Other disclosures involve attributes or acts, which, when distinguished conceptually, are not the

unrestricted Lord in Himself. The taste of this disclosure is required for knowing that secret: one who has not tasted it has not known it through thought, reflection, or sensation, and cannot understand without it the secret that depends upon it, even if he understands its outward wording. [The printed negative particle in this sentence is unstable.]

Similarly the secret of “God was, and nothing was with Him” cannot be fully grasped without this taste. Divine attributes eternally belong to the Essence, so the mind ordinarily cannot envision a state of the Essence without their display. The recipient of a disclosure where attributes are not separately manifested can apprehend that, under the primordial consideration, nothing is “with” Him, just as under that disclosure nothing is “with” Him now. Qūnawī goes on to say that one without this witnessing cannot understand the secret ...

Editorial note

Hadith wording and attribution require verification independently of this edition; al-Mahāʾimī's doctrinal use is reported, not the hadith authenticity.

Compared with scan. English removes the unsupported softening “not necessarily” and restores the source’s categorical distinction of inheritances. The source’s ولا يشترط لمعرفته ذوق هذا التجلي appears to lack a consistent connective/negative; the contextual reading is expressly flagged. Hadith-like sayings remain citations made by the author, not independently authenticated reports.

Printed p. 112

Text Eight: fixed entities, causality and principiality outside time

MSH-P112 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

... of Q 54:50, “Our command is but one”: the divine self-disclosure under this aspect is like a single moment, “like the blink of an eye.” This is characteristic of the special essential disclosure, whereas other forms can continue for two or more instants. Even a reading of the verse as referring to the Last Day can be connected to the same principle, for the general disappearance of things under essential disclosure would be implicated. Without the taste, the matter is not known in the requisite sense.

Another effect is that one who has not tasted this disclosure does not know the principiality of origination without an existent time. Such principiality is essential self-disclosure [the print’s intervening words are defective], because origination, even essential origination, occurs in other considerations and entails a priority and posteriority resembling those within time. He repeats “know” to deny the speculative thinkers’ claim to know this in reality. He begins with inheritance because it is the first rank of this special perfection, then with the absence of any other that can contain him because this is the perfection of the heir; then “nothing with Him,” the

perfection of that absence of containment; then the unity of the command. [The printed transition to the principiality of origination is compressed.] Through this the knower descends to the station of subsistence, existing not through himself, for then he would be temporal. Understand.

Qūnawī: “Likewise one who has tasted this witnessing and has already known that fixed entities are the realities of existents, that they are not produced [as realities], that the Reality of the Real transcends making and being affected, and that there is [no] third matter apart from the Real and the fixed entities, must—if what we have said is properly established for him—know that nothing affects anything else, that things bring about their own effects in themselves, and that what are called efficacious causes and reasons are conditions for the appearance of the effects of things in themselves, not instances of one reality affecting the reality of another.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The purpose is to show that the matters mentioned—becoming an heir, having a heart encompassing his Lord, and knowing the secrets of “nothing with Him,” the unity of the command, and the principiality of origination—depend upon this special essential disclosure as plainly as this question does. One who tastes this witnessing after knowing that the fixed entities, the fixed forms of things in eternal knowledge, are the realities of existents, and that realities are not made, knows that the entities too are not made. These two premises will be explained later. The reality of the Real transcends making and influence, as all sound intellects establish. There is no third matter in the world and in things apart from the Real and the entities: these are confined to existence and realities; existence is the reality of the Real, and realities are the entities. He must therefore—

Editorial note

Not-made fixed entities ≠ independently existing entities; keep distinction between epistemic fixedness and outward existentiation. Arabic argument has several syntactic defects requiring print checking.

Compared with scan. Restored the omitted explanatory sequence and precise final continuation; removed the unsupported qualification independently subsisting fundamental. The printed ومن ثم أمر ثالث requires the bracketed [no] from the explicit following gloss وليس ... أمر ثالث; no Arabic emendation is asserted. The printed مبدئية الإيجاد دال في زمان and the transition near unity of the command are defective and marked.

Printed p. 113

Text Eight: a precise nonstandard account of causality

MSH-P113 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —know, if these premises are established for him, that nothing has an effect upon another thing. An effect would either be imposed upon the fixed entities (which are not made and do not admit essential alteration), upon the Real (which plainly does not admit alteration), or upon their conjunction. But if that conjunction is considered in its existence or its reality, the same problem recurs; if a further composite of those two is proposed, an infinite regress ensues. Nor can an effect alter the reality of the nonexistent qua nonexistent, since under that aspect it has no actual reality to receive an alteration.

The premises concerning nonalterability of the Real and nonproduction of fixed entities explain one aspect. The distinctive self-disclosure provides a further experiential insight: “things affect themselves.” The point is that unrestricted existence embraces all perfections in potential, while the determinate realities of existents are intrinsic affairs whose preparednesses call for the manifestation of their corresponding perfections. In this explanatory register, each determinate reality specifies what is disclosed from the Source in accordance with its capacity; it is this determination of preparedness that is called a thing's influencing itself. He says “if what we have said is established for him” because one may fail to accept the disclosure mentioned and suppose that no disclosure occurs except in a locus. Perfections would then depend upon loci, and the loci would affect existence’s possible perfections. Or one may believe that the entities are made and so affirm an effect upon them.

One might even suppose the divine Reality itself subject to being made and therefore altered by its loci. The objection is that denying causal influence seems sophistical: we plainly encounter causes acting upon one another. Al-Mahāʾimī replies that he does not grant that they are causes: an agent of influence requires a recipient, and once these premises are accepted there is no recipient. The differentiated affairs demand manifestations according to the preparedness of their fixed entities, yet do not independently bring these about. Their manifestations therefore require conditions, as fire latent in a stone appears after another stone strikes it.

Are those conditions then causes of appearance? They are conditions for the occasion and mode of appearing, not causes that create the underlying reality or its essential claim to manifestation. Even concerning appearance they modify its conditions or qualities rather than the bare fact of manifestation. Such conditions include necessary attributes and other things such as intellects, souls, and natures. Calling them causes is not literal. Understand these subtleties, and you will gain the treasures of realities.

Editorial note

Central disputed argument: does the differentiation of preparedness have real ground independent of the fixed entity? Preserve distinction between existence and its determinate relations.

Printed p.113 is absent from the acquired scan. English and Arabic checked against the publicly linked page-stamped transcription only. Corrected the misreading that someone who had tasted the disclosure nevertheless rejects it, restored the explicit no-recipient argument, and included necessary attributes among the enumerated conditions. No claim of visual or manuscript verification.

Printed p. 114

Text Eight: existential influx and causal relations

MSH-P114 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī: “Understand influx (*madad*) in the same way. There is nothing that supplies influx to something other than itself: it reaches from a thing's inward dimension to its outward dimension, and the luminous existential self-disclosure makes this apparent. Making apparent does not affect the underlying reality of what it manifests. Relations affect one another in the sense that some occasions give rise to others, and their ruling appears in the reality that is their origin.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: As you have learned that things’ effects do not come from another but from their inward dimension, understand their existential influx likewise. Their existence is not from another; influx reaches from a thing’s inward dimension to its outward dimension. Although nonexistent externally, it existed in eternal knowledge. That existence was inwardly its own and comes outward through its demand. Its demand does not independently bring it forth, so luminous self-disclosure—the connection of manifest existence—is a condition. This disclosure’s manifestation does not affect the reality of the existence it manifests, since that reality was already obtained inwardly for the fixed entities. Do not object that disclosure, a relation, affects manifestation, another relation, and thus there is real influence. Some relations affect others only in the sense that one causes another to arise in the intellect, so that its ruling appears in the reality that is its source. The ruling becomes an attribute of that reality. Neither the reality as such nor the relation as such is affected; their manifestation presupposes their establishment in their source. Understand.

Qūnawī: “Among the things known by one who tastes this disclosure is that fixed entities, insofar as they are mirrors, have no effect on the divine existential self-disclosure except through the appearance of the multiplicity [latent] in the unseen of that disclosure. This is an effect on the relation of manifestation belonging to what conditions manifestation. The Real is too exalted to be affected by another; the realities of created things, insofar as they are their own realities, are also above such

alteration, since under this aspect in the taste of perfection they are the very affairs of the Real. Nothing other than them can alter them. Thus no mirror *as a mirror* affects the reality reflected in it, for the reasons already explained.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The exact question of the fixed entities' diversification as mirrors of existential self-disclosure is a further point not established by the prior account, which dealt specifically with the alleged effects of mirrors ...

Editorial note

On p114 the line «(1) أي التجلي البرقي...» is a modern printed editor's footnote: omitted from authorial text. The notion of “from within” is not independent creaturely existentiation.

Printed p.114 is absent from the acquired scan. Review is against the public page-stamped transcription only. English restores the original identity argument about inward existence and removes the unsupported “separate created stock” qualification. The transcription reads التعدد الكامل; [latent] follows the explicit explanatory الكامن on p.115 and is marked as interpretation, not scan-verified Arabic. This page’s final gloss continues p.115.

Printed p. 115

Text Eight: neither mirrors nor appearances alter the relevant intrinsic realities

MSH-P115 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

[Continued from the prior page.] The preceding account concerned what happens to the reflected image, the purported efficacy of mirrors upon the effects of things, and the influxes to them. Qūnawī singles out the matter because the contrary opinion is widespread: namely, that the fixed entities, in acting as mirrors for existential self-disclosure, multiply the one existence and make it many, thus exerting an effect upon its multiplication; and that the Real exerts an effect upon these entities by manifesting them after they had remained concealed in nonexistence.

Al-Mahāʾimī: One who has witnessed the Real apart from a locus of manifestation knows His perfection to be unrestricted by either unity or plurality. Although unity is the first determination, at that rank it is not simply opposed to plurality: its aspect predominates and plurality remains concealed. The fixed entities do not affect the one existential disclosure by producing plurality in it. Rather, they occasion the manifestation of a multiplicity that was hidden and subordinate within that disclosure. When disclosure is referred to the entities considered under their multiple aspects, the relations of manifestation multiply. It is under this relational consideration that the apparently singular disclosure is described as multiple. Likewise the Real does not alter the entities' very realities through a new plurality.

Their relation to the one existential disclosure is a condition for showing the conceptual multiplicity already pertinent to their determination, not a real change impressed upon their essences.

He argues for both assertions. First, if mirrors truly caused a modification of the disclosure, the Real would be acted upon by another. Yet the primordial unitary disclosure pertains to the divine station, whose necessary character precludes being affected by what is other, whether in essence or essential properties. Were there no ground for plurality in the relevant rank, it could not be brought forth simply by the mirrors. Second, if the entities' realities were themselves altered through disclosure, this would amount to a change in the states of the divine Essence, since the entities, before manifestation, are understood as its eternal affairs (*shuʾūn*). Such affairs cannot be affected from without. Through the relation of the unitary disclosure to them, their conceptual multiplicity appears and becomes real. Therefore the mirror, whether identified with the Real or with creation, does not as mirror causally alter the reality of what appears in it. Its role is conditional and relational, not real influence. As explained, influence would be real if a thing affected another’s reality without the addition of a condition. God knows best.

Qūnawī (continuing onto the next page): “Understand this text, then, and reflect upon it …”

Editorial note

The source uses compressed and occasionally inconsistent pronouns. Distinguish pre-existing *iʿtibārī* plurality from extrinsic efficacious change; do not interpret denial of alteration as denial of all manifested difference.

Entire page compared with scan. English retained with two restorations: the printed assertion that conceptual multiplicity becomes real, and the final definition of real influence without an added condition. The p.114 continuation and the p.116 opening remain aligned.

Printed p. 116

Text Eight concludes; Text Nine begins with general rules about manifestation

MSH-P116 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī, completing Text Eight: “For I have placed in it precious sciences and secrets whose worth only God can measure. This is the truth of certainty (*ḥaqq al-yaqīn*) and an unambiguous text. Whatever you hear that differs from it, even if correct, is correct in a relative sense. This is the explicit truth beyond doubt, and God is the one who guides and directs.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Among these precious sciences are the lightning-like essential disclosure; the fact that disclosure in loci does not restrict the One disclosed; His abiding transcendence from contingent events despite His appearance within them; the absence of a causal effect from one intrinsic reality upon another in a fashion that would vitiate unity; the manner in which things' effects are understood in relation to their own realities; the perfection of the human being, its connection with the special disclosure, the latter's cessation, and the benefits that remain. There are also the secrets of prophetic inheritance and capaciousness of the heart, “God was and nothing was with Him,” “Our command is but one” (Q 54:50), and the principiality of origination [without] an existent time.

He calls this “the truth of certainty” because in it the Real does not veil creation, nor creation the Real: the effect of each thing is ascribed to it, yet there is no effect except God’s, and He is not other than them. It is the clarifying definitive text, bringing one to the station of subsistence, with distinction alongside pure divine unity. Formulations that attribute effects to God alone, or alternatively to creatures, are not simply false: action belongs to existence, but becomes manifest through their forms, so each attribution corresponds to one aspect while failing to express the full relation. Apparent difficulties can arise in either direction. This is the explicit truth that excludes doubts. God directs one to the realization of this station, correct without qualification because both revealed law and decree are realized through it, and guides one to understand and follow it through His favour and generosity.

Text Nine — Qūnawī: “Among the universal texts are some I recorded in my *Miftāḥ ghayb al-jamʿ wa-tafṣīlih* and in other books I composed, not by adopting the words of anyone else, since that is not my practice. God has safeguarded me against it and through His particular lofty gift made me independent of external, lower borrowings. Yet since this book is devoted to these texts, I must include those texts here also.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Having explained disclosure in loci and without them, and the way in which neither locus nor appearance truly alters the other except under a figurative or relative attribution, Qūnawī now turns to another rule ...

Editorial note

Qūnawī’s *Miftāḥ* title and quoted material need comparison with independent textual witness; transmitted saying about divine pre-eternity is not independently authenticated here.

Compared with scan. The print reads مبدئية الإيجاد في زمان موجود, unlike the explicit لا في زمان موجود on p.111; [without] marks the contextual correction. Restored the omitted “He is not other than them,” the final prayer, and the distinction of certainty from relative correctness. Text Nine begins on this page as in the print.

Printed p. 117

Text Nine: causality of multiplicity becomes manifest only in a viewed locus

MSH-P117 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

[Continued explanation of Text Nine.] The new universal propositions concern the principle that disclosures of the aspect of being a source of many things appear only through loci, and the precise sphere in which their figurative effects can be spoken of. They are universal because each is applicable throughout its particulars, although they develop matters already discussed.

The plural “texts” is appropriate even if there are only two main formulations, since a plural may cover more than one; indeed, the final one contains numerous distinct implications. The reason for repeating earlier formulations is the present work's intention to gather these texts comprehensively. Qūnawī emphasizes that he presents what was originally disclosed to him rather than borrowed from others. Al-Mahāʾimī explains the inferior “external borrowings” as kinds of weakness associated with natural veils in the human descent, which obstruct actualization of intelligible knowledge. He says that his protection from them comes through the special gifts of the disclosures mentioned. “Made me independent” indicates that independence from imitation comes only through these special gifts; otherwise one must imitate the shaykhs. [The print varies between expressions resembling gifts and forms, and has التعليل where the contrast suggests التقليد.]

Qūnawī: “Among them I say: everything that is a cause of the existence of multiplicity and of a multitude cannot, precisely insofar as it is such a cause, become determinate through appearance or present itself to a viewer except in something viewed.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Both the abstract “multiplicity” and its many members are specified to signal their real correlation; what counts as one under one aspect, such as the human person, may count as manifold by consideration of all that it comprehends. The qualification “insofar as it is a cause” matters. The intelligible possibility or eternal knowledge of multiplicity needs no external locus. The Real may disclose Himself without any locus; yet His determination *as source of multiplicity* cannot become articulated except in a corresponding object of manifestation. This does not mean that the divine Essence acquires a determination within itself. The detailed display of multiplicity requires mirrors such as the divine names and attributes, intellects, souls, and the remaining levels.

This holds when the Real is spoken of as seeing Himself precisely as the cause of plurality: a determinate vision of actual plurality requires those particular loci. He may know His power to cause plurality without them, but the detailed appearance *qua actual plurality* is conditioned by their presence. Likewise this aspect cannot appear to a creaturely viewer precisely insofar as …

Editorial note

The final clause continues on printed p118. “Cause” is restricted by *min ḥaythu huwa kadhālika*, not ascribed simpliciter to the absolute Essence.

Full page compared with scan. English revised to restore the commentator’s positive insistence on following the shaykhs in the absence of special gifts, rather than merely contrasting disclosure with imitation. The printed الهيبات/الهيئات and التعليل are textually unstable in this explanation, and the interpretation is marked; Arabic is retained.

Printed p. 118

Text Nine: intrinsic production, extrinsic conditions, and modes of causality

MSH-P118 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

[Text Nine continued.] The Real cannot display His character as cause of the existence of multiplicity to a servant except through an object of contemplation, because His disclosure without a locus entails the total withdrawal from attention to multiplicity. The two perspectives are thus not conflated.

Qūnawī: “Another [universal text] is that no thing produces or brings forth what is contrary to itself or what differs essentially from it, however numerous the classes and kinds of production—intelligible, spiritual, imaginal, imaginative, sensory, and natural. This applies universally to everything called the source of one or more things, or a productive root. But it possesses this description only when considered in respect of what it is in itself, and under another hidden consideration accessible to only a few accomplished investigators.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Nothing proceeds from a thing intentionally, nor does it bear fruit [without] intention, that is its contrary—what stands at the furthest extreme of difference—or is distinct from it in a way preventing either from being predicated of the other. This applies to every genus and form of production: immaterial meanings; spirits and souls; imaginal objects occurring in the separate imaginative domain; bodies and their sensory features; and bodily natural faculties. The rule ranges over special angels appointed to particular tasks, human beings engaged in many activities, and the elements and their generated results, including minerals, plants and animals. A proportion or suitability (*munāsaba*) must subsist between agent and recipient.

But the restriction is decisive: the rule concerns a thing conceived *in respect of itself alone*. With the addition of a further factor, a relation of suitability may arise that was not found in the isolated subject. That is why products fall into such different kinds. Qūnawī also says that there is another, obscure consideration, understood by very few realizers. Al-Mahāʾimī expressly states that he is not one of those who have

penetrated it. He conjectures that the additional factor too may require what differs from that opposite or those like things [the printed wording is difficult]. Each thing has a particular Lord, with a manifestation and self-disclosure at a particular time; nothing contrary to its particular object of lordship can come from it. Understand. The suggestion remains explicitly conjectural.

Qūnawī (continuing): “Where something appears contrary to what we have set out, that comes about only through some condition or conditions extrinsic to the thing's essence and according to them and the relational configuration arising from their conjunction, namely …”

Editorial note

Al-Mahāʾimī explicitly says «ولست منهم»—he does not claim realization of Qūnawī’s hidden perspective. This is a key index of epistemic qualification.

Compared with scan. Restored the contrast of intentional proceeding and [unintentional] fruition; the printed إلى قصد is read from the explicit غير قصد on p.120, so the repair is bracketed. The conjecture concerning the additional factor is translated more fully and its difficult wording marked.

Printed p. 119

Text Nine: conditional causal wholes and the impossibility of perfect reproduction

MSH-P119 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (completing the preceding sentence): “… the conjunction of the reality described as a source with external conditions and considerations, and the rules of the rank in which that conjunction becomes determined. ‘Each acts according to its own configuration’” (Q 17:84).

Al-Mahāʾimī: The objection that a contrary or alien result can evidently arise from a thing misses the qualification already stipulated. Such a result is prohibited only when the thing is considered strictly as it is in itself, without further contributing conditions. For example, the universal soul may be described as proceeding from the Real with the first intellect as its condition, or the various lower ranks with a multiplicity of such conditions. Contrary or disparate products arise in virtue of those extrinsic conditions, of the resulting relational configuration, of considerations belonging to essence or conditions, and of the governing properties of the particular rank established by their combination. The source does not require a merely sensory arrangement; a nonmaterial conjunction may also be operative. Hence agency is predicated of the relevant whole, whose several constituent principles each operate according to their specific character. The citation of Q 17:84 functions both as allusion and as support for this account.

Qūnawī: “Nor does any thing produce its own identical reality, or anything resembling it in every respect. That would entail that existence had come about twice, appearing within one and the same reality, at one and the same rank, from one and the same aspect, and in one and the same arrangement. This would be obtaining what is already obtained, which is impossible because it has no benefit and amounts to futility; the true, wise and knowing Agent is exalted above a futile act. There must therefore be a difference between roots and what they bring forth.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: He begins what amounts to a third proposition. Just as a thing considered in itself does not produce its own opposite or an alien reality, so it does not produce itself again or something wholly similar in every relevant aspect—reality, level, respect, configuration, time, place and accompanying determinations.

Editorial note

The printed marginal note «(1) خليقته وملكته : أي...» is a modern editorial footnote in the transcription; not reproduced as authorial content. Translation of Q 17:84 is contextual rather than exhaustive.

Entire page compared with scan. Body English retained apart from restoring the opening of the final gloss, what amounts to a third proposition. Removed the prior inline editorial note and forward-looking sentence from translated authorial prose. The actual modern footnote below the rule is excluded from Arabic body.

Printed p. 120

Text Nine: a single effusion, inexhaustible possibilities, no identical repeated disclosure

MSH-P120 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: Qūnawī first says “nor does it bring forth,” suggesting that what does not arise even apart from deliberate intention cannot arise simply through intention, and adds “nor does it appear,” to forestall the supposition that a mirror can reproduce an identical thing or a likeness in absolutely every respect. His assertion that existence would thereby “have come about” is interpreted in the special sense of *appearing*, not as saying that existence itself began in time: the earlier demonstration treated existence as intrinsically necessary. He uses the idiom “obtaining what is already obtained” to capture the impossibility of an exact duplicate manifestation at the same reality, rank, aspect and arrangement.

These conditions must be distinguished. Two different specific realities—a horse and a cow, for example—can share the animal rank, while differing essentially. A reality at one rank can appear under different accidental aspects. An overall arrangement (*nasaq*) is different from any one isolated aspect. Reproducing a thing identical to

itself in all these respects would be trivially impossible; producing what resembles it in *every* respect would amount to precisely the same claim, since any real personal difference would already break complete likeness.

The impossibility is explained not as ordinary logical duplication of an already existing acquisition, but as the purposelessness of absolute repetition in divine manifestation. This is impossible for the true Agent, because what is false does not concern Him; the wise Agent, because one who is not wise may act in vain; and the knowing Agent, because another may do so through ignorance. There must therefore be some difference between roots and their fruits. Understand.

Qūnawī: “The possible things are without limit, whereas the effusion from the Real, the root of all roots, is one. Therefore there is no repetition in existence for anyone who understands what we have said. Understand. Hence the realizers say that the Real, glorified and exalted, has never disclosed Himself twice in one and the same form to one person, nor [in an entirely identical form] to two persons. Some distinction from one aspect or several aspects is inevitable, as I have already indicated. Understand, and God is the guide.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This is another argument against obtaining what is already obtained, understood as manifestation. He makes it clear through two further considerations. First: possible things are without end, as commonly accepted, and each requires a manifestation. If manifestation were repeated, it would exceed the infinite. If each manifestation were set against a possible thing, then, if the possible things did not come to an end before—

Editorial note

Important to distinguish a conceptual claim against exact repetition from a physical theorem about events. The proof invoking infinity continues on p121 and must be read together with it.

Compared with scan. Restored the author’s separate explanations of true, wise, and knowing, and translated the infinity argument directly rather than replacing it with a neutral summary. That historical argument is reported as the commentator’s reasoning, not validated as modern set theory. The final sentence continues p.121.

Printed p. 121

Text Ten begins: negative unrestrictedness and the first principle of determinations

MSH-P121 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —manifestations, the lesser would equal the greater. If the possible things came to an end, they would be finite, and manifestations would exceed them by a determinate amount and also come to an end. Thus the infinite, indeed what exceeds it, would be finite. This is the proof by correspondence against an infinite regress.

Second: the effusion from the Real Most High is one, and what is one does not have two appearances in a single mirror. Once these two premises are known and conceded, there is no repetition in existence.

For this reason the realizers, among them Abū Ṭālib al-Makkī and his followers, say that the Real—glorified and exalted—has never disclosed Himself twice in one form to one person. Otherwise the effusion would be multiple, since it would necessarily appear twice in one mirror in one state; but one thing cannot appear multiply in a single mirror in a single state. Nor does He disclose Himself in one form to two persons. Possible things could, as a matter of possibility, be finite, but their infinitude is necessary. Otherwise the second person could repeat the first, and similarly with other possible things; what has not appeared cannot appear in relation to eternal knowledge, so possible things would be finite. This argument is persuasive, as is the practice of the shaykhs. Accordingly, two disclosures must differ in some respect—at least numerically—or in several respects through differences in essential features, accidents, or both together. If repetition among possible things is impossible, its impossibility between the Real and what appears from Him follows all the more. Understand this station, so that you may know that disclosures are infinite and mutually dissimilar, that the Real resembles nothing in which He discloses Himself, and why the shaykhs' unveilings differ. God guides you to know them.

Text Ten — Qūnawī: "Know that, since no attribute or name can be ascribed to the Real under His unrestrictedness, nor any ruling—negative or affirmative—passed upon Him, we understand that attributes, names and judgements are applied or attributed to Him only under determinations. Since it has become clear that every plurality, whether existent or mentally conceived, must be preceded by a unity, the determinations in virtue of which names, attributes and judgements are attributed to the Real must be preceded by a determination that is the principle and source of all determinations. Beyond that is only pure unrestrictedness, which is a negative matter entailing the negation—"

Editorial note

Exclude the printed editorial note citing al-Kāshānī's *Laṭāʾif al-aʿlām*. The regress proof is explicitly characterized as persuasive, not a strict philosophical demonstration.

Full page compared with print. Corrected electronic متعلقة to printed متعقلة (also explicitly glossed as existence in the mind on p.122). Restored the actual proof-by-correspondence argument and the full nonrepetition argument without substituting a modern summary; the historical reasoning is reported, not validated. The opening completes p.120. Modern editorial footnote excluded.

Printed p. 122

Text Ten: unrestricted Essence versus the first determinate basis of names

MSH-P122 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (completing Text Ten's opening proposition): "… qualities, judgements, determinations and considerations from the innermost reality of His Essence—exclusion of confinement or enclosure in any attribute, name, determination or anything else we have enumerated or referred to collectively."

Al-Mahāʾimī: After establishing that roots and fruits cannot be altogether identical, Qūnawī explains differences in their proximity and remoteness according to the fewer or greater mediations involved, and the gifts, recipients and governing rules connected with those mediations. The necessary preliminary is that the Real, when considered under *negative unrestrictedness*, cannot have a predicate, name or ruling ascribed to Him. An attribute is described here as what belongs to an essence, and a name as an essence qualified by an attribute; examples of rulings include life, knowledge and power. Even affirmative and negative judgements of this kind require a determinate respect.

Thus attributes, divine names and their judgements are not predicated of pure unrestrictedness through *ḥaml al-muwāṭaʾa*, nor ascribed through *ḥaml al-ishtiqāq*, except insofar as determinations furnish the appropriate basis.

Because any plurality—whether externally existent or mentally conceived—is understood to presuppose unity, the many determinations presuppose a prior determination that serves as their common principle and source. This determination is called the Principle because there is no distinction there between "principle" and "principle" [the print repeats the word]. He does **not** identify this principle with the absolute Essence under purely negative unrestrictedness. Pure unrestrictedness excludes qualities, determinations and their governing rulings and so is not itself the next determinate source in the explanatory sequence. When determinations are ordered, their corresponding names and attributes are ordered as dependent branches. Qūnawī's stress on nonrestriction forestalls the notion that the Absolute already contains these determinations as a differentiated series without any mediating principle.

Qūnawī (beginning a new qualification): “Those of sound intellect, even if they lack veridical unveiling, may consider the order of the attributes and names. If they cannot conceive names or attributes beyond …”

Editorial note

This passage directly distinguishes an absolute negative consideration from principial determination; not a numerical transition inside a changing divine Essence. Al-Mahāʾimī invokes two logical forms of predication: ḥaml al-muwāṭaʾa and ḥaml al-ishtiqāq.

Entire page compared with scan. Corrected the electronic metathesis متعلقة to printed متعقلة. Restored the omitted sentence that calls the determination a principle; the print repeats المبدأ والمبدأ and no conjectural Arabic emendation is adopted. Removed a modern explanatory aside from translated authorial prose. The modes of predication remain explicitly distinguished.

Printed p. 123

Text Ten: rational order of divine names, non-temporal priority, and divine gifts

MSH-P123 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continued): “—what they have conceived and their intellectual apprehensions have reached, those names are essential relative to them. Their realities furnish an inference in the phase of theoretical reason, while veiled, because their ruling is comprehensive, the other attributes and names depend upon them, and the determination of what follows depends upon them.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This guides the veiled theologians who deny the ordering of the subsequent names, namely the attributes of acts. Shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan al-Ashʿarī said that these are originated relations ordered after the eternal attributes. If they cannot conceive names and attributes beyond what they have conceived and assert the [eternity] of all of them, even attributes of acts, as the Ḥanafīs do [the print instead reads “nonexistence”], we say: what is prior is the attributes of the Essence relative to attributes of acts. This is inferred from the comprehensive ruling of the essential attributes and the dependence of the others, the attributes of acts, upon them. The determination of the attributes of acts that follow the essential attributes depends upon these in accordance with their realities. Those realities indicate that some are comprehensive and are followed, so the rest depend upon them, whereas others are not. One in the phase of theoretical reason, which is veiling, understands this indication. The qualification is made because those of unveiling do not need it. The clause concerning dependence explains the preceding clause concerning subordination. This dependence and subordination are not temporal: all are eternally

beginningless, meaning not preceded by nonexistence. They are ordered through needing what precedes them. This is essential origination, which the theologians do not affirm. Understand.

Qūnawī: “From this rule one can understand essential and nominal divine gifts. Every gift and good reaching creation from the Real is either an essential gift, a nominal gift, or one combining the Essence and the names.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: He now begins the intended subject. He makes all the gifts divine because they do not relate to the unrestricted Essence. He explains them as goods reaching creation from the Real, excluding pure evil, which, even if it occurred, would not be called a gift. Likewise, what reaches the attributes or fixed entities from the Essence of the Real is not called this, because giving implies prior nonexistence. He first divides gifts into essential and nominal: a gift whose principle is the Essence [without] considering a particular name is essential. We impose this qualification because a mediation is necessary: the Essence as such is independent of—

Editorial note

Historical attribution to Ashʿarī and Ḥanafīs is al-Mahāʾimī’s report, not a verified ecumenical summary. Distinguish ḥudūth dhātī from temporal origination; the continuation of “gift” categories follows p124.

Full page compared with print. The print indeed reads بعدم كلها in the attribution to the Ḥanafīs; the contextual rendering [eternity] is an explicit conjecture for بقدم, not a verified school doctrine or manuscript reading. The modern warning about historical ascriptions has been moved out of the translated prose into this note. The print من اعتبار اسم معين lacks an explicit negative; [without] is supported by the division on p.124. Restored exact final continuation into العالمين on p.124. No Arabic conjecture imposed.

Printed p. 124

Text Ten: essential, nominal and mixed gifts; unreckoned and reckoned bestowal

MSH-P124 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing Text Ten): —the worlds. A gift considered in this way is essential, and one considered through a particular name is nominal. A more detailed threefold division turns on the aspect that predominates: where the aspect of necessity prevails, the gift is designated essential; where the aspect of possibility prevails, nominal; where the two are balanced or nearly balanced, a composite gift pertaining jointly to Essence and names. Understand.

Qūnawī: “As for essential gifts, no reckoning applies to them, and their determinations cannot be fixed or encompassed by a number. As for nominal gifts and those ascribed jointly to the Essence and the names, either their relation to the

Presence of the Essence is stronger and more complete than their relation to the Presence of names and attributes, or the reverse. When the relation to names and attributes predominates, reckoning is applied to them—difficult or easy—according to what predominates and what is subordinated. Here lies a great secret that cannot be divulged. If, however, the result of that predominance is a stronger relation of those gifts to the Presence of the Essence, this is the kind without reckoning, because essential giving and what is more strongly related to it are both issued and received only through an essential correspondence. Nothing else makes such giving necessary.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The rule explains the results attending the respective gifts. Essential giving is not subject to numerical enumeration because it is founded on an essential correspondence between giving and reception; its forms and qualities are not bounded, just as disclosures of the Essence are inexhaustible. Nominal and mixed gifts may incline toward the Essence or toward particular names. If an individuating name governs, the relevant individual instances, duration and conditions have determinate bounds: each name has a specified domain of authority and of what and when it governs. In this register, reckoning may be difficult, involving punishment, or easy, involving reward. He cites Q 84:7–9: whoever receives his record in his right hand “will be called to an easy reckoning” and return joyfully to his people. He says “according to predominance and subordination” to reject the supposition that some names entail—

Editorial note

There is a likely duplicated clause «فإن غلبت نسبتها... أو بالعكس» in the digital Arabic: retain as transmitted, record as possible editorial duplication. Do not turn relative predominance into an absolute division of the Essence.

Entire page compared with scan. Corrected the mistaken attachment of the opening العالمين to the source of gifts: it completes the Essence’s independence of the worlds on p.123. Removed an unmarked interpretive aside from authorial prose and restored the exact final continuation. The lemma contains a duplicated clause concerning predominance of the names; English translates that clause once, and this omission of repetition is explicitly recorded. Arabic preserves the print’s duplication.

Printed p. 125

Text Ten: reckoning, essential correspondence, mercy and scriptural proofs

MSH-P125 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continued): ... reckoning while others do not. He emphasizes this because he is certain of it, and speaks of a great secret that cannot be divulged. Its explanation is that the names return to the Essence. Thus reckoning, even when

difficult under some names, returns to that in which there is no reckoning: mercy, even if it takes the form of punishment. Since punishment is His judgment, it bears a rational appropriateness to their acts, and it contains a perfection of wisdom in which one takes pleasure as regards intellect, although one suffers as regards nature.

Perhaps in the next world intellect will predominate in them over nature. Moreover, the disclosures to those undergoing punishment must be disclosures of the names; their punishment must therefore come to an end in some respect, namely the one we have described. Shaykh Muḥyī al-Dīn explicitly stated this. This relation has already been discussed because of its frequent occurrence in reality. If the outcome—that is, the effect of the prevailing and subordinated aspects—is a strong relation of those gifts to the Presence of the Essence, the expression used indicates that this outcome necessarily follows, just as the conclusion follows from a sound syllogism. This differs from relation to the names, which is not necessary, since it may change.

‘That, then, is what [has no reckoning]’ uses a restrictive construction to indicate that, of these two classes, absence of reckoning belongs exclusively to this one. Had this restrictive formula been used of the essential gifts [mentioned first], it would have suggested that reckoning is necessary for everything else, including this class.

He then gives the reason for absence of reckoning in both places: ‘Because essential gifts’—those mentioned first—and what has a stronger relation to them, this last class, issue from the agent and are received by the recipient only through an essential correspondence in both. What belongs essentially never ceases or comes to a halt. This pertains specifically to mercy, since mercy's relation to the Essence precedes wrath's relation. Because the aspect of the names is evident in the last class, one might suppose that it is without reckoning from the side of the Essence but subject to reckoning from the side of the names. He rejects this: nothing necessitates the gifts except that correspondence; the subordinated aspect has no effect. Understand.

Qūnawī: ‘Whoever does not know this foundation does not know the reality of God's saying, “God provides for whom He wills without reckoning” [Q 2:212], nor the secret of His saying, “This is Our gift; bestow it or withhold it without reckoning” [Q 38:39], and similar passages repeatedly mentioned in the Mighty Book, and also in prophetic reports, such as the saying that seventy thousand of his community will enter Paradise without reckoning …’

Editorial note

The argument about the ultimate character of punishment and Ibn ʿArabī attribution must be compared to passages in *Fuṣūṣ* and *Futūḥāt*. The scriptural words and prophetic report are nested quotations, not original words of al-Mahāʾimī.

Stage 13 review: The supplied phrase حكمه لما كان العذاب has been rendered with حكمه understood as “His judgment”. A defective transcription of حكمة (“wisdom”) is also possible in this context. This review has not checked the page image and does not establish either reading.

Printed p. 126

Text Ten: the two classes of unreckoned divine giving

MSH-P126 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continued): ‘… and with every thousand, seventy thousand.’ These possess gifts of the names, but their relation to the Presence of the Essence is stronger than their relation to the Presence of the names and attributes. For this reason they follow those who possess essential correspondence and share in their states. Know this.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Whoever does not know that essential gifts, and those whose relation to the Essence predominates, have no reckoning does not know the reality of ‘God provides for whom He wills without reckoning’ [Q 2:212]—that is, the cause explaining it by a demonstration of the reason why. This is a gift of the names in which the relation to the Essence predominates, as shown by the fact that ‘God’ is a name encompassing the Essence and attributes, while the Essence is exalted within it. He is high in His nearness and near in His height. Likewise, mashīʾa is above irāda, so it too has a relation to the Essence. ‘Without reckoning’ means in occurrence and timing.

Nor does such a person know the secret of ‘This is Our gift’ [Q 38:39]: an essential gift that entails neither obligation nor recompense, even from the aspect of guidance for which the perfected are returned from the Real to creation. Bestow it by teaching whomever you wish, or withhold it, for it is ‘without reckoning’; that is why this phrase is placed last.

He first says ‘reality’, indicating something established in hearts because it concerns the manifest names; he then says ‘secret’, indicating that it concerns the Essence, which is the greatest of the unseen mysteries. He adds that the prophetic reports likewise state that these two classes of gifts are without reckoning: those related to the Essence alone, and those whose relation to the Essence predominates. The first class is the seventy thousand; the report indicates this by making them those who are followed.

The second class is those indicated by ‘with every thousand, seventy thousand’. These possess gifts of the names, but their relation to the Presence of the Essence is stronger because the aspect of necessity predominates.

Editorial note

Modern notes about hadith collections (numbers 1 and 2) omitted from authorial Arabic. “Without reckoning” interpreted variously across Q 2:212, Q 38:39, and hadith; keep these contexts distinct.

Printed p. 127

Text Ten: recipients and their six modes of request, including unspoken receptivity

MSH-P127 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: Perhaps the first number, seventy thousand, alludes to the number of divine veils, while the additional multitudes indicate that each thousand brings into its train the same number through its intensified relation of correspondence. This is offered as a possible explanation, not as something proved by the numeral itself. The stronger, essential correspondence can govern recipients whose gifts are otherwise nominal; by following the essentially qualified, a recipient can sometimes attain through dependence what would be inaccessible through independent standing. Hence Qūnawī's instruction, “Know this.”

Qūnawī: ‘Having described the classes of gifts and their governing rules, let us describe the classes of their recipients. In receiving them they fall into levels, differentiated according to their requests of preparedness, state, rank, spirituality, natural temperament, or adventitious nature, which are expressed by the tongue of the seeking recipient.’ **Al-Mahāʾimī:** Having finished with the classes of gifts—essential gifts, gifts of the names, and those related to both—and what follows from them, he describes the classes of their recipients. Their reception differs in degree, so the gifts are also divided according to their classes. He explains that their levels multiply according to their requests.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The first class is requests of state; the receptive state [the wording here is uncertain] is preparedness, the receptivity bestowed by the Most Holy Effusion upon the divine affair. The second is requests described as ‘purified from the fixed entities’ [المقدسة عن الأعيان الثابتة: the construction is uncertain]. The third is requests of rank, encompassing every rank among the ranks of descent. The fourth is requests specific to certain ranks: spiritual requests, related to the spirit and what corresponds to it, such as heart and soul; requests of natural temperament, related to the body insofar as it is composed of the elements; and requests of adventitious nature, which arise according to impulses originating in the bodily faculties.

These requests arising from nature are what he says are expressed—that is, through words indicating them once they have settled in the heart—by the tongue of the seeking recipient. This suggests that a supplicant is answered only when he seeks from God with complete knowledge and fully compliant receptivity. Requesting the impossible does not secure an answer, as with requesting prophethood in this age. The preceding requests, however, are not things voiced in words ...

Editorial note

Al-Mahāʾimī’s enumeration is not perfectly parallel to Qūnawī’s list (note ambiguity of ḥāl, istiʿdād and fixed entities). Preserve without collapsing request from preparedness into spoken supplication.

Stage 13 review: The class enumeration remains textually unstable: the first clause combines الحال and الاستعدادية, and the second has المقدسة عن الأعيان الثابتة. The English now exposes those uncertain constructions rather than pretending the enumeration is securely established. No emendation or scan verification is claimed.

Printed p. 128

Text Ten: highest recipients behold a single effusion under differentiated conditions

MSH-P128 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… at all. Understand.

Qūnawī: ‘In summary, the highest rank of recipients in receiving what comes to them from the Real's effusion and gifts is to see the face of the Real in the conditions and causes called intermediaries, and in the chain of ordered sequence. The recipient thus knows and witnesses that the causal intermediaries are nothing other than determinations of the Real in the divine and cosmic ranks, with all their different kinds. This means that between the received effusion of the Real and the recipient there is only the effusion's own determination through qualified receptivity, without the addition of a contingent ruling required and necessitated by the effect of the effusion's passage through the intermediary ranks and its being coloured by the rulings of their contingencies.’

Al-Mahāʾimī: In every class of recipients distinguished by the requests already mentioned there is a further gradation. The highest rank of recipients—whether they receive through a request of preparedness, state or otherwise—is qualified by ‘in their receiving’ [the following explanation of this qualification is unclear in the supplied text]. He uses the singular for the Real's effusion because it is originally one, and also mentions His gifts, which articulate that effusion. He mentions both to indicate that their vision of His face follows one and the same course in undifferentiated and differentiated reception: they see the face of the Real in conditions and causes.

A condition is that upon which something depends without its exercising an effect on it; a cause is that upon which it depends together with an effect. Mentioning both indicates seeing His face in what exercises an effect and what does not. They are called ‘intermediaries’ because they intervene between the first effusion and the recipient, and ‘the chain of ordered sequence’, that is, the order of the beings proceeding by effusion from divinity to …

Editorial note

Page 128 contains an extensive separately marked modern editorial footnote citing al-Shaʿrānī and abridged *Futūḥāt*. The entire note is excluded from al-Mahāʾimī's running prose. Qūnawī's formula is explicitly about *taʿayyun* through receptivity, not numerical identity among all presented objects.

Stage 13 review: In the commentary on في قبولهم, the supplied phrase إما بحسب السؤال قدر is unstable. Its precise explanation of the qualification has not been reconstructed. The English marks this uncertainty; the Arabic is unchanged.

Printed p. 129

Text Ten: conditions, causes, and determination of one intelligible effusion

MSH-P129 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

… humanity.

Al-Mahāʾimī: He mentions these two designations to indicate that both encompass causes and conditions. Intermediaries are not restricted to conditions: a proximate cause mediates between the true agent and the recipient, all the more a remote cause. Nor is the chain of ordered sequence restricted to causes: although conditions do not enter the chain of agents, they enter the chain of ordered beings. Thus one sees the face of the Real in all of them. The recipient knows this if he belongs to the people of knowledge, and witnesses it if he belongs to the people of direct vision.

He mentions causal intermediaries particularly because, if these effective things are identical with the Real despite their apparent independence and do not subsist through their own essence, non-effective things have still less claim to independence [the intervening wording is unstable]. They are nothing other than determinations of the Real in the divine ranks, such as names and attributes, and the cosmic ranks, such as fire and water in burning and drowning, despite the different kinds of causes and conditions. This indicates that the lowliness of some does not prevent them from being His determinations because of His exaltedness; nor should one say that, if all were His determinations, they would be equal or close in degree. Their disparity arises only from relations and considerations.

Their being identical with the determinations of the Real depends upon two premises. First, between the Real's first, non-sensible effusion and the recipient among sensible things there is nothing except that first effusion's own determination through receptivity qualified by a divine or cosmic rank. The qualification 'non-sensible' is needed because the veiled person imagines many intermediaries other than the effusion between it and a sensible recipient, but imagines no intermediary between a

sensible effusion and its recipient. Without the qualification one might suppose that the sensible effusion was meant, and the argument that the intermediaries are identical with the non-sensible effusion would not be established.

No contingent ruling is added to that non-sensible effusion, such that the combination of effusion and ruling would mediate between the effusion and the recipient. The contingent ruling in question is what the effect of the effusion's passage through the intermediary ranks ‘requires’ and ‘necessitates’. He uses both terms to include operation by choice and by necessity. He mentions the ‘effect’ so that one does not suppose that passage alone imposes a contingent ruling on the effusion without affecting it. That is not so: a thing's ruling is its established effect. This effect is the effusion's being coloured by the rulings of the intermediaries' contingencies. The evidence that such rulings are not added to the effusion that passes through the intermediaries is that those rulings subsist in the intermediaries, and a single accident does not subsist through two causes [the supplied word بسببين requires verification].

Editorial note

Critical interpretive distinction: (i) source-effusion, (ii) its *taʿayyun* by receptivity, (iii) contingent properties inhering in intermediaries. The final accident argument is al-Mahāʾimī’s reasoning, not an independently established invariant across all Akbarian authors.

Stage 13 review: The final argument in the supplied Arabic reads والعرض الواحد لا يقوم بسببين, literally “a single accident does not subsist through two causes”. The former English silently substituted the scholastic formulation “two subjects”. That may be the intended reading, but it has not been established here; بسببين remains in Arabic and the English flags it. The earlier causal-intermediary paragraph also contains unstable connective wording.

Printed p. 130

Text Ten: al-Ẓāhir, al-Bāṭin, receptivity and the limits of verbal unity

MSH-P130 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: Certainly, the effusion acquires a determination through passing through them; the intermediaries are therefore determinations of the effusion. That is one premise. The other is that the determinations of the effusion are determinations of the Real. This is explained by the Shaykh's words:

Qūnawī: ‘One sees that the effusion is a self-disclosure among the self-disclosures of the inward aspect of the Real. The multiple determinations that attach to it are the rulings of the name the Outward, insofar as the outward aspect of the Real is a locus of disclosure for His inward aspect. The rulings of manifestation multiply the

unrestricted unity of inwardness. These rulings are what are called recipients, and they are the forms of the divine affairs, nothing else. Understand. God speaks the truth and guides whom He wills to a straight path.’

Al-Mahāʾimī: This explains that the effusion's determinations are determinations of the Real: one sees the effusion as a self-disclosure among the self-disclosures of the inward aspect of the Real. He specifies this because the Real has many self-disclosures from the side of the Outward. Its being affected by multiplicity shows that it is a disclosure of the Inward: the effusion multiplies with the multiplicity of recipients, while multiplicities belong to the rulings of the name the Outward. Thus the effusion is the name the Outward, and the effusion is a self-disclosure of the Real through the Real, insofar as the outward aspect of the Real is a locus of disclosure for His inward aspect. The rulings of manifestation multiply the unrestricted unity of inwardness—that is, the unity belonging to the Inward [the connective wording is unstable]. This is unrestricted unity, not unity opposed to multiplicity; rather, it includes multiplicity.

The rulings of the name the Outward make that multiplicity manifest from it. Those rulings are called recipients, namely the fixed entities. The fixed entities are the forms of the Real's affairs. Thus the rulings in the name the Outward are forms of the Real's affairs, which are rulings of the name the Inward. The forms of a thing are its determinations; these are therefore determinations of the Real. Accordingly, the intermediaries are identical with His determinations, and a fortiori are nothing other than them. Understand.

This is what can be drawn from the expression that indicates unification by way of unveiling. God speaks the truth, which is unification itself, containing no multiplicity whatsoever. Otherwise, an expression necessarily indicates ‘unification’ as a verbal noun, ‘the one who unifies’ as an active participle, ‘what is unified’ as a passive participle, and a subject and predicate. He guides whom He wills among His servants to a straight path of tasted unification, which cannot be expressed. He qualifies this by mashīʾa because it is above irāda. Perhaps it is pure guidance—that is, acquisition has no part in it, since intellectual and transmitted proofs have no part there. He calls it the straight path because whatever lies below it is not free of a claim to partnership with God. Exalted is He above what they associate with Him.

Editorial note

Qūnawī says the *rulings* of al-Ẓāhir are recipients, and al-Mahāʾimī identifies them with fixed entities. Do not silently equate the several technical levels. His remarks on inadequacy of language are qualified specifically to tasted unity.

Stage 13 review: The running English now retains the commentator’s explicit claim that the effusion is the name the Outward, and his denial of a role for intellectual or transmitted proofs “there”, in the tasted unity under discussion. These are the commentator’s claims. The earlier translation added doctrinal qualifications not present in this paragraph. The connective around بأحكام الظهور بعدد مطلق وحدة البطون remains unstable in the supplied Arabic.

Printed p. 131

Text Eleven: divine response, knowledge and spiritual obedience

MSH-P131 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Text Eleven — Qūnawī: “A clear text and universal rule yielding knowledge of divine responsiveness and answer, and of their refusal.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Having finished discussing those who receive, he begins to discuss which of them are answered and which are not. Since answering resembles carrying out a command, because supplication and command resemble one another in their verbal form, he calls answering “responsiveness” (*muṭāwaʿa*) by an explicit metaphor. He then explains it in conjunction with refusal, to dispel a mistaken impression. The report cited below employs this metaphor. Its point is to indicate the obedient person's exalted rank: he comes to be responded to by the One whom all obey, willingly or unwillingly. Though figurative, this increases the desire for the obedience that brings it about. Calling the text “clear” indicates that it admits no casting of doubt after some supplications have been accepted. To state this explicitly he adds “a universal rule.” Although a rule is necessarily universal, the added “universal” indicates that there is no exception in any respect.

He says “yielding” knowledge, rather than “concerning” knowledge, to make explicit that this knowledge follows necessarily from the rule as a conclusion follows from a syllogism, thereby strengthening the assertion. He also mentions refusal, because a thing is often known through its opposite.

Qūnawī: “Know that the complete, explicit measure and the verified, sound proof drawn from taste—by which one knows when the servant is obedient to his Lord and when the divine answer reaches him swiftly in the very matter he asks, without impediment or delay—is sound knowledge and perfect responsiveness. The more correct his knowledge of the Real and his conception of Him, the swifter the answer in exactly what he asks. The more complete his attentiveness to the Real's commands and his readiness to carry them out with perfect obedience, the more complete is the Real's responsiveness to him compared with His responsiveness to other servants.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: A “measure” names that by which the quantity of something in heaviness or lightness can be known. A “demonstration” names a syllogism composed of syllogisms in an arrangement productive of a conclusion. These terms are applied metaphorically to the stated rule to indicate that it admits neither increase nor decrease nor the casting of doubt. The measure is described as “complete,” because an incomplete one cannot establish a quantity beyond the possibility of increase or decrease; and as “explicit,” because some measures are not known to be complete and sound, their condition being ambiguous. He thus makes clear that it has neither deficiency nor ambiguity. Even some self-evident matters admit verbal challenges,

without those challenges producing doubt in the hearer's heart—as with the objections of the sophists and the foolish concerning self-evident and theoretical matters.

Editorial note

The phrase “divine obedience” is a marked metaphor (*istiʿāra*), not a doctrinal attribution of servitude to God; distinguish exact requested-object answer from wider forms of response.

Stage 13 review: The definition of demonstration and the phrase concerning the sophists and the foolish are translated from the supplied Arabic without correcting their unusual formulation. This review does not certify those readings against a photograph.

Printed p. 132

Text Eleven: exact answer versus response, and seeing God without ḥulūl or ittiḥād

MSH-P132 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: The proof is called one of *taste* because its premises are not objects of the bodily senses, but are intuitively apprehended. Since a claimed intuition can be mistaken, Qūnawī adds “verified”; because fallacies can mimic proof, he adds “sound.” The density of these descriptors is deliberate, given the large number of petitioners and the relatively small number of visibly immediate answers.

He says here, “in knowing when the servant is among those obedient to his Lord,” whereas he initially spoke of knowing divine responsiveness and answer. This is because the servant's obedience entails the Real's responsiveness; what he intends to establish is the consequent. He therefore first mentions the thing sought, then begins the explanation by mentioning the antecedent, whose presence indicates the consequent's presence. He does not do this with answering, because answering does not necessarily entail knowledge: an answer can occur without it in a state of desperate necessity. He therefore retains the initial order for answering. He restricts the answer to the very thing requested, because an answer in the unrestricted sense is obtained by every particular individual: either verbally—“Here I am, My servant”—or in action, with the response deferred or otherwise disposed of in relation to what was requested [the supplied wording concerning timing and substitution is unclear]. He makes soundness of knowledge the cause of answering, and the perfection of the servant's obedience the cause of divine responsiveness, using an interlaced arrangement (*laff wa-nashr mushawwash*).

He arranges it in this way because the rank of responsiveness is greater, and so he mentions it first in the initial statement. Answering stands to responsiveness as a simple constituent to a composite, and so he mentions answering first in the second statement.

Since the expression here contains some ambiguity, he elaborates it: “the more correct his knowledge of the Real.” Since “knowledge” is most often used for intellectual apprehension, he explains it by adding “and the more correct his conception of Him.” He uses both expressions so that “conception” will not suggest that God has a form within which He is confined. The divine answer in the very thing asked is then swifter. This comes through seeing Him in everything without confinement, indwelling in things, or union with them. “More complete attentiveness to the Real's commands” means attending to His explicit expressions and indications, adopting the more cautious courses and the strict prescriptions. Prohibitions are included, since abstaining from prohibited things is commanded. Hastening to carry them out in action, with perfect obedience and complete exertion, makes the Real's responsiveness to him more complete than His responsiveness to other servants—even if those others are His enemies, to whom the Real is not responsive at all.

Qūnawī (continuing): “For this reason it befits the state of the great ones among God's people that most of their supplications are answered ...”

Editorial note

The distinctions *maʿrifa* / *taṣawwur*, exact answer / general response, and taste / discursive proof are textually explicit. In p132 the source syntax is compressed; no independent authentication of reports is claimed.

Stage 13 review: The supplied phrase «مؤخرا ومفوضا عن المسؤول عنه في الحال، أو مؤخرا» is syntactically unclear; the English marks the uncertainty rather than silently replacing مفوضا with a conjectured word. The simple/composite comparison in the following paragraph concerns the rank of answering relative to responsiveness.

Printed p. 133

Text Eleven: petition directed to the Real versus a mental representation

MSH-P133 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing Text Eleven): “... because of their perfect obedience, sound knowledge of God and accurate conception of Him. The saying ‘Call upon Me and I will answer you’ (Q 40:60) alludes to this. One who lacks sound witnessing knowledge and whose conception is relative is not calling upon the Real who has guaranteed him an answer by saying, ‘Call upon Me and I will answer you’ (Q 40:60). Rather, in

supplication he turns toward individualized images formed in his mind from his own reasoning and imagination, from another person's imagination and reasoning, or from their combination.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: For this reason someone in this condition is deprived of an answer in the very thing he requested, or it—that is, the answer—is delayed. He argues for the stated rule first from what occurs and then from the Qurʾānic text: because perfect knowledge brings about answering and perfect obedience brings about responsiveness, the state of the great ones among God's people entails that most of their supplications are answered.

He uses “most” because that is what is known with certainty. It has not been established by complete induction that all their supplications are answered, which would allow an argument by complete induction; rather, the argument is from incomplete induction. He then indicates the ground of the argument by saying “because of perfect responsiveness,” together with knowledge of God and conception of Him: they combine the condition of answering with the conditions of responsiveness, which exceed answering. How, then, could answering fail to occur for them? He gives responsiveness priority here to indicate that the perfection of knowledge is completed only through it. He repeats “and conception” so that “knowledge” will not be taken to mean merely apprehending Him from the standpoint of His attributes, as the term might suggest.

Since an argument from incomplete induction gives incomplete indication, he adduces the Qurʾānic text: “Call upon Me and I will answer you” (Q 40:60). Its explicit wording indicates that when someone turns toward Him with a correct conception, the Real answers without another condition. By its contrary implication it indicates that one lacking sound knowledge—that is, witnessing knowledge through which the Real is witnessed in everything without being confined to things, indwelling in them, or united with them—is not calling upon the Real, and so the answer guaranteed by “Call upon Me and I will answer you” is not necessarily due to him. He repeats the verse because the desperately distressed person may be answered … [the sentence continues on p.134].

Editorial note

Modern footnote on timings of supplication is excluded. Interpretive inference from Q 40:60 is al-Mahāʾimī’s exegetical use, not the only possible reading of the verse. “Most” is explicitly based on incomplete induction.

Printed p. 134

Text Eleven: incomplete mental images and the distinct promise to the distressed

MSH-P134 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: The separate promise of answer to the desperate—“Who answers the distressed one when he calls?” (Q 27:62)—is conditioned by desperate necessity (*iḍṭirār*), rather than by supplication itself as in the preceding case. A petitioner lacking adequate knowledge may turn toward a mentally individuated picture. Since that image necessarily fails to correspond to the Real, it does not unconditionally necessitate an answer.

The mental picture may result from one's intellectual reasoning, one's own imagination, the imagination or speculation of another person, or a mixture of these. In speaking of a person's own faculties Qūnawī puts rational examination first, since a seeker should ask whether a proposed account is fitting. In describing borrowed accounts, he reverses the order to signal the danger of conforming one's mental image to another's imagination before examining the reasoning behind it. A corrupt image can become entrenched when private imagining and borrowed conception reinforce one another. He describes these corrupt images so that they may be avoided in every case.

Someone in that state may not receive the *particular* thing requested, although the matter may be answered in a different way according to whatever partial aspect of the divine names the petitioner actually apprehends. Thus an answer in some respect is not ruled out; Qūnawī's restriction concerns the very object of the petition. His clarification “that is, the answer” prevents the delay from being understood as referring only to an answer in exactly what was requested. The wording implies that the person is not without some answer, because he calls upon the Real under one of His aspects.

Qūnawī (continuing to p. 135): “When such a person is answered, this is because of the secret of divine accompaniment, according to which nothing is devoid …”

[The remaining lines of the web transcription on this printed page, beginning «يسأل عنه وإذا كان مستبشرا», belong to a lengthy modern editor's *hāmish*, not to al-Mahāʾimī; they are deliberately omitted from the running Arabic text.]

Editorial note

The printed page has a large modern editorial footnote interleaved after main text. Do not count this footnote as Mahāʾimī. Arabic copy-text here ends mid-quotation and resumes on p135.

Printed p. 135

Text Eleven: two grounds for response to imperfect petition—maʿiyya and existential necessity

MSH-P135 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (completion of p. 134): "... of the Real, or else because of the perfect concentration arising in desperate people, who have been promised an answer in consequence of their plea born of necessity and the preparedness produced by that very necessity."

Al-Mahāʾimī: If a person focused on a limited mental picture nevertheless receives the particular answer without delay, one of two accounts applies. First, divine accompaniment (*maʿiyya*) reaches throughout beings: the relations and appearances of the divine attributes embrace every cosmic reality and form, as indicated by "He is with you wherever you are" (Q 57:4). The commentator carefully says "divine" accompaniment rather than identifying it simply with the unrestricted Essence in itself. The Essence as such, being independent of all worlds, has no relation to things as such. The term "divine" indicates that the relation is considered under the attributes. Although 'He is with you' might suggest an essential accompaniment of identity, that suggestion is removed by 'God sees what you do.'

This pervasive accompaniment is a cause of answering, because it entails that nothing is devoid of the Real [the supplied Arabic at this point is defective]. It is nevertheless not a cause that necessitates answering, because the petitioner attends to the image as the Real Himself rather than as a locus of manifestation. The image has two aspects: one calls for answering and the other prevents it. If the former is strengthened by some hidden factor, the person is answered; otherwise not.

Second, a desperate person's complete concentration of aspiration (*jamʿiyyat al-himma*) generates the receptivity attached to the promise of Q 27:62. Even if his conceptual orientation is deficient, necessity may draw his whole attention toward the One who answers, since the Real's accompaniment is not absent even from the concept by which he calls. The request born of necessity gives the divine accompaniment preponderance, together with the preparedness arising from that necessity as a locus of mercy [the supplied connecting syntax is unclear]. The pronoun in "produced by it" refers, al-Mahāʾimī specifies, to necessity rather than the act of requesting. This second cause necessitates answering; understand this.

Qūnawī: "The state of someone like this differs from that of one possessing a right conception and a verified knowledge. The latter has the Real present to awareness and turns toward Him with a genuine presence and orientation. Though this may not be comprehensive in every aspect, it is enough that he truly conceives and recalls the

Real in directing himself, even at some ranks and from the aspect of certain names and attributes. This is the state of the intermediates among God's people, and their state ...”

Editorial note

Do not turn “divine accompaniment” into the absolute Essence’s occupancy of a mental form. Distinguish receptive distress from conceptual correctness. A Qurʾānic source reference on p135 requires verification of the cited verse placement.

Stage 13 review: The supplied phrase «مقتضية عدم خلق شيء عن الخلق» is defective; its surrounding argument clearly concerns nothing being devoid of the Real, but the English explanation is marked and no Arabic emendation is adopted. The construction adjoining «لا محل الرحمة» is also unclear and remains flagged for source checking.

Printed p. 136

Text Eleven: the intermediate station versus comprehensive realization through essential disclosure

MSH-P136 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (completing p.135): “... the previously mentioned state is that of those who remain veiled.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: A person who addresses a mental form, even if occasionally answered in exactly what he asks, differs from a person possessing correct conception and verified knowledge. Correct conception is defined by correspondence to reality, not by a merely stipulated limit, and must be accompanied by decisive proof—either intellectual or experiential. The knowledgeable recipient brings the Real to awareness before petitioning and orients himself toward Him with genuine presence, so that the Qurʾānic promise “Call upon Me; I will answer you” (Q 40:60) applies under its proper meaning. This contrasts with someone who brings an imagined form in his mind to awareness and turns toward it: there is no necessity at all that he be answered. The person with correct conception must be answered even if his conception does not extend to every aspect—the Essence, names, attributes, and all the remaining ranks and considerations. For the necessity of answering, it suffices that he have a conception corresponding to the Real at some ranks and bring the Real at those ranks to awareness as he turns toward Him.

Since this could suggest that some veiled people also turn toward the Real at certain ranks, he explains that these are high ranks attained from the aspects of certain names and attributes, not from the aspect of the imagined form, which impairs knowledge. Bringing some divine ranks to awareness does not impair it. Conception at certain ranks of names and attributes is the state of the intermediates among God's people. Thus they are often answered in exactly what they ask without delay; if the

answer is delayed or substituted, this is in accordance with the authority and restriction of that name. The state mentioned previously—bringing to awareness an imagined form in the mind—is the state of the veiled, for whom answering is not necessary at all. Such a person does not know that the form is one of the Real's loci of manifestation, but instead holds a mistaken conception of it [the supplied expression «يتوهم غيبتها», literally “imagines its absence,” is unclear], and so grows distant from the Real. The intermediate knows it to be of His names, thereby draws near to the Real, and must be answered. Understand this.

Qūnawī: “As for the perfect ones and the singular individuals (*al-kummal wa-l-afrād*), their turning toward the Real follows the essential disclosure already described, which they have received, and their attainment of the station of perfection depends upon winning that disclosure. It brings them complete knowledge comprehending the aspects of every name, attribute, rank and consideration, together with correct apprehension of the Real from the standpoint of that essential disclosure, attained through the most perfect witnessing. For this reason the answer to their requests is not delayed.”

Editorial note

This is explicit station-relative phenomenology: an intermediary may have veridical yet name-conditioned cognition; the complete one retains the fruits of essential disclosure. The argument about answers is that of Qūnawī under al-Mahāʾimī’s interpretation.

Stage 13 review: The expressions «بالتقييد» in pair2 and «يتوهم غيبتها» in pair3 remain questionable in the supplied Arabic. This review has not silently substituted التقليد or عينيّتها, nor claimed a photographic check.

Printed p. 137

Text Eleven: the lightning disclosure ends, but its comprehensive knowing remains

MSH-P137 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: Qūnawī has distinguished the veiled, who may sometimes receive an answer because of an additional circumstance, from intermediate people who commonly receive what they ask through more accurate knowledge or more complete obedience. He now explains why the comprehensive person's apprehension is of a different order. Their petition follows the particular essential disclosure earlier called lightning-like (*barqī*), the receipt of which marks full realization of the station of perfection.

Crucial temporal distinction: Although this disclosure itself does not persist for even two breaths, **its fruition is a comprehensive and abiding knowledge** of the aspects (*ḥaythiyyāt*) of all names and attributes, the divine and cosmic ranks, and

their various considerations. Following the special disclosure, the accomplished knower descends to the ranks of names, attributes and other modes without losing the correct apprehension gained from seeing the Real without a locus. Because that witnessing was complete, the conception remains in their spirits even after the disclosure ceases. Consequently no attribute veils the Essence from this recipient, nor does the Essence veil the attributes, nor do the other levels block one another. The wording ‘through the most complete witnessing’ indicates that the conception disappears only when witnessing is incomplete; where it is complete, the conception does not disappear.

In this station the knower's petition draws on the combined languages of the Essence and divine names. Al-Mahāʾimī takes Qūnawī's denial of delay to imply that the requested object is not replaced either. Changing the requested object is an even greater withholding of acceptance than delaying it. Delay is a kind of refusal, and there is no refusal when the request is made through the tongue of the Essence and the names—how much less when it is made through the tongues of them all.

Qūnawī: “Furthermore the perfect ones, and whichever of the singular individuals God wills, have access to the Preserved Tablet, indeed to the Pen-rank, indeed to the Presence of divine knowledge. They therefore discern what is decreed to occur, because knowledge of its occurrence has preceded it and it must come about. Thus they ask for nothing whose existence is impossible because it has not been decreed, nor do their aspirations turn toward seeking or willing such a thing. I include ‘willing it’ because there are some whose volition conditions the occurrence of things even without supplicating or verbally asking the Real for their occurrence.”

Editorial note

A prime textual answer to the research question: p137 explicitly distinguishes transient essential disclosure from persistent cognition, rather than inferring it speculatively. Apparatus should link pp108–110 and 136–138.

Printed p. 138

Text Eleven: divine foreknowledge, the Preserved Tablet and conditioned decrees

MSH-P138 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī: “I witnessed this concerning our master—may God sanctify his spirit—over many years, in more matters than I can enumerate. He told me that he saw the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace, in one of his visionary events, and that the Prophet gave him glad tidings, saying: ‘God is quicker to answer you than you are to supplicate Him.’”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This provides another explanation for the asserted immediacy of answers to the perfect ones. Among the poles (*aqṭāb*), the accomplished are said to have knowledge of divine will, and among certain singular individuals (*afrād*) of the more comprehensive willing or choice that precedes a particular determination. The supplied explanation distinguishes the preceding, comprehensive willing (*mashīʾa*) from the particularizing will (*irāda*), although the construction explaining the singular individuals' exemption from the latter is difficult. The commentary then distinguishes degrees of awareness: the Preserved Tablet, identified with the Universal Soul and containing detailed inscriptions of cosmic events; the Pen-rank, identified with the First Intellect and containing those inscriptions in undifferentiated form; and the Presence of divine knowledge on which both depend.

Because the people of essential disclosure must descend through and pass through these ranks, they know their contents and discern what has been determined to occur and what has not. Qūnawī mentions only the first of these paired alternatives, as in the verse mentioning ‘garments that protect you from heat’ (Q 16:81), where one counterpart stands for the other as well. They therefore do not petition for a nonexistent outcome that divine knowledge has excluded. The impossibility in question is **not intrinsic impossibility**—it need not be a contradiction in the nature of the proposed event. Rather, a thing may be impossible *in relation to the determinate content of infallible prior divine knowledge*: its actual occurrence contrary to that knowledge would entail that divine knowledge had been false. Those with a share in knowledge of the decree do not direct will, aspiration or formal prayer toward what has been decisively excluded. Hence an apparent refusal in such a case does not arise.

The words about *willing* rather than merely *asking* matter because the causally relevant condition may, on this account, be an accomplished person's aspiration or will without verbal supplication. Al-Mahāʾimī then distinguishes what is **definitively fixed** in the divine decree (*jāzim*) from what is **conditioned or suspended** (*muʿallaq*). The latter is said to depend on supplication or other ordained causes, while the former does not depend on those additional conditions. If an event is divinely decreed to occur upon the will of such a person, it occurs with that will even if no explicit petition is voiced.

[Editorial distinction: the modern footnote identifying “our master” as Ibn ʿArabī is excluded. Al-Mahāʾimī himself explicitly names Muḥyī al-Dīn ibn ʿArabī in the continuation on p.139; the attribution therefore does not depend solely on that modern footnote.]

Editorial note

The print transcription reads «إيراداتهم» in one line for «إراداتهم», likely a scribal or OCR error; no emendation applied. Page 138 ends after the passage on conditional decree; Text Eleven continues on p139.

Stage 13 review: The identification of Qūnawī's teacher with Ibn ʿArabī is explicitly made by al-Mahāʾimī in the supplied main text on p.139, not merely by the modern editor. This establishes the commentary's attribution, not independent authentication of the vision-report.

Printed p. 139

Text Eleven — perfect human, will and knowledge

MSH-P139 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: In explaining “I witnessed,” he means that he gained from the perfected, perfecting master Muḥyī al-Dīn ibn ʿArabī—may God sanctify his spirit—knowledge resembling direct vision: Ibn ʿArabī had seen the Prophet, blessings and peace upon him, in one of his spiritual occurrences, that is, his unveilings or intimate conversations. The Prophet gave him the good news: “God is quicker in answering you than you are [in turning to Him].” That is, God responds through the mere will, before supplication is uttered. Qūnawī gives the long account of seeing the Prophet and receiving the glad tidings, first to indicate that he saw one whose being seen is a seeing of the Real, then to praise the vision as glad tidings from the Prophet. He next explains what he had stated in summary while preserving the Prophet's reported wording.

Qūnawī: “This station is above the station in which prayers are answered. It is among the distinctive characteristics of perfect responsiveness (*kamāl al-muṭāwaʿa*), whose station is above ordinary responsiveness. Ordinary responsiveness is confined to what was indicated previously: promptly carrying out commands, pursuing what pleases the Real, and fulfilling His rights to the extent of one's ability. The Prophet alluded to this when his uncle Abū Ṭālib, seeing how quickly God answered his appeals, said, ‘How swiftly your Lord comes to what you desire, Muḥammad!’ Another report says, ‘How responsive your Lord is to you!’ The Prophet answered, ‘And you, uncle—if you obey Him, He will respond to you.’ The station I called higher than this concerns the servant's complete conformity, in virtue of his reality, to what the Real desires of him through the first, universal will, related to the attainment of complete *jalāʾ* and *istijlāʾ*. That is what calls forth the world's existentiation, together with the Perfect Human who is the intended entity in particular. Everything besides him is intended derivatively, for his sake and by reason of him: whatever is indispensable to attaining the intended end is itself intended. This is what I mean by ‘intended derivatively.’”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The station at which mere willing is answered is higher than the station of verbally expressed prayers, since the latter requires the additional act of giving voice to the request before the answer. Response to willing is a characteristic of the servant's perfected responsiveness, through which the divine will responds to his will before he speaks. Perfect responsiveness is thus higher than simple

responsiveness, wherein the divine response follows verbal petition. Ordinary responsiveness, as previously described, consists in hastening to [the duties whose detailed account continues on p. 140].

Editorial note

The editor reports that he could not locate sources for the two Abū Ṭālib reports; their verification remains unresolved. Page ends in the middle of al-Mahāʾimī's sentence.

Printed p. 140

Text Eleven — perfect human, will and knowledge

MSH-P140 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: [The ordinary station entails] carrying out the Real's obligatory commands, pursuing His pleasure through recommended works, and observing His rights by holding correct belief concerning Him and acting sincerely, without seeking payment or self-interested advantage. Qūnawī restricts these activities to what lies within one's capacity, because their perfect accomplishment properly belongs to the station of perfected responsiveness.

He repeats the point, though it has already been mentioned, lest the previous discussion be taken to concern *perfected* responsiveness when it concerned responsiveness without that qualification. Then he argues that the servant's responsiveness entails a divine response to his request, using the reported words, "Uncle, if you obey Him ..." The intended sense is: my Lord hastened to answer what I desired, in recompense for my compliance with Him. This principle, in the report's terms, is not peculiar to the Prophet but applies to anyone who obeys God. Thus the servant's obedience entails that the Real responds to his request. Abū Ṭālib's "How swiftly your Lord comes to your desire" means that He responds to what you love and ask for more swiftly than to others.

In the other transmitted version, "How responsive your Lord is to you" means how promptly He answers your supplication. On the first reading, the Prophet's own rejoinder employs the rhetorical figure of *mushākala*, matching the expression of the earlier statement; on the second, Abū Ṭālib's own expression also belongs to this figure. The two versions are included because the first emphasizes the speed of response, whereas the second indicates response simply—this being the meaning intended by calling God "responsive." The second also suggests that this way of speaking is found both before and after Islam, without being prohibited.

Such is the station of responsiveness in general. The superior station of perfected responsiveness is what Qūnawī describes as the servant's complete accord with what the Real desires. Al-Mahāʾimī specifies: 'not in respect of his reality, which is

unrestricted Being, but in respect of his determination by it.’ The following words about the alternative expression *muwātāh* (‘accordance’) are syntactically incomplete in the supplied text. The ‘first will’ concerns what is intended intrinsically, because the Perfect Human is the most complete of creatures. This universal will is directed toward the manifestation of every perfection capable of manifestation and toward the full realization of *jalāʾ* and *istijlāʾ*. *Jalāʾ* means the holy Essence's manifestation to itself within itself, while *istijlāʾ* means [the corresponding manifestation expounded on p. 141].

Editorial note

Several awkward expressions in the transcription of the fourth paragraph require comparison with print. Modern marginal notes reporting that the editor could not locate the prophetic reports are excluded.

Stage 13 review: The qualification «لا من حيث حقيقته الذي هو الوجود المطلق لكن باعتبار تعينه به» is retained in translation despite tension with the preceding lemma's ‘in respect of his reality’. The following «ولهذا لو ورد لفظ المواتاة» is incomplete as supplied. No independent witness has been used to remove لا or otherwise normalize this passage.

Printed p. 141

Text Eleven — perfect human, will and knowledge

MSH-P141 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: [*Istijlāʾ* is] the Essence's manifestation to itself within determinations. The perfection of the first [*jalāʾ*] includes appearing in the ranks of names and attributes; the perfection of the second is that these determinations, both in their undifferentiated and differentiated aspects, be gathered together within the determination comprising all determinations, namely the comprehensive human rank. The pursuit of the perfection of *jalāʾ* and *istijlāʾ* occasions the existentiation of the cosmos, in which perfections folded together in the Essence become differentiated, and of the Perfect Human, in whom those perfections are again brought together after differentiation. He therefore comprises both the undifferentiated and the differentiated perfections. Thus the Perfect Human is specifically intended by God **under this consideration of the will**; otherwise God, exalted is He, is independent of all worlds. Everything other than the Perfect Human—whether a human being who is not perfect or another kind of being—is intended in a subordinate way, as an antecedent or completion relative to him.

Qūnawī therefore adds “and because of him”: through the human being the complete manifestation of the Real is connected with the divine will. The principle is that whatever is indispensable to an end is also intended, but the first object is desired for its own sake, whereas the second is desired derivatively. Because the Perfect Human,

as complete locus of manifestation, is intrinsically intended under this relation, and because his ranks express what is intended by the first universal will, his willing is answered without the further condition of verbal petition. Such is not the case with the merely obedient servant.

Qūnawī: “The Perfect Human, rather than any other, is specifically intended because he is a complete place of manifestation of the Real. Through him the Real manifests in respect of His Essence and all His names, attributes, rulings, and considerations, as He knows Himself through Himself within Himself, including what His names, attributes, and other rulings and considerations contain, together with the realities of what He knows in the entities of His creatures. This takes place without distortion caused by a deficiency of receptivity or an imperfection in the mirror, which would otherwise cause the reflected thing to appear differently from what it is in itself.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This explains why, among poles and singular saints, the Perfect Human is intended by the Real rather than the separate intellects, souls, bodies, or others. He is a complete locus of manifestation in both comprehensive and detailed respects, without defect or distortion in that manifestation. Through him the Real manifests in respect of the Essence, while the human being is nevertheless qualified by existence and displays the names and attributes: he lives, knows, possesses power and will, hears, sees, and speaks; within him are life, knowledge, power, will, hearing [continued on p. 142].

Editorial note

The copy-text reads «فمقصود بطريق للإنسان الكامل» and «ليس المظهر كامل» in awkward constructions; retain the witnessed reading and flag for collation.

Printed p. 142

Text Eleven — perfect human, will and knowledge

MSH-P142 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: [The qualities previously mentioned continue with] sight, speech, and the rulings attaching to the Essence and attributes. The Perfect Human is necessary *through Him*, while possible *in himself*, and displays the relevant considerations of unrestrictedness, restriction, and other relations in their completeness. The Essence manifests in him according to the manner in which God knows Himself by Himself, not by an added knowledge nor under the consideration of how He knows Himself in other loci. This is the human being's *fanāʾ* in Him. The names and attributes also manifest in the manner of God's knowledge of what His Essence comprises of names, attributes, rulings, and considerations: this is the servant's *baqāʾ* through Him. There manifest in him, too, the realities of God's known things—the fixed entities of His

creatures—because he is a microcosm of the greater world. Thus he gathers both the divine and created copies, each manifest in him completely and without a distortion arising from deficient receptivity. Such distortion would mean a defect in the mirror's functioning, as with a physical mirror that is bent or elongated and consequently alters the reflected shapes.

The human being's reception is perfect in respect of its mirroring because he is the complete locus of manifestation for Essence, names, attributes, and the remaining considerations, unlike ordinary people.

Qūnawī: “One who is of this kind has no will distinguished from the will of the Real. He is, rather, a mirror of his Lord's will and other attributes. Accordingly, his supplication is absorbed into his will, which does not differ from his Lord's will, and what he wills comes about, as God has said: ‘Effecting whatever He wills’ (Q 11:107). Whoever realizes what we have described, if he supplicates, supplicates with the tongues and through the ranks of all the worlds, being a mirror of them all. If he refrains from supplication, he does so as a locus of manifestation of the Real under one of his two aspects—the aspect facing the divine presence; in that respect he does not differ from Him insofar as He is ‘the One effecting whatever He wills.’”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This supplies the explanation of the phrase “among the distinctive characteristics of perfect responsiveness,” after the meaning of that station and its difference from simple responsiveness have been expounded [the sentence continues on p. 143].

Editorial note

A long quotation attributed to Ibn ʿArabī in the modern editor’s footnote (from an answer numbered 108) has been excluded from the translated running text. The phrase “necessary through Him, possible in himself” must not be confused with unqualified creaturely necessity.

Printed p. 143

Text Eleven — perfect human, will and knowledge

MSH-P143 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: [The explanation concerns] the distinction from responsiveness in general. Answering a mere act of willing is a mark of perfected responsiveness because the servant of this qualification mirrors, in his very reality, what the Real desires of him in the first universal will directed toward complete *jalāʾ* and *istijlāʾ*. Consequently, he has no will distinct from the Real's will: he mirrors his Lord's will and the other divine attributes. His will is the shadow of the divine will—indeed, it is identical with it in respect of reality. He therefore does not need to supplicate, because his petition is absorbed into willing, and his willing does not stand apart from

the will of his Lord. What occurs is whatever the Lord wills, since the Real effects what He wills and no intended thing fails to conform to that will. Universal existence responds to Him by nature, like the limbs of a healthy human being under his perfected faculties. A mirror lit by His light conveys the illumination to what faces it, as water lit by the sun lights up an opposing wall. Therefore **he effects what he wills through his Lord, not through himself**.

Qūnawī then describes one who has attained a still higher realization of *jalāʾ* and *istijlāʾ* and abides in *baqāʾ*. Such a person does not dissolve his petition into willing; rather, both his petition and his willing are answered. If he prays, he does so through the outward tongues of all worlds and through their ranks—which express implicit requests through states, receptivities, and other conditions—because he mirrors them all. The petition of them all is necessarily accepted. If he does not pray, his will is answered because his omission of petition proceeds from his being a locus of manifestation of the Real. The Real does not supplicate, for supplication belongs to the servant; **God is too exalted to become a servant, just as a servant is too lowly to become a Lord**. Every restricted thing has an aspect facing unrestrictedness; in this servant that aspect is perfected because he is a complete locus of manifestation. Consequently his will mirrors the will of the One who effects what He wills.

Qūnawī: “Beyond this station there is no further target for the aspirant, no ladder to another rank or station. Beneath it stands one who turns to the Real with complete knowledge and correct conception, the one meant by the address, ‘Call upon Me and I shall answer you.’ The Real's report is true. As that servant has succeeded in doing what has been described, the conclusion necessarily follows: he must be answered—unlike the other kinds of people turning toward Him whose states we have discussed. Know this and you will attain precious secrets and unfamiliar sciences which neither thoughts nor understandings have reached and which fingers have not inscribed with pens. God is the guide.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, there is no object of aspiration beyond this actualization of perfect responsiveness, through which the servant becomes a mirror of [the explanation continues on p. 144].

Editorial note

The text gives strong identity-language concerning willing but immediately qualifies the causal agency as “through his Lord, not through himself”; do not cite the former without the latter.

Printed p. 144

Text Eleven concludes; Text Twelve begins

MSH-P144 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: [The preceding section closes:] There is no further object at which aspiration can aim beyond the actualization of the servant as a mirror, in his own reality, of what the Real desires through the first universal will relating to the perfection of *jalāʾ* and *istijlāʾ*, together with that realization in the station of *baqāʾ*. There is no ascent to a further rank, because this rank comprises all ranks, and no higher station, for it is beyond the stations. Both the prayer and the willing of such a person are answered.

Below this complete one is the person turning to the Real with complete knowledge and a correct conception which does not contradict the Real in any respect, who has attained the highest degree accessible short of encompassing the innermost reality of the Real—something impossible. This person receives an answer according to “Call upon Me; I will answer you” (Q 40:60), but does not receive the same kind of immediate fulfillment of mere willing. He is addressed by “Call upon Me” precisely because someone whose willing is already answered has no need of petition except to realize servanthood and the task of mirroring the world.

Although this knowledgeable servant is below the first, the response to his prayer cannot be withheld: the Real's report is true, and He has promised an answer where supplication occurs. The servant's complete knowledge and correct conception make the relevant supplication possible, so the promised conclusion—response—follows necessarily, like a conclusion in an argument. Qūnawī adds “inevitably” to underscore the necessity, unlike the middle and veiled people described before, who direct themselves toward a different conceived image; answering them remains possible rather than necessary.

These other cases are mentioned to show the difference: if the person of complete knowledge could be left unanswered, he would be like the others, but divine wisdom does not permit this. Their supplication does not fall under the promise in the same way because they have not invoked God while apprehending Him under a correct conception. To understand this principle is to attain secrets concerning the necessity —or otherwise—of answers to petitions and willing, and an uncommon understanding of the complete and incomplete knower. These secrets concern whether answering a petition or willing is necessary, or neither is necessary; the unfamiliar knowledge distinguishes the complete from the incomplete knower in a specific, universal account. Thoughts have not reached these matters of unveiling—nor even understandings born of taste. Fingers have not inscribed them with pens, since inscription follows thought and understanding. The ensuing phrase concerning ‘what they write’ is unclear in the supplied text. God alone guides to such secrets and sciences through His essential self-disclosures; understand this.

[Editorial] Text Twelve begins. Al-Mahāʾimī: Qūnawī calls it a “noble text” because the previous text argued that those with the fullest knowledge receive the quickest answer. He now explains the perfection of knowledge, and also the perfection of the human being as a locus of manifestation of the Real, in the manner [continued on p. 145].

Editorial note

At least two expressions in the middle paragraph appear syntactically defective in the online transcription. Translate provisionally pending printed collation.

Printed p. 145

Text Twelve — highest degree of knowledge

MSH-P145 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: [The Perfect Human is a manifestation of the Real] in the way He knows Himself through Himself within Himself, and a mirror for what the Real intends by the first universal will, together with the consequences and manner of this mirroring. These are weighty matters, hence the description “a noble text.”

Qūnawī: “Know that the highest degrees of knowledge of anything, for any knower whatever, whether the object of knowledge be one thing or many things, arise only through union with the known and the absence of otherness between the knower and it. The cause of ignorance of a thing, preventing full apprehension of it, is nothing other than the predominance of the ruling of that by which the knower and known are each distinguished from the other. This is a non-spatial distance; distance, wherever it occurs, obstructs complete apprehension of what is distant. Degrees of knowing a thing vary according to the extent to which the ruling of that by which the knower and known are united prevails. This is true nearness, which removes the separation that constitutes true remoteness, indicated by the rulings of difference and distinction.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The difference between this discussion and the third derivative proposition of the earlier texts is that the latter dealt with perfect encompassing of a thing and showed that such encompassing is impossible. The present discussion concerns the cause of knowledge and how it can attain the highest possible degree of apprehension.

The opening of the explanation connects this highest knowledge of God with His answering the person who turns toward Him in supplication. The highest degree of knowledge is considered whether its object is the Real or creation, and whether its knower belongs to the order of the Real or of creatures. The object may be one intrinsically, like a simple thing; one accidentally, like a composite; or plural as plural.

Al-Mahāʾimī schematically divides the cases into eight: the Real knowing Himself alone, Himself with the world, one creature alone, or that creature with the rest of the world; and a creature knowing the Real alone, the Real with the world, itself alone, or itself with another creature. Each case is approached through the union of knower and known and the exclusion of otherness.

In the first and seventh cases this is evident. In the others, the known must have a likeness present to the knower, with its image impressed in the mirror of knowledge so that, to vision, it is not distinguished from the mirror. **This** is what “union” signifies in the explanatory analogy. Moreover, each thing is united with all things in the consideration of unrestrictedness, where abstraction reaches its highest limit and otherness is absent.

He then explains why ignorance requires a cause: it is adventitious relative to existence, which entails knowledge in the sense already discussed. For this reason, ignorance is defined as an obstacle to the **perfection** of apprehension, not to every apprehension whatsoever: each thing is apprehended under some aspect, such as its thingness or existence. That is an effect of the original unity under unrestrictedness. The obstructing factor is the predominance of [the distinguishing ruling, continued on p. 146].

Editorial note

The transcription appears awkward in its enumeration of eight cases; the eightfold scheme follows the intended contrasts but its precise syntax needs collation. The mirror analogy is not evidence for the literal numerical identity of created knower and known.

Printed p. 146

Text Twelve — true nearness and the perfection of knowledge

MSH-P146 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: [Ignorance arises from the dominance of] the factor by which knower and known are distinguished from one another. This could seem to assume what requires proof, so Qūnawī describes it as non-spatial distance, which impedes knowledge. Distance—whether sensory or non-sensory—prevents a complete grasp of the remote object, since not all its accidental characteristics, qualities, and measures can then be known.

The point is apparent in sensory distance. In the non-sensory case, an analogy is used —called *tamthīl* as a procedure of exposition, though a direct insight according to realization: non-sensory distance prevents the likeness of the known from being fully present in the knower, just as physical distance impairs the complete presentation of what is seen to the faculty of sight. If distance produces ignorance, nearness

produces knowledge. Distance and nearness are relational, however, and their degrees are neither simply identical nor precisely measurable. Consequently, degrees of comprehensive knowing and ignorance vary with the prevalence of that aspect through which knower and known are united.

Qūnawī calls the ruling of the unifying factor “true nearness,” since nearness in space, time, or qualities is mediated, whereas this nearness has no intermediary. True nearness removes separation, difference, and otherness, which comprise true remoteness, whether sensory or non-sensory. His initial statement could suggest that remoteness is exclusively non-sensory. The intention, however, was first to explain non-sensory distance by analogy with sensory distance, then to establish the obstructive character of both. All rulings of otherness and distinctness are thus gathered under the description “true remoteness” because they possess the relevant character of distance.

Qūnawī: “When you witness this and taste it through verified unveiling, you will know that the reason for the perfection of the Real's knowledge of things is that He beholds them in Himself and that their multiplicity and otherness are absorbed in His unity. The being of anything in anything—whether its locus be formal or nonformal—occurs and appears according to the determination and manifestation of that in which it occurs. Thus we say: the Real knows Himself through Himself, and He knows things within Himself by the very knowledge through which He knows Himself.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This means that the proposition is witnessed through inward vision that gives rise to immediate finding (*wijdān*, hence *dhawq*), by a verified unveiling which renders evident that the highest degree of knowledge for every knower is attained through union with what is known.

Editorial note

The copy-text reads «نية» where a verb meaning “he indicated/clarified” appears intended; it is not emended. Distinguish the analogical proof from the author’s claimed epistemic verification through unveiling.

Printed p. 147

Text Twelve — divine knowledge, unity and otherness

MSH-P147 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: Qūnawī makes the attainment of this knowledge depend on the witnessing he has just described. The preceding argument only establishes, generally, the importance of nearness; true nearness itself is realized through unveiling and tasting. He therefore qualifies the unveiling as verified, since a mental image cannot attest this reality: this nearness has no corresponding form that could represent it

and lies beyond the sphere of discursive reason. One then understands how the Real's knowledge is complete even though its objects are many and possible while His knowledge is one and necessary. The explanation is His *istijlāʾ* of things: their appearing within Himself according to their determinations, as in a mirror. The mirror and the reflected object are united under the relevant consideration, and multiplicity and otherness are absorbed into His existential unity, where they are considered one and necessary.

Hence it is said that unity is coextensive with being, and that every possible thing is surrounded by two necessities, antecedent and subsequent. The multiplicity and otherness of the objects are absorbed in the Real's unity **as they occur within divine knowledge**, even though their distinct realities retain plurality and possibility, which entails otherness. The way a thing exists in a locus is determined by that locus, not simply by the thing considered in itself. Whether the locus is nonformal, as knowledge is, or formal, as with an ordinary mirror, determination and manifestation follow the character of the receiving locus. Things, accordingly, appear under unity and necessity within the Real's knowledge.

When being appears in the distinct realities, by contrast, it appears under the rulings of plurality and possibility. The things are one and necessary in divine knowledge because there the unity is such that knower, known, and knowledge are united. The Real therefore knows Himself through Himself, without an additional representation or a separation of knower and known. His knowledge of things is perfect insofar as it consists in His knowledge of Himself and in His beholding them within Himself.

Qūnawī: “When the divine report came that God was, and nothing was with Him, the otherness of things was denied in relation to the unity that is their intrinsic locus, and the Real's priority was established from the standpoint of unity.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: He adduces the prophetic report, understood as divine communication, to argue for the necessity of things and their lack of otherness to the Real **in respect of their inscription in eternal knowledge**. He invokes ‘It is only a revelation revealed’ (Q 53:4), while identifying this report as hidden revelation. Since, by consensus as he states, the realities of things were in His knowledge, ‘God was and nothing was with Him’ must be interpreted to mean that nothing was with Him that differed from Him. Thus the otherness of [things is denied under the relevant consideration; the argument continues on p. 148].

Editorial note

The transmitted report “God was and there was nothing with Him” requires a separate ḥadīth-critical dossier; translation alone does not establish its variants or authenticity. Crucially distinguish the modality “within divine knowledge” from manifested plurality.

Printed p. 148

Text Twelve — first determination and the two modes of manifestation

MSH-P148 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: [Continuing the preceding explanation:] The otherness of things is denied in relation to the unity serving as their locus, for they are considered identical with the Real **under the relation of knowledge**. Here the Real's priority to things is established: they were the Real initially, and the Real is their first principle, from the standpoint of the unity belonging to things. Considered in respect of their many distinct realities, however, they are not simply the Real, nor is the Real “first” in that same sense. Their plurality coexists with His unity; the ensuing discussion will invoke the principle that only one proceeds from what is one. Things are nevertheless one insofar as universal being is in view, and it is in that respect that the Real is their first principle.

Qūnawī: “When the multitude of things related [to knowledge] in a secondary way—which had previously been concealed within unity—became distinguished, and the multitude together with unity was actually gathered, the perfection initially hidden in unity became manifest. Thus the door opened to the perfection of *jalāʾ* and *istijlāʾ*, the true object of aspiration, and the rulings of unity appeared in multiplicity and those of multiplicity in unity.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This explains the perfection of God's differentiated knowledge of many things. The things were hidden within the unity identified with the **first determination**, possessing a conceptual multiplicity insofar as essential knowledge relates to them. They then came to be related under the consideration of plurality. Intellectually regarding them under that aspect requires that they be distinguished from one another; this distinction and real unity are combined in essential knowledge. Through that combination the perfection latent in existence under unity became manifest—namely the perfection of the divine names, which manifests in loci. Thus the perfection of *jalāʾ*, the holy Essence's manifestation to itself within itself, and of *istijlāʾ*, its manifestation to itself within its determinations, is opened: the two modes of manifestation are joined.

This joining is described as the true object of the Essence's willing, for the transmitted saying states, “I was a hidden treasure and loved to be known.” At this point rulings of necessity become manifest within the plurality: the things are qualified by actual being, which, as the philosophical account states, is not without antecedent and subsequent necessities. Conversely, the rulings of plurality, through the properties of possibility, appear within unity, because when unity relates to plurality and is displayed in its mirrors it appears coloured by their characteristics. To an observer those characteristics seem to qualify unity, although in reality they belong to plurality; unity also comprises them insofar as it contains that plurality.

Editorial note

The opening line is syntactically corrupt or duplicated in the online transcription; first paragraph is provisional. The phrase “hidden treasure” is cited, not certified as a sound ḥadīth. Keep first determination, conceptual distinction, and manifested plurality separate.

Stage 13 review: The phrase ‘they were the Real initially’ renders «أنها كانت حقّا أولا» under the expressly stated consideration of unity. It should not be silently weakened to ‘considered in the Real’ or read as a temporal transition from God into creatures. The corrupted opening syntax remains unresolved.

Printed p. 149

Text Twelve — unity and plurality in knowledge

MSH-P149 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī: “Unity makes multiplicity one, because unity becomes a common measure among the many things which are distinguished intrinsically from one another. It thus joins their differentiating features, since it gathers them in itself, as we have said. The many, in turn, make the One appear as many under the determinations responsible for the differentiated appearances of the One: the colouring and being-coloured and the varied qualities required by the differing receptivities of the many things capable of receiving that one self-disclosure.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: When the rulings of unity appear in multiplicity, unity makes that multiplicity one by extending to each of its members, in a way compared with a universal extending to its particulars. Hence the saying: “In everything there is a sign / indicating that He is One.” Unity becomes the shared element in the many insofar as they are qualified by it; **under the consideration of unity** they are not distinguished. Their distinction arises instead from their individual realities and quiddities. These are themselves distinct not simply because they are realities—since realities can resemble one another—but through specific differentiating characteristics attached to their genera. These differentiae are existential because they constitute the genera; in respect of reality they are identical with unity, which is being. Unity joins the differentiations of multiplicity because it gathers the many realities in itself, those realities being its *shuʾūn* (affairs or modalities), as already explained.

Knowledge of actual multiplicity is a perfection insofar as the rulings of unity relate to it, but multiplicity as such is not that perfection. Conversely, when the rulings of plurality appear in unity, the manifold realities cause the unity manifested in them to appear multiple in accordance with the determinations that accompany its manifestation. These determinations produce diverse appearances of the One: the locus colours what manifests with the colour of the rulings of possibility. The text also speaks of being coloured by the rulings of necessity, but the syntax of this reciprocal

clause is defective in the supplied Arabic. Differences in receptivity belonging to the quiddities of the many things produce different qualities, though all receive a single essential disclosure. The One therefore appears multiple according to these differences, as one face has multiple appearances in different mirrors or as sunlight is modified by coloured glass and the reflected light bears the glass's colour. The resulting appearances are one with their source-image under one consideration and diverse in their configurations according to the readiness of the loci. Accordingly, an additional relation of knowledge to these configurations is posited—not as a **temporal renewal**, but as an **order of rank**, since the appearances are dependent on the original known image [the sentence continues on p. 150].

Editorial note

The exact predicational force of “a common measure” must not be transferred uncritically into a theory of generic being or a literally shared genus. The page explicitly excludes temporal renewal.

Stage 13 review: In «بصبغ للمظهر الظاهر بلون أحكام الإمكان» the locus is read as colouring what manifests with the rulings of possibility. The subsequent «وانصباغ الظاهر يظهر بلون أحكام الوجوب» is defective as supplied; its exact reciprocal formulation requires source checking. No Arabic emendation is adopted. The differentiae are expressly said to be «عين الوحدة» in respect of reality, not merely related to it.

Printed p. 150

Varieties of disclosure and the timelessness of divine knowledge

MSH-P150 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

[Continuation of al-Mahāʾimī from p. 149]: These reflected forms are subordinate, in their order, to the original form that is known in itself.

Qūnawī: Thus there arises a fresh knowledge of the kinds of manifestation and the rulings necessarily accompanying them. These rulings comprise the effects of things upon one another, whether through establishing or undoing, outwardly or inwardly, in higher or lower realms, within a determinate duration or without such duration, and in concordance or in discordance. All of this occurs through the connection brought about among them by the existential, immediately experienced self-disclosure, which gathers their dispersed elements together, as we explained.

Al-Mahāʾimī: When the many determinate things make the One appear manifold in the kinds of manifestation proper to their various receptive capacities, the forms in which the One appears also differ. Accordingly, knowledge of those kinds of manifestation is said to be renewed, meaning that it follows knowledge of unity by an order of nature, not by a temporal succession. The manifest is united with the manifester in respect of existence. The manifest is an image of the manifester—al-

Mahāʾimī expressly identifies “manifester” here as an active participle—and in reality it is identical with it; its otherness consists in being its image. Therefore knowledge of the image follows knowledge of essential unity in rank.

These manifestations have determinate consequences. Something may affect another by bringing something about, as rain causes a crop to grow, or by undoing it, as fire burns wood. Such relations may be outward, as in those physical examples, or inward, as when two affirmative premises yield an affirmative conclusion and premises including a negative yield a negative conclusion. They may belong to higher orders, as with the influence of intellects upon souls and what lies below them, or to lower orders, as with the generation and corruption of elements acting upon one another. They may be time-bound, as in effects of intellects upon elements or elements upon one another, or not time-bound, as in the influence of intellects upon souls. They may be concordant, as good actions conduce to felicity, or discordant, as corrupt actions bring misery and punishment.

All these are diverse knowledges and are said to be renewed only in the sense that their order depends on the judgment of unity and the connection among the things themselves. Even when the things are contrary to one another, they are joined by the one existential disclosure common to them all, within eternal knowledge. What changes is the relational determination between that knowledge and the things, in view of the contrarieties belonging to them. Understand this carefully.

Qūnawī: Knowledge, delight and felicity, in all their different varieties, follow correspondence or affinity (*munāsaba*); ignorance, torment and wretchedness follow the strength of the rulings of separation and distinction. As for the intermingling of the rulings of union and those of distinction, its sway is perpetual. The source of each group of these rulings, through some kind of correspondence, and that to which it returns in respect of relation … [continued on p. 151].

Printed p. 151

Correspondence, alienation, and spiritual felicity

MSH-P151 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): …and its support is what is called a rank (*martaba*). Understand.

Al-Mahāʾimī: If the highest degree of knowledge of a thing is union with the known, then knowledge of all degrees, together with the enjoyment and felicity corresponding to it, follows the degree of correspondence between knower and known, between the one enjoying and what is enjoyed, and between the felicitous person and what confers felicity. Gnosis, faith, virtuous character and good deeds bring about this correspondence. Conversely, ignorance, torment and misery occur according to the strength of the differences separating the ignorant person from what

is unknown, the sufferer from what causes suffering, and the wretched person from what makes him wretched. One must therefore avoid unbelief, vicious dispositions and disobedience, lest these rulings of separation and difference predominate.

Separation has these effects because it opposes correspondence and therefore yields contrary effects. Where it is weak, it cannot overcome the original correspondence arising from the participation of all things in existence. But where the rulings of union —associated with the attributes of necessity—and those of separation—associated with the attributes of possibility—are mixed in approximately equal strength, each exercises its sway for as long as the mixture lasts. A person in whom both are present may be knowing, happy and enjoying under one aspect but not under another. Thus the people of the Paradise of Acts are felicitous insofar as they are delivered from the Fire, yet deficient in felicity relative to the people of the Paradises of the Attributes and of the Essence.

Someone who first enters the Fire and later Paradise is, on this account, governed at first by separation and afterwards by union. The power of faith belongs to the person's inward spirit, while the power of bad acts attaches to outward behaviour. What attaches to the outward can pass away, unlike what is rooted in the inward. It is also possible to state the governing principle more simply: ignorance, torment and misery arise only where separation and distinction become strong, for when weak they cannot defeat the original affinity of existence.

Nor should one imagine that union abolishes all distinction. Both determinations persist after manifestation: under the consideration of necessity there is the One, necessary Reality, present throughout; under the consideration of determinations and possible attributes there are always creatures. The origin of each cluster of the rulings of union and of distinction, through a particular affinity with real unity, is what is designated a rank (*martaba*).

Therefore the Real, glorified and exalted, knows these things with complete knowledge. That correspondence has an effect upon them from His side because it is original in Him, whereas … [continued on p. 152].

Printed p. 152

Asymmetry of divine and creaturely knowledge; decree and measure

MSH-P152 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): …their correspondence does not produce that knowledge in them, because in them it is derivative and therefore weak. Affinity may be common to two terms, but its power differs according to the rank of each. What the relationship between God and creation, or creation and God, ultimately refers to is precisely this rank. Its operation at the level of God, whose unity is original, is

incomparably greater than at the level of creatures, whose unity is derivative through existence. Without this distinction, the two knowledges would be equal merely because both parties share a correspondence. Understand.

Qūnawī: When I began composing this text, I was told inwardly, in the course of writing, that the rulings attributed to unity and to the one Real, expressed as the rulings of necessity, have, as viewed from unity, a single foundational ruling: the reality of *qaḍāʾ* (decree). The *maqādīr* (measures) are the effect of the manifold determinations of the objects of knowledge relative to that single ruling. The appearance of existence in accordance with those differentiations involves first a reception of influence and then an exercise of influence among the enumerated things, by restoring to them the effects proper to them. Know this, consider the strange matter to which I have drawn attention, and you will attain a rare knowledge. God is the guide.

Al-Mahāʾimī: This expands the explanation of the perfection of divine knowledge in both its undifferentiated and detailed aspects. The former is called decree; the latter, measure or determination, without excluding either from the comprehensiveness of the divine Essence. The rulings attributed to unity—namely the first determination—and to the One Real—namely the second determination or degree of divinity—are called rulings of necessity. But their ultimate origin, when viewed from unity, is one ruling: the reality of decree, or the divine knowledge of His Essence in His Essence. In the degree of the first determination, these rulings are not actually multiple, so union with the objects of knowledge is most intense there. This is why one is obliged to accept the decree with contentment.

As for the measured determinations, their meaning is that each object of knowledge occurs in its apportioned measure of time, place and accompanying accidents. These measures result from the differentiations of the objects of knowledge originally embraced potentially by unity under the one ruling, insofar as that ruling relates to the objects after relating to the Essence that comprehends them. The result is that each object seeks what its own nature can receive, either immediately or through another. Union at this level is less intense than at the first, and this is the detailed knowledge that constitutes the domain of measure (*qadar*).

Finally, the existence of the One Real appears, according to His names and the differences among those objects of knowledge, first with efficacy in the higher ranks of the intellects and souls, and again in the levels beneath them.

Printed p. 153

The dispositions of the fixed entities and the meaning of qadar

MSH-P153 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

[Editorial heading: The dispositions of the fixed entities and the meaning of qadar]

[Continuation of al-Mahāʾimī]: Those lower levels are bodies and corporeal things. Their existence appears through the return to the enumerated things of the determinate effects already proper to them in the state in which their fixed entities subsisted. Eternal knowledge of these things is thereby complete also in this respect: in their manifested state they do not differ from what they are in the sphere of measure. Under one consideration they are united with the single existence; even when their particular effects are considered, they are also the very objects of knowledge, since they are restored rather than independent in every respect.

Qūnawī's injunction to 'know this' means that it is an unusual knowledge not found in books, disclosing the meaning of decree and predestination in a way not previously explained. God guides one to the verification of such sciences, which discursive thoughts cannot attain and ordinary sight does not perceive.

[Editorial heading: Opening of Text Thirteen: the limit of knowledge of created things]

Al-Mahāʾimī (introducing the next text): This noble text explains the remaining secrets of the subject. It states the furthest attainable degree of knowledge of things other than God, and the degree of union possible with them. The utmost such union occurs in the mirror of eternal divine knowledge. Things are intrinsically different from one another; God cannot be known as He is in Himself, because what has no being of its own cannot become united with existence as such. He is unknowable from the aspect of unqualified absoluteness, for the conditioned qua conditioned cannot be united with the absolute qua absolute. Moreover, His determinations are without end, just as human states are without end. One therefore knows Him in relation to the correspondence between such states and His determinations, which are His names; knowledge of His names and intrinsic modalities is thereby conditioned. Within these limits one comes to know His decree and measure.

Qūnawī: Know that the highest degree of knowledge of any thing whatsoever, **except the Real**, consists in knowing it through a knowledge arising from a complete vision of it in God's knowledge. This knowledge has two signs. The first is that what you have learned frees you from having to examine it again and again in the hope of increasing your understanding. For an increase in knowledge after a prior claim to know the thing indicates that the first knowledge was deficient. Had it been perfect from the outset, further acquisition would be unnecessary, as is the case with God's knowledge. Such completeness depends upon knowledge that completely encompasses its object.

Al-Mahāʾimī (page breaks at this point): The highest degree of knowledge available to created knowers, whether human beings or angels, concerns a thing other than the Real, whether immediately evident or reached by reasoning. To know the Real as He knows Himself is impossible, as was explained and will be explained

again. One knows the thing in this highest degree when the very thing and its reality are shown within divine knowledge, through the removal of the veils between it and … [continued on p. 154].

Printed p. 154

Knowing a thing by seeing it in divine knowledge

MSH-P154 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing from p. 153): …your heart, with all of its receptive powers, so that the thing is disclosed fully, without its being lost to awareness by reason of annihilation (*fanāʾ*). This differs from grasping a thing through discursive definitions, which, before complete purification, are usually accompanied by mistaken imagination and corrupt fancies. That is why one sees even accomplished rational investigators disagreeing about definitions despite their exertions.

The first of the two signs that this knowledge has been attained is that the certainty acquired by tasted experience (*dhawq*), with the purity of the heart and the keenness of the soul, makes further repeated inquiry unnecessary. Such repetition might otherwise occur through reason or unveiling, even if the original discovery had been achieved by inquiry after purification and the cultivation of these capacities. The repetition cannot be needed simply to impress the knowledge upon the heart, since it is already firmly established there, and the concomitant properties of the known can be deduced from it.

An attempt to increase one's knowledge after claiming already to possess complete knowledge is possible only where the first knowledge was deficient. Were the first knowledge exhaustive in every respect, an increase would seek an aspect already possessed. This would be the impossible acquisition of what is already acquired. Since divine knowledge is perfect in every respect, its supposed increase is impossible. He may, however, seek to unfold in detail what He already knows completely in His Essence, so that knowledge relates to it in an active mode. The kind of knowledge which renders further inquiry unnecessary depends on encompassing everything about the known; since a conditioned knower cannot encompass the unconditioned Real, this cannot occur in any creature's knowledge of God.

Qūnawī: The second sign indicating that this knowledge has been acquired and is sound is that the reach of one's knowledge extends throughout the thing and goes beyond its restriction, until one sees its furthest limit as connected to the absoluteness of the Real.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The second sign confirms both the acquisition of knowledge through wholly seeing the thing in God's knowledge and its validity. Unlike the first sign, which merely shows that the thing is known, this also permits knowledge of why it is so. Qūnawī says it is a sign *from which one draws an inference*: there is an evidential

path here analogous to rational demonstration. It is that knowledge extends to all the thing's parts, accidental features and different respects; then it passes beyond it to what is above it, through its essential constituents and accidents; and in turn to what is above those, repeatedly, until the utmost horizon of the thing comes into sight ... [the argument continues on p. 155].

Printed p. 155

The horizon of the known and the inexhaustibility of divine manifestation

MSH-P155 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continued): ...and the conceptions of everything above it, until its furthest conceivable boundary is seen as connected with the Real's absoluteness, beyond which there is nothing. Only then is the thing known with complete knowledge. This requires seeing the thing within God's knowledge, which comprehends the beginning, the end and every intermediate connection, without limit.

The first sign has already implied that one cannot possess such complete knowledge of God, because His determinations are without end and the finite cannot encompass that which has no limit. The first passage therefore left the point implicit; here it is stated expressly.

Qūnawī: Knowledge of the Real is not of this sort. It attaches to Him only insofar as He becomes determined within a degree, a locus of manifestation, a state, an aspect, or a consideration. Whenever He is delimited for the knower through a determination under one of these heads, there becomes apparent and determinate to that knower, from the absolute Essence and according to the state of the recipient of disclosure, something that was not determined for that person before.

Al-Mahāʾimī: No human knowledge of the Real can run through Him and then transcend Him in the way just described. Such knowledge concerns Him through some definite level, such as *aḥadiyya* or *wāḥidiyya*; through a manifesting locus, such as spirits or bodies; through the states of manifestation and hiddenness; through the considerations of absoluteness and restriction; or through the consideration that none of these restricts Him, without any contradiction. Each of these is a determination, whereas real absoluteness is a negative notion. At any given moment the knower receives from the absolute Essence a new determination appropriate to the state of the recipient, distinct from what was delimited previously. But where is the unconditioned absoluteness in such apprehensions? To comprehend it would require comprehending all that lay beyond an individual determination, thus conditioning the absolute by what could be conceptualized beyond it.

Qūnawī next argues that divine determinations are inexhaustible: some of them can certainly be conceived, but there is no final determination enclosing all the rest, for this is the rank of absoluteness.

Qūnawī: Just as the human being's states do not reach any fixed terminal boundary, so the determinations of the Real and the varieties of His manifestation to humanity are inexhaustible, occurring in proportion to human states—which themselves are determinations of the absolute Essence of the Real and varieties of His disclosure.

Qūnawī (continuing): It has already been pointed out elsewhere that the names are names of states and that states alternate over the entities ... [continued on p. 156].

Printed p. 156

States, names and the impossibility of encompassing the Real

MSH-P156 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

[Continuation of the discussion of Text Thirteen]

Qūnawī: By contrast, the Real turns through the states, as the Most High says, “Every day He is upon some affair” (Qurʾān 55:29). Understand; do not interpret the matter away. Endeavour instead first to see it directly. Believe, submit, and you will be safe. God alone gives success and inspiration.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Human states do not reach a final state after which none is possible. Their change and succession is a matter of observation. Since they are determinations of the absolute Essence and varieties in the appearances of that Essence, the Real's determinations and modes of disclosure to human beings have no final limit. A determination differs from a variety of manifestation: the former is a cause of manifestation insofar as it is surrounded by the qualifying attributes that bring the manifestation about; the latter is the diversity of appearances occasioned by diverse determinations. Because human states and attributes constitute loci in which the Essence appears under the consideration of attributes, their diversity occasions diversity of manifestation, and each manifestation entails a determinate relation of correspondence. Human states thus serve as qualifying conditions for such differentiations. The divine names, under which the Real becomes determined, are names in relation to those human states, which mediate the diversity of manifestation and hence of determinations.

The Qurʾānic statement that He is engaged in an affair each day (55:29) has elsewhere been used to indicate that these affairs are inexhaustible: the days do not terminate, so neither do the affairs. Since the divine affairs stand in relation to the fixed entities and the comprehensive human being includes all of these, the states of the human being are likewise inexhaustible, as are the resulting varieties of manifestation and determinations. It is therefore impossible to encompass them. How,

then, could one reach their furthest end and proceed beyond them to circumscribe what lies beyond? Understand. Do not reinterpret this statement away, for it is intended as stated; seek to witness it. Believe first and submit, rather than mistakenly claim to know what cannot be known, namely the Real through every one of His determinations. God grants this realization, which is the realization of the limits of knowing; He inspires surrender where attainment has been found impossible. God knows best.

[Opening of Text Fourteen, on the same printed page.] Al-Mahāʾimī: Qūnawī designates the following text an exalted text. The preceding discussion established that the Real is united with all things, and therefore knows them perfectly, whereas creatures cannot be united with Him in the same fashion and so cannot know Him through all His determinations, much less in absolute freedom from determination. The present text explains the cause of this majestic greatness that veils the union, which is why it is called an exalted text. Its explanation begins with the fact that union, in ... [continued on p. 157].

Printed p. 157

Every absolute has a face toward restriction

MSH-P157 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): ...absoluteness, predominates, so multiplicity does not appear there, although it has an aspect toward finitude with which it is united. Restriction also has an aspect toward absoluteness, but this does not predominate in it and therefore does not appear there; multiplicity appears instead because it is actual there. To the extent that unity appears within restriction, absoluteness is known, though not as the Absolute knows it.

Qūnawī: Know that no existent described as absolute lacks an aspect toward restriction, even if only through becoming a determinate object of the thought of some thinker or several thinkers. Nor is there any existent judged to be restricted that lacks an aspect toward absoluteness. Yet none knows this except one who knows things completely, after knowing the Real and knowing everything one knows through Him. Whoever has not tasted this vision has not realized true knowledge of either God or creation.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Every existent describable as absolute has, without exception, some aspect toward restriction: either it already bears a determination or can bear one without being confined to it. This is the respect in which the Real is united with creation, creation with the Real, and some creatures with others. The least restriction is that the absolute becomes distinguished as an object in someone's understanding. The conception of a thing requires that it be represented through a likeness by which it is distinguished from other things, whether essentially or accidentally, even at the

level of a single instance. Thus the absolute is restricted in an individual's conception without ceasing to be absolute in itself; and in the conceptions of many thinkers it receives representations that are numerically distinct, especially where those representations differ from one mind to another.

Equally, anything judged to be restricted has an aspect toward absoluteness. One cannot make a judgment about the absolute without recognizing some character under which to judge it; once recognized, the character may form the apparent limitation. Yet it still has an aspect toward the absolute, because a limiting predicate inheres in something more fundamental than that predicate, to which thought can return. The bearer cannot simply be eliminated while the predicate remains, for an attribute cannot subsist without a subject. Hence the existence in every conditioned existent is the absolute, intrinsically necessary existence of the Real, which is qualified by the attributes of its loci of appearance.

Such a point can be understood only by someone who has fully known that things, considered as quiddities, do not themselves possess existence, but are encountered with existence so that it appears through the mirrors they afford and their descriptions become the qualifications of its manifestation. Nonexistent quiddities are not independently attributes of existence, for this would make what exists bear as an intrinsic attribute its contrary, nonexistence; neither are such quiddities the independently existing bearers of existence. Rather, absolute existence is the bearer, and its apparent qualifications arise through its relation to these quiddities.

Printed p. 158

Quiddity and existence; opening of Text Fifteen

MSH-P158 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing Text Fourteen): Those qualifications become manifest at the level of relation after having been undifferentiated within the absolute Essence. Their proper understanding requires knowing that the Real is absolute existence, which in turn requires knowing that He exists of Himself: He is necessary, incapable of receiving nonexistence or being transformed into it. Nor is He a mere rational concept without external reality; everything is realized through Him, whereas His reality is through Himself. There is no independent existence belonging to any other.

Whoever has not witnessed this station—that existence is absolute, that it appears under qualifications by relation to its loci, and that the quiddities have no being of their own—has not realized what it means to know the Real as absolute existence. The Real is not an accident inhering in quiddities, nor their substrate; thus He is not multiplied or individually determined by their multiplicity. Nor do creatures possess

existence by themselves: they exist through Him, and so remain, considered in themselves, upon the station of nonexistence. The Real, as He always was, has nothing coexistent with Him in beginningless eternity. Understand.

[Opening of Text Fifteen, on the same printed page.]

Qūnawī (title): A text explaining the secret of perfection and *greater perfection*.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The preceding text, in saying that every absolute has an aspect toward qualification, might prompt two mistaken thoughts. First, that qualification detracts from the absolute by excluding other qualifications; second, that it makes the absolute more perfect because it previously lacked that qualification. The present text addresses the first mistake by clarifying the secret of perfection and the second by clarifying the secret of the more perfect, after stating a governing distinction.

Qūnawī: The Real has an intrinsic perfection and a perfection of the divine names whose manifestation depends on bringing the world into being. Viewed in the light of determination, both are perfections of the names; for every judgment made by a judge concerning something presupposes that the thing judged has become determinate in the judge's conception. Were the Essence not conceived before the names were predicated of it, and distinguished from everything else through its independence in possessing existence, one could not judge it to possess intrinsic perfection. Every determination through which the Real is conceived is one of His names, since among the realizers the names are nothing but determinations of the Real. Hence every perfection predicated of the Real may, under this consideration, be called a perfection of the names. Conversely, insofar as the emanation of the divine names from the presence of His unity is an entailment of His Essence, all the perfections predicated of Him are intrinsic.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The perfection inseparable from the Real admits two considerations. Under one consideration it is divided into intrinsic perfection and perfection of the names. Intrinsic perfection is that whose existence and manifestation depend on nothing: it is manifest to His Essence in His Essence, beginninglessly and endlessly, without dependence on determinations or restrictions. In this respect the Real is independent of all worlds. As for the perfection of the names, although its existence does not ... [continued on p. 159].

Printed p. 159

Three accounts of intrinsic and nominal perfection

MSH-P159 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): ...depend on anything, its manifestation and actual realization depend on bringing the world into existence, because the names are relations between the Essence and things, and a relation is realized only through both

of its terms. This does not mean that the Essence gains a perfection it lacked. Rather, it concerns the perfection of its manifestation in loci, after its perfect manifestation to itself.

Under a second consideration, both are perfections of the names: to judge that the Real possesses perfection, one must first conceive what is being judged. Such a conception distinguishes the subject from what lies outside it, however slightly—even, for example, through our conceiving it before the names are attributed to it or through our distinguishing its independence in the possession of existence. Anything distinguished in relation to something else is in that respect determined. Every determination through which the Real is conceived is called a divine name among the realizers, for names are, considered as bare relations, non-existent in themselves and cannot be independent causes of existence. They are in truth determinations of the Real under such relations. Thus there is no predication of perfection without some determination, and both modes of perfection may be called nominal, even when their manifestation does not depend on bringing anything else into existence.

Under a third consideration, both perfections are intrinsic. Those called intrinsic under the first consideration are plainly so. The others also spring from the presence of divine unity. From the presence of His unity (*waḥda*) are derived *aḥadiyya* and *wāḥidiyya*, and the names arise from *wāḥidiyya*. What arises from something which itself arises from the Essence ultimately arises from the Essence. Moreover, its being made manifest is already included in what the Essence entails, for the names are enfolded within it. Hence all the perfections ascribed to the Real may be ascribed to His Essence under this consideration. Understand.

Qūnawī: When this has been settled, we say that one whose perfection is from his own Essence cannot be diminished in that perfection by outward accidents and concomitant features in certain levels of manifestation—as though these could undermine it.

Al-Mahāʾimī: This addresses the first apparent difficulty. Perfection that belongs to a thing essentially is its perfection eternally. It is not impaired when, relative to a level or a manifesting locus, it is accompanied by contingent and passing restrictions or by externally associated, more persistent concomitants. Even when those qualifications exclude other or opposite qualifications, they cannot damage intrinsic perfection … [continued p. 160].

Printed p. 160

Qualification neither diminishes nor adds to the divine Essence

MSH-P160 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continued): ...because an attribute attaches to the Real under the consideration of a particular level, not at every other level. He thus remains absolute and, as absolute, perfect. In the first distinction, which separates intrinsic from nominal perfection, the Essence is not altered as names vary any more than it is multiplied by their multiplicity. A particular name's absence at a given level entails no deficiency in the absolute Essence. In the second account, where all perfections are regarded as nominal, every perfection remains in the first determination even if it is not manifest in later determinations; what is absent in one rank is not thereby absent from another. In the third, where all are intrinsic, the Essence is the source of every rank: the source of the first is thereby the source of what proceeds from it, and ultimately the source of all perfections. Understand.

Qūnawī: Nor is it permissible to imagine that its perfection contains a deficiency that is then made good by such attributes. Rather, in certain levels, external accidents and concomitants can make apparent the quality of its *greater perfection*; knowledge that this is its manner is itself among those excellences.

Al-Mahāʾimī: This resolves the second difficulty. Qualification does not perfect an Absolute that had previously been defective. Essential perfection remains as it always was, while a description of greater perfection becomes manifest, by means of qualifications and concomitants, at levels such as that of the Perfect Human, where divine names appear. This follows readily if intrinsic and nominal perfections are distinguished. If all perfections are called nominal, the perfection belonging to the first determination is unchanged; the additional description of greater perfection belongs to further determinations. And if all are called intrinsic, what belongs to the Essence without mediation remains unchanged, while there is an additional manifestation through intermediaries.

An objection might arise: does this not, after all, make the Essence complete itself through these manifestations? No. The quality of greater perfection appears by the manifestation of the Essence in its own affairs or modalities (*shuʾūn*). These modalities are included within the Essence and already known and present there; therefore they gain no perfection that was previously absent. What is added is only the relation of their appearing in manifesting loci, and a relation, as such, is not another independently existing perfection. The author mentions knowledge of this state because, in the rank of absoluteness, these affairs are not differentiated but remain enfolded or potential; one cannot ascribe to what is merely potential the completed appearance belonging to the level of determination.

[Opening of Text Sixteen on the same printed page.] Al-Mahāʾimī: Qūnawī calls the next text a very noble text. Having just examined perfection, which is a *description*, he must now consider what is described, as it is known through its true levels. [The explanation continues on p. 161.]

Printed p. 161

The Reality knows Himself without an additional image

MSH-P161 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): The text is noble because it comprehends all the realities described by perfection, and exceedingly noble because it imparts complete knowledge of the subjects and their attributes.

Qūnawī: The reality of the Real consists of the form of His knowledge of Himself, inasmuch as that knowledge is determined through its relation to Himself, under the consideration in which knowledge, the knower and the known are one.

Al-Mahāʾimī: What essentially distinguishes the Real from everything else is the form of His knowledge of Himself. Were such a form hypothetically distinct from what it represents, it would correspond perfectly to it. Here, however, the point is the necessary self-relation of knowledge entailed by His conception of Himself. This excludes consideration of God's self-knowledge through His appearance in the loci of manifestation, or through the conception other knowers possess of Him. Nor does His knowledge of Himself involve an added intelligible image standing over against a separately existing subject, with another relation joining them. Such an image would veil the known, and God is exalted above this. It would also introduce multiplicity into the first determination, which is simple from every point of view. Rather, knowing, knower and known are one, because neither the image nor its relation adds something to what is imaged. This excludes the differentiated self-knowledge ascribed under the degree of the names.

Qūnawī: His intrinsic attribute, which is not other than His Essence, is a unicity of comprehensiveness—an all-gathering oneness beyond which no gathering, relation or consideration can be conceived.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Qūnawī mentions the intrinsic attribute because it is through such an attribute that the Essence is known to the highest degree available to the knower. It is not other than the Essence in what it refers to, even if the concepts of subject and attribute differ. Without conceptual difference there could be no meaningful predication of an attribute of a subject. The intrinsic attribute is the unique comprehension of existence and all its ranks and descriptions. Nothing more comprehensive can be conceived, for it comprehends both unity as distinguished from differentiation and unity as gathering differentiation, without either opposing the other or restricting the comprehensiveness to one side. There is no special relation

confining it to gathering rather than differentiation, nor an unqualified absoluteness superadded to it as a further consideration. It comprehends both the unrestricted and the conditioned without being confined by the very description of comprehending them.

Qūnawī: Actual realization of this attribute through witnessing, and complete knowledge of it, consist in knowing that in every determinate thing the Real may be judged determinate according to what makes Him apprehensible in it under determination, while also knowing that He is not confined by that determination and that, considered as He is in Himself, He is undetermined.

Printed p. 162

The Real as known in loci of manifestation

MSH-P162 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: To witness this attribute truly, so that one's seeing amounts to the eye or reality of certainty, and to know it completely with the certainty of knowledge, is to recognize the Real in every thing determined as a rank, a branch, or an individual. One may judge the Real determinate in that thing, not because His Essence is intrinsically limited, but because the senses or intellect, or His self-disclosure under names proper to the rank, make Him apprehensible there in a particular manner. The witness must know that He is not restricted by determination at all, much less by the particular determination presently encountered; considered in Himself He is not determined. His appearing in different forms depends on ranks. He therefore retains the purity of His absoluteness while appearing in a determinate locus. To know this is to know an all-embracing unity beyond which no other union, relation or consideration can be placed. Since the attribute had been declared identical in reality with the Essence, Qūnawī now explains this identification.

Qūnawī: This is the form of His knowledge of Himself. Thus He knows His Essence as determinate relative to His manifestation in things according to those things, and relative to one who witnesses Him only in a locus; yet He also knows, exalted is He, that considered in Himself He is undetermined, even at the very moment when He is judged determinate, because the apprehension of one who perceives Him only through a locus is limited—whether that locus is regarded as the very reality appearing or as other than it.

Al-Mahāʾimī: God's being present in each determinate thing in a way that warrants judgment about His appearance there—while not being confined to it and while remaining undetermined in Himself—is what the form of divine self-knowledge signifies. If such a form were an addition, it would perfectly correspond to His reality. In divine self-knowledge the Essence is understood as determinate relative to its appearances in the determinate things, in proportion to their receptive aptitudes,

without thereby becoming confined by them. It is also known in relation to the one who sees it only in a locus. Such a person's knowledge is a shadowed participation in divine knowledge as it relates to that person's fixed entity. But God knows, under another consideration not restricted to this relational knowledge, that He is Himself undetermined, even when a creature judges Him determined. This further consideration is not the very same as God's knowing Himself in connection with that limited knower, because a knowledge of something follows what its object is; only the creature perceiving Him under a particular limitation knows Him through that limitation alone. This limitation of apprehension applies when the locus is taken as identical with what appears: for example, someone sees God restricted to some manifest things and confines Him there, or instead places Him in all the loci but still confines Him to them. In respect of His knowledge as it relates to these people, He knows Himself … [continued on p. 163].

Printed p. 163

Divine reality and the essential poverty of creation

MSH-P163 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continued): …In either case the Real knows the person under the aspect of that person's conception of Him, whether the conception is gravely mistaken or true in one respect; and in another aspect He knows Himself as unqualified by that person's conception. Consider this.

Qūnawī: The reality of creation consists in the form of their Lord's knowledge of them; their intrinsic quality is *poverty*, which makes manifest absolute richness—but not just any sort of poverty. Understand.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The essential reality distinguishing creatures from the Real, despite the unity of existence, is their form as known in their Lord's knowledge at the second determination. The realities intended here are the fixed entities (*aʿyān thābita*), not the intrinsic modalities (*shuʾūn*): the latter are the reality of those fixed entities, rather than directly the reality of created things. The intrinsic quality entailed by their nature without mediation is dependence on God: dependence upon Him for the establishment of their intelligible realities in His knowledge, for the existence that appears through them, and for the qualities by which they are known. Such dependence gives expression to the unrestricted self-sufficiency of the Real. The poverty of which Qūnawī speaks is the poverty whose recognition brings to light divine richness; not every species of dependence is the intrinsic quality of creation. For example, the divine names' dependence upon loci for their manifestation is not itself that same creaturely poverty. Understand.

[Opening of Text Seventeen on the same printed page.] Al-Mahāʾimī: The following text is called exceedingly noble because the preceding teaching, that the Real's manifestation follows the receptive character of the loci, could suggest He lacks true essential attributes—contrary to reason, transmitted revelation and consensus. The new text therefore examines transcendence or incomparability (*tanzīh*) in its different formulations, identifying what is sound in them. Its nobility lies in joining incomparability and resemblance while affirming every perfection of God without making other things partners with Him, and in declaring Him beyond all descriptions. The resulting insight is deeper than unaided rational understanding or the surface of revealed wording.

Qūnawī: The fruit of rational incomparability is to distinguish the Real from what is called other than Him through negative attributes, out of concern for imagined deficiencies that are posited in minds but do not occur in existence. The fruit of scripturally expressed incomparability is to deny existential plurality and partnership in the rank of divinity, even as Scripture affirms a sharing in certain positive attributes without equality or likeness.

This is indicated in the expressions “God is the best of providers” (Qurʾān 62:11), “the best of creators” (23:14), “the most merciful of those who show mercy” (7:151), and “God is greater” ... [the source reference and continuation follow on p. 164].

Printed p. 164

The inadequacy of purely negative transcendence

MSH-P164 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Continuation: ...[the printed source cites Qurʾān 9:72], and similar expressions.

Editorial source note: Q 9:72 says “approval from God is greater”; the source’s short phrase “God is greater” is not a verbatim quotation of that verse.

Al-Mahāʾimī: God is declared incomparable through reason, revealed law and unveiling, but their modes of incomparability are not the same. Reason exempts Him from certain features because it regards them as deficiencies. By excluding these, reason attributes to Him negative qualifications opposite to them. The rational procedure thus distinguishes the Real from other things by such negations. Qūnawī does not approve of this form of incomparability: deficiencies, as deficiencies, are privative considerations and cannot belong to existence in itself. Everything that actually exists has perfection insofar as it exists. Deficiency is posited by the understanding when a manifestation occurs in one locus rather than another. Nor is there contradiction within existence as such; opposition belongs to comparisons between definite ranks.

The author speaks of its *fruit*, but he does not approve of this fruit either: the Real is distinguished from what is other than Him only through considerations, not because attributes exist in other things that are absent from the Real. This would prevent the Real from embracing all perfections and would fail to establish the most complete unity.

As for the incomparability communicated by the outward sense of Scripture, the expressions of the Book, the Sunna and the public statements of learned authorities exclude a partner, equal or like in the rank of divinity. Its consequence is the denial of several independently existing gods. Qūnawī specifies existential plurality rather than merely conceptual plurality. Yet even this is not the whole matter, for revealed speech also attributes such positive perfections as hearing, seeing, life, knowledge, power, will and speech to creatures, without equating them with divine attributes. The denial of likeness does not abolish attribution of the same general terms under unequal modes. In speaking of God as the *best* of providers and creators, and the most merciful of the merciful, Scripture itself retains a grammatical comparison with other providers and merciful agents. The surface reading, taken to deny all commonality whatsoever, is therefore incomplete; a fuller understanding must reconcile the scriptural expressions. That is the work of the incomparability disclosed through unveiling (*kashf*).

Qūnawī (opening of the account of unveiled incomparability): The incomparability understood by the people of unveiling is to affirm the Real's universal comprehensiveness without limiting Him to the description of comprehending; it distinguishes the rulings proper to the various divine names. Not every ruling may rightly be attributed to every name. Indeed, among the names … [continued on p. 165].

Printed p. 165

Incomparability through unveiled comprehensiveness

MSH-P165 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): …are some to which certain rulings cannot possibly be attributed, although those rulings belong to other names. The same applies to attributes. Among the fruits of unveiled incomparability is the negation of what is other, while retaining numerical determination. This involves no positing of a deficiency that must be negated, nor conceiving a perfection that needs to be added to the Real through some further affirmation. Peace.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Here the author states the very principle of incomparability rather than merely its consequence, signalling that this mode of transcendence, unlike the preceding conceptions, is valid from the outset. Under unveiled incomparability, nothing is excluded from the Reality's comprehensiveness; yet that

comprehensiveness does not enclose or delimit Him. He is present in differentiation as well as in unity. The Real thus has a unity comprehending both gathering and distinction, taken together and separately. This concerns the Essence.

For the names, unveiled incomparability means not attributing to one name every ruling that applies to another. Certain rulings cannot belong to a name *qua* that name, even though they belong to another. The Essence comprehends them all: the rulings of the name that abases cannot, *as such*, be assigned to the name that exalts, and vice versa. Qūnawī therefore makes the authentic principle and its fruit explicit. The negation of a separate 'other' follows from comprehensiveness, while the numerical distinction of appearances remains. Were every numerical distinction simply erased, differentiation would have no place and the Real would be confined to pure gathering. Thus what is called other than Him under one consideration is not independent of Him under another.

Nor does this imply an original deficiency in the Essence that is overcome by including all things. All their possibilities are comprehended there, so the Essence is not deficient; no new event alters it. Similarly, one cannot suppose that the Real acquires a perfection through some newly affirmed creaturely attribute. The Real is essentially perfect, and the perfections displayed under restriction belong in reality to Him as the ground of their manifestation.

The author's concluding expression 'peace' may be read as a salutation of those who practise this unveiled incomparability and avoid the limitation of the earlier viewpoints. Thus the Qurʾānic conclusion is appropriate: 'Glory be to your Lord, Lord of might, beyond what they describe' (37:180), for creatures' formulations of incomparability and resemblance do not exhaust Him; 'peace be upon the messengers' (37:181), because of the correctness of the transcendence they convey; and 'praise be to God, Lord of the worlds' (37:182), for He comprehends the whole without diminution or change and all perfections belong to Him. Understand.

Printed p. 166

Text Eighteen — How a locus determines the mode of presence

MSH-P166 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī: A noble text.

Al-Mahāʾimī: In the preceding text it was said that all things subsist in the Real, although the Eternal cannot be the receptive locus of originated events. Earlier, it had been said that the Real pervades all things, although the Eternal is too exalted to be contained in the originated. This noble text removes that apparent difficulty, since it explains how something originated may be described as eternal under one consideration, and how the Eternal may be described as newly appearing under another. He did not make it a defining limit (*ḥadd*), in view of what had been stated

earlier: every absolute has an aspect toward restriction, and conversely. [Reading note: the 2008 print has *ḥaddan*, “a limit/definition.” The context may suggest *jiddan*, “exceedingly,” referring to the degree of praise in the heading, but that conjecture is not adopted here.]

Qūnawī: The manner in which anything is in something else follows the character of its locus, whether that locus is intelligible or formal. Consequently, the possible objects of knowledge, insofar as their determinations are established and inscribed in the knowledge of the Real, are described as pre-eternal. Likewise, everything determined in divine knowledge bears, under another aspect, the ruling of origination: the existence of the world and the knowledge possessed by its inhabitants are originated and receptive, unlike the existence and knowledge of the Real. Know this, and, if God wills, you will be rightly guided.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The establishment of any state in a locus is qualified as originated or pre-eternal in accordance with the locus, even if considered in itself that state would not be so qualified. This is true whether the locus is intelligible, such as the Creator's knowledge or created intellects, or formal, as in elemental bodies.

The possible objects of knowledge are originated by their own nature. Nevertheless, they are described as pre-eternal insofar as their determinations subsist in the eternal divine knowledge: what is established in that knowledge as an object of knowledge is not something temporally superadded to it. One must not make divine knowledge a place in which new events come to be. The same determined objects, which are described as eternal insofar as they are known by God, are subject to the ruling of origination insofar as they exist externally. The being of the cosmos and the knowledge of its inhabitants are originated in their outward existence, for they are receptive of and dependent on God's existence and knowledge.

This is not the case with the existence and knowledge of the Real, which are eternal considered in themselves. When originated things appear, the ancient existence and knowledge may be described as newly appearing **with respect to manifestation and relation**, not through an origination in themselves. The Eternal is related to the originated and thus receives a relative description without changing in His own reality. Understand this and you will reconcile the outward law (*sharīʿa*) and the inner reality (*ḥaqīqa*) at the point from which pure divine unity proceeds, if God wills.

Printed p. 167

Text Nineteen: Why the absolute cannot be named as though it were another thing

MSH-P167 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī: A noble text, among the noblest, most majestic and most comprehensive statements of the universal principles of divine and cosmic knowledge.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The preceding text examined a thing under the aspect of the locus in which it is established; the present text considers what belongs to it under the aspect of itself. It discusses the divine realities: the Essence, its essential names and their rulings, their effects and their efficacy through the Essence, its knowledge and its unity; the way its knowledge acts as a mirror of the Essence and names and as the source of multiplicity; and the ranks, their relations and the arising of some from others. The text is noble because it gathers the results of the previous texts, majestic because it includes their premises, and comprehensive because it unites beginnings and ends.

Qūnawī: Know that the application of the name *Essence* (*dhāt*) is true of the Real only in respect of His determination: that first determination which, in the conception of creatures other than the perfected, comes after an imagined absoluteness whose nature is unknown and which has no name. That supposed absoluteness is a negative description of the Essence, imagined as distinct from every determination. The affirmative reality actually given, however, is the first determination.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Beginners in this discipline sometimes suppose that the name *Essence* belongs to the Real under the aspect of sheer absoluteness. But this absoluteness is a negative meaning, without a known attribute or a name. They call it the unseen of the Real because, according to their supposition, it stands above everything. If *Essence* named something below this absoluteness, the absoluteness would be above the divine Essence; yet all agree that nothing is above Him.

The supposition derives from the reasoning that every determination is preceded by non-determination, and that non-determination is absoluteness. Qūnawī corrects it. The word *Essence* signifies the Real under consideration of the first determination, since there is, by agreement, no name preceding it. To make *Essence* the name of something prior to that determination contradicts the very assertion that the supposed prior absoluteness is not circumscribed by being an essence, just as it is not circumscribed by any description. Moreover, the Real's intelligible determination in His knowledge of Himself is considered at the first determination: what has not been conceived under that aspect by the Real cannot be conceived as something superordinate by another knower, so that the name *Essence* could be applied to it.

What the unperfected understand as a prior absoluteness is thus a mental supposition formed by contrast with various modes of absoluteness and restriction. It is a negative description, not another entity higher than the Real. Something can stand above another only if it is itself something. If one objects that it must be something because it is distinguished from all determination, the answer is that this distinction is posited by imagination … [continued on p. 168].

Printed p. 168

First determination, essential names and the two presences

MSH-P168 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): ...just as imagination posits non-determination above every determination. Yet non-determination is a negative consideration and therefore cannot genuinely be above or prior to what is determined. The first determination alone is the affirmative reality at issue. Accordingly, *the divine Essence* is a name applied there, not a name for a non-existent abstraction. Certainly one may describe the Essence negatively as not confined by either absoluteness or restriction. That is an account relative to the ranks, not an additional state prior to the first determination. Because it commonly figures in ordinary people's conception, they imagine it to precede that first determination. Understand.

Qūnawī: The Essence intrinsically comprehends the essential names, the keys of the unseen; and the referent of the name *Essence* is in no respect other than its names. The names, however, differ from and oppose one another; and again they are united with one another from the standpoint of the Essence that comprehends them all.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The first determination intrinsically includes the essential names, the keys of the unseen and of the divine relations: the Living, the Knowing, the Powerful, the Willing, the Hearing, the Seeing and the Speaking. Were these names present only through a further intermediary, that intermediary, rather than the essential names themselves, would be the key of the unseen.

An objection might be raised: if the first determination included several names, it would no longer be the first determination but already the presence of the names. The answer is that in the first presence the One named by the term *Essence* differs in no respect from His names. In their own presence, the second determination, the names differ conceptually from one another, sometimes oppose one another in their rulings, and also agree in the comprehending Essence. Thus they may be predicated of one another in one respect and all of them predicated of the Essence.

Editorial clarification: Unity at the first determination does not abolish the names; their differentiation at the second does not posit a plurality of independent essences.

Qūnawī: Unicity (*aḥadiyya*) is an attribute of the determination, not of the absolute being determined, since the absolute has no name and no attribute.

Editorial note: An explanatory footnote to *aḥadiyya* is present in the online transcription but is not represented here as part of Qūnawī's or al-Mahāʾimī's running medieval text. The argument continues on p. 169.

Printed p. 169

Aḥadiyya, wāḥidiyya, and efficacy without a separate intermediary

MSH-P169 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: This anticipates an objection. How can the Essence include the essential realities expressed by the names if it is called *Essence* at its first determination, when only the Essence alone can be conceived? Is it not called unicity precisely because the names are not distinguished there? How, then, can it comprehend them under that aspect?

Qūnawī's reply is that absolute indetermination, as such, does not become determined and has neither name nor attribute. Hence it cannot itself be described as determination or unicity. In the consideration of *aḥadiyya* the names are not distinguished; in that of *wāḥidiyya* the names are taken into account. Yet the Essence is more comprehensive than the descriptions of it as either unicity or unitive plurality, and can therefore comprehend the names without their becoming separately distinguished in the first consideration. Understand.

Qūnawī: From the standpoint of these names, insofar as the Essence does not differ from them, we say that the Real acts by the Essence. Understand.

Al-Mahāʾimī: This follows from the names' non-otherness in relation to the Essence. The realized knowers can therefore say that the Essence effects things without an intermediary. On the other hand, the Essence considered solely in itself is self-sufficient beyond the worlds, so the operation of the names must also be acknowledged. Yet those names are the very Essence at the rank of unicity, and are included by the Essence at the rank of *wāḥidiyya*. Under the former respect and in their actual referent, what appears to be an intermediary is not a second entity standing between the Essence and its effect. Qūnawī's injunction to understand indicates that those who speak of an intermediary also speak truly, but under a different consideration.

Qūnawī: The Essence has just one inseparable concomitant, different from it only relationally; that concomitant is knowledge.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Consider the seven essential names. The Essence has one first concomitant, whether approached under the aspect of *aḥadiyya* or of [*wāḥidiyya*]; the others follow through it, in the order of intelligible dependence. Even this first concomitant is not really separate from the Essence. Under the differentiated aspect of *wāḥidiyya* it is distinct only by relation, and under unicity the knower, knowledge and known are united from every aspect. Thus what might be spoken of as an intermediary between Essence and the other essential names is not an intermediary in any fully independent sense.

He then explains that this concomitant is knowledge, not life. Although knowledge depends upon life, life … [continued on p. 170].

Reading note: At the second occurrence above, the 2008 print repeats *aḥadiyya* (أحديتها أو أحديتها). The bracketed *wāḥidiyya* is a contextual conjecture, not an independently attested reading.

Printed p. 170

The one concomitant, unitive plurality and knowledge as mirror

MSH-P170 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): …is known only through knowledge. The dependence here concerns intelligible apprehension alone; otherwise, all these attributes are beginningless and everlasting.

Qūnawī: The Real's unitive oneness (*waḥdāniyya*) is established in respect of knowledge. In it and through it the rank of divinity and the other ranks and things known become determined, for all are inscribed therein.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Unitive oneness follows the Essence's comprehension of the names, but it is established under consideration of knowledge, because knowledge receives all the intelligible determinations and nothing is thus determined prior to being known in that way. In knowledge and through knowledge the degree of divinity, which is *wāḥidiyya*, becomes determined, as do the other universal ranks and particular objects of knowledge. Qūnawī says both *in it* and *through it* to indicate that determination is a ruling about a determinate object: the intelligible inscription within knowledge is the occasion of that determination, much as it is with the other ranks. Furthermore, what contains all in knowledge encompasses them; what is encompassed is lower in rank than its comprehending principle, and what is lower subsists through what is higher.

Qūnawī: Knowledge is the mirror of the Essence insofar as the Essence comprises the essential names from which it differs in no respect, as already explained. Knowledge is also the source and the spring from which intelligible multiplicity proceeds. I called knowledge a mirror for the known things, and a mirror for the Essence with its essential names, because knowledge, insofar as it is distinguished from the Essence by a conceptual rather than a real distinction, makes the Real's determination conceivable in His understanding of Himself within Himself. Thus His intrinsic knowledge is like a mirror for Him.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Knowledge is the place of the intelligible inscription of all because it mirrors the Essence together with its essential names. Those names are the keys of the unseen; for the Essence to encompass them is to encompass all its intrinsic modes (*shuʾūn*). The Essence appears in the first rank with the essential names precisely because they are not other than it. Its appearance is their appearance.

The modes do not yet appear as distinct in that rank, because their discrimination depends on the discrimination of the names. Although the names appear through the appearance of the Essence, they are not yet differentiated in the first determination. Knowledge, however, mirrors the Essence with those names, and for that reason is the origin and emergence-point of intelligible multiplicity: the distinct meanings represented by the fixed entities. Through it those entities proceed, as intelligibly differentiated, from the first rank and are manifest in the second.

An objection arises: how can knowledge be a *mirror* of the Essence if the essential names are not other than it and knowledge itself is not other than the Essence? A mirror ordinarily differs from what it displays. [Continued p. 171.]

Printed p. 171

Knowledge, self-manifestation and the universal ranks

MSH-P171 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): When one says that knowledge is the mirror of the Essence, the operative term is *like* a mirror. It would be impossible for a thing to depend on itself as on an independent second thing. What makes the expression legitimate is the relative intelligible distinction between divine knowledge and the Essence at the second rank, the distinction made possible by considering the Essence's relation of understanding itself. Through that merely conceptual difference the Real's determination in His self-understanding can be conceived. His very Self is like a mirror for His Self, and since His knowledge is His Self, His intrinsic knowledge may all the more appropriately be called His mirror.

Qūnawī: For this reason we said elsewhere that the reality of the Real is the form of His knowledge of Himself. We also indicated that every manifest thing appearing in a locus differs from that locus in one or more respects, except the Real, who may be the very manifest and the very locus of manifestation. Remember.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Because knowledge is like a mirror of the Essence, differing from it by a relative and conceptual distinction rather than a real one, we said elsewhere—"in Text Fourteen," as this commentary puts it—that the reality of the Real is the form of His knowledge of Himself. Were His knowledge not like a mirror for Him, no form of Him would be inscribed in it. This, too, is figurative language: there is no form there, since knower and known do not differ there and there is no actual multiplicity at the first rank.

To explain this absence of difference between knower and known, he indicated that everything manifest in a locus differs from that locus in one or more respects, except the Real. Here he cites the words, “It bears fruit through nothing, and His very entity does not appear from it,” from the seventh and eighth texts, which he combined. [The quoted wording is awkward in the 2008 print; it has not been silently repaired.] Yet in Text Four he also says: “His true unity, which effaces all considerations, names, relations and attributions, is the Real's conception and apprehension of Himself in respect of His determination.” It is understood from this that, according to this unity, the Real is both the manifest and the locus of manifestation. He says “Remember” so that you may recognize the two passages, the exception and the rule from which it is excepted.

[Cross-reference note: “Text Fourteen” is the printed reference; the self-knowledge discussion occurs under Text Sixteen in the present edition's heading sequence.]

Qūnawī: As for the *ranks* (*marātib*), they are universal determinations encompassed by the single intrinsic concomitant, knowledge. They are like loci passed through by the unrestricted effusion issuing from the Essence, considering the non-otherness of the effusion and its giver, as previously noted in connection with the Real's being manifest and being a locus of manifestation.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The ranks are universal determinations, and universals insofar as they are universal have their being in knowledge. Knowledge, the one intrinsic concomitant, therefore comprehends the ranks. They are inscribed therein just as the Essence is mirrored therein, though their two kinds of inscription must not be confused. The ranks have an additional form in the presence of knowledge, so that they become like loci through which there passes ... [continued on p. 172].

Printed p. 172

The universal ranks modify one unrestricted effusion

MSH-P172 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing from p. 171): The universal effusion from the Essence, in passing through the intelligible ranks, is delimited by the particular capacities of those ranks. It is called unrestricted because the manifest and the locus of manifestation are united at the first determination, the rank of unity. The giver of effusion is the manifest, and the effusion is the locus of manifestation; they are united there. The effusion is qualified only through the additional forms that belong to the ranks as they are inscribed in the divine knowledge.

Qūnawī: The ranks have a share in the reality of producing an effect, though not absolutely: they do so insofar as they are, as I have said, like loci.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Since the effusion becomes differentiated as it traverses the ranks, they contribute to its effective determination. The single unrestricted effusion is qualified and multiplied by the differentiated loci; before these considerations there is no such qualification, because effusion and giver are considered one. But the ranks do not exercise efficacy absolutely. As was shown in Text Four, a thing is an agent in the fullest sense only if it is effective as that very thing, without having to introduce an additional qualification or some external excellence. In the present case, the rank's effect depends precisely on the addition of its function as an intelligible locus. This is a qualified, not absolutely independent, causality.

Qūnawī: Every rank is therefore an intelligible place of disclosure for a group of rulings of existence and possibility. Those rulings branch from the essential names, from the principal divine names, and from the derivative names which follow them.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Each rank is an intelligible mirror for the rulings of necessity and possibility, just as a sensible locus acts upon what appears within it: “The colour of water is the colour of its vessel.” The rulings of necessity concern effective agency; those of possibility concern receptivity. The two kinds are joined in each rank without being simply identical. The former branch from the essential names that do not signify realities added to the Essence—for instance the names *He*, *God*, *Existence*, *Pre-eternal*, *All-knowing*, and *Manifest*. They also branch from the mothers of the divine names, that is, the primary names previously described as the keys of the unseen. The rulings of possibility branch from the following or derivative names, such as Creator, Provider and Fashioner, in their connections to the receptivities of creatures. It is through the rulings of these names that the ranks have the efficacy being discussed. In ultimate truth the efficacious source is the names, and hence the Essence to which they belong. Understand.

Qūnawī (opening of the next sentence): The ranks have fixed entities in the domain of divine knowledge and intelligible apprehension, and ... [continued p. 173].

Printed p. 173

Fixed entities have no independent efficacy

MSH-P173 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): ...they do not exercise an effect independently, but only through existence. Such too is the relation of necessity to the ranks: the ranks are effective, and their ruling is manifest in everything that comes into contact with them and becomes determined with them, through the conditioning of unrestricted effusion as it reaches and passes through the rank.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The text explicitly repeats that it is **the ranks**, not the previously mentioned names, that have fixed entities, lest the pronoun be taken as referring to the nearest antecedent. Their mode of efficacy is that of intelligible loci of the

combined rulings of necessity and possibility. The fixed entities considered as intelligible forms are, under that respect, non-existent externally; the non-existent does not act upon what exists. The qualified effusion, however, is existential and realized externally. Thus the fixed entities possess no independent power to produce it. Their effect is through existence, which carries the rulings of necessity through the essential names, and the rulings of possibility through the derivative names.

Why, then, does Qūnawī not simply attribute the entire effect to existence? Because existence as unrestricted does not, by itself and as unqualified, account for the variety of its concrete appearances. Considered in its unity, the effusion is one; its differentiation depends on the ranks. Their rulings appear in every effusion that relates to them. The relation called 'contact' is not a physical collision. It is the effect's becoming determined at a rank, according to that rank's capacity. An effusion that **arrives and remains** at a rank is conditioned in one manner, whereas an effusion **passing through** it toward another rank is conditioned in another manner. These differences account for why ranks may have an effect even when a disclosure is not arrested within them.

Nor is it enough to give this efficacy exclusively to the rulings of necessity and possibility. Those rulings do not stand alone; they have to be established under the ranks. The resulting causal account therefore considers the intelligible ranks together with the relevant divine and possible rulings. Understand.

Qūnawī: The ranks are like relative endpoints when one considers the course of essential effusion and existential self-disclosure through the stations and degrees determined between eternity without beginning and eternity without end—without a final goal or fixed resting-place.

Al-Mahāʾimī: This answers an objection. If ranks influence effusion only when effusion reaches and is determined at them, how can they condition what merely passes through them? He says that the ranks are relative endpoints, whether one considers effusion as arriving at them—so that their existence endures from eternity without beginning to eternity without end, as with the sanctified spirits—or as passing through them. Some do not endure, and effusion moves from them to others. Even where the share proper to a rank does not pass from it to another, it passes, through the mediation of effusion … [continued on p. 174].

Printed p. 174

Relative termini, perpetual self-disclosure and renewed creation

MSH-P174 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): ...to what it affects below itself. All are therefore relative endpoints; this suffices for the determination of effusion with them and its contact with them.

The ranks are relative endpoints by reference to the journey of essential effusion, that is, existential self-disclosure, through successive stations and degrees. The term *stations* may be applied to those points from which the effusion moves altogether to another place; *degrees* to the remaining differences of order, including those in which a disclosure endures while another proceeds. The series is situated between what is without beginning and what is without end, yet there is no last goal beyond which nothing remains, and no absolute cessation at the point already reached. New creation (*khalq jadīd*) is constantly realized across the instances of manifestation. Movement is treated here as an affirmative existential event, whereas rest, insofar as it is the sheer negation of movement, is privative. Consequently the course of disclosure is ceaseless. A rank thus counts as the end of what has preceded it, but not as the absolute end of what succeeds it. Understand.

Qūnawī: It is now evident from what I have explained that the ranks gather the groups of rulings that stand established within them from the presences of necessity and possibility. They make manifest the results of their conjunction, but according to the ranks themselves—not simply according to the rulings taken alone, nor according to unrestricted effusion alone. Their relation is that of shapes and moulds to things shaped and moulded when these reach and occupy them. This is their efficacy. They are fixed in their intelligible entities; the resulting rulings are traced back to them and ultimately attributed to them, for they are their source and their return. Understand.

Al-Mahāʾimī: A rank gathers the rulings of necessity and possibility that apply to it, and these remain established relative to it, even if a particular effusion passes away from it or affects something else through it. The rulings arise from the divine and necessary names and from the names connected with the possible realm, whose respective presences abide. Accordingly the rulings derived from them also have a stable intelligible place.

The ranks manifest the results produced by the conjunction of the two orders of rulings. The manifestation is ascribed to the rank as the intelligible mirror and place of conjunction, not to the rulings taken in abstraction: without their place of establishment they are not independent agents. Nor can it be attributed merely to unrestricted effusion, which, as such, does not independently produce its own

differentiation. This is clarified by comparing a rank with a shape or mould: the arriving effusion receives a determinate form, while the ranks themselves do not change. For this reason he says: “They are fixed …” [continued on p. 175].

Printed p. 175

The fixed entities, responsibility and the order of the names

MSH-P175 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): The fixed entities of the ranks remain established in the domain of knowledge. The results of the assembled rulings are referred to them, since the effects are the effects of those intelligible realities; the difference of outcomes follows from the difference of the fixed entities. Consequently the variation of recompense is connected with the determinate recipients and their acts, not with the decree itself. These determinate entities are the sites where recompense occurs, while necessity and its rulings do not, by themselves, become recipients of reward or punishment. The ranks are also the points from which the relevant actions proceed. The Qurʾānic expression 'as a recompense for what they used to do' states this relationship. None of this implies that the fixed entities have existence independently of God; their existence is through Him and His self-disclosure. Understand: the point enables the joining of divine determination (*qadar*) and revealed obligation (*sharʿ*).

Qūnawī: Then know that the ranks are linked by the emergence of some from others, and the names are likewise ordered. Divinity, together with its universal names—the Living, the Knowing, the Powerful and the Willing—is a shadow of the Essence insofar as the Essence intrinsically comprises the keys of the unseen. Yet between divinity and the Essence under that aspect there is a subtle difference, disclosed to the perfected in their direct experience. In the divine presence the degree of divinity is conceived as distinct from the principal names just mentioned. The Essence, however, is conceived as different from its essential names only by those veiled from essential self-disclosure. Those to whom essential self-disclosure is granted neither conceive nor witness that kind of separation, except when they consider their knowledge of how the veiled conceive it. Their true distinction follows what I have indicated: the Essence is in no respect other than its essential names, although the names differ among themselves and cannot be separated from the Essence. And the degrees of the keys of the unseen are unequal, some following others; the same has been shown of the derivative divine names, such as Creator, Originator and Fashioner. Remember.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The earlier account treated each rank as a relative terminus; this passage shows that the ranks also have an order in which one proceeds from another, following the corresponding order of the names. The presence of divinity is *wāḥidiyya*, with the four principal names just mentioned. These four are called universal because the Hearing and Seeing are comprehended under the Knowing,

while the Speaking is referred to the Powerful and the Willing. Divinity in that respect is the shadow of the Essence in its *aḥadiyya*, in which the seven essential names are gathered as the keys of the unseen.

Yet if *aḥadiyya* contains the same essential names as *wāḥidiyya*, why are they two ranks? The difference is precise and is understood according to the mode in which names are distinctly conceived and actually manifest. In the rank of divinity the Essence can be conceived as distinct from these names … [continued on p. 176].

Printed p. 176

Self-disclosure, distinction, and ordered names

MSH-P176 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): In the rank of divinity the names are manifested in actual differentiation; in the rank of unicity they are not conceived as different from the Essence, because they are there potentially. Those veiled from this truth speak as though there were no names and attributes at all at the level of the Essence and as though all names belonged exclusively to the divine presence. Some accordingly deny the possibility of essential self-disclosure: they imagine the Essence as stripped of all attributes and therefore unable to disclose itself, given its independence of the worlds; yet self-disclosure necessarily has the meaning of being manifest.

Those to whom the Essence is disclosed do not conceive the distinction as one between an attribute-less Essence and a presence in which attributes first come to exist. They do not witness such a distinction in essential disclosure. For to disclose itself is to be manifest, and in this perspective the disclosure of the Essence entails the manifestation of all things, since the Real is what appears in everything while also remaining inwardly hidden from all. They can nevertheless understand the distinction when they consider the understanding of those who are veiled. The unveiling of all things includes knowledge of other persons' limited understandings and thus allows them to grasp the distinction **as it appears to those persons**, not as an independent difference in reality.

What these knowers recognize as a true distinction is the one already indicated: at the first rank, the Essence is in no respect other than its essential names, whereas at the rank of divinity it is distinguished from its names. The names nevertheless belong together in reality, despite the unequal degrees of the keys, and all the more so of the derivative names. The Knowing precedes the Living in manifestation, while the Living is a condition; the Powerful proceeds from [these two], and the Willing from the three. Thus some follow others. [Reading note: the print has the awkward phrase *wa-l-qādir ʿanhā*; “these two” explicates the apparent reference and is not an independently attested correction.]

The Shaykh had already indicated this order in the divine names, which are followed by the derivative names. In the chapter explaining the remaining secrets of Text Eleven he said, “The names are states …” Understand.

Text Twenty

Al-Mahāʾimī: Since the arising of some ranks from others requires an affinity connecting what comes after to what precedes, he says:

Qūnawī: A chapter on connection.

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, on the connection of some names with others, whereby some arise from others and are ordered after them.

Qūnawī: The secret of affinities lies in sharing that which removes the rulings of otherness under the aspect that establishes the affinity.

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, the cause of affinity and the animating principle that sustains … [continued on p. 177].

Printed p. 177

Text Twenty: The meaning of *munāsaba*, affinity

MSH-P177 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): …it, namely affinity. The reason that two things can be suitably related is that they share an aspect in virtue of which the differentiation between them is set aside—though in another respect they remain different, so that one can precede the other and the other follow it. Affinity (*munāsaba*) may be **intrinsic** (*dhātiyya*) or a matter of **rank** (*martabiyya*). Intrinsic affinity occurs between the Real and the human being, or between human individuals; rank-based affinity is here treated among human individuals. The two kinds must not be confused.

Qūnawī: The first and highest is intrinsic affinity. Between the Real and the human being—who is the intended locus—it is established in two ways. The first concerns the weakness of the effect of the human being as a mirror upon the self-disclosure determined in that mirror, so that it does not give the disclosure a qualification incompatible with divine transcendence, beyond the necessary qualification of determination. That qualification does not impugn the greatness, majesty and oneness of the Real. This also involves freedom from most of the rulings of possibility and from the properties of intervening mediations. The different degrees of the ones brought near and of the solitary perfected ones derive from this aspect.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Intrinsic affinity comes first because it concerns the highest and earliest ranks of manifestation. Among loci it belongs in the fullest sense to the human being, and especially to the perfect human, who is the intended end of manifestation. One aspect of this affinity is negative or privative: the mirror's own fixed reality exerts the least possible limitation on the self-disclosure that appears within it. The less the mirror's individual properties distort the disclosure, the more closely the appearance resembles its source under the aspect of transcendence. Yet a created mirror cannot be altogether without an effect, for what appears in it necessarily has the determination of appearing in *this* mirror rather than another.

The commentary says that this qualification impugns the Real’s greatness, majesty and oneness. It impugns greatness because it is a shadow and cannot equal that whose shadow it is; majesty, because it entails an encompassing of this manifest shadow, whereas majesty excludes that; and oneness, because the determination of another implies duality. [Reading note: this statement of an impairment is printed, although the preceding Qūnawī lemma calls the determination non-impairing. The phrase describing the encompassing is printed الإحاطة العلية; its exact sense remains uncertain.] For these reasons Qūnawī speaks of the **weakness** of the mirror's conditioning action, rather than its complete absence. The same negative affinity comes from the high rank's relative freedom from possible limitations and from intermediary properties. Thus, when the rulings of necessity become numerous … [continued on p. 178].

Printed p. 178

Two aspects of affinity with the Real

MSH-P178 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): When the rulings of necessity predominate, intrinsic affinity is established under the first aspect.

Qūnawī: The differences in degree of the ones brought near—the poles and solitary individuals—before the Real follow from this aspect.

Al-Mahāʾimī: One whose mirror has the weaker limiting effect, and whose rank is less burdened by the rulings of possibility, enjoys greater proximity; the contrary condition entails a lesser degree of proximity.

Qūnawī: The second aspect of affinity with the Real is according to the servant's share in the form of the divine presence. This share varies with the measure of comprehensive gathering (*jamʿiyya*) in the person. Affinity strengthens or weakens with the narrowness or breadth of the circle of the human being's comprehensiveness, in accordance with the receptivity of that person: one has fewer shares where that circle is restricted, and more where it is expanded.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The second aspect is affirmative: the servant's acquiring the moral qualities and displaying attributes that reflect the divine names, in a way appropriate to created existence. It does **not** mean that a divine attribute migrates from God to the servant, or that numerically the same attribute inheres in two subjects. Rather, the servant receives a share in a spiritual and intelligible *image* of the divine presence, not a material image and not an independent share in the divine Essence. The broader the servant's comprehension of the moral qualities and attributes through which divine names are manifested, the stronger the affinity. The breadth or narrowness of that gathering follows the person's fixed entity as a mirror, its aptitude and receptivity. Consequently the same disclosure is received in unequal degrees.

Qūnawī: One who comprehends the attributes and rulings included in necessity and possibility, insofar as they can actually be manifested in any age, and who also possesses affinity under the first aspect, is the one who has perfection. That person is loved by the Real and is intended for his own sake. In virtue of his reality as the **isthmus of isthmuses** (*barzakh al-barāzikh*), he mirrors both the Essence and divinity together with their concomitants. One possessing the first aspect alone is beloved and brought near, but is not the intended end in that same complete sense.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Since at least one of the two aspects must obtain, the two can also be combined. Thus the one who gathers what the station of necessity comprises of divine attributes, and what the station of possibility comprises of the rulings of the ranks, on condition that it is possible ... [continued on p. 179].

Printed p. 179

The perfect human as isthmus of isthmuses

MSH-P179 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): ...for those attributes and rulings to appear in actuality in every age and time. He adds this condition because some cannot appear at all, or cannot appear in certain times; their absence therefore does not diminish the person's perfection. The first aspect of affinity with the Real must also be established: the weakness of the mirror's effect upon the Real's self-disclosure and its freedom from the rulings of possibility. This is the human perfection through which prophecy is established when prophecy is possible, and the stations of the Pole and the solitary individual in our time. Such a person is beloved of the Real through affinity with Him under the first aspect, and is intended for his own sake in respect of his reality as the isthmus of isthmuses, through its comprehension of the essential and divine names.

He is called the *isthmus of isthmuses* because he joins, in a higher and more inclusive way, what less comprehensive intermediary ranks join only under limited aspects. Other isthmuses mediate necessity and possibility or spirits and bodies. The complete human reality, however, is a mirror of the Essence insofar as it comprehends the

intrinsic names without otherness and a mirror of the divine presence insofar as it comprehends the names and their consequences among necessity and possibility. Hence the perfected human possesses the most encompassing created knowledge of the Real through the disclosure of these aspects in him.

The end of creation, in this account, is the manifestation of this comprehensiveness, joining synthesis and detail. The person who possesses only the first mode may be beloved because of purity and proximity and may resemble the divine in having fewer possible limitations; nevertheless, without gathering the relevant whole, he does not have the fully intended comprehensive station. The earlier discussion, especially Text Ten, should be recalled here.

Qūnawī: Intrinsic affinity among human beings is likewise established in two ways, corresponding to those two divine–human aspects. One is through a shared temperament (*mizāj*): the two persons' temperaments may lie at the same degree among the degrees of equilibrium covered by the broad range of human temperaments, or their degrees may adjoin one another. This is a great principle in the path of realization, known by immediate experience to very few. For the determinations of human spirits from the spiritual worlds and their unequal nobility and spiritual dignity are connected with the number and strength of the mediations between them and the first principle, and with the multiplicity or weakness of possible limitations. After God's decree and determination, the decisive condition in this ordering is temperament, in accordance with which a spirit becomes individually determined. The temperament closer to genuine equilibrium, the centre around which the perfected souls are determined ... [continued p. 180].

Printed p. 180

Temperament as a condition of spiritual manifestation

MSH-P180 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): ...receives a more noble and elevated spirit in relation to the ranks of the higher intellects and souls. A temperament further from the point of equilibrium receives what corresponds to a lower rank and a lesser measure of nobility.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Intrinsic affinity between human beings has two aspects analogous to the divine–human case. The first is a relative absence of dissimilarity in the constitution: the two persons may occupy one degree among the different degrees of balance proper to the human species, or neighbouring degrees with no intermediate degree between them. Each class of generated things—mineral, vegetable, animal and human—has its distinctive constitution; each species within a class, each subgroup, and each individual also has its proper constitution. If the constitution required for a species disappears, that kind of individual cannot persist. The species-

wide temperament thus comprehends a range of variations in individual and subgroup temperaments, and similarity or adjacency within this range establishes the relevant affinity.

This affinity has special significance, says the commentator, for the relation of spiritual pupils to masters, for their capacity to benefit one another, and for the attraction of one to another. The connection is not commonly understood even experientially among guides. For human spirits become individually determined from spiritual ranks—the intellects and souls—and are differentiated in nobility according to the greater or lesser interposition of other ranks. Fewer and weaker intermediaries mean that the rulings of possibility are less numerous and more attenuated. More powerful or more numerous mediations mean stronger and more numerous limitations. After God's decree, the mixture's degree of equilibrium conditions the manner in which a spirit is determined and manifested in the embodied person.

A temperament in which the opposed elemental tendencies are more completely harmonized approximates unity, and is therefore suited to receiving a nobler spirit. The closest approach to true equilibrium is described as the centre of the circle within which perfect souls are determined, a point at which the elemental tendencies are brought into complete balance. Al-Mahāʾimī marks this as differing from the philosophers' account of equilibrium. The spirit is received according to that degree of suitability, whether it derives, in the cosmology assumed here, from the intellects or from the higher souls. A temperament further removed from the centre corresponds to a lower degree of spiritual manifestation. [Continued p. 181.]

Printed p. 181

From temperamental affinity to spiritual affinity

MSH-P181 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): The further the constitution is from genuine equilibrium, the lower the rank of the spirit it is apt to manifest, according to the gradations presupposed by this cosmology.

Qūnawī: Know and understand what I have said about a shared temperament, and by understanding it ascend to knowledge of the affinity proper to spirits under the other aspect, the one analogous to the hidden and purely divine intrinsic affinity.

Al-Mahāʾimī: The second human affinity, the one corresponding to the affirmative affinity between human and Real, consists in sharing spiritual qualities, elevations of station, and degrees of realization. This too is related to temperament under the model just described, for a spirit connected with a higher source is more encompassing of the descriptions of necessity, while one bound to a lower determination bears more of the rulings of possibility. Where the two forms of affinity are joined, the individuals share in more complete humanity. Understand.

Qūnawī: If you know this through witnessing or through a realized understanding, you will perceive that some spirits have their first station of determination at the Preserved Tablet, others in the spirituality of the Throne from the station of Isrāfīl, others at the Footstool from the station of Mīkāʾīl, and others at the Lote Tree from the station of Jibrīl; and thus in a descending order to the lowest heaven, associated with Ismāʿīl, chief of its angels—peace be upon them all. Then you will recognize that the principal condition of the different ranks of human spirits, after God's prior knowledge, providence, decree and will, is what has just been described concerning temperaments, their closeness to or distance from the point of genuine equilibrium. The divine providence and will are displayed through the sound formation of the bodily constitution, which is followed by the breathing of spirit and its becoming determined. Understand and remember.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Once you know, by the witnessing of those who possess certainty, or otherwise by verified understanding, that temperament entails a spirit's determination in nobility or baseness, you know that the beginning of the station of some spirits—that is, their perfection in determination through equilibrium—is from the Tablet. This is so whether the original determination comes from the Tablet or from above it. Perfection through equilibrium, however, is not connected with what lies above the Tablet, because the Tablet is the Universal Soul, called the green emerald. It has a dark relation to primordial dust, the sea of Nature, just as it has a luminous relation to the First Intellect. Equilibrium is therefore in its charge, unlike what will be said concerning affinity of rank. Since it is like the heart of the whole cosmos, its operation extends to the body of the whole. For this reason he does not restrict it to the spirituality of any one of the celestial spheres.

Printed p. 182

The spiritual orders and the breathing of spirit

MSH-P182 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): The determination of some spirits begins from the spirituality of the Throne—the Throne of the All-Merciful—and the spirituality of the angels called the *Wāhibāt*, arising from the station of Isrāfīl. Thereafter some arise from the spirituality of the Lote Tree of the Furthest Limit, the limit of the station of worshippers, below the Footstool in the sphere of the zodiac, and from the angels named in connection with Jibrīl's station. Some arise from the spirituality of the sphere of the fixed stars: the *Tāliyāt*, from the station of Riḍwān, keeper of the gardens. Some arise from the spirituality of Saturn: the *Nāziʿāt*, from the station of the angel al-Karīm. Some arise from the spirituality of Jupiter: the *Mulqiyāt*, from the station of the angel al-Muqarrab. Some arise from the spirituality of Mars: the *Fāriqāt*, from the station of al-Khāshiʿ. Some arise from the spirituality of the Sun: the *Ṣifāt*, from the station of al-Rafīʿ. Some arise from the spirituality of Venus: the

Fāniyāt, from the station of al-Ḥamd. Some arise from the spirituality of Mercury: the *Nāshiṭāt*, from the station of the angel al-Rūḥ. Some arise from the spirituality of the Moon: the spiritual angels, from the station of Ismāʿīl—peace be upon him. The names of these angels were mentioned by the perfect and perfecting Shaykh Muḥyī al-Dīn Ibn ʿArabī—may God sanctify his spirit—in the treatise *ʿUqlat al-mustawfiz*. [Reading note: the unusual order-names are transliterated as printed in this edition; they have not been replaced by conjectured canonical forms.]

Qūnawī: You will then recognize ...

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, when you know what we have mentioned through witnessing or verified understanding, you recognize that the greatest condition of the differing nobility or baseness of human spirits is the proximity or distance of temperaments from the point of genuine equilibrium. He qualifies it as “greatest” because other conditions also bear upon these differences: celestial cycles, the particular properties of places, and the circumstances of the parents. But this comes after God's prior knowledge, called providence, decree and will. He puts it afterwards because it is an effect of temperament, which is an effect of providence, namely will. Its effect is specified according to the divine fashioning called equilibrium. This fashioning is called divine because it arises from the divine rank; it is followed by the breathing of spirit, which is the spirit's determination, since it passes from its unseen station into manifestation, namely determination.

This is why he says “Understand.” He says “Remember” so that you may thereby recognize intrinsic affinity under the other aspect: the gathering of the properties of those angels and [their] entity. [The final pronoun وعينه is obscure in the printed text.]

Qūnawī: As for affinity of rank, it is not of one aspect alone but of several aspects. One concerns the original sources which are the beginnings of the determinations of spirits mentioned just above ... [continued on p. 183].

Editorial note

2008 scan printed p182, PDF index180; scan_p182.png. The image reads من مقام الملك الروح, not the digital فلك الروح.

Printed p. 183

The original spiritual sources of rank-based affinity

MSH-P183 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): ...the original sources from which spirits are determined. The source of the highest of them, that is, the spirits of the perfected, is the Mother of the Book (*umm al-kitāb*). The first determination of certain others, in knowledge and in

an existence comprehended under unity, is the reality of the Supreme Pen, called the First Intellect and Universal Spirit. Some are determined from the Preserved Tablet, others from the spirituality of the Throne associated with Isrāfīl, some from the spirituality of the Footstool associated with Mīkāʾīl, and others from the rank of Jibrīl at the Lote Tree. This ordering continues down through the types of these spiritual principles to the lowest heaven, whose spiritual chief Ismāʿīl corresponds to what the Peripatetic philosophers call the Active Intellect.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Know that from the many aspects he selected three: that through which the beginning occurs, that toward which the end is directed, and that on which the middle depends. The first concerns their original sources, meaning the principles of their original determination without considering their perfection. It was indicated above that the principles of determination in respect of origin are the very principles in respect of perfection.

He then explains that the source of the determination of the highest spirits—the spirits of the perfected, among prophets, poles and solitary individuals—is the Mother of the Book, namely comprehensive divine knowledge. It is so called because it is the origin of origins for intellects and soul, which are divine books: the “book” here means the great cosmos, and knowledge is its origin. The determination of some begins in a differentiated manner under one aspect of their existence, while being comprehensive under another. This unity is relative to what lies beneath it. Existence here is actual, unlike at the first rank. Its source is the reality of the Supreme Pen itself, without the Preserved Tablet's relation to it. It is called Pen because through it the cosmos is recorded and inscribed; Intellect because it first understands the whole, being first in rank among creatures; Spirit because through it the cosmos is governed; and Universal because the universal spirits are its particulars. [Reading note: the print's explanation of the name “Pen” has the apparent error قلبًا, “heart,” in place of قلمًا.]

Some spirits are of the Throne and of Isrāfīl, that is, from its soul and intellect together. The names are elucidated so that one does not imagine that these principles possess other things through which the stated affinity arises. He also indicates that these are the spiritual principles and their genera. At the end he calls [the principle of the lowest heaven] the Active Intellect to deny the claim that the Active Intellect is related only to the world of the elements.

The Peripatetics are a group of philosophers whose earliest members learned from Plato while on the road, according to what al-Sayyid al-Samarqandī mentions in his commentary on the *Ṣaḥāʾif*. [This is the commentator's historical claim.]

Qūnawī: The other aspect concerns their imaginal manifestations, for spirits … [continued on p. 184].

Printed p. 184

The absolute imaginal world as a locus of spirits

MSH-P184 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): ...despite their unequal ranks, are never without the loci through which they become determined and appear, according to all the realized knowers. The first rank in which human spirits appear, apart from the perfected, is the **absolute imaginal world** (*ʿālam al-mithāl al-muṭlaq*).

Al-Mahāʾimī: This is the second aspect among the selected kinds of rank-based affinity. It concerns the starting-point of outward appearance, rather than the original spiritual source considered in itself. The absolute imaginal world is the realm in which spirits may appear through perceptible forms without gross bodies and without requiring the particular faculty of imagination lodged in an individual person's brain. Such forms make distinct appearances possible without reducing the spirit to elemental matter.

The argument is that, without loci of manifestation, spirits could not be distinguished, because they are simple and one in species. Without such loci, their distinction would require a differentia added to the genus in which their specific unity is shared; what accounts for unity differs from what accounts for distinction. Differences of rank do not suffice, since they belong to general accidents. Nor do specific properties yield individual distinction. Particular accidents do not attach before manifestation. The first rank of manifestation of spirits other than those of the perfected is therefore the absolute imaginal world: before it they possess no determination of the kind reserved for the perfected, and appearance cannot precede determination. This world is in the sphere of the zodiac, according to what the verifying Shaykh Muḥyī al-Dīn Ibn ʿArabī —may God sanctify his mystery—mentions in his *ʿUqla*.

Qūnawī: Imaginal forms may take their originating material from the subtleties of the powers of this natural life and from its purified and refined substances clothed in the qualities of spirits. Yet their descriptions and states in Paradise are manifested according to their spiritualities and powers and according to the properties of their imaginal loci.

Al-Mahāʾimī: This indicates that the imaginal world both supplies and receives the loci through which the spirits of the people of Paradise appear. The natural human faculties involved are the animal powers, including outer and inner senses, and the vegetative faculties, as these are refined by righteous acts and noble character. [Continued p. 185.]

Printed p. 185

Imaginal forms and the degrees of Paradise

MSH-P185 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): ...and the subtleties of its substances, namely the heart and soul, on condition that the heart is purified of the stain of the commanding soul and the soul is purified of its attributes and dispositions, so that these substances acquire the qualities of spirits and the paradisal forms accord with them. Yet those forms have states and qualities in Paradise that appear only according to their spiritualities and powers embodied in imaginal form, and according to the properties of their imaginal manifestations. The evidence is their transformation and alteration without generation and corruption. The qualities and states of those forms therefore belong to the imaginal world. Since this world is the return of the manifestations of spirits, it is also their beginning. He then returns to explaining affinity among people through this.

Qūnawī: The dwellings of the people of Paradise manifest the ranks of their spirits, in respect of their standing before the Real and in respect of their first imaginal manifestations. The Prophet—God bless him and grant him peace—indicated this by subtle allusions, such as his saying, “ʿAlī, your palace in Paradise faces my palace”; in another narration, “is alongside my palace.” He said something similar concerning al-ʿAbbās. Concerning the generality of believers he said, “One of you knows the way to his dwelling in Paradise better than to his dwelling in this world.” This is nothing other than the ruling of affinity.

Al-Mahāʾimī: He indicates that, just as the imaginal world is the return of the manifestations of the spirits of the people of Paradise in respect of the purity of their forms and states, it is also the return of their dwellings. This demonstrates still more clearly that it is the beginning of their manifestations. The dwellings of the people of Paradise are the ranks of their spirits appearing therein, in respect of their standing before the Real: their proximity or distance through affinity with Him. Their dwellings rise or descend accordingly, and according to their imaginal manifestations, which are the first manifestations. The dwelling accords with whether a person's imaginal form is purer or more turbid.

He adduces the Prophet's saying to ʿAlī, “Your palace in Paradise faces my palace.” For proximity of ʿAlī's spiritual standing to that of the Prophet is not possible: the lowest rank of the prophets is above the highest rank of the saints, and he is the most excellent of the prophets. Where, then, is his standing in relation to ʿAlī's? It must therefore be in respect of ... [continued on p. 186].

Editorial source note: The modern editor says he could not locate either wording of the palace report to ʿAlī. The reports above are translated as attributions in the medieval text; this review has not independently verified their transmission.

Printed p. 186

The imaginal 'market' and multiple layers of manifestation

MSH-P186 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): ...the imaginal manifestations. That is why he counted this among the subtle allusions. The other narration, “alongside my palace,” confirms it: alignment applies more directly to outward form, so this too subtly points to imaginal manifestations. Moreover, even were ʿAlī's standing near that of the Prophet, how could something similar hold for al-ʿAbbās? Nearness in imaginal manifestations is quite possible despite distance in standing before God. This is an affinity in sensible things and does not require affinity in realities related to the Real to precisely the same extent.

He then anticipates the objection that this account succeeds only if spiritual affinity is considered in those dwellings. He answers with the report concerning the generality of believers, “One of you knows the way better …,” then states his point explicitly: “This is nothing other than the ruling of affinity.”

Qūnawī: As for the market of Paradise, comprising beautiful human forms which its inhabitants may choose to put on as they wish, it belongs to some of the streams of the absolute imaginal world, the source and spring of manifestations. It is a channel of the sustaining influx that reaches the manifestations of the spirits of the people of Paradise from the imaginal world.

Al-Mahāʾimī: This answers an implicit question. The materials of the imaginal form are the subtleties of the powers of this natural constitution and its purified substances; its attributes, and likewise its states, appear according to its spiritualities, powers and the properties of its imaginal manifestations. But the materials of the forms in the market are not the subtleties of those natural powers, which are fixed and do not change after death and resurrection. Nor are they attributes appearing from their spiritualities as they stand—adding that there is no need of *al-takharruj* [an unclear term in the printed sentence]. Nor do they come from the properties of their imaginal manifestations, for those have already appeared in the first forms. What, then, are these forms? Likewise, their dwellings manifest the ranks of spirits according to their standing before the Real and their imaginal manifestations. What is this market, which is one of their dwellings? It does not accord with their differing standing before the Real, since all share access to it; nor with their imaginal manifestations, which would require distinctions in this dwelling's appearance.

He answers that the first account concerns original forms and original dwellings, constituted from the sea of the absolute imaginal world. These other forms and dwellings are secondary, arising from some of that world's streams. The absolute imaginal world is a vast sea, the source of many manifestations and forms. The

distinctions required in the original dwellings need not be required in the secondary ones; and the properties of their manifestations that appeared in … [continued on p. 187].

Printed p. 187

The nourishment and attire of Paradise

MSH-P187 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): …the first form belong to the original higher properties; these others belong to accidental properties. [The printed sentence then has the incomplete words إذ فيها, “since in them …”.]

The supply of manifestation must continually reach the inhabitants because existence is ever renewed: at every moment there is a new creation. This aid does not arise from the undifferentiated sea under consideration of its absoluteness, since that consideration does not pick out this individual rather than another. Particular channels of imaginal supply explain how one recipient receives one form and another recipient another. The principal forms are called principal because they gather numerous qualities and correspond to numerous channels, while the secondary forms express further and changing qualifications. Understand.

Qūnawī: The source of their food, drink, garments and everything in which they delight lies in the grounds of the ranks of their acts, beliefs, dispositions, attributes and degrees of equilibrium in all these matters.

Al-Mahāʾimī: Whatever reaches the inhabitants successively must come through an appropriate particular channel; otherwise there would be an undifferentiated and unvarying supply. Instead they receive continual increase and variety. The rapid return or replacement of forms, such as the restoration of birds and fruits after consumption in descriptions of Paradise, is taken as a sign that their mode of existence is imaginal rather than elemental. The construction of Qūnawī's sentence can also be read so that the 'grounds of the ranks of their works' are the source of their food and clothing. On that reading those enjoyments are themselves determinate forms of the imaginal world; in either case the relative equilibrium of deeds, beliefs, characteristics and other qualities conditions what appears. Understand.

Qūnawī: As for the robes and gifts that angels bring from the Real to the generality of the people of Paradise when conveying them to the mound of vision for a visit and audience with the Real, these are manifestations of the rulings of the names and attributes to which those visitors are truly related, whether or not they know it. Through those gifts their affinity with the Real is strengthened, and the subtle bonds of their attachment to Him are enlivened, by means of the names and attributes that

hold the degree of lordship over [those] visitors. [Reading note: the print reads أولياء الزائرين, literally “the friends/guardians of the visitors”; “those visitors” is the contextual reading suggested by the commentary on p188.]

Al-Mahāʾimī: This indicates what appears to them in respect of their spirituality and standing before the Real, after explaining what appears to them in respect of their imaginal manifestations and properties. It also rejects the supposition that these gifts likewise belong to the imaginal world; hence the wording, “As for the robes and gifts.” He specifies the generality of the inhabitants because the perfected have no need of these: they abide continually in vision. The simple-hearted (*al-bulh*) do not attain this rank, because their spirituality lacks the perfection corresponding to the rank of vision. He explains that the gifts come from the Real to indicate that they do not come from the imaginal world, for through that world there is no affinity with … [continued on p. 188].

Printed p. 188

The gifts brought before the vision of the Real

MSH-P188 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): …the Real. Thus through it they do not merit being carried to the mound of vision to visit and sit with the Real. These gifts are manifestations of the rulings of the names and attributes on which the visitors actually depend, even if they have not yet known that dependence. He then explains the benefit of the angels' bringing the gifts: the visitors must acquire a new receptivity. If their continuing receptivity sufficed, vision would continue with it. Vision moreover requires affinity of Essence and names; affinity with the Essence does not arise by itself, since there is no connection between the two, but through the names and attributes possessing a particular lordship over those visitors. The gifts enliven the subtle ties, namely their connections with the Real. Once these ties are enlivened, their affinity with the Real draws near, and through both Essence and names together they merit being carried to the mound of vision.

Qūnawī: God's saying to the angels near the end of the assemblies of visitation, concerning the people of Paradise, “Return them to their palaces,” indicates the ending of the rulings of the affinities received through those robes and gifts, and the ending of the rulings of the names and attributes which, as such, establish a relation between them and the Real and require their gathering and presence with Him. When the sway of the names and attributes opposed to the rulings of the names and attributes requiring gathering becomes manifest, the rulings requiring distinction appear, and distance and veiling occur. Understand.

Al-Mahāʾimī: This gives evidence that the gifts manifest the rulings of the names and attributes. Otherwise the affinity received through them would not cease when the rulings of the names establishing affinity between the visitors and the Real cease. Yet affinity does cease, as shown by the cessation of the vision it entails when they are returned to their palaces. An effect necessarily follows its cause; hence the cause, namely affinity, has ceased, and its cause must also cease. The account then turns to the rulings of the names and attributes opposed to the former names and attributes, which become lords over those visitors after lordship had first belonged to the preceding, opposed names. [The printed transition here is syntactically compressed.]

When the sway of these names appears, the rulings requiring distinction between the visitors and the Real appear, and distance and veiling occur. When in turn the sway and rulings of these names requiring distance and veiling end, the sway of the first names returns, and the visitors return to vision. It is therefore known that each name has a determined limit of sway, in respect of locus and time; its lordship accords with those ... [continued on p. 189].

Editorial note

Facsimile printed p188, PDF zero-based index186, scan_p188.png: the Qūnawī lemma reads النسبة and جمعهم.

Printed p. 189

Text Twenty — Degrees of the audience with the Real

MSH-P189 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): ...times.

Qūnawī: As for the differences of their ranks while sitting with the Real, these accord with their differing ranks in the Real Himself, and with the soundness of their beliefs concerning God, or their sound knowledge and witnessing, and their earlier preference for the presence of the Real over everything else. The length or brevity of the audience, the differing honour of what is addressed to them, and what they understand of His address accord with what we have mentioned. They also accord with their presence to what they knew of Him, or their calling Him to mind according to their beliefs concerning Him; their affinity with His presence in respect of the station of the mound of vision; and the self-disclosure from Him particular to them. Know this.

Al-Mahāʾimī: This indicates what appears to them according to intrinsic affinity, after describing what appears according to affinity through names. Although all share in affinity, their differing degrees of proximity to and distance from the Real accord with their ranks in the Real Himself. Intrinsic affinity differs in degree, whether in

respect of the weakness of the effect of the servant's rank upon the determined divine self-disclosure, or in respect of the servant's share in the form of divine comprehensiveness. It also accords with the soundness of their beliefs concerning God. These too yield intrinsic affinity, to the point of entailing annihilation in Him and subsistence through Him.

By specifying soundness he excludes corrupt beliefs, which entail distance and veiling. This concerns the complete. Their previous preference—that is, before being carried to the mound of vision—for the Real's presence over all else also yields intrinsic affinity through love of Him, until the person becomes a manifestation of eternal love and it appears therein in its fullness or in some measure. This applies both to the complete and to others.

He then explains that the length or brevity of the audience accords with the aforementioned ranks in the Real Himself; soundness of beliefs, knowledge and witnessing; and preference for the Real's presence. It also accords with their presence to Him in this world and their calling Him to mind according to their beliefs, and with their affinity to His presence through the names which brought them to the station of the mound of vision and bestowed the self-disclosure particular to them. The factors mentioned first entail only the audience itself, with a certain measure of nearness or distance. The differing honour of what they are addressed with and what they understand follows the same pattern, even though the address is one.

Qūnawī: As for the condition of the perfected—may God benefit us through them in what we have mentioned and in other matters—it is contrary to ... [continued on p. 190].

Printed p. 190

The perfected and unrestricted essential self-disclosure

MSH-P190 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): “—that. They have passed beyond the presences of the names and attributes, and the self-disclosures peculiar to them, into the open field of essential self-disclosure. They are as the Prophet—God bless him and grant him peace—reported concerning them: ‘A class of the people of Paradise from whom the Lord neither hides nor veils Himself.’ This is because they are not confined within Paradise or any other world or presence. As I have indicated elsewhere, neither Paradise nor anything other than Paradise can encompass a perfect human being. Although they appear in whichever loci of manifestation they will, they transcend confinement, restrictions, places, and times, as does their Master. Rather, they are with Him wherever He is, and where there is neither ‘where’ nor ‘whereabouts’: no body,

distance, veil, movement to a visitation, or ending under the ruling of a particular time, name, or attribute. Understand, strive, and aspire to join them and share in some of their exalted ranks, for God is the patron of beneficence.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This corresponds to his earlier statement: “The first of the ranks of the loci in which the divine spirits appear—apart from the perfected—is the imaginal world.” He thus speaks of their concealment in appearing through what we have mentioned: the imaginal world, imagined forms and their food and drink, robes of honour and gifts, the dune of vision, and other things. The generality are different: their state is confined to the presences of the names and attributes, and to the self-disclosures peculiar to them beneath those presences, in the imaginal world and elsewhere. These people have passed beyond the presences of the names and attributes to the open field of essential self-disclosure. They therefore possess the highest ranks of essential affinity, in which the names have no part. They are, as the Prophet—peace be upon him—reported, a class of the people of Paradise from whom the Lord does not hide at any time, or veil Himself in any respect when He discloses Himself to them.

The reason for this absence of hiding and veiling is that they are not restricted to a locus of manifestation, whether Paradise or another world or presence. Everything restricted is narrow, whereas the perfect human being is expansive with the expansiveness of his Lord. He has a locus of manifestation in every place without being confined to it. Thus, although they appear in whatever loci they will, they are not confined to them. Likewise they are not confined to places or times, for otherwise they would be limited by them. They are concealed in appearing in every place and time without restriction. Rather, they are with Him in every place and time, and where there is no place or direction. They have become universal loci for their Lord in all His self-disclosures. Consequently, they have neither distance from Him nor a veil from Him in any respect. Neither do they make a transition for a visitation, since that would particularize a place, and they transcend this—

Editorial note

Full page retranslation replaces compressed gloss and removes content that belongs to p. 189. Scan compared with printed p. 190. Printed والسماء والصفات is contextually read as the names and attributes, with السماء retained in the Arabic transcription; this is a marked interpretive reading, not manuscript-supported emendation. The awkward printed opening of the gloss (فقال: خفاء لهم) is rendered conservatively.

Printed p. 191

Intermediate ranks and Adam in the lowest heaven

MSH-P191 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —nor does their vision end under the ruling of a particular time, for they have passed beyond times; nor under the ruling of the names and attributes that require distinction, for they have passed beyond the presences of the names and attributes. Understand. They are with the Real in all things. Strive to join them in some of their exalted ranks by following them—indeed, to share independently with them in this. God is the patron of beneficence, so do not look at your own deficiency and thereby cease this striving.

Qūnawī: “As for the affinities established among people in respect of their intermediate ranks, their model—which draws the attention of one who has neither unveiled nor witnessed them to their details—is what the Prophet—God bless him and grant him peace—mentioned in the report of the Night Journey: he saw Adam, peace be upon him, in the lowest heaven, with the dark forms of the felicitous among his descendants to his right and those of the wretched to his left. When he looked to his right he laughed, and when he looked to his left he wept. This points to the ranks of the generality of the wretched and the felicitous.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This indicates the third of the forms of affinity pertaining to rank: those upon which the intermediate condition rests, the barzakh between this world and the greater Resurrection—that is, the states of the grave. He gives as a model of this affinity what the Prophet mentioned in the report of the Night Journey. This model draws attention to the details of those affinities, which are ordered according to their higher and lower stations. Only one who has neither unveiled nor witnessed them needs this indication; otherwise he has no need of the report. The Prophet saw Adam in the lowest heaven so that Adam might oversee the division of his children into higher and lower groups. For this reason, the dispatch of those destined for the Fire is entrusted to him on the Day of Resurrection. His laughter expresses his satisfaction with the dark forms of the felicitous. His weeping expresses his grief for them on seeing their deficiency. His right signifies the essential side, because it is the strong side [a short phrase here is unclear in the print]; the strong is more favoured than the weak. Understand from this report that in the barzakh the abode of the wretched is beneath the lowest heaven, while the felicitous are above that.

He then indicates the details, saying:

Qūnawī: “The people of wretchedness are those for whom the gates of heaven were not opened at death. They have different ranks in their wretchedness. The Prophet—salutations upon him and his household—reported that the spirits of some of the wretched are gathered in Barahūt, al-Ḥalīyatayn, al-Khāsiʾayn—”

Editorial note

Full page retranslation restores the final Qūnawī lemma, previously omitted, and preserves its continuation onto p. 192. Scan checked. The expression printed as الجانب القوي أنا لها، والقوي أحلى من الضعيف is textually difficult; English flags the unclear short phrase rather than inventing an explanation. Names after Barahut are transliterations of this edition’s uncertain forms, not verified geographical identifications.

Printed p. 192

Degrees of wretchedness and felicity in the barzakh

MSH-P192 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): “—and al-Khābitayn. The ranks of the wretched begin at the concave inner surface of the lowest heaven, in which Adam is, and their lowest rank is what he—peace be upon him—mentioned. The ranks of the generality of the felicitous in the barzakh are in the lowest heaven, at differing degrees gathered within a single rank. The ranks of the elect among the felicitous are those to which he pointed in the report of the Night Journey after mentioning Adam: Jesus is in the second heaven, Joseph in the third, Idrīs in the fourth, Aaron in the fifth, Moses in the sixth, and Abraham in the seventh—peace upon them all. The same applies to those who fully share with these prophets and inherit from them, at differing ranks within these heavens. These reports from the Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—concern what he witnessed during one of his night journeys. For it is established that the Prophet experienced thirty-four ascents, whose reports Abū Nuʿaym, the traditionist of Isfahan—God have mercy upon him—transmitted, collected, and authenticated.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, since he saw the dark forms of the wretched to Adam's left, the gates of heaven were not opened to any of the wretched when they died. They have no heavenly locus of manifestation, and their wretchedness has different ranks.

The Prophet reported that the spirits of some of them are gathered in Barahūt and al-Khāsiʾayn. These are well-known transmitted accounts. Their rank in wretchedness is therefore the sphere of earth. Yet the report of the Night Journey states that they are beneath the lowest heaven, which implies that they are in the sphere of ether.

The way to reconcile the two, indicating their different ranks, is that the ranks of the wretched begin at the concave inner surface of the lowest heaven. Their highest rank, for those whose wretchedness is least, is the sphere of ether, because they are close to Adam in disobedience and in hope of forgiveness. Their lowest rank is what the Prophet mentioned: some are gathered in Barahūt and al-Khābitayn.

He then mentions that the ranks of the generality of the felicitous—that is, those who had wretchedness [the printed phrase is awkward]—are, in the world of the barzakh, the lowest heaven. He qualifies this by ‘in the barzakh’ because at the Resurrection they will be in Paradise above those abodes. Within the lowest heaven they also have differing ranks, although they share its single rank. This is because they combined obedience and disobedience and obtained forgiveness, like Adam. And the ranks of—

Editorial note

Full page retranslation preserves all lemma and gloss and the continuation onto p. 193. Scan checked. The claim of thirty-four ascents is a claim in Qūnawī’s text, not independently authenticated by this working edition. The printed wording أي من كان شقاوة is syntactically defective and is marked in English. The uncertain place/name forms are retained as printed transliterations.

Printed p. 193

Why heavenly ranks are not confined to seven prophets

MSH-P193 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —the elect among the felicitous are above that. Even if they committed acts of disobedience, these were replaced with good deeds and so were not taken into account. This is as the Prophet reported concerning these prophets. The same applies to the perfected among their heirs and followers, although their ranks also differ. He explains that, because they are people of perfection, they are not confined there; these are only some of their loci of manifestation. The Messenger's reports concern some of what he witnessed during some of his ascents.

Qūnawī: “How could this condition be confined to these seven prophets, to the exclusion of others? It is clear that the messengers and prophets are many, and among them are perfected ones identified by God, such as David, whose vicegerency is explicitly stated, and other great prophets who were messengers. Where, then, are their intermediate ranks determined after death? [The printed transition to the upper and lower worlds is defective.] The lower world is the locus in which the ranks of the wretched are determined, in all their differences. It follows that the levels at which the ranks of the prophets and messengers, the perfected among their heirs, and the elect among the felicitous are determined after death and before the gathering must be in the heavenly presences. What occasioned the Prophet's statement is what has already been indicated: it is a model of what was not individually mentioned. Understand.

“This particular report from the Prophet concerning these seven was occasioned only by a state, an affinity in attributes, acts, or state. It is as with John, peace be upon him, who is sometimes with Jesus and sometimes with Aaron, peace upon them all. This follows only from his sharing with both of them. Reflect, and you will be guided, if God wills.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Nor is the establishment of those ascents for the Prophet precluded. How, then, could this condition—that is, determination in the heavens—be confined to these seven, when the messengers and prophets are numerous and the perfected are not confined to these seven? Consider David: God—mighty and majestic—explicitly stated his vicegerency, saying, “O David, We have appointed you a vicegerent” [Q 38:26]. He said of Adam, “I am appointing a vicegerent on earth” [Q 2:30]. How, then, could David be below him? The same applies to other great prophets and messengers. Aaron was not one of the messengers; if he had a determination in the heavens, how could the messengers lack one? If their ranks were not determined in the heavens, where would their intermediate ranks be determined after death and before the Resurrection, when in—

Editorial note

Full page retranslation restores detailed argument and follows its boundary. Scan checked. The Qūnawī lemma has the defective printed transition ومن ثم إلى العالم الأعلى الأسفل; English marks the crux rather than silently constructing a complete Arabic sentence. The commentary’s descriptions of the prophets are translated as the author’s statements.

Printed p. 194

Heavenly affinities and the opening of Text Twenty-One

MSH-P194 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —reality there are only the upper, heavenly world and the lower, elemental world in which they could be determined? The lower world is the locus of the determination of the ranks of the wretched, according to their differing levels. How could the felicitous—indeed, the prophets and the perfected among their descendants—share those ranks with them? Nor can their ranks be determined in those [paradisal] abodes, because that belongs specifically to what follows the gathering.

It follows that the ranks of the prophets and messengers, the perfected saints among their heirs, and the elect among the felicitous—even those who have not reached the ranks of the saints—are, after death and before the gathering, in the heavenly presences. How, then, could they be confined to the prophets named? Rather, the reason why the Prophet mentioned these seven is what has already been indicated:

this was one of his visions. What he stated in that report is a model of what was not individually specified. They were, however, mentioned collectively, since he placed the dark forms of the felicitous to Adam's right, indicating that they are in the heavens.

He then states the cause of this particular witnessing. In that state, an affinity of those prophets with those heavens predominated—an affinity in attributes, acts, or state, not an essential one. Otherwise they would never change from those heavens. But this is not so, as with John, who is sometimes with Jesus and sometimes with Aaron. This difference follows from his sharing [with them; the following printed wording is difficult]. Essential affinity does not change. Moreover, taking the differing reports to be sound indicates a plurality of ascents. Hence the shaykh says, “Reflect, and you will be guided”: that is, as their sharing in those attributes and states is, so are their determinations in the heavens.

Text Twenty-One

Qūnawī: “A very noble text.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: In the previous text he mentioned the Real and creation, their ranks, and their essential affinities and affinities of rank. He now mentions the divine unity that gathers all of them, without the Real veiling creation or creation veiling the Real. Its nobility comes from this station's exalted rank above the other stations. It is ‘very’ noble because it is the return and end of all of them.

Qūnawī: “Know that the Real is pure existence, in which there is no difference. He is one with a true unity that is not conceived in opposition to multiplicity, and whose realization in itself or conception in knowledge does not depend—”

Editorial note

Full page retranslation restores the transition and beginning of Text Twenty-One. Scan checked. The printed phrase إلا من مقتضى مشاركته الذاتية لا تتغير conflates the changeable sharing with the assertion that essential affinity does not change; the translation marks the syntactic difficulty rather than treating an inferred repair as attested Arabic. Bracketed paradisal identifies the contextual referent of تلك المنازل without adding an Arabic reading.

Printed p. 195

True unity, conceptual opposition, and the theologians

MSH-P195 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): “—in sound, realized knowledge upon conceiving an opposite to it. Rather, it is established through itself and establishes [others]; it is not established [by another]. Our saying ‘unity’ is for declaring transcendence and conveying understanding, not for indicating the concept of unity as it is conceived in veiled minds.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, the Real in the first determination and the essential forms of knowledge is pure existence. He did not say ‘abstract existence,’ since there He is not restricted to manifestation or hiddenness. There is no difference within Him through the realization of two things, such as quiddity and existence, or the absolute and its restrictions.

Pure existence is one because it is necessary through itself and admits no plurality. Its unity is real, not a relative unity opposed to multiplicity. How could it be conceived in opposition to multiplicity, which is the opposite of unity, when it has no opposite at all? Otherwise its realization in the mind would depend on its opposite there. Nor does its realization in itself depend on its opposite, for then the Necessary would depend on another; nor does its conception in sound knowledge depend on conceiving an opposite. He explains ‘sound’ by ‘realized’: knowledge obtained through unveiling. This differs from the knowledge of veiled theologians, who required demonstrations of divine unity to establish it. They conceived unity in opposition to multiplicity, imagined it to be additional to the Essence, and established it by demonstrations on the model of something accruing to the Essence. But it is not so. Rather, unity is established through itself, externally and mentally; it establishes what is other than itself and is not established by another, such as their demonstrations.

He then anticipates a question: the Essence as such can be conceived as one or many, so how can unity be identical with it? He answers that our saying ‘unity’ declares transcendence beyond the multiplicity imagined by the veiled, and conveys that this Essence is pure existence itself. Unity is coextensive with existence: every existent possesses unity, even the many—not insofar as it is many, but insofar as there is multiplicity within it, for unity accrues to multiplicity.

It may be said: existence, but not unity, accrues to the many insofar as it is many. We answer: when unity accrues to the multiplicity within it, it thereby accrues mediately to the many. The difference of aspects is an intellectual matter.

It may be said: if unity were existence itself, division would be annihilation; but that is false, for the cleaving—

Editorial note

Full retranslation against the page and scan removes the Text Twenty-One heading/opening that belongs to p. 194 and preserves the objection continuing onto p. 196. Printed p. 195 was visually compared. The difficult phrase إذ هو فيه وثمة is rendered according to its immediate contrast of manifestation and hiddenness without adding a new doctrine.

Printed p. 196

The sea analogy and the limits of apprehending pure existence

MSH-P196 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —of the green sea by a mosquito with its needle plainly does not annihilate it and bring two other seas into being.

We answer: division could be annihilation only if it [negated] unity; the sea's unity remains. Suppose we grant that it becomes many: it has then ceased to be in respect of unity. The origination of two seas—that is, a quality assigned to two seas before their origination—cannot be sheer nonexistence, even if it is other than existence. Thus he did not mean to indicate the concept of unity opposed to multiplicity, in which its subject is supposed to be an individual admitting no division. Unity and multiplicity are united in Him without the Essence of the Necessary—exalted is He—becoming multiple.

Qūnawī: “Once you know this, we say: He—glory be to Him—in respect of the unity to which attention has been drawn, and His detachment from the loci of manifestation and from the descriptions attributed to Him through those loci and His manifestation in them, is not apprehended, encompassed, known, characterized, or described.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, once you know that He is pure existence without difference and that His unity is not opposed to multiplicity, we say that the Real—glory and exaltation be to Him—in respect of the unity indicated is not fully apprehended. He qualifies the statement this way because knowledge of Him is possible from the standpoint of the unity He has in the attributes. Complete apprehension would require distinguishing Him from what is other than Him; how could what has no opposite be distinguished from what is other than it? Nor is He encompassed by an essential definition: there are no intrinsic constituents within Him to be defined through differences of genus and differentia in His Essence. Nor is there a descriptive definition, since concomitants are not taken into account in that presence. He is not characterized by a characterization distinguishing Him intrinsically, or described by a description distinguishing Him accidentally, since these are not taken into account there. The same applies in respect of His detachment from the loci of manifestation,

which are His attributes under one consideration, though not in respect of His Essence: He is then not restricted by anything that distinguishes Him. Everything we have mentioned concerns distinction. Understand.

Qūnawī: “Everything apprehended in entities and witnessed among created things, however a human being apprehends it and in whatever presence the witnessing occurs—apart from the apprehension of abstract meanings and realities in their unseen presence by unveiling, which is why I said ‘in entities’—that is, whatever is apprehended in a locus of manifestation, consists only of colours, lights, and surfaces differing in quality and quantity, which appear, or whose likenesses appear, in the imaginal world connected with the human constitution or separate from it in one respect, according to what exists externally or whose constituent elements exist externally. The multiplicity of all these is sensed, while their oneness is intellectually grasped or intuited. All this consists of the rulings of existence—or say, the forms of the relations of His knowledge, or attributes inseparable from it—in respect of—”

Editorial note

Scan compared. The print has لو كان مبدأ للوحدة, literally “if it were a principle of unity”; the English [negated] is a contextual interpretive repair, not an attested Arabic reading. The mosquito/needle/sea analogy is restored. The final lemma ends on بحيث at this page boundary; its continuation is on p. 197.

Printed p. 197

Outward sense, inward imagination, and what each apprehends

MSH-P197 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): “—its association with each existent entity through the secret of its manifestation. It appears in it, through it, for it, and according to it. However you wish to put it, what is thus named is not existence itself.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This answers an implicit question: you said that existence in respect of its unity is neither apprehended nor known, and also that unity belongs to it intrinsically and is among its coextensive concomitants. Yet we sense it in entities and created things, and know it in abstract meanings and realities in their unseen presence by unveiling.

He answers: apprehension either concerns abstract meanings and unseen realities, which are intellectual things without existence—so how can existence be apprehended in them? Unveiling apprehends them in their unseen presence, which is nonexistent—or it concerns entities. Everything apprehended in entities, whether a human being—the most complete of apprehenders—apprehends it through intellect,

spirit, heart, outward senses, or inward senses, and likewise whatever is witnessed among created things in any divine or created presence, must be in a locus of manifestation, whether sensible or spiritual.

What is directly apprehended is colours and lights, and incidentally surfaces differing in quality through their differing colours. Difference in quantity does not entail that apprehension of the surfaces [the printed construction here is awkward]. This concerns outward sense.

As for inward sense, what is apprehended is their likenesses. Those likenesses are in the imaginal world connected with the human constitution: the imagination, which is in the front of the brain. Or they are in the imaginal world separate from the human being in one respect, because it is not one of his faculties but is in the sphere of the zodiacal constellations. It is nevertheless connected with him in another respect, since without it he would not apprehend at all. Those likenesses appear in one of the two worlds in accordance with the external things they represent: likenesses of the colours, lights, and surfaces mentioned. Or [their elements] are externally established, as in the case of a sea of mercury.

Sensing and apprehending these is not sensing and apprehending existence. The multiplicity of them all is sensed, especially in surfaces differing in quality and quantity. The oneness concomitant with existence in them is intellectually grasped or intuited—that is, apprehended by intellect or intuition. Thus, when the unity coextensive with existence is not apprehended, existence is not apprehended either.

Do not say: ‘You have said that their unity is intellectually grasped or intuited, so it has been apprehended, and consequently—’

Editorial note

Full retranslation restores the opening continuation and the specific psychology/cosmology omitted from the previous paraphrase. Scan compared. The historical locations assigned to imagination and the separate imaginal world are translated as the commentator’s account. Printed أو على ما تقرر ذاته في الخارج is obscure; [their elements] follows the immediately preceding lemma’s مفرداته and is an interpretive rendering, not an Arabic emendation.

Printed p. 198

Rulings of existence and the multiplicity involved in knowing

MSH-P198 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —‘existence has been apprehended.’ For we answer: complete apprehension is intended, and it has not been apprehended in that way, but only generally. Moreover, this unity apprehended in the things is not the unity of existence, which is not apprehended in them at all. Since what is seen of these things

is not existence itself, we say that all this apprehended content is the rulings of existence in respect of its association with each entity to which existence is attributed. This association is not by contact, but through the secret of its appearing in them—that is, in their realities—and its appearing when they see it in another, as you see it in the horizons and in yourselves. It appears through them for themselves or for another, and according to them, not in its totality as it is. Hence its manifestation differs in the human being and in other things.

Or we say: all this apprehended content is the forms of the relations of His knowledge—that is, the realities within it—in respect of its association with each of those realities, and so forth. Or you say: they are attributes inseparable from it in respect of the association mentioned. The difference between this and ‘rulings’ and ‘forms’ is that attributes pertain to the Essence, even through another description; rulings may pertain to attributes alone; while forms must be peculiar to the attributes, not within the attributes but within their loci of manifestation. Say and designate it however you wish.

The result is that what is apprehended is not existence, which is the one Real insofar as He is one. The shaykh then gives the reason:

Qūnawī: “Existence is one, and is not apprehended by what is other than it insofar as the other differs from it. As already stated, the one insofar as it is one is not apprehended by the many insofar as they are many, and conversely. Apprehension is not possible for the human being insofar as he is one with a true unity like the unity of existence. Rather, it is possible insofar as he is a reality qualified by existence and life, with knowledge subsisting in him, an affinity established between him and what he intends to apprehend, and the obstacles preventing apprehension removed. He apprehends what he apprehends only through his multiplicity, not through his oneness. His apprehension of that in which there is no multiplicity at all is therefore impossible, for the reason already given. This point has secrets concerning the soul, which I have discussed in greater detail in my book *Uncovering the Veil of Jealousy from the Secret of Perplexity*. Later in this book there will also be further clarification of what we have stated and established, if God—exalted is He—wills.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Existence is not apprehended in them because it is one, and the one is not apprehended by the many insofar as they are many: they differ from it; difference is separation, and separation prevents knowledge, as stated in Text Eleven.

Editorial note

Full page translation compared with scan. The printed أسرار نفسية is translated as “secrets concerning the soul” rather than silently emended to نفيسة. Explanatory additions about independent objects and perfect identification in the old English are removed.

Printed p. 199

Human conditions of knowledge and the return to the fixed entities

MSH-P199 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): For this reason the many are not apprehended by the one insofar as it is one. Moreover, if the one were apprehended by the many, forms would be impressed according to the parts of the many, and it would be apprehended as many. If the many were apprehended by the one, they would be represented in the one, which is impossible because the one has no capacity for the representation of the many within it. Yet the one may be apprehended by the many through a single aspect [the following construction is compressed], and the many by unity insofar as the one encompasses them potentially.

Hence he said, “It is not apprehended by what is other than it insofar as the other differs from it,” and, “insofar as it is one.” He then anticipates the question: why may the human being not apprehend it in respect of his unity? The many insofar as they possess unity may apprehend the one; that is why the earlier prohibition was qualified by ‘in respect of multiplicity.’ He answers that the human being's apprehension of the Real is not through his being one with a true unity like the unity of existence, since he has no such unity. Even if this is granted, he apprehends only through multiplicity: his qualification by existence involves quiddity and existence; in addition to these two, life is required, since the dead apprehend nothing. A fourth condition is knowledge, a fifth affinity, and a sixth the removal of obstacles. Thus the human being, insofar as he is human, [cannot apprehend that in which] there is no multiplicity at all, for the reason already given. He apprehends the Real only in respect of His attributes or loci of manifestation.

If it is asked, ‘Does this not contradict the earlier account of essential self-disclosure to him?’ we answer: this self-disclosure does not occur while his egoity remains, but when it is overwhelmed beneath the light of the unitary self-disclosure and existential unity predominates over him in that soul. There is an oneness within the human being: when it appears and predominates, he apprehends through it, not through his humanity. Yet the human being in respect of his oneness apprehends nothing. If he apprehends, he no longer remains a human being qualified by oneness. Understand.

Qūnawī: “Let us return to complete the discussion we were pursuing. We say: in the case of the Real, existence is His very Essence; in everything other than Him it is something additional to its reality. The reality of each existent is the relation of its determination in its Lord's knowledge from eternity. In the terminology of the realized among the people of God it is called a ‘fixed entity’; in the terminology of others, a ‘quiddity,’ ‘the known nonexistent,’ ‘the established thing,’ and the like.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This returns to establishing that the Real is existence, not something additional to His reality through which—

Editorial note

Full translation compared with scan. The print contains an unstable sentence beginning فإذا كان كذلك and ending لما مر أن الكثير لا يدرك الكثير يقدر إدراك الإنسان; the bracketed English reconstructs the argument from the explicit lemma on p. 198 and marks the supplied words. No Arabic repair is presented as attested. The final gloss is kept incomplete at the physical page boundary. The older English softened the absolute language concerning egoity and added an explanatory conclusion absent from the page; both are corrected.

Printed p. 200

Arguments for existence as the Real’s Essence and as additional to contingent quiddities

MSH-P200 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —it would subsist by that existence, and without its accession would not exist but remain nonexistent. As for the first claim: if His existence subsisted in His quiddity, it would need that quiddity, which would be other than it; whatever needs another is possible. The [cause] cannot be other than the quiddity, or His existence would be necessary through another. It must therefore be the quiddity. A cause precedes its effect in existence; the quiddity would thus precede existence through existence. This is impossible and contradictory, entailing a thing's preceding itself and an infinite regress.

It may be said: the cause precedes, but we deny that it must precede in existence. Consider a possible quiddity: it receives existence, and the recipient precedes, though not through existence, as you yourselves have said. Again, parts constitute a composite quiddity; what constitutes precedes, but not through existence, since we affirm this priority even when we disregard existence.

We answer: the intellect must first consider existence in that which imparts existence, and must consider the absence of existence in that which receives it. In what constitutes a quiddity, it must disregard both existence and nonexistence. The objection is therefore removed. The difference between the disputed case and your examples is clear: existence is considered in the disputed case, nonexistence in the first example, and neither in the second.

If you say, ‘We do not grant that what imparts existence to something must possess existence beforehand; this applies only when it imparts existence to another, or else it would exist twice,’ we answer: existence would then be other than the quiddity that

brings it into existence. That quiddity would have an existence before its existence, and there would be an infinite regress. Moreover, we do not grant that the parts of a quiddity lack priority in mind and externally.

As for the second claim, there are several arguments. First: a possible quiddity, considered as such, admits nonexistence; otherwise possibility would disappear. The quiddity together with existence refuses nonexistence. If existence were the quiddity itself or a part of it, the quiddity could not admit nonexistence, because contradictories would coexist. Rather, in itself it would refuse nonexistence, just as it does when existence is considered.

It may be said: if by admitting nonexistence you mean that it is established while devoid of existence, we do not grant its establishment then. If you mean its cessation, we do not grant that, were it existence, it could not admit cessation. Existence itself ceases; thus existence admits nonexistence without contradictories coexisting.

We answer: its establishment is necessary, because it is not made, as he will shortly explain. We deny that existence ceases; otherwise it would receive its contradictory, which is even more impossible than the coexistence of contradictories, as already stated. Second: we conceive a quiddity while doubting its existence.

It may be said: its external existence, not its mental existence, which is the very act of conception; the discussion concerns existence without qualification.

Editorial note

Full page retranslation compared with scan. Bracketed [cause] supplies an antecedent required by the compressed printed opening وهي ليست غير الماهية. The arguments about quiddities and existence are translated as the commentator’s claims, including his absolute denial of existence’s cessation; no explanatory substitution about disappearance of manifestations is added.

Printed p. 201

The eternal determination of realities and competing terms for quiddity

MSH-P201 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): The answer is that the realization of mental existence does not prevent doubt about it. Hence people have disagreed about it, and whoever establishes it does so by demonstration. Moreover, an external quiddity is devoid of mental existence until it is conceived, so the two differ. Its difference from external existence has already been established; it therefore differs from existence without qualification. There are lengthy investigations here, most of which were treated in the introduction. What remains is not appropriate to the books of the Sufis; consult works of theology and philosophy for it.

He then states what the reality of each thing is—the reality to which existence is additional: the relation of its determination in its Lord's knowledge from eternity.

To explain: the eternal Essence includes many affairs, without distinction among them within it. Eternal knowledge has a relation to each affair, through which it becomes determined and a form in eternal knowledge. Through the attribution of existence to it, the thing is realized. Hence the theologians say that every thing has a reality through which it is what it is, different from everything else, whether inseparable from it or separable. That reality answers the question ‘What is it?’—for example, ‘rational animal’ in answer to ‘What is a human being?’

The words ‘the relation of its determination’ exclude the affairs and absolute existence, in which there is no relation. ‘In the knowledge of the Real’ excludes their appearance in the forms of existence, for these are existent quiddities. It also excludes [creaturely] knowledge: quiddities need not be established there except in accordance with the Real's knowledge. In creatures' knowledge they are conceptual matters whose establishment is not necessary. Hence the theologians say that they are not established apart from existence. ‘From eternity’ excludes the Real's knowledge of them as qualified by existence in His knowledge, for that qualification is not the quiddity itself but additional to it, as we have said.

In the terminology of the people of God, who make this reality an established, eternal matter, it is called an ‘entity’ because of its determination and distinction, and ‘fixed’ because of its establishment in the knowledge of the Real, without qualification by external existence. In the terminology of others it is a ‘quiddity,’ because for them the thing is realized through it; for the realized knowers, however, realization is through existence, not through it. ‘The known nonexistent’ is the expression of some theologians who hold that existence is additional to it: for them it is not established and is therefore nonexistent. ‘The established thing’ is the expression of the majority of the Muʿtazila, on the basis that the possible nonexistent is established. For the people of God, however, ‘thing’ is restricted to the existent, because He says, ‘I created you before, when you were not a thing’ [Q 19:9], although you were possible. Here there are—

Editorial note

Scan compared. The print’s واحترز بذلك أيضا عن علم الحق conflicts with the immediately following contrast with علم الخلق; [creaturely] is an explicit contextual rendering, not an Arabic emendation. The designation of the fixed entity is garbled in print as أمرا ثابتا أزليا علنيّا لتعينها...; English follows the evident entity/fixed explanation and the lemma on p. 199, while retaining the unamended Arabic. The continuation boundary at وهنا is preserved.

Printed p. 202

The one effect and al-Ṭūsī’s argument for the principle of unity

MSH-P202 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —lengthy investigations that do not concern our present subject.

Qūnawī: “From the Real—glory be to Him—in respect of the unity of His existence, only one proceeds. For it is impossible for the one, insofar as it is one, to manifest and bring into existence what is more than one. For us, however, that one is the general existence effused upon the entities of generated things: those that have come to exist and those that have not, whose existence was previously known. This existence is common to the Supreme Pen, which is the first existent and is also called the First Intellect, and to all other existents, as the speculative philosophers have mentioned. For the realized knowers, there is nothing but the Real and the world. The world is nothing additional to realities known to God—as we indicated before—qualified by existence as established.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Having finished explaining that He is existence itself, he begins what follows from its unity. He says that in respect of the unity of His existence only one proceeds from Him, because of the necessary impossibility of the one, insofar as it is one, manifesting more than one. The same applies to the one bringing more than one into existence insofar as it is one.

The realized master Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī—may God sanctify his secret—said:

“This judgment is close to evident. People's frequent resistance to it is due to their overlooking the meaning of true unity. Its demonstration is this: the concept of a thing's being such that A necessarily follows from it differs from the concept of its being such that B necessarily follows from it. That is, its causality for one differs from its causality for the other. The difference between the two concepts indicates a difference between their realities. Thus what was supposed to be one thing is two things, or a thing described by two differing attributes, although we supposed it one. This is a contradiction. This much suffices to establish the point.”

He then adds, for greater clarity:

“If two necessarily follow from the one, they are either its constituents, its concomitants, or one is a constituent and the other a concomitant. If we suppose them to be concomitants, the original argument returns unchanged: its being such that the first reality necessarily follows differs from its being such that the second necessarily follows. [The printed transition to their being constituents is compressed.] If we suppose the third case, the respect entailing that concomitant must be the same

respect as that constituent. The principle of the respect of entailment must not lie outside its essence, or else the argument returns. In each case composition follows: either in the structure of the thing, as with a body divided into matter—”

Editorial note

Full page retranslation restores al-Tusi’s quoted argument omitted from the old paraphrase and removes a discussion of the First Intellect not present on this page. Scan compared. The printed transition ولم يقف فهما من مقوماته is difficult and is marked. The unusual final ثابتا in the Qunawi lemma is retained conservatively rather than silently replaced by an unattested reading.

Printed p. 203

Objections to al-Ṭūsī and the causal respect of a simple principle

MSH-P203 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Ṭūsī, quoted by al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): “—and form; or because it exists after being a certain thing, as with the First Intellect, through the multiplicity that necessarily accompanies its existence owing to the difference between its quiddity and its existence; or after its existence through division, as with a thing divided into its parts or its particulars. In every case its reality is divisible.” Here his words end—may his station be exalted.

Al-Mahāʾimī: If you say, ‘This argument entails that a simple thing cannot cause even one effect. The concept of its being the agent of such-and-such differs from the concept of its essence: we conceive the simple essence while doubting whether it causes such-and-such. If this concept constitutes it, it is composite; if it is a concomitant, the argument begins anew. There is no infinite regress, but an ultimate constitutive respect, and thus composition follows.

‘In sum, this regress follows not from a plurality of effects but from the causal respect's difference from the essence, and from its being caused by the essence if it is not constitutive. Whether it causes one or more makes no difference. One must therefore accept the regress or hold that this respect is uncaused. Either way, the argument fails.’

I answer: the single respect is His Essence; this cannot hold of two different respects. It is therefore neither caused nor constitutive, and may be a cause, so the two respects would not be different. [The printed text repeats this last reasoning; its wording is unstable.]

If you say, ‘We do not grant the necessity of a regress. It would follow only if being a cause were a positive matter; this is denied, for it is another, eternal matter, and it requires a cause [as printed].’

I answer: its being an entailing cause is a positive matter, because the existence of the effect depends on it. Unless the agent is in itself such that the effect necessarily follows from it, the effect does not proceed. Not everything is an agent of everything. There must be a meaning peculiar to it, in respect of which it is an agent, whether anyone considers it or not.

If you say, ‘If its being a cause is conceptual, the argument falls; if real, two have proceeded from the First, since the first effect would not be an effect.’ I answer: the First Principle is a cause through itself, so its causality is its very Essence. Otherwise the effect would depend on another matter that makes its existence from Him preponderate. That matter would then be the first effect, a contradiction.

Imam Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī objected that many things may be denied of the one: we say that a thing is neither a stone nor a tree. It may be described by many things: we say that this man stands and sits. It may receive many things, as substance receives blackness and motion. There is no doubt that the concepts of denying—

Editorial note

Scan compared. The printed reply after قلت: الحيثية الواحدة ذاته contains a repeated clause and a logically unstable formulation; English makes the difficulty explicit instead of presenting a conjecturally tidied argument as a direct translation. The subsequent printed فإنه يفتقر إلى علة appears to require a missing negation in context; the rendering preserves and marks it. The al-Razi objection begins on this page, not p. 204.

Printed p. 204

Al-Ṭūsī’s reply: negation, reception, and two senses of proceeding

MSH-P204 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī, reporting al-Rāzī (continuing): —those things of it, its qualification by them, and its reception of them differ. The division just given returns, until it follows that only one thing can be denied of the one insofar as it is one, that it can be qualified by only one thing, and that it can receive only one thing.

Al-Ṭūsī, quoted in reply: “Denying one thing of another, one thing's qualification by another, and one thing's reception of another are matters not realized by the existence of just one thing. They do not follow from the one insofar as it is one, but require more than one antecedent thing, so that these matters follow for those things under differing considerations. The proceeding of many things from many things is not impossible.

“To explain: negation requires the prior establishment of both what is negated and that of which it is negated; the latter's establishment alone does not suffice. Qualification likewise requires a qualified subject and an attribute, and receptivity a recipient and something received. Difference in what is received, such as blackness and motion, requires a difference in the recipient's condition. A body receives blackness insofar as it is affected by another, and receives motion insofar as it has a condition that does not [prevent] its departure from it. But for the proceeding of one thing from another it suffices to posit a single thing, the cause. Otherwise it would be impossible for all effects to depend upon one principle.

“Do not say that proceeding, too, is realized only after both a source and something proceeding are realized. We answer: ‘proceeding’ has two meanings. One is a relation accruing to cause and effect insofar as both are together; this is not our subject. The second is the cause's being such that an effect proceeds from it. In this sense it precedes the effect and then the relation accruing to both. This is our subject. It is one matter if the effect is one. That matter may be the very essence of the cause, if the cause causes through itself. Or it may be a state accruing to the cause, if it causes not through itself but according to another state. If the effects are more than one, that matter must differ, and multiplicity within the essence of the cause follows, as already stated.” End of quotation.

Al-Mahāʾimī: It has also been objected that bringing into existence is impossible without two things proceeding: quiddity and existence. Again, the central point stands in relation to [many] points; the concept of its being opposite one point differs from the concept of its being opposite—

Editorial note

Full page retranslation compared with scan and restores the central-point objection at the end. The print reads لا ينفع خروجه عنها in the motion example; [prevent] is a contextual interpretation of a probable textual error, not an attested Arabic correction. The boundary remains open for p. 205.

Printed p. 205

The central point, substance, and branching chains of causes

MSH-P205 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —another. If one or both of these [relations] were intrinsic to the central point, composition in it would follow. Otherwise the point would be their source, and either composition or an infinite regress would follow. Again, substantiality causes spatial occupancy and the reception of existent accidents: two effects of something simple. Do not say that one is in respect of a state and the other in respect of a place, for our discussion concerns its receptivity to both, which is among the accidents of its essence.

The answer is that quiddity is not made. Even if we grant that it is made, it is described as preceding existence, which is its attribute. Do not say that making it is precisely obtaining its existence; we answer that then the quiddity is not made. It remains as it was, but has been qualified by existence.

The central point's being opposite a point on the circumference is in respect of the relation between them; this differs from the relation between it and another point on the circumference. The two oppositions therefore do not arise from one aspect. The cause of each relation is the central point together with a point on the circumference. The argument about substance is complete only if its simplicity is established, both matters are established as existent, and the plurality of grounds and conditions is excluded: it receives spatial occupancy because it has position, and accidents because it is a substrate.

It may be said: if only one proceeds from the one, [one would produce one other], and so on to the last of existents. This is false: Zayd is plainly not the cause of ʿAmr, nor vice versa. Al-Ṭūsī answers in his treatise: more than one may proceed from the one when it is not considered [in isolation from] something else. For example, when one other proceeds from the one, another, B, may proceed from the two together; then another, C, from it together with B; then one other from every pair. Thus it does not follow that either of two things is the cause of the other: one may belong to one chain and the other to another.

It may be said: if one proceeds from Him and then another from Him together with the first, His effect upon the first is unconditional, while His effect upon the second is conditional upon the first. Being the source of the first unconditionally differs from being the source of the second conditionally; either composition or an infinite regress follows. We answer: we do not grant that the First alone acts upon the third. What acts is the aggregate, and the composition is in that aggregate.

Moreover, we say that it would follow that one of two things caused the other only if the first effect—

Editorial note

Full page retranslation compared with scan. The printed objection أن لا يوجد الواحد واحدا آخر and the formulation إن الواحد الذي لا أعتبر معه شيئا آخر are internally unstable; bracketed expressions convey the causal-chain argument indicated by the explicit examples, without claiming an Arabic emendation. The edition’s point and substance counterexamples are retained in full.

Printed p. 206

General existence and the rejection of compulsory intermediaries

MSH-P206 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —were one existent in every respect. But the effect must have an existence proceeding from the Necessary, and a quiddity receiving it through possibility. Something else may therefore proceed from the first effect in respect of each constituent.

Once you know this, we say that the author mentioned the impossibility of the one ‘manifesting’ [more than one] so that one should not suppose the prohibition to concern only origination and to exclude the Sufis' account of things as manifestations. He included this to make the generality explicit. [The printed sentence is defective.]

The view that more than one cannot proceed from what is one in every respect is subject to the scholars' denunciation because it entails things interposed between the Real and daily occurrences and other things, in such a way that He would be unable to originate them without [these intermediaries; the printed transition is defective]. For this reason they declared the philosophers who hold it unbelievers. The shaykh rejects what entails that consequence while accepting the principle. He says: for us that one is general, absolute, simple existence. Its multiplicity does not contradict its true unity; likewise the relations and subtle connections in the First Intellect.

This existence is effused upon all the entities of possible things and their realities fixed in eternal knowledge. [The printed wording that follows, beginning فأبعد منها في الحال والماضي لم توجد, is corrupt.] It speaks of what has not existed in the present or past, of impossibility even when through another, and of eternal foreknowledge that it will not exist. Yet eternal knowledge concerns the existence of things. General existence is connected with them potentially from eternity, while their actual manifestation follows the order. Knowledge concerns each thing according to what it is.

This general existence is common to the Supreme Pen, which is the first existent through that general existence, as the report says, ‘The first thing God created was the Pen.’ It is also called the First Intellect, in the saying attributed here to the Prophet, ‘The first thing God created was the Intellect.’ It is called a pen because it is the principle of recording and writing, and an intellect because it is immaterial. This existence is also common to all the other existents, even daily occurrences, so that all depend upon God without an intermediary. His effect is not confined to the First Intellect, as the speculative philosophers say.

He qualifies them as the speculative philosophers because the other theologians, apart from the Muʿtazila, reject both the consequence and the principle—

Editorial note

Scan compared. This page has several substantial corruptions in the 2008 print, not just the electronic transcription. English marks the irrecoverable middle span rather than silently supplying a reconstructed paragraph. Contextual completions in the surrounding argument are bracketed. Reports concerning creation of the Pen and Intellect are rendered as citations in the text, without endorsing their authentication. No modern editorial footnote is incorporated into the translation.

Printed p. 207

Why the fixed realities are not made in eternal knowledge

MSH-P207 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —because in their view both necessarily entail an intermediary between Him and all other existents. The shaykh then rejects this intermediary because it would be between a thing and itself: in reality there is only the Real. The world is nothing additional to realities known to God. Initially they have nothing in existence apart from their establishment in His knowledge; then they are qualified by external existence. An intermediary would therefore be either between Him and His existence, which is His very self; between Him and other realities; or between Him and the aggregate of the world's existence and its realities.

He indicates the invalidity of the second possibility as follows:

Qūnawī: “The realities, in respect of their being known and the determination of their forms in the Real's essential, eternal knowledge, cannot be made: originated things cannot subsist in the Essence of the Real, and the Real cannot be a container for another or be contained. There are other corrupt consequences that are evident to those with insight. Understand.

“For this reason they are not described as made by realized people of unveiling, or by realized speculative thinkers. What is made is existence; what has no existence is not made. If it were otherwise, eternal knowledge would have an effect upon the determination of its objects within it from eternity, although they are not external to the one who knows them. To affirm that they are made would therefore require either their co-presence in existence with their knower, or that their knower be a locus receiving an effect from himself within himself, and also a container for another, as stated. All this is false, for it impugns the purity of His unity and entails that effused existence accrues as an accident to already existent things, not nonexistent ones. All this is impossible, because it obtains what is already obtained, and for other reasons there is no need to discuss at length. Understand.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: It is thus established that in the respect mentioned they are not made. There are not two existences, as we have said: existence is one, common to all of them and received from the Real. An intermediary between the Real and the realities

of the world could be conceived only if those realities were made. But in respect of their being known to the Real—the determination of their forms in His essential, eternal knowledge—they cannot be made. The realities are realized in this respect, apart from existence, before the world. This respect has therefore belonged to them from eternity and is everlasting.

In respect of their being forms known to someone other than God, or known to Him through the manifestation of His knowledge in loci of manifestation, they may be made; but this is an incidental matter. Insofar as they are realities, they are not made. Their being made in the former respect is impossible because that knowledge does not differ from the Essence in any way. It shares the Essence's immunity from originated things subsisting within it. Moreover, what subsists in that knowledge, an attribute of the Real, subsists in the Real. If—

Editorial note

Full page retranslation compared with scan. The whole Qunawi lemma is retained. The concluding transition from the lemma to the gloss is followed as the print presents it; labels are editorial and do not assert independent manuscript division of the passage.

Printed p. 208

Consequences of treating the eternal realities as made

MSH-P208 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —they were made, they would be originated, and could not subsist in the Essence of the Real or in His inseparable, eternal attribute. If those realities did not subsist in the Real or in knowledge while being established there, they would either inhere [in Him] or be substrates for Him, and all of this is impossible. To make them made also entails other corrupt consequences evident to those with insight. For these reasons realized people of unveiling, and realized speculative philosophers, do not describe them as made.

He then explains those corrupt consequences, after indicating that they are so clear that every realized knower accepts them: what is made is external existence, and what is not external is not made. The entities have no existence, even though existence appears through them, upon them, and is attributed to them.

Moreover, if quiddities were made—and there is no doubt that they are known to God, since His eternal knowledge encompasses all—they would first have originated in His eternal knowledge. They would not originate from the Essence as such, because of its independence of everything. Eternal knowledge would therefore have an effect upon the determination of its objects within it, although its objects are not external to their knower: they subsist in the knowledge that subsists in Him. Rather, they are

nonexistent for themselves and have no existence except through the Real, since He is absolute existence. Their existence is not external, so it could only be within the essence of their knower.

If their being made were affirmed, they would either be originated from eternity, co-present in existence with their knower—but temporal origination from eternity is impossible—or not co-present, but originated within His Essence. Their knower would then either be His very self, making Him a locus receiving an effect from Himself in Himself, or be other than Him, making Him a container for another. He transcends being a container or something contained.

He then invalidates all of this by an argument suited to divine unity: God is one in every respect in His eternity. This would impugn the purity of His unity, since differing realities would exist alongside Him with independent existence [the following printed transition is unclear]. Furthermore, if they were made, they would be existent; existence effused upon them would then be an accident of things already existent. Existence would be repeated upon them: obtaining what is already obtained. This is impossible for that reason and for others that need not be discussed at length.

For example: the quiddities would then be realized by existence while it was absent. Or: if they were made, humanity would, when not made, be [not] humanity. It would therefore be denied of itself, which is—

Editorial note

Full translation compared with scan. The printed text contains local defects (ولا يعلم, وتلك المفاسد لا توصف بالجعل, فلا يكون إلا بالترتيب معه), and the missing negative in the humanity example). English renders the evident argument with explicit brackets at consequential repairs; Arabic is not silently emended. The final sentence continues on p. 209.

Printed p. 209

One existence, its relations, and the absence of an intermediary

MSH-P209 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —impossible.

Or it may be said that some concomitants accrue to quiddities as such, as evenness does to four. If four were supposed to be not even, it would not be four. The quiddities must therefore be established apart from individual existences—individual existence being existence itself. Were they made, their making would precede existence, but this priority is impossible. It is thus established that the realities, in respect of their being known to the Real, are not made, even though their being made under another consideration is possible. If they are not made in themselves, there are not two

existences in reality. A plurality of existence would follow only if quiddities were existent in themselves and, because they differ intrinsically, existence differed intrinsically with their difference.

Existence as such is one in the Real and in creation. It is common to all realities in respect of its manifestation in them and through them. Its source is the Real; it is effused from Him upon them as the sun's light pours upon what faces it. He indicates that the existence of the world has no need of an intermediary:

Qūnawī: “This one existence accruing to created possibilities does not differ in reality from the hidden existence of the Real, detached from entities and loci of manifestation, except through relations and considerations such as manifestation, determination, the multiplicity arising through association and the acceptance of the ruling of commonality, and similar descriptions that accrue to it through its connection with loci of manifestation.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Since the existence accruing to created possibilities—he qualifies them this way because it does not accrue to anything else—is one, some possible things cannot serve as an intermediary for others, either for that existence to be obtained in itself or for its relations and considerations to be obtained.

As for the first: it does not differ in reality from the hidden existence of the Real, detached from entities and loci of manifestation, even though this is [manifest] and not detached from them. Difference in these matters does not entail difference in reality. It is therefore necessary through itself and has no need of an intermediary at all. Suppose we grant that it is not necessary: it is still one, and its occurrence in one possible thing differs from its occurrence in another only through attribution.

As for the second: those relations and considerations accrue to it through the loci of manifestation. These are nonexistent, so cannot be intermediaries. If their existence is considered, the First Intellect is not an intermediary for what is below it; rather, each locus is its own intermediary. This is because the fundamental considerations are [three]: manifestation—

Editorial note

Scan compared. The print’s باطلا ظاهرا in the gloss is contradictory in context; [manifest] supplies only the readable intended opposition to الباطن in the lemma. The final الظهور ثابتة is read contextually as the introduction of the three considerations continued on p. 210; [three] is a marked interpretation, not a manuscript-supported correction. The strong claim واجب بالذات is translated without softening.

Printed p. 210

The Cloud as the wellspring of manifestation

MSH-P210 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —in the loci of manifestation, determination through them, and multiplicity according to their number. The first two arise through its association with them; the third through its acceptance of the ruling of commonality, which follows from association. Likewise the other attributes accrue to it through connection with the loci of manifestation. Each locus is its own intermediary in these considerations and attributes, not in existence itself. There is therefore no intermediary between the Real and creation. What is thought to be an intermediary is so only because those considerations arise at its occurrence, not through it. If the world does not need an intermediary in respect of quiddity, existence, relation, or its attributes, it does not need one in respect of their aggregate, since nothing has arisen there that would require it.

He then states that an intermediary is needed between the Real and His association with the possible realities, because He is in Himself independent of the worlds. This intermediary cannot therefore belong to the world, whether its reality or existence, but must be from the Real, His names, and His attributes. He indicates this as follows:

Qūnawī: “The wellspring of the loci of existence's manifestation, in respect of its association [with them], the presence of its self-disclosure, and the abode of its determination and descent, is the Cloud mentioned by the Prophet—God bless him and grant him peace. It is the station of lordly descent, the point from which the essential, all-merciful generosity issues from the unseen identity and the veil of the might of selfhood. In this Cloud is determined the rank of the first, unseen, eternal marriage, which opens the presences of the divine names through the essential, eternal orientations. We shall shortly unseal the key of its keys, if God—exalted is He—wills.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, the source of the loci of manifestation, through which the realities of possible things become mirrors of the existence of the Real—not in respect of His Essence, independent of the worlds, but in respect of His association with those realities. This association is not like bodies' association with one another, an inhering thing's association with a substrate, or a substrate's association with an inhering thing. It is in respect of His self-disclosure in realities, so that He appears in the fixed entities, after His manifestation in His Essence to His Essence. Hence the abode of His determination is lower than the first determination, extending to the other determinations. This descent is not from a high place to a low one; it means drawing down toward the loci of manifestation. What draws down is the Cloud

mentioned by the Prophet when asked, ‘Where was our Lord before He created creation?’ He said, ‘In a cloud, with air above it and air below it.’ The Cloud is therefore the presence of oneness-with-multiplicity, like a fine veil between creation—

Editorial note

Compared with scan. Corrected digital العلماء to printed العماء (twice) and restored the missing last authorial line «فالعماء هو حضرة الواحدية بمنزلة الحجاب الرقيق بين الخلق والتعين». It continues on p. 211 with «الأول». The printed hadith’s ما is linguistically ambiguous; English gives the non-negative reading while preserving Arabic. The modern editor’s long footnote begins below the rule and is excluded.

Printed p. 211

The first marriage and the opening of the divine names

MSH-P211 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —and the first determination.

It is the wellspring of the loci of manifestation and the intermediary in association because it is the station of lordly descent from the first determination to the second. Hence he relates it to the Lord. It is the point from which lordly generosity issues. ‘The All-Merciful’ is a name encompassing the names of acts, through which He gives everyone entitled to it their due of existence. He descends first from the unseen identity to the first determination. There He has a veil concerning selfhood, being pure existence without distinction among the names and affairs. He then descends from it to the station of lordship and all-merciful existence; the affairs become distinguished here. In this Cloud is determined the rank of the first marriage, the loving orientation indicated by the saying cited here as the Prophet's: ‘I was a hidden treasure and loved to be known.’

It is called a marriage because through it there is connection with the realities on the part of One who is in Himself independent of the worlds; or because it precedes the names' determination through them for manifestation. This presence is therefore the wellspring of the loci of existence's manifestation. This marriage opens the presences of the divine names, because they are relations between the Essence and the loci of manifestation in respect of His appearing in them through His names. These relations follow from the Essence's connection with the loci in the presence of the Cloud. He specifies ‘divine’ names because the essential names require nothing to open them, being the Essence itself.

These names open through the essential, eternal orientations toward His affairs, to complete the matter of—

Editorial note

Compared with scan. Removed the material beginning «الأولى شؤونا مجملة...» from authorial Arabic: it is the continuation of the modern editor’s footnote from p. 210, visibly below the rule on p. 211. The actual body ends «لتكميل أمر» and continues at p. 212 «الوجود». The Hidden Treasure saying is translated as a citation made by the commentator, not as independently authenticated prophetic speech.

Printed p. 212

Existence considered in itself and the absence of distinction

MSH-P212 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —existence, by manifesting actually in the locus of manifestation the possible attributes that are potentially within it.

He says, “We shall unseal the key of the keys”: this is the loving orientation. Perhaps that key is existence's inclusion of the many considerations and the exalted affairs potentially within it. Hence he says:

Qūnawī: “If you understand, existence has two considerations. One is insofar as it is existence alone, which is the Real. From this aspect, as already indicated, there is in it no multiplicity, composition, attribute, characterization, name, trace, relation, or ruling. Rather, it is unalloyed existence. Our saying ‘existence’ conveys understanding; this is not a real name for Him. Rather, His name is His attribute itself, and His attribute His Essence itself.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: If the wellspring of the loci of manifestation is the presence of the Cloud—and this is among the ranks of the Real, since it precedes creation and there is something above it, the Cloud intervening between that and creation—then existence in the rank of the Real has two considerations, if you understand this meaning. One is insofar as it is existence alone, in the rank of oneness.

In this rank it is the Real without two considerations alongside it, since it is necessary existence through itself, as explained in the introduction. From this aspect, as already indicated, oneness has no actual multiplicity or composition of existence and quiddity or anything else. There is no non-established attribute or established characterization, no name differing from Him or trace making Him manifest. In this consideration He has no relation to a thing, nor a thing to Him, because of His independence of the worlds; nor any ruling that He is a principle or not a principle. Although He is not devoid of these, they are not distinguished under this consideration. In this consideration He is unalloyed—that is, pure—existence.

He then anticipates a question: ‘Existence is predicated of Him, and a predicate must differ from its subject in some respect; how, then, can He have no name differing from Him?’ He answers: our saying ‘existence’ conveys understanding. Because it is the most general of things, He is indicated by it; but there is no real name distinguished from Him there. In that rank His name is His attribute itself, and His attribute His Essence itself, since there is no distinction or duality there in any respect. That is, if a name were supposed for Him, it would not be distinct from the attribute, nor the attribute from the Essence: all, within existence itself, is existence itself.

He then anticipates another question: how can there be no characterization or attribute distinguished from Him, when He is qualified by perfection, knowledge, life, and power, whose concepts differ? How are they not distinguished there? He answers —

Editorial note

Full retranslation compared with scan. The opening mixes a short repeated quotation with the commentator’s explanation; English distinguishes these speakers editorially rather than reproducing the edition’s unreliable bracket span. The denial before يقال عليه الوجود appears faulty in print and is rendered as the objection required by the reply; no Arabic correction is asserted. Name, attribute, and Essence remain explicitly identified as in the source.

Printed p. 213

Essential perfection and the identity of knowledge with the Essence

MSH-P213 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī: “His perfection is His very essential existence, established for Him from Himself, not from another. His life and power are His knowledge itself. His knowledge of things from eternity is His knowledge of Himself itself: He knows Himself through Himself, and knows every thing through His very knowledge of Himself.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The perfection established for Him in oneness and the first determination is His very existence, which His Essence requires. Perfection too is therefore established for Him from Himself. Deficiency is nonexistence, so perfection is existence. Existence is established for Him from Himself, not from another, because it is His very self. Were it other than Him, existence would be obtained from what is other than existence and would not be necessary through itself. Likewise His life and power are His knowledge of Himself. Everything that is aware of itself is called living, and what is not aware [the printed sentence stops here]. Power means doing what one wills; His act is known, so what He knows to exist He does, and what He does

not, He does not. The reduction of will, hearing, sight, and speech to knowledge is evident. These attributes return to knowledge, and His knowledge of Himself is His very self, as already explained.

It remains to discuss His knowledge of things. He says, “His knowledge of things is also His very knowledge of Himself.” This is because He—mighty and majestic—knows Himself through Himself, not through a likeness additional to Himself, so that one might say He knows Himself through an additional knowledge. His eternal knowledge of things is His very knowledge of Himself because things consist of existence and realities. Existence is His very self, and realities are the forms of His knowledge. The forms of knowledge do not differ from knowledge in the eternal rank. Hence he specifies ‘from eternity’: all, within existence itself, is existence itself. Thus no characterization or attribute is distinguished there.

He then anticipates a question: how can He be identical with these differing, multiple things despite His utmost unity and simplicity? He indicates the answer:

Qūnawī: “Differing things are united in Him, and multiple things issue from Him, without their containing Him or His containing them, or their bringing Him forth from a prior hiddenness, or His bringing them forth from Himself and making them appear. He has a unity that is the source of every multiplicity, and a simplicity that is identical with every composition. [He is] last and first [the printed transition is unstable]. Everything contradictory in the case of another is established for Him in the most perfect ways.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Things that differ in respect of quiddities are united in respect of existence, because it is common to them. Multiple things issue from Him, so their multiplicity has its source in His unity. Multiplicity was unity in the first rank, then became multiplicity attributed to its quiddities. But His many relations to those quiddities are not by His being a substrate—

Editorial note

Full page retranslation compared with scan. The incomplete وما لا يشعر is marked instead of silently supplying a sentence. The printed آخر، وأول مرة in the lemma is unstable; English identifies the First/Last contrast supported by the following gloss while marking the transition. A detached modern doctrinal explanation is not added.

Printed p. 214

Unity as the source of multiplicity and simplicity as the source of composition

MSH-P214 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —for them, or by His inhering in them, so that He would be a substrate for originated things, their attribute, or situated within them. He is exalted beyond that. Rather, they manifest Him and are manifest through Him.

This does not mean that they bring Him forth from a hiddenness preceding this manifestation, for He has always been manifest to Himself. Rather, His manifestation in them follows His hiddenness relative to them. Likewise, their manifestation from Him does not mean that He brings them out from Himself and makes them appear. The entities remain as they are forever, never smelling the fragrance of existence, although existence appears through them and their forms. If they were qualified by existence, existence would be among their accidents and follow them, although it precedes them. This is why the question is obscure.

He then anticipates another question: these relations must be many, so how can He, together with them, be one in every respect and truly simple? He answers: He has a unity that is the source of every multiplicity, whether of relations or other things. All relations exist potentially within it, like the tree in the seed. In itself it is actually one in every respect; insofar as it is the source of multiplicity, there is potential multiplicity within it. Likewise, His simplicity is identical with every composition insofar as it is the source of compositions. In itself it is actual simplicity in every respect; insofar as it is the source of compositions, it is identical with all of them.

He then adduces the fact that God is called ‘First and Last’ together, because His attributes are eternal without beginning or end. His firstness is in respect of His unity and simplicity; His lastness in respect of His multiplicity and composition. They are therefore united in Him.

He anticipates another question: multiplicity and composition involve deficiency incompatible with eternity and intrinsic necessity. He answers that everything contradictory in the case of another is established for Him in the most perfect ways. Both are established in Him only in respect of the unity, simplicity, and necessity within them, not the aspects of deficiency, which are privative. We have already explained that every restricted thing has an aspect toward absoluteness, every absolute an aspect toward restriction, and everything in a locus is there only according to that locus. He then refutes the ordinary people who disagree with this.

Editorial note

Full page translation compared with scan. The long footnote below the rule, continuing onto p. 215, is modern editorial material and is not translated as al-Mahaimi’s body. The commentator’s direct statements about divine multiplicity/composition are preserved with his own qualifications, rather than replaced by a modern harmonizing paraphrase.

Printed p. 215

Speaking about the Real and seeing opposites through Him

MSH-P215 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī: “Everyone who speaks about Him but not through Him, denies of Him every ambiguous matter, and confines Him within his own apprehension is mute and silent, ignorant and confounded, until he sees through Him every opposite within its very opposite—indeed, as identical with it—while distinguishing its reality from Him.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, everyone among the scholars who imagines he speaks about Him, but does not speak through Him, because he claims complete distinction in order to affirm his own self; who denies of Him every matter whose reality is ambiguous to his intellect, not knowing that his existence is the Real Himself, while the other is only his reality, which has no existence; and who confines the Real within what he apprehends as the Necessary Existent, the Eternal, free of deficiencies—such a person is mute and silent concerning the realities of things, ignorant and confounded concerning them. He does not know the Real as He is until he sees every opposite within its very opposite: the eternal in the originated, the originated in the eternal, the intrinsically necessary in the possible, and the possible in the intrinsically necessary. Indeed, he sees each as identical with the other in respect of existence, while distinguishing the reality of each opposite from the one, necessary Real, without believing in indwelling or union.

He then explains this in detail:

Qūnawī: “His unity is His multiplicity itself; His simplicity His composition itself; His manifestation His hiddenness itself; His lastness His firstness itself. He is not confined within the concept of unity or existence, and is not delimited—”

Editorial note

Scan comparison establishes that the authorial body ends «ولا ينضبط». All subsequent Arabic in the digital body map, beginning «وحدة وجوده لم يصدر عنه إلا واحد» and ending «مستفاد من الحق سبحانه وتعالى», is a modern editorial footnote continued from p. 214 below the printed rule. It is removed from authorial Arabic and not translated as medieval text. The lemma continues directly on p. 216 «لشاهد ولا في مشهود».

Printed p. 216

Manifestation and hiddenness beyond conceptual confinement

MSH-P216 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): “—by a witness or within something witnessed. It is His to be as He has said, and to appear as He wills, without confinement to absoluteness or restriction. His is the meaning encompassing every letter, and the perfection embracing every attribute. Everything whose beauty is hidden from the veiled, in which blemish and deficiency are imagined—whenever its inner reality is uncovered so that its attribution to Him is understood to be sound, the form of perfection is found within it, and it is seen as a platform for the self-disclosure of majesty or beauty. All the names and attributes are multiple with Him within His very unity; they are His very self. He does not transcend what is established for Him, and is not veiled from what He has displayed in order to perfect it.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: His true unity is identical with its opposite, multiplicity, because multiplicity is not in existence itself but in its forms, which are identical with it insofar as they have no existence without it. They are therefore one in respect of existence, which requires unity and is coextensive with it. Unity is thus identical with multiplicity in respect of existence. Likewise His true simplicity is identical with its opposite, composition: this is not in existence itself but among its forms, which are identical with it, and so forth.

Likewise His manifestation is His hiddenness itself, because the manifest is the form of the hidden. Lastness, a concomitant of manifestation, is firstness itself, a concomitant of hiddenness. The identity of what is entailed in its referent entails the identity of the concomitant in that respect. He then explains why two opposites can be united in Him: their union is impossible in something confined within a single concept. The Real is not confined within any concept—not unity, such that He would oppose the many, nor existence, such that He would oppose nonexistence. Hence He is realized in multiplicity and in possible realities, which are nonexistent. Absolute nonexistence is not intended, for it is not established. Understand.

He therefore has no opposite, just as He has no equal. He then says that although the witness of reason indicates confinement to unity and existence, making Him necessary existence, He is not delimited by it according to the proofs of unveiling. Those indicate His manifestation in multiplicity and in possible realities. Yet He is not delimited within that which is witnessed either.

He says that it is His to be as He has said: ‘They encompass nothing of His knowledge except what He wills’ [Q 2:255]. This concerns oneness. ‘And to appear as He wills’ concerns oneness-with-multiplicity, according to the preparednesses in the fixed

entities for receiving manifestation in particular forms, at particular times and places. Yet He is not confined to either oneness or oneness-with-multiplicity. How could He be confined, when His is the meaning encompassing—

Editorial note

Full page retranslation compared with scan, continuing the actual p. 215 lemma without the intervening modern editorial footnote. Terms ahadiyya and wahidiyya are distinguished as oneness and oneness-with-multiplicity. The source’s referential logical argument is retained without substituting a modern analogy.

Printed p. 217

Perfection in restricted manifestations and the plurality of attributes

MSH-P217 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —every letter among necessary and possible existents, and the perfection embracing every attribute of absoluteness and restriction?

He then answers the difficulty posed by deficiency and blemish in restricted things: how could He be qualified by these when they oppose perfections? He says, “Everything whose beauty is hidden”: the imagination of blemish and deficiency comes only from the hiddenness of beauty, which belongs to the self-disclosure of beauty and majesty.

We say this because whenever the inner reality of the matter—expressed by ‘the shin’—is uncovered, so that existence, intrinsically perfect and combining the attributes of majesty and beauty, may rightly be attributed to it, the form of existential perfection is found within it. It appears to the extent of its preparedness and is hidden where its preparedness cannot manifest it. Despite its limited preparedness to manifest existence as it is, it is a platform—that is, a complete, clear locus—for the self-disclosure of majesty and beauty. These are among the concomitants of existence; its existence makes what is within it a platform for the disclosure of both together.

Having said that multiplicity in existence is unity itself, he explains where multiplicity is established and how it coexists with unity: it is in the names and attributes. These are many in their concepts and necessary rulings, yet all are within the very unity in respect of their referent. That unity itself is the Essence in respect of its referent, so all are the Essence itself. Unity and multiplicity are therefore together within it.

He then answers the supposition that multiplicity in Him entails many gods, although God transcends a partner by the agreement of those rational people and people of unveiling whose views carry weight. His answer is that, according to some of them,

He does not transcend multiplicity in attributes, since those are established for Him in their view. He transcends multiplicity in subjects possessing those attributes, which are not established. This is precisely the position of the Sunnis, including the Ashʿarīs and others.

He then answers the question of how multiple attributes are affirmed in unveiling, when they would otherwise be veils from the Essence. He answers: He first discloses the attributes to them; when they are perfected, He discloses the Essence, thereby completing for them the disclosure of the attributes as well. The perfected person is not veiled by one thing from another: creation does not veil him from the Real, so how could the Real's attributes veil him from Him?

Having mentioned veiling and sanctity, he digresses. Since it was said that everything by which He is described is identical with its opposite, veiling in His case would be disclosure itself, might abasement itself, independence need itself, and sanctity deficiency itself. Yet these—

Editorial note

Full translation compared with scan. The assertions concerning Sunni theology and the equivalence of opposites are the commentator’s claims, rendered with their stated qualifications. The prior English’s broad paraphrase is replaced by the full sequence of objections and replies.

Printed p. 218

Veil, might, independence, and sanctity under distinct considerations

MSH-P218 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —matters are affirmed by consensus, and their opposites denied by it. An explanation is therefore needed. It is what he says:

Qūnawī: “His veil, might, independence, and sanctity signify His reality's distinction from everything that opposes it, His lack of connection with anything, and His lack of need for anything in the establishment and continuance of His existence. Nothing is realized through itself or through anything except Him. Take heed.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: His veil signifies His reality's distinction from everything opposing it. There is no opposition except in respect of existence [the printed formulation is difficult], so there is no veil in that respect. His reality's distinction is a veil because it produces the separation that brings ignorance of Him. If you say, ‘There is no reality and existence there; His reality is existence itself,’ we answer: what is intended is the

reality of existence through which existence is existence. Although existence is most evident in its actuality, it is most hidden in respect of its reality, since it cannot be defined by an essential or descriptive definition.

His might signifies His lack of connection with anything, because connection with what is lower [the printed expression is defective]. In respect of the absoluteness of the Essence He is mighty. But because He has an aspect toward restriction, He becomes connected with created things, so that they appear and exist.

His independence signifies His lack of need for anything in the establishment and continuance of His existence. This is in respect of the Essence. In respect of the names, however, their appearance in loci of manifestation requires the fixed entities through which and in which they appear.

His sanctity signifies all of this, likewise in respect of the Essence, not the names. The proof is that nothing is realized through itself or through anything else except Him. He is therefore neither veiled from it, nor unconnected with it, nor independent of it in His manifestation in loci of manifestation, nor sanctified beyond that.

He says, “Take heed”: attend to this subtle point when applying the expressions veil, might, independence, and sanctity. He then begins the rulings of existence insofar as it is existence alone:

Qūnawī: “In this respect, intellects and thoughts do not apprehend Him—glory be to Him. Directions and regions do not contain Him. Inner sights and eyes do not encompass witnessing or knowing Him. He transcends formal and intelligible restrictions, is sanctified beyond receiving any determination concerning quantity or quality, and is exalted beyond being encompassed by intuition, understanding, supposition, or knowledge. Through the perfection of His might He is veiled from all His creatures, the perfected among them—”

Editorial note

Full translation compared with scan. The print’s صبوته وجوده is rendered contextually as establishment of existence, supported by the immediately following gloss ثبوت وجوده; no Arabic emendation is asserted. Other difficult printed phrases (ولا ضدية إلا بحسب الوجود; التعلق بالدون ذاته) are marked where they affect the reasoning. The lemma continues on p. 219.

Printed p. 219

Negative judgments of transcendence and eternal knowledge of the world

MSH-P219 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): “—and the deficient.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Insofar as He is existence alone, neither immediate intellects nor discursive thoughts apprehend Him. Directions and regions do not contain Him, so outward senses do not apprehend Him. Inward insights and all eyes do not encompass unseen witnessing and certain knowledge of Him. He explains this by His transcendence of formal and intelligible restrictions: how could senses, intellects, and thoughts—which are restricted—apprehend Him? He explains His transcendence of formal restrictions by His sanctity beyond every determination of quantity or quality, and His transcendence of intelligible restrictions by His exaltation beyond being encompassed by intuition, understanding, supposition, or knowledge.

He explains the inability of inner sights and eyes to encompass Him by His being veiled through the perfection of His might from all His creatures: the perfected possessor of insight and the deficient person limited to outward sight. He describes the perfected as the one turning toward Him, and the deficient as the one turning back from Him. He qualifies the one turning toward Him by ‘in his supposition,’ indicating that, since He is veiled from him and he has not apprehended Him, how could he truly turn toward Him? It is an imagined turning, even if it gives him a station or state. He then anticipates the question: if intellects and insights do not apprehend Him, they have nevertheless apprehended His transcendence. He answers:

Qūnawī: “All the intellects' declarations of transcendence, whether through their thoughts or their insights, are negative judgments that convey no real knowledge. Even so, they fall short of what His majesty requires and His sanctity and perfection deserve. The source of His knowledge's connection with the world is His very knowledge of Himself. This connection appears through the appearance of the relations of His knowledge, which are His objects of knowledge. He knows what is without end through the encompassing character of His knowledge and His being the source of every thing. He knows His Essence, its concomitant, and the concomitant of that concomitant, collectively and separately, generally and in detail, and so on without end. Whatever He determines, or knows to have its rank determined, under a condition and cause, He knows with its condition and cause. His prior knowledge of it [the printed construction is unstable] entails its determination. Otherwise He knows it through Himself—glory be to Him—and however He wills. No knowledge arises newly for Him, and no matter or ruling is determined in His case that confines Him.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Since He is existence alone, He does not differ from existents in this respect. When His knowledge connects with Himself, it connects with the world as distinguished from the Real. “The appearance of this connection”—that of His knowledge with the world—is through the appearance of the relations of His knowledge. Since those relations are the objects known and have appeared, the connection with them appears, just as existence's connection with them appears when its relations—the realities of existents—appear. And since—

Editorial note

Full translation compared with scan. The gloss’s references to المقبل إليه في زعمه do not appear in the printed lemma spanning pp. 218–219; the wording is retained in the gloss and the lemma is not silently expanded. The unstable ولازمة أن سبق علمه بذلك تعينه is rendered with an explicit notice, not treated as secure Arabic. The final explanatory sentence is kept open at the page boundary.

Printed p. 220

How one eternal knowledge encompasses multiplicity and temporal occurrence

MSH-P220 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —this implies that His knowledge is one, it might seem that He could not know the many through it, although He knows endlessly many things.

He says: He knows what is without end because His knowledge encompasses His Essence, and His Essence encompasses things, since their realities are His affairs. This concerns the realities. As for existence's connection with them, He knows through being the source of every thing. This is among the attributes of the Essence that do not differ from it in its own rank, and is one of its concomitants. When He knows the Essence wholly, He knows this attribute, because knowledge of what entails entails knowledge of its concomitant. He therefore knows the Essence's being a source and what follows from this: existence's connection with things—that is, the realities that are affairs within the Essence and fixed entities in knowledge. He knows them collectively and generally in respect of the Essence, and individually and in detail in respect of the attributes and existential connection. His one essential knowledge thus extends to endless objects of knowledge.

It might follow that He does not know temporal occurrences: in the first respect, because that is not the respect of their identity with Him; in the second, because they are not necessary concomitants of His being a source, but contingent matters. He therefore says, ‘Whatever He determines … under a condition or cause,’ without the Essence depending upon it; or whatever He knows to have its rank determined under one of these, because it depends upon it in respect of its reality—He knows that thing through knowledge of its condition and cause. Even when it does not depend upon these so that they are necessary for it, He knows it through knowledge of its concomitant condition or cause, if His knowledge has preceded that it has a cause and condition and is determined only in their presence. That condition and cause must return to what is a concomitant of His Essence, or what He is intrinsically a source of. A concomitant has identity with the Essence in one respect, so He knows it in both respects. If it is connected with no condition or cause, necessary or otherwise,

He knows it through Himself, because it follows from His being the source of things. However He wills a thing—whether connected with a condition and cause or not—He must know it eternally.

It might be imagined that when He knows a thing through its condition, cause, or concomitant, His knowledge is renewed. Furthermore, from eternity He knows Zayd's existence as future; when Zayd exists, He knows his existence; when he perishes, He knows it as past. How could knowledge not arise newly for Him? The answer is that from eternity He knows Zayd's existence at a particular time, its being present at that time, future in relation to eternity, and past in relation to what follows it. He thus knows what He has known—

Editorial note

Full page retranslation compared with scan. The compressed conditional-knowledge discussion is translated as a sequence of the author’s distinctions, without importing a modern theory of time. The final temporal example continues on p. 221.

Printed p. 221

Knowledge without renewal and existence actual and necessary

MSH-P221 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —and likewise its dependence upon cause and condition does not entail its origination. He knows from eternity its ordering upon them. His knowledge of them entails His knowledge of it without knowledge of the cause temporally preceding knowledge of the effect.

He then states that knowledge is renewed through renewal of the known only for one in whose case a matter is determined that confines him. If he is confined within a time, he knows what is relative to that time, not another. Since God is not restricted by these times—His being from eternity is His very being for eternity—no knowledge arises newly for Him. Nor is a ruling determined in His case such that one could say He knows only Zayd's existence at a particular time, without knowing its futurity relative to eternity or its pastness relative to what follows his passing away. Rather, He knows all states through one knowledge. Likewise He knows what originated beings know, because their knowledges are shadows of His knowledge.

Hence God says, ‘Until We know’ [Q 47:31; the edition cites 47:32]. He encompasses things completely through all knowledges, but these are not renewed in His case, although their manifestation in loci of manifestation is renewed. Understand.

He then mentions a third ruling of existence insofar as it is existence alone:

Qūnawī: “His perfection is through Himself. His existence is actual, not potential; necessary, not possible. He transcends known change and origination. Originated things do not contain Him so as to display or preserve Him. He does not bring them into being through need of another, nor do they bring Him into being. Things are connected with Him in respect of what is determined from Him; He is not connected with them in respect of their distinction from Him through multiplicity. Their existence for themselves depends upon Him, while He does not depend upon them. Through His reality He is independent of every thing, while every thing needs Him for its existence.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: His essential perfection is through Himself, not through His names, attributes, or loci of manifestation, because it is His Essence itself. The names, attributes, and their loci are only among its lights. His manifestation in what is outward is the reflection of His light within Himself. Hence His existence is actual, not potential, for what is potential is deficient.

This concerns His existence in His Essence, not the attributes of acts, which are sheer relations, or the loci of manifestation. Likewise His existence through Himself is necessary, not possible, even though His manifestation in the loci—

Editorial note

Full retranslation compared with scan. Corrected the English Qurʾan reference to 47:31 and expressly recorded the edition’s 47:32. The modern editor’s footnote defining essential perfection is not included as the author’s prose. The page’s final distinction continues on p. 222.

Printed p. 222

Unchanging essence and changing relations to manifestation

MSH-P222 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —is through possibility, because perfection belongs to the Necessary, not the possible. The possible is deficient; if it is perfect, that perfection is not through itself. Since He is intrinsically necessary, He transcends known change, which would require the loss of a state within Himself. Only His relations to the loci of manifestation change.

Since He transcends change, He transcends origination, because the origination of something within Him would entail His changing from what He was. Yet He is related to originated things through His connections with the realities of possible things, to appear in and through them, not in respect of the Essence or the essential and divine attributes. Because of His essential perfection and transcendence of changes, originated things do not contain Him by becoming His accidents so as to display Him as colours, lights, and dimensions display bodily substances. Nor do they contain Him

as receptacles preserving Him from appearing, for that would entail essential change and deficiency: His manifestation and hiddenness would then not be through Himself. Certainly, His manifestation and hiddenness here, in the loci of manifestation, are through them. In relation to His Essence He is manifest; in respect of independence from the worlds He is hidden.

Since His perfection is through His Essence, He does not bring originated things into being out of need for another. He brings them into being only to appear in loci of manifestation after His complete manifestation in His Essence. The perfection accruing to existence in respect of its inclusion of the affairs of possible things is completed only through them. The affairs within the Essence are the Essence itself, so this is no need for another. Neither do originated things bring Him into being, for He exists through Himself; His existence is not repeated through them. Rather, they appear and are connected through Him, and their manifesting reality acquires actual attributes that were potential through Him. What is brought into being is His connection with them. Those attributes appear upon Him through that connection after their hiddenness.

He then anticipates a question: since His perfection is through Himself and He has no need of originated things, in what respect are things connected with Him, so that He brings them into being? The answer is that their connection is [not] in respect of their otherness and distinction, but insofar as they are His determinations in manifestation, through which the perfection that is not essential to Him appears. Their existence is [His] existence with the restriction of His determination through them.

Their distinction concerns their multiplicity through their realities, unlike the aspect of existence: the effusion is one and becomes multiple according to the multiplicity of realities. Since their connection is through existence, their existence for themselves depends upon Him, without reciprocity. He is independent of everything through His reality, which is the reality of existence, although He is not independent of the loci in respect of His manifestation in them. Every thing needs Him for its existence, since nothing has existence from itself. Otherwise every thing would be intrinsically necessary, and there would be many things intrinsically eternal.

Editorial note

Scan compared. The print’s bracketed paragraph beginning ارتباط الأشياء به من حيث غيريتها lacks the negative required by بل; English supplies [not]. The printed ووجودها غير وجود مع قيد تعينه بها is likewise defective; [His] follows the explicit one-existence argument around it and is an interpretive repair, not an attested Arabic variant. The bracketed paragraph is treated as an explanatory gloss rather than automatically attributed to Qunawi.

Printed p. 223

Providence, existential light, and the second consideration of existence

MSH-P223 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: Having stated that things are connected with Him through their existence, he explains what causes existence to be connected with them:

Qūnawī: “Between Him and things there is no relation except providence, as has been said; and no veil except ignorance, confusion, and imagination, because of His utmost proximity and nearness, and the excess of His might and exaltation. His providence is, in reality, the effusion of His existential light upon what is imprinted in the mirror of its entity—which is the relation of its being known—and is prepared to receive the ruling of His bringing it into existence and being a locus of His manifestation. He is exalted: ‘Nothing is like His likeness’ from the first aspect, while ‘He is the Hearing, the Seeing’ from the second.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Here begins the second consideration; what preceded concerned pure existence. Although discussions of connection were mentioned, they were digressions. The primary purpose was to explain existence as such and its rulings in that respect. Rulings concerning its connections were introduced because explaining the essential rulings depended upon them: things are made clear by their opposites.

That is, between the Real as such and things there is no relation of His existence's connection with them—despite His essential independence of them—except providence, which is prior knowledge, as the philosophers say. Otherwise He would need them to perfect His Essence, or act in vain, which is a deficiency.

Since things exist through His existence because of His providence for them as forms of His affairs, there is no veil between them and Him, owing to His utmost proximity and nearness, except their ignorance and the confusion of imagining their multiplicities. Owing to the excess of His might and exaltation, all these loci together cannot encompass Him, still less one of them.

He then explains that providence, although interpreted as prior knowledge of all things, is in reality the effusion of existential light. Prior knowledge does not suffice for things to occur externally without effusion—that is, the determination of His existence in respect of its luminosity and manifestation, not in respect of the Essence. Providence is completed only through this effusion, which is therefore its reality, as though the greatest of its intrinsic constituents.

He then identifies that upon which effusion occurs: what is imprinted and inscribed in the mirror of its fixed entity. He does not make it the fixed entity itself, since the entity's nonexistence continues. What is imprinted is its form; effused existence

attaches to that form. That reality is a relation of its being known to God. But what is imprinted must be prepared to receive the ruling of God's bringing it into existence and appearing within it. Otherwise it does not exist, even if it is intrinsically possible.

He then states that rational transcendence concerns the first aspect: a likeness is what can take the place of another of its kind—

Editorial note

Full retranslation compared with scan. The lemma's printed نسبة إلى العناية is contextually rendered "no relation except providence," following the author's explicit gloss إلا العناية; this is an interpretive correction, not silently altered Arabic. The two Quranic expressions are from 42:11. The long modern editorial footnote beginning below the rule is excluded.

Printed p. 224

The veil of might and why determinate manifestation is called creation

MSH-P224 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —but existence has no plurality, so it has no likeness. 'The Hearing, the Seeing' concerns the second aspect. Yet this includes a transcendence disclosed by unveiling when expressed exclusively. He indicates this by first saying, 'He is exalted.' He then states that this transcendence continues always, even when He appears in loci of manifestation:

Qūnawī: "Whenever He is apprehended or witnessed, addresses or is addressed, this is from behind the veil of His might in the rank of His self just mentioned, through the relation of His outwardness and the ruling of His self-disclosure in the abode of His descent: the association of His general existence with possible things, and the shining of His light upon the entities of existents. It is nothing other than this."

Al-Mahāʾimī: Whenever the Real is apprehended through certain knowledge, witnessed with the eye of certainty in loci of manifestation or elsewhere, addresses any creature—angel, prophet, or saint—or is addressed, He must then be behind the veil of His might in the rank of oneness. He remains in His original rational transcendence.

Apprehension and the other acts mentioned occur through the relation of His outwardness to things. This relation is the ruling of His self-disclosure to them in the abode of His descent toward nearness to them. That nearness is through the association of His general existence with possible things. His association is not by contact, but by His light's shining upon the entities of existents. None of these acts occurs except through outwardness; oneness retains its rational transcendence.

He then explains why what exists and appears in them is called creation, although it is the transcendent Real in every rank, always:

Qūnawī: “From this aspect, when the determination of His existence is considered as restricted by the attributes inseparable from each determinate possible entity—which are in reality the relations of His knowledge, collectively and separately—and by what follows from those attributes, the matters called affairs, properties, accidents, and the effects following the rulings of the name ‘Time,’ called times, ranks, and abodes, that determination and individuation is called ‘creation’ and ‘other.’ You will shortly learn its secret, if God—exalted is He—wills.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The transcendent Real is called ‘creation’ and ‘other’ from the second aspect when the determination of His existence is considered as restricted by the attributes inseparable from each determinate possible entity. The first qualification excludes Him in respect of the first determination; the second excludes His determination through the attributes of divinity and lordship. ‘Possible entities’ excludes impossibilities, which are called neither creation nor the Real.

Editorial note

Compared with scan. Removed the final digital line «نقائص مفروضة في الأذهان غير واقعة في الأعيان» from authorial Arabic: it is a modern editorial footnote continued from p. 223, below the rule on p. 224. English preserves the actual final body sentence excluding impossibilities. The dense list in Qunawi’s lemma is translated without treating editorial headings as source prose.

Printed p. 225

Properties, accidents, time, and the complete description of createdness

MSH-P225 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī: He then states that those entities are, in reality, relations of His knowledge, indicating that their basis is nonexistence. They have no attribute apart from considering existence's determination through them. Hence we said that existence is restricted by those attributes.

He states that there is no difference between the attributes collectively and separately, lest one suppose that when those attributes are gathered together they are not called creation, since comprehensiveness belongs especially to divinity. The comprehensiveness meant here, however, is that of all the inseparable attributes accruing through determination according to possible entities. These are essential attributes of those things, further restricted by what follows from them. Through these concomitants distance from necessity and proximity to possibility increase, confirming their created character.

He mentions them lest one suppose that these incidental matters do not bring about createdness, since the basis of existence is necessity. It should not be said that the basis is altered merely through the accession of these attributes. This supposition is removed because their accession follows the establishment of createdness; they do not oppose or confront that basis. These concomitants include the matters called ‘affairs’: things' receptivities to existent attributes; properties peculiar to some things rather than others; and general accidents accruing to a thing without being peculiar to it. Although these attributes are not essential constituents, they endure in their subjects.

Likewise there are effects following the rulings of the name ‘Time,’ one of God's names, as in the report: ‘The son of Adam hurts Me: he reviles Time, while I am Time; I turn night and day.’ Those rulings are called times, and their effects are temporal changes. There are also effects accruing through ranks, from the highest world [the printed formulation is compressed], and through abodes, such as what accrues to the elements through their reception of composition and transformation from one form to another.

He mentions these matters to indicate that created things must possess all these forms. The list does not exclude anything, but discloses the full created reality and its attributes. He then states that its secret will soon be known: he will say, ‘Through His permeation of every thing,’ and so forth. You will understand it, if God—exalted is He—wills.

He then mentions the rulings of existence from this aspect:

Qūnawī: “Every attribute is then ascribed to Him—”

Editorial note

Full translation compared with scan, restoring the detailed enumeration of attributes and temporal effects. The final lemma continues on p. 226. The modern editor’s explanation of إذ ذاك below the rule is excluded; its final continuation on p. 226 is also removed from the page map there.

Printed p. 226

Permeation without division or indwelling

MSH-P226 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): “—He is named by every name, appears through every trace, receives every ruling, is restricted in every place by every trace, and is apprehended by every faculty: sight, hearing, intellect, understanding, and the other powers and organs of perception. Remember.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: When existence is restricted by what has been mentioned, every originated attribute is ascribed to it. It is named by every name of originated things, appears through every trace of theirs, and receives every ruling of change. In each place it is restricted by the trace suited to that place, whether the place is intelligible or sensible. It is then apprehended by every outward faculty, such as hearing and sight, and every inward faculty, such as intellect and understanding, and other powers: common sense, imagination, estimation, memory, and reflection; and organs of perception such as the soul, heart, and spirit. Remember this matter, lest the Real veil you from creation or creation veil you from the Real.

He then states the secret of its restriction by these descriptions despite its transcendence of them:

Qūnawī: “Know that this is through His permeation of every thing by His essential light, sanctified beyond partition, division, and indwelling in spirits and bodies. Understand.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: But all this is whenever He loves and however He wills. He is restricted by these attributes through His permeation—that is, His manifestation in such a way that His light flows through every thing. This is the essential, existential light that manifests all, while transcending partition within itself. Its division through the loci of manifestation is impossible; it appears in each locus according to the preparedness He has given it. This permeation is not indwelling, whether in immaterial spirits or in bodies as such. Although His manifestation in them accords with their preparedness, it is not by necessity, but whenever He loves and however He wills. Preparedness comes to it through His love and will, and self-disclosure accords with it. When He permeates them, He is restricted by their restrictions, which accrue to them through this permeation.

He then states that during permeation He is not confined by what He permeates:

Qūnawī: “At every time and in every state, He receives these two opposing universal rulings through Himself, not through an additional matter, and unites every two differing things, absent and present, outgoing and incoming. If He wills, He appears in every form; if He does not will, no form is ascribed to Him.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: He receives through Himself at a temporal time and in a changing state. He specifies this because in respect of eternity He does not receive all—

Editorial note

Full translation compared with scan. Removed «الساري في كل شيء» from authorial Arabic: it is the last line of the modern editor’s footnote begun on p. 225, visibly below the rule. The printed placement of «ولكن كل ذلك متى أحب وكيف شاء» outside the main brackets is followed conservatively in the commentary layer; speaker labels remain editorial.

Printed p. 227

Opposing rulings and forms that do not alter essential perfection

MSH-P227 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —otherwise originated things would be eternal. It may also be said that He is receptive through Himself, but eternity prevents the reception. He thus receives the two universal rulings, detachment and restriction: detachment from everything in the first, and restriction by everything in the second. They are opposites with the utmost difference between them. Opposition, however, is considered only with respect to particular subjects and individual determinations. His receptivity is through Himself, not an additional matter ascribed to Him, since there is nothing beyond absolute existence whose attribution to Him could be considered. Although the effect of His receptivity to restriction by some matters concerns an additional matter, that matter is conceptual in relation to existence itself. His gathering of opposites—indeed, of every two differing things, whether opposed or not —is in respect of His form, not His Essence alone.

Forms differ with the different matters appearing in them, and those matters differ through the will ascribed to Him. If He wills, He appears in every form; if He does not will, no form is ascribed to Him at all. This is as on the day when He says, ‘Whose is the dominion today? God's, the One, the Overpowering’ [Q 40:16]. He says ‘if He does not will’ to indicate that willing nonexistence and not willing are alike in the non-attribution of forms. What is intended is the absence of will's connection, for will is eternal and does not cease. He then states that these forms do not change Him from what He is in oneness:

Qūnawī: “His determination and individuation through forms, and His qualification by their attributes, do not impair the perfection of His existence, His might, or His sanctity. His manifestation in things, His making them manifest, and His determination and restriction through them and their rulings, insofar as they are themselves, do not contradict His exaltation, freedom from restrictions, or essential independence of everything described as existent. Rather, He—glory be to Him—unites realities that resemble and differ so that they combine, and those that differ and stand apart so that they remain diverse.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: His determination through specific and individual forms, and qualification by their originated attributes, do not impair the perfection of His existence in oneness and oneness-with-multiplicity. These determinations and individuations concern the loci of manifestation, not the Essence. They therefore contradict neither the Essence's perfection, nor His might beyond connection with them, nor His sanctity beyond originated things. What happens to a form in a mirror when the mirror moves or breaks does not happen to the possessor of the form. Thus His manifestation in things, His making them manifest, His determination through

their lowly ranks, and His restriction by their possible realities and originated attributes from this aspect do not contradict His exaltation from another aspect, oneness; nor His essential absoluteness—

Editorial note

Full translation compared with scan. The distinction between nonexistence of will and absence of its connection is retained. The mirror illustration and the exact ending of the argument are preserved rather than condensed into a general explanation.

Printed p. 228

Expansion and contraction, origination and restoration through love

MSH-P228 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —nor His essential independence of all. Rather, while transcending all, He gathers realities that resemble one another and those that differ —that is, are proximate—and combines them. He makes them one, or gives them oneness, through the affinity between those realities, so that they accord with His unity accordingly.

He also gathers what is mutually incompatible and what stands apart, without a unifying affinity between them. They therefore do not accord with His unity and remain diverse, yet they come together through existence within existence. He does this to display receptivity through gathering and separation, because it encompasses all of them. He then mentions the names through which manifestation occurs at [origination] and concealment at annihilation:

Qūnawī: “Through His existential self-disclosure hidden things appear, and blessings descend from the unseen into the witnessed, through His names the Expander and the Originator. Through the withdrawal of the ruling of His descent, existents become hidden and cease, through His names the Contractor and the Restorer.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: Through His self-disclosure by general existence, according to the demand of the name the Expander upon the realities, and the Originator's making it manifest as restricted by them and their states, the realities and their attributes hidden in oneness-with-multiplicity appear. The blessings of those realities descend, through manifestation, from the unseen unity into the witnessed. These are the external self-disclosures upon them, actually complete after being potentially theirs. Then, through withdrawal of the ruling of His descent—that is, His nearness to the realities—what has become actual among them in external existence becomes hidden,

indeed ceases externally, according to His names the Contractor and the Expander, concerning manifestation and hiddenness, and the Restorer, who returns what appeared to what it was at first.

He then explains why these names connect with origination and annihilation:

Qūnawī: “He—exalted is He—was veiled by His might, and was Forgiving. When He loved to be known, He drew near and appeared in whatever He willed, however He willed, and was Loving. Through love, insofar as He is lover, He originates, and love makes Him manifest. Through love, insofar as He is lover and beloved, He restores every thing within His grasp and subdued beneath the force of His taking hold, because of the strength of His act and the weakness of what receives it.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: When He regards His exaltation and independence, He veils Himself from things through His might and is Forgiving—that is, concealing them. When He loves to be known, to perfect the world and existence through manifestation in loci and to bring what is potentially possible for both into actuality, [He draws near to] the realities and appears in whatever He wills through the eternal will that bestows preparedness upon them, however He wills there. He is thus Loving, through His appearing in them and making them appear. Through love, insofar as He is lover alone—there being no beloved from creation before origination—He originates—

Editorial note

Full translation compared with scan. The print’s عند الاتحاد is rendered [origination] from the creation/annihilation context and marked as interpretation; Arabic remains unchanged. The gloss actually adds الباسط alongside القابض and المعيد; this is preserved, not conformed to the shorter lemma. The defective printed وما من الحقائق is rendered [He draws near to] the realities from the lemma’s دنا, explicitly marked.

Printed p. 229

The Glorious Throne, the First Intellect, and divine action upon causes

MSH-P229 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): —the realities by giving them existence, while love makes Him manifest by appearing in them after His manifestation through Himself within Himself. Through love, insofar as He is lover in created forms and beloved in respect of reality, He restores [them] to Himself. This includes the saying cited here as the Prophet's: ‘Love of homeland is part of faith.’

He then indicates that being lover and beloved does not suffice: every thing must also be in the grasp of His will and subdued beneath the force of His taking hold, which is His power. These are realized through the strength of His act, so that He is

overpowering and grasping, and the weakness of [what receives] the act, so that it is grasped and overpowered. Thus no other is an agent, and He is not a recipient of action.

He then states what the first locus of manifestation is, through whose mediation these things and their causes appear:

Qūnawī: “The locus of manifestation of His power, the instrument of His wisdom in His action according to His customary way, and the locus of appearance of the secret of contraction and expansion, origination and concealment, unseen and witnessed, disclosure and the formal, causal veil through which He performs what has been mentioned—though not absolutely—is His Glorious Throne.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: The locus of manifestation of His overpowering power is the Glorious Throne, which is the First Intellect, as the realized shaykh Muḥyī al-Ḥaqq wa-l-Dīn Ibn al-ʿArabī—may God sanctify his spirit—explains in his treatise called *al-ʿAqliyya*. It is an instrument for His doing things as required by the wisdom that orders effects upon their causes, according to His customary way of bringing things into existence following the orientations of the universal intellects and souls.

The First Intellect is a locus of contraction in respect of its possibility, and expansion in respect of its necessity through its Lord; origination in respect of its existence, and concealment in respect of its immateriality; unseen in respect of belonging to the world of spirits, and witnessed in respect of its manifestation through its Lord; disclosure in respect of its recording unseen matters, and a veil in respect of its mediation between the Real and creation. It thus becomes a formal veil—that is, according to outward appearance, since in reality there is no agent except God. But because things are brought into existence upon its orientation, this is attributed to it as a cause, not as an agent.

Through this, the Real does what He does on the occasion of its orientation—not through its assistance or causality, but upon its orientation. This is as we say of our acts: they are the Real's creations, yet they occur upon our orientations toward them. All are therefore His acts without qualification. He then adduces evidence for this whole account in his following statement—

Editorial note

Full translation compared with scan. Restores the final occasionalist explanation formerly shifted onto p. 230 and preserves the quotation’s opening on p. 230. The printed ضعف الفعل is interpreted with [what receives] in light of the explicitly quoted ضعف المنفعل on p. 228. The homeland saying and the attribution of al-Aqliyya are source claims, not independent authentication.

Printed p. 230

Qurʾānic proof, divine freedom, and the opening of Text Twenty-Two

MSH-P230 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): “For this reason He—exalted is He—said, disclosing the secret of this matter: ‘For one who has a heart, or gives ear while present’ [Q 50:37]; ‘Your Lord's grasp is indeed mighty. It is He who originates and restores. He is the Forgiving, the Loving, Lord of the Glorious Throne, Doer of whatever He wills’ [Q 85:12–16], in the two ranks of absoluteness and delimitation. His saying, ‘Doer of whatever He wills,’ answers an implicit question that He knew would arise from a veiled objector.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, because of the ordering we have mentioned, He—exalted is He—spoke to disclose its secret by way of allusion, so that understanding it belongs specifically to one who has a heart that discovers the obscure meanings of the Qurʾān, or who gives ear to the shaykhs who disclose them, being present and wholly attentive, as though looking at what he hears. Your Lord's “grasp”—that is, His power—is mighty: it acts upon whatever He wills, however He wills. He originates insofar as He is Loving, and restores insofar as He is both Forgiving and Loving. He does this through the Glorious Throne, which is the First Intellect. Restoration is to hiddenness; origination is to manifestation.

His saying, “Doer of whatever He wills,” indicates that He has no need of causes, as one might suppose from His saying, “Lord of the Glorious Throne.” Rather, He does whatever He wills, with causes and without them. Causes accord with wisdom. The saying also indicates that He does not necessitate things by His essence, as one might suppose from the statement that forgiveness and lovingness necessitate restoration and origination. He therefore explains that their self-disclosure, too, is through His will and choice, not through necessitation, as the people of veiling maintain.

Text Twenty-Two

Al-Mahāʾimī: Having finished establishing unity, he begins to disclose what most often veils it. He explains this in his saying—may God be pleased with him—“A noble text.” It is the last of the texts because through it the clarification of divine unity, the noblest of the objects sought, attains completion. The remaining veils become easy to uncover once this is uncovered. Its position at the end is also because the complete clarification of divine unity occurs at the station of the oneness of gathering and distinction, which is the last of the stations as they are conventionally known.

Qūnawī: “Know that the greatest doubt and veil is that the multiplicities occurring in the one existence necessitate the effects of the fixed entities within it, and thus give the impression that the entities have appeared in existence and through existence—”

Editorial note

The opening of Text Twenty-Two belongs to printed p. 230, not p. 231. The printed lemma reads توجب; the separate appendix p. 267 reads يوجب. This translation preserves the commentary reading rather than silently replacing it with بموجب. Digital تجابيها is corrected to printed تجليها. This page was compared with PDF page 229 (zero-based leaf 228).

Printed p. 231

The effects of the fixed entities and the language of relative stations

MSH-P231 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Qūnawī (continuing): “—whereas only their effects have appeared in existence. They themselves have not appeared and never will appear, because their very selves do not entail manifestation.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: This is the greatest of the doubts that veil divine unity because all the veils of deficiency, possibility, and changes branch from this one. Once it is removed, it is as though all have been removed.

He means that these multiplicities are only the effects of the fixed entities within the one existence that is manifest through them. They therefore give the impression that it is the entities that have appeared in existence and are what is seen, and that they have appeared through an existence peculiar to them, other than the existence of the Necessary. He rejects this: what is manifest in them and through them is the Real. Only the effects of the entities have appeared within that one existence. Those entities have not appeared and never will appear, because in themselves they do not entail—that is, do not admit—manifestation. They are nonexistent things, and nonexistence has no manifestation. Rather, existence is the Manifest and the Hidden.

Hence Shaykh Muḥyī al-Dīn said in *Inshāʾ al-dawāʾir*: “Existence is not something additional to existence,” because existence is what is manifest. This does not contradict its being additional to quiddity in what is other than the Necessary. He then explains how to interpret statements of the realized knowers that differ from this, in the shaykh's words—may God exalt his station:

Qūnawī: “Whenever a realized knower reports otherwise, or ascribes existence and manifestation to those entities, that report is in the language of certain ranks and relative tastes. That is, its correctness is established only in relation to a particular station, or particular stations, short of the taste of the station of perfection. As for the definitive text whose ruling is not abrogated, it is what we have stated. The same applies to everything mentioned in this book: it is the explicit truth according to

which the matter is. What is said otherwise may be correct without qualification, as is what we have stated here; or it may be correct in relation and attribution to a certain station, as already indicated.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: That is, whenever a realized knower reports from his unveiling something other than our statement that manifestation belongs to existence—for example, saying that manifestation belongs to the entities and that existence is realized in them, or ascribing both existence and manifestation to them and saying that they possess relative existence, which is the shadow of true existence, and that they are what is manifest through it—he reports only in the language of certain ranks of unveiling and certain relative tastes. This does not mean that a reporter who has unveiled all the stations reports in this way from some of them. It means that these words are correct from their speaker only when he has reached a particular station, or particular stations, and is confined to them, without having reached the station of perfection. One who has reached it takes no account of the entities' manifestation or existence: rather, the one existence is what is manifest within them.

Editorial note

This page begins with the continuation of the lemma opened on p. 230. The printed opening includes هي، ولا تظهر, omitted from the linked digital transcription. The phrase الوجود ليس بزائد على الوجود is retained as printed; no unrecorded emendation to الموجود is supplied. Compared with PDF page 230 (zero-based leaf 229).

Printed p. 232

The final rule of manifestation and the printed interruption

MSH-P232 · Arabic source · Al-Mahāʾimī

Al-Mahāʾimī (continuing): This is the definitive text that nothing higher abrogates, unlike those stations, which are abrogated by what is higher than they are. He then states that all his definitive texts proceed from the station of perfection and are correct without qualification. This differs from what is mentioned in his other books and in the books of others: that may or may not be so, although it must be correct in relation and attribution to some station. The earlier indication, in the third subdivision of the first three texts, was that all unveilings must be correct in some respect.

If it is asked, “It has been stated repeatedly that the entities are manifest,” we answer: what is meant is their manifestation through the Real's manifestation within them, not through their own selves, just as their existence is in this way. That manifestation and existence are the Real Himself, not the entities; the entities are forever nonexistent.

If it is asked, “Then this would not be one of the definitive texts,” we answer: it would fail to be one of the definitive texts only on the assumption that manifestation [occurs] through their very selves. Otherwise, this statement admits no abrogation. Understand.

Qūnawī: “When what I have mentioned in this text becomes clear to you, you will know that manifestation is in existence, but on condition of multiplicity together with the effects of the entities within it; and that hiddenness is an intrinsic attribute of the entities, and also of existence insofar as its unity is conceived. The matter turns between manifestation and hiddenness, predominance and subordination: what diminishes from the manifest is included in the hidden, and conversely. Relations and attributions are forms of states and rulings that arise among the ranks. Some make others manifest, and some conceal others, according to the predominance and subordination just indicated. Understand.”

Al-Mahāʾimī: O God, bless our master Muḥammad and his family and companions, and grant them peace. That is, [when] what I have mentioned becomes clear to you—that manifestation belongs to the effects of the entities within existence—you know that manifestation belongs to existence. For the entities have no effect insofar as they are themselves, because they are nonexistent, but only insofar as existence is connected with them. The effects are therefore, in reality, the effects of existence on condition of the entities. “Then, when the effects of existence become manifest on condition of—”

[The sentence ends at this point in the 2008 printed edition.]

“Its end; and praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds.”

Editorial note

The physical print witness (printed p. 232 = PDF page 231, zero-based leaf 230) itself stops after فإذا ظهرت آثار الوجود بشرط, followed by the end formula. The interruption is not merely a defect of the online transcription. Its prior cause is unestablished; no manuscript or independent commentary edition was collated. The lemma reads الظهور في الوجود (manifestation is in existence), while the later gloss and the appendix p. 267 read الظهور للوجود (manifestation belongs to existence). These readings are kept distinct. The difficult printed phrases أن الظهور إما بذاتها and وما ظهر لك are rendered syntactically with minimal brackets, without claiming an Arabic emendation. The final formula is recorded without assigning it conclusively to the author or an earlier copyist/editor.

Qūnawī · al-Nuṣūṣ

Qūnawī’s separate original

The Arabic text printed separately on pp.235–267 of the same modern volume. This is not an independent manuscript witness.

Printed p. 235

Qūnawī’s preface and the first text

QNW-WIT235 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

In the name of God, the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful.

Praise belongs to God, who has made clear, through the settled stations of aspiration, the ranks and degrees of the knowledge of certainty, its eye and its truth; and who, through the stilling of seekers' restlessness, has clarified the state of reaching the utmost sought by their souls, according to their differing degrees in the stations of knowing Him as He draws them near. He has distinguished His elect from the rest of creation by assigning them no goal among all His worlds and the Presences of His Names and attributes except His Essence. Rather, He has made the utmost reach of their aspirations the noblest objects of His essential knowledge and the highest objects of His will, until their ultimate desire and furthest aim become what He wills through His Essence for His Essence.

From the highest aspects of His first, original intrinsic affairs and His loftiest determinations, He is their very certain knowledge, its eye and its truth, throughout the ranks of His essential knowledge, relating first to Himself and then to its objects. They are absorbed in Him insofar as they are themselves, while their ruling remains and pervades all His existents and Presences.

May God bless the one who realizes Him through the most perfect witnessing and the fullest, noblest and most comprehensive knowledge, with enduring presence with Him in all His abodes, states, ranks and modes of being: our master Muḥammad, his family, the elect of his community and his brothers who receive from God his most complete inheritance, embracing his knowledge, states and stations.

They realize the results of their distinctive shares, which distinguish them from what belongs to the special properties of intermediaries, the fruits of following, and the rulings of connecting bonds: a blessing whose ruling continues and whose fruitfulness endures as time endures, in its universal reality and the forms of its detailed rulings expressed as years, months, days and hours.

A noble text: the first of the texts, which must be placed first. Know that, in respect of the Real's essential absoluteness, no judgment may rightly be pronounced concerning Him, no attribute used to define Him, and no relation ascribed to Him—whether unity, necessary existence, principiality, an exigency to bring into existence, the proceeding of an effect, or a relation of knowledge from Him ...

Printed p. 236

Essential knowledge and the first determinations

QNW-WIT236 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...to Himself or to another. All of these entail determination and restriction. There is no doubt that conceiving any determination entails the priority of nondetermination; everything mentioned therefore conflicts with absoluteness. Indeed, conceiving the Real's absoluteness requires understanding it as a negative description, not as an absoluteness opposed to restriction. It is freedom from the familiar unity and multiplicity, and from confinement to absoluteness and restriction, their conjunction, or transcendence of them all. All these may truly be predicated of Him while He transcends them all. Their attribution to Him and their denial of Him are on equal terms; neither alternative is more appropriate.

Once this is clear, it is known that ascribing unity, principiality, effecting, creative action and the like to the Real is valid only under the consideration of determination.

The first determination conceived is the intrinsic relation of knowledge, considered as distinct from the Essence by a relative, not a real, distinction. Through this intrinsic relation of knowledge the Real's unity, necessary existence and principiality are conceived, especially since His knowledge is of Himself within Himself [the edition repeats “within Himself”], and His very knowledge of Himself is the cause of His knowledge of everything. Things are determinations of His universal and detailed intellections; quiddities are those intellections. These are intellections whose being conceived arises one from another—not that anything originates in the Real's intellection; God is exalted above what does not befit Him. Rather, the intellection of some is posterior in rank to others. All are beginningless and endless intellections on one unchanging footing, conceived within knowledge, which relates to them according to what their realities require.

What their realities require has two modes. One is their being conceived through the absorption of their multiplicity in the Real's unity: the detailed is conceived within the undifferentiated. It is like a knowledgeable, intelligent person seeing with the eye of knowledge, in a single seed, the branches, leaves and fruits contained there potentially, and in each of those fruits what was contained in the first seed, and so on without end.

The other mode is the conception of the rulings of unity, collection after collection. Each collection is conceived together with the quiddities it comprises, which are forms of those multiple intellections that multiply the one existence. This is the reverse of the first absorption mentioned: that was the absorption of multiplicity in unity ...

Editorial note

The repeated phrase في نفسه is retained and marked in English; it has not been silently deleted.

Printed p. 237

Ranks of necessitation and relative judgments

QNW-WIT237 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...whereas this is the absorption of unity in multiplicity. Let this be understood.

Know that, in His absoluteness and all-encompassing character, the Real is not named by a Name, assigned a ruling, or determined through an attribute or designation. Ascribing exigency to Him is no more appropriate than ascribing non-exigency, since the exigency either conceived or denied at that point is itself a determinate ruling and restricted description.

Know further that, although exigency is intrinsic, it has three ranks. In the first it depends upon neither a condition nor a necessitating ground which causes its determination. In the second its determination depends upon one condition alone. In the third the appearance of its rulings depends upon conditions, causes and intermediaries.

The ruling of the first exigency is essential effusion without a necessitating ground, not conceived in contrast to a recipient or its preparedness. The second requires a single existential condition: the First Intellect, which mediates between the Real and the possible things whose existence has been decreed up to the Day of Resurrection. In the third rank, the appearance of the effect and ruling depends upon diverse conditions, as with the remaining existents.

I do not mean that there are three exigencies differing in reality. There is one exigency with three ranks; from the aspect of each rank one effect or several appear and are determined. Understand.

Among the divine texts is this: unitive, intrinsic knowledge is qualified by multiplicity in respect of its relation to objects of knowledge. The apprehension of them is realized only through its determinations and relations. Its relation to each known thing follows that thing as it is in itself: simple or composite, temporal or spatial, neither temporal nor spatial, temporally limited in reception and finite in ruling and description, or neither temporally limited nor finite in these respects. Know this.

Another consequence of the texts we have mentioned is that the judgment of every judge concerning any subject follows both the judge's condition at the time of judgment and the subject's condition at that time. If ...

Printed p. 238

Knowledge, existence and perfect realization

QNW-WIT238 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...the subject is of a kind that passes from one state to another, the judge's judgments vary in each state and differ according to the states assumed by the subject. If the subject is of a kind that remains fixed on one footing, the judgment remains fixed according to the determinate relation and requirement of the judgment concerning it. The matter then follows the judge's condition when judging: either his essence requires him to pass through states according to their character, or his essence requires that he remain fixed while states change. His judgment follows one of these two alternatives, which encompass the ranks of every judge and every subject judged; no judgment or subject lies outside what I have described.

Another consequence is that knowledge follows existence: wherever existence is, knowledge is, without separation. Knowledge differs according to the degree, complete or deficient, in which a quiddity receives existence. Where existence is received more completely, knowledge is more complete. Knowledge diminishes according to the deficiency of reception and the predominance of the rulings of possibility over those of necessity, the reverse of the first case. Know this.

Among the further consequences of these verified texts is a matter to which I have alluded elsewhere in my writings in the course of discussing another subject and in its idiom. But I have set this book apart for definitive texts arising from the tastings proper to the station of perfection, rather than the ordinary idiom of restricted tastings belonging to particular stations, which originally rest upon the Presence of a divine Name or attribute, the root and source of that particular tasting. I must therefore distinguish and set apart what belongs to the most perfect and comprehensive station: the soundness of its establishment and its correspondence to

what God knows of the matter expressed, in the highest, most complete and perfect degrees of His knowledge. This differs from establishing validity relative to one station rather than another, or under the consideration of a particular state or time rather than other states and times.

Having laid down this general introduction, we say, in explaining the text we intend to clarify: whatever a person apprehends through reflection, unveiling, sense or imagination, jointly or separately—if his reflection, unveiling, sensory apprehension or imagination does not reach the apprehension of what lies beyond it after knowing ...

Printed p. 239

The limits of knowledge and the unrestricted Real

QNW-WIT239 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...its intrinsic features and universal concomitants, he has not apprehended that thing with complete and rightful apprehension, nor known it as it should be known.

This holds whether the object of his apprehension and knowledge is the world in respect of its meanings and spirits, or in respect of its forms and accidents, or whether the object of his knowledge is the Real. Whenever the reality of the matter and the manner in which each object of knowledge is determined in the Real's knowledge are disclosed to him, he finds it to be so. Unless his knowledge of the Real reaches His absoluteness and the sheer unity of His true Essence—which no name, description, judgment or designation determines, which no witnessing or intellection circumscribes, and which is confined to no determinate thing—he has not known that beyond God there is no further goal; that encompassing Him in knowledge or witnessing is impossible; and that beyond absolute, true existence there is only imagined nonexistence. There is indeed another, higher, more complete and more revealing way to know the impossibility of knowing God as He knows Himself. By God's praise and grace we have known it through tasting and witnessing. But it is forbidden to explain it or commit it to writing; the utmost that may be said of it is this indication.

The tasting, knowledge and witnessing attained by the possessor of a station, insofar as that tasting and station rest upon the presence of a divine Name which is the station's direction of orientation, may have that Name as the limit of their knowledge of the Real—especially from the aspect according to which the Name is identical with the Named, as we have explained elsewhere. Yet these are relative limits. Beginnings and ends are signs of relative perfections; the matter is otherwise with true perfection.

This is indicated in His address to His most perfect servant: “And to your Lord is the final end” (Q 53:42). God has included another subtle, hidden point in this verse. He did not say, “And to your Lord is your final end.” Rather, He indicated that his goal within unrestricted lordship is the goal of goals, beyond which there are only detailed degrees of greater perfection, which stop at no boundary or end.

The Prophet also indicated this in one of his intimate prayers: “I seek refuge in Your good pleasure from Your displeasure, in Your pardon from Your punishment, and in You from You. I cannot enumerate praise of You; You are as You have praised Yourself”—that is, I cannot reach everything that is in You. He thus joined an indication that encompassing Him is impossible with a disclosure ...

Printed p. 240

The most comprehensive determination and principiality

QNW-WIT240 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...that his knowledge of the Real had reached the goal of goals. This is like an explanation of the verse just mentioned: “And to your Lord is the final end.”

The prophetic reports contain many indications of what we have said. Whoever follows them after awakening to, and understanding, what I have mentioned will find it clear and evident.

We further say that this station and tasting have different idioms which express them in different forms. Among its Qurʾānic idioms, as regards its designation, is that whose people God says “know everyone by their marks” [an allusion to al-Aʿrāf, Q 7:46]. This is a distinctive property of overlooking the boundaries by reaching, in knowledge of things, the limit which makes possible a view of what lies beyond them.

Its idiom and name at the station of prophecy is the “point of ascent” (*muṭṭalaʿ*), as the Prophet said of the Mother of the Qurʾān—indeed, of the secret of every verse: “It has an outward aspect, an inward aspect, a limit and a point of ascent, up to seven inward aspects”; and in another version, “up to seventy inward aspects.” I have drawn attention to this in the commentary on the Fātiḥa; consult it there.

Its name and idiom in the terminology of the people of God is the “standing place” (*mawqif*): the end of every station, from which the next station is overlooked. In the tasting of the station of perfection, relative to any two stations, it is the isthmus that joins them; relative specifically to the station of perfection, it is the “isthmus of isthmuses.”

A noble text, difficult to attain. The unseen identity of the Real points to His absoluteness under the consideration of nondetermination and to His true unity, which effaces all considerations, Names and attributes.

Relations and attributions express the Real's intellection of Himself and His apprehension of Himself in respect of His determination. Although this determinate intellection and apprehension immediately follow the absoluteness just indicated, relative to the Real's determination in the understanding of every understander in every self-disclosure they constitute an unrestricted determination. It is the most comprehensive of determinations: the witnessing of the perfect ones, the essential self-disclosure, to which belongs the station of the highest affirmation of unity.

The Real's principiality follows this determination. Principiality is the origin of considerations and the wellspring of relations ...

Printed p. 241

Causality and the mirror of reality

QNW-WIT241 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...and attributions, outwardly apparent in existence and inwardly present in the domain of intellections and minds.

What is spoken of as “one, necessary, absolute existence” expresses the determination of existence within the intrinsic divine relation of knowledge. It is in respect of this relation, and no other, that the Real is called “the Principle” by the realized knower. Understand and reflect: in this text I have included for you the root of the roots of divine knowledge. God is the guide.

Every traveller, whatever path he takes, whose goal is the Real—provided that he gains some felicity from Him—is a possessor of an ascent, and his travelling is an ascent. Understand.

A noble, universal text containing majestic secrets. Know that whatever is described as exercising an effect upon one thing or several is not fully entitled to that description unless it affects the reality of that thing as it is in itself, without conceiving any additional qualification joined to the reality described as exercising the effect, or any external condition whatsoever. I mention these qualifications because of effects attributed to things in respect of their ranks, or in respect of considerations necessarily attached to their realities. I mention them also because of the widespread view among the people of discursive reason and most people of tasting that whatever has the character of a mirror, whether intelligible or sensible, has an effect upon what is reflected in it: the mirror returns the reflected form to itself, and the reflected form appears in it according to the mirror's character.

This is correct in one respect, but not without qualification. An effect of the mirror upon what it reflects would be validly asserted only if it affected the reality of the reflected thing as such. That does not occur. The mirror's effect on what is reflected is established only in relation to the apprehension of someone who does not know the

reality of that thing and has apprehended it only in the mirror. The mirror is not the receptacle of the thing's reality; it is a place in which its likeness and some of its appearances are displayed. Appearance is a relation attributed to the reflected thing insofar as its form is reflected in the mirror, not the reflected thing's very reality.

By “some of its appearances” I intend to indicate that the distinctive essential self-disclosures occur neither in a locus of manifestation nor in a mirror nor according to any rank. Whoever apprehends the Real through these disclosures has witnessed the reality outside the mirror, as it is in itself: not according to a locus or rank, as we have said, nor a Name, attribute, determinate state or anything else of that kind. Through tasting he knows that the mirror has no effect upon the reality.

Editorial note

The compressed causality lemma omits في after يؤثر, making the isolated syntax ambiguous. The commentary at printed p.104 explicitly supplies في and identifies the object as المؤثر فيه, supporting the English “unless it affects the reality of that thing as such.” The later condition returns to the reality described as exercising the effect. This interpretive aid is recorded without silently emending the appendix Arabic.

Printed p. 242

Essential self-disclosures and inward assistance

QNW-WIT242 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

Our master, the Imam—may God sanctify his spirit—used to call these disclosures “the lightning-like essential self-disclosures.” At that time I did not know the reason for this name or what the master intended by it.

These lightning-like essential self-disclosures occur only for one who is entirely emptied of all descriptions, states and rulings belonging to the divine Names and necessity, or to possibility. This emptiness is absolute: its absoluteness does not differ from the Real's. But it remains for no longer than a single breath; hence its comparison to lightning.

The reason it does not endure is the comprehensiveness of the human reality. Just as this comprehensiveness does not allow it to endure, so, if human comprehensiveness did not include the emptiness and absoluteness which attract these disclosures, it would not encompass every description and state. The ruling of comprehensiveness therefore establishes it and denies its permanence. When God bestowed this disclosure upon me, I found strange effects from it in my inward and outward being. Among them was that, although it does not last two breaths, it leaves in its recipient descriptions and kinds of knowledge which God alone can encompass. On the night

when I wrote down this incoming inspiration, I learned that whoever has not tasted this witnessing is not a receptacle for the inheritance and has not known the secret of the saying, “I have a time with God in which none but my Lord has room with me.”

Nor has he known the secret of the saying, “God was, and nothing was with Him”; or of His words, “Our command is but one, like a glance of the eye” (Q 54:50); or the secret of the principial bringing into existence which occurs in no existent time. Likewise, one who tastes this witnessing, having already learned that the fixed entities are the realities of existing things and are not made, that the Real's reality transcends being made or affected, and that there is no third thing besides the Real and the entities, must—if what we have said is truly realized in him—know that nothing has an effect upon anything else. Things have effects upon themselves. What are called effective causes are conditions for the appearance of the effects of things within themselves, not realities acting upon realities other than themselves.

Understand assistance or replenishment in the same way. Nothing supplies something other than itself: the supply reaches the outward aspect of a thing from its inward aspect, and the luminous, existential self-disclosure makes this apparent. Making something appear does not constitute an effect upon the reality of what is made apparent. Relations affect one another in the sense ...

Printed p. 243

Conditional agency and the source of things

QNW-WIT243 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...that some are the cause of the arising of others and of the appearance of their ruling in the reality which is their origin.

Among the things known by one who tastes this disclosure is that the fixed entities, insofar as they are mirrors, have no effect upon the divine existential self-disclosure except with respect to the appearance of the multiplicity latent in the unseen of that disclosure. This is an effect upon the relation of appearance, which is a condition of making apparent. The Real is exalted above being affected by another. The realities of beings, considered as their realities, are likewise exalted above being affected: from this aspect, in the tasting of perfection, they are the very intrinsic affairs of the Real, and nothing other than them can affect them. No mirror, insofar as it is a mirror, therefore affects the reality of what is reflected in it, for the reasons already explained.

Understand this text and reflect upon it. I have included in it precious kinds of knowledge and secrets whose worth God alone can measure. This is the truth of certainty and the clear, definitive text. Whatever you hear that contradicts it, even if correct, is correct relatively. This is the plain truth in which there is no doubt. God is the guide and director.

Among the universal texts are statements I have included in the *Key to the Unseen of Comprehensiveness and Its Differentiation* and in other books which I composed without borrowing anyone's words. That is not my practice: God has protected me from it and, through His pure, exalted gifts, has freed me from dependence on external, lower borrowings. Since this book is devoted to such texts, those statements must also be included here.

Among them is this: whatever is the cause of the existence of multiplicity or of a multitude cannot, insofar as it is such, become determined in an appearance or appear to an observer except in what that observer sees.

Another is this: nothing gives rise to, or nurtures, what is contrary to it or altogether different from it, across the diverse kinds of fruition—intelligible, spiritual, imaginal, imaginative, sensible and natural. This applies to everything called the source of one thing or several, or a fruitful root. But this description belongs to it under the consideration of itself as itself, and under another, hidden consideration known only to the rarest realized knowers.

Whenever something contrary to what we have said seems to occur, it does so only through a condition external to the thing's essence ...

Printed p. 244

Names of the Essence and the absence of repetition

QNW-WIT244 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...or through several conditions, and according to those conditions and the intelligible configuration produced by their conjunction: that is, the conjunction of the reality described as a source with the external conditions and considerations and with the rulings of the rank in which that conjunction is determined. God says, “Each acts according to his own disposition” (Q 17:84).

Nor does a thing produce itself, or something resembling itself in every respect. That would require existence to be attained twice, appearing in one reality and one rank in precisely the same manner and order. This would be the acquisition of what is already acquired. It is impossible because it has no benefit and would be purposeless play; the true Agent, the Wise and Knowing, is exalted above purposeless action. There must therefore be some difference between roots and their fruits. Possible things are without end, while the effusion from the Real, the root of roots, is one. For whoever understands what we have said, there is no repetition in existence. Understand.

Hence the realized knowers say that the Real never discloses Himself twice to one person in the same form, nor to two persons in the same form. There must be a distinguishing feature and a difference in one respect or several, as I indicated earlier. Understand; God is the guide.

A noble text. Since no attribute or Name can be ascribed to the Real in respect of His absoluteness, and no negative or affirmative judgment can be made concerning Him, attributes, Names and judgments can be applied or attributed to Him only in respect of determinations. Since every existent or intelligible multiplicity must be preceded by unity, the determinations in respect of which Names, attributes and judgments are ascribed to the Real must be preceded by a determination which is the principle and origin of all determinations. Beyond it there is only sheer absoluteness. This is a negative expression, entailing the denial of attributes, judgments, determinations and considerations of His inmost Essence, and freedom from confinement or restriction to a description, Name, determination or any other thing mentioned explicitly or comprehensively.

Those of sound intellect, even if they lack authentic unveiling, may consider the attributes and Names that follow this determination. If they cannot conceive Names and attributes beyond what they have conceived and reached through rational apprehension, these are the Names of the Essence relative to them. In the domain of discursive reason ...

Printed p. 245

Essential correspondence and divine gifts

QNW-WIT245 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...while still veiled, their realities serve as indications because their rulings are comprehensive, because other attributes and Names follow them, and because the determination of what follows depends upon them. From this principle the divine gifts of the Essence and of the Names can be known. Every gift and good reaching creation from the Real is either a gift of the Essence, a gift of the Names, or a combination of the Essence and the Names.

The gifts of the Essence are subject to no reckoning; their determinations are neither regulated by number nor confined within it. As for the gifts of the Names and those attributed jointly to the Essence and the Names, either their relation to the Presence of the Essence is stronger and more complete than their relation to the Presence of the Names and attributes, or the reverse. If their relation to the Names and attributes predominates over their relation to the Essence, they are subject to reckoning—difficult or easy according to the predominance and subordination involved.

Here lies a great secret which cannot be divulged. If, however, the outcome of predominance and subordination is a stronger relation of those gifts to the Presence of the Essence, there is no reckoning for them. Gifts of the Essence, and those strongly related to it, are neither bestowed nor received except through an intrinsic affinity. Nothing necessitates them other than that affinity.

Whoever does not know this principle has not known the reality of His words, “You provide for whomever You will without reckoning” (Q 3:27), nor the secret of “God provides for whomever He wills without reckoning” (Q 24:38), nor the secret of “This is Our gift: bestow or withhold without reckoning” (Q 38:39), and similar expressions repeated in the mighty Book.

They also occur in prophetic reports, such as the statement that seventy thousand of his community will enter Paradise without reckoning, and with every thousand another seventy thousand. These latter are recipients of gifts of the Names, but their relation to the Presence of the Essence is stronger than their relation to the Presence of the Names and attributes. They therefore follow the people of intrinsic affinity and share in their states. Know this.

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Prayer, knowledge and the conception of God

QNW-WIT246 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

Having described the divisions of gifts and their rulings, let us describe their recipients. Their reception occurs in different classes, differentiated according to their requests: requests of preparedness, state, rank, spirit, natural constitution and temperament, or incidental natural condition, which the tongue of the requesting recipient expresses.

In general, the highest rank of recipients, in receiving the Real's effusion and gifts, consists in seeing the face of the Real within the conditions and causes called intermediaries and the ordered chain. The recipient knows and witnesses that the causal intermediaries are nothing other than determinations of the Real in the divine and cosmic ranks, in all their diversity. Between the received effusion of the Real and its recipient there is nothing but the determination of that effusion by a restricted receptivity. No ruling of possibility is added through the effusion's passage across the ranks of intermediaries and its being coloured by the rulings of their possibilities. The recipient sees the effusion as a disclosure of the Real's inward aspect. The multiplicities and determinations which have attached to it are rulings of the Name “the Manifest,” insofar as the Real's outward aspect displays His inward aspect. The rulings of manifestation multiply the unrestricted unity of hiddenness; those rulings are what are called recipients. They are the forms of the intrinsic affairs, nothing else. Understand. God speaks the truth and guides whom He wills to a straight path.

A clear text and universal rule for knowing divine compliance and response, and their withholding. The complete, explicit measure and the verified, sound proof through tasting for knowing when the servant is obedient to his Lord, and when the divine response will reach him swiftly in the very thing he requests, without substitution or delay, are sound knowledge and complete compliance.

The sounder a person's knowledge and conception of the Real, the swifter the response to the precise thing requested. The more completely he watches for the Real's commands and hastens to fulfil them with complete compliance, the more completely the Real complies with him in comparison with other servants. Hence the state of the greatest people of God entails that most of their prayers are answered, because of their complete compliance and sound knowledge and conception of God. This is indicated by “Call upon Me; I shall answer you” (Q 40:60).

One who lacks sound, witnessed knowledge and has only a relative conception is not calling upon the Real who guaranteed the response in those words. In his prayer he turns instead towards an individualized image in his mind, produced by his reflection and imagination, or someone else's imagination and reflection, or ...

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Response to prayer and divine initiative

QNW-WIT247 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...by a combination of these. A person in this condition is therefore denied an answer concerning the precise thing requested, or the answer is delayed.

Whenever such a person receives an answer, its cause is the secret of divine togetherness, which entails that nothing is devoid of the Real, or the complete concentration attained by those in desperate need. They have been promised an answer because of their compelling plea and the preparedness produced by their desperation.

Their condition differs from that of someone with a sound conception and realized knowledge. Such a person truly holds the Real present and turns towards Him. Although he may not do this from every aspect, it suffices that in turning towards the Real he conceives and holds Him present, even if only in certain ranks or from the aspect of particular Names and attributes. This is the condition of those in the middle ranks among the people of God; the preceding condition belongs to the veiled.

The perfect ones and the singular individuals turn towards the Real in accordance with the essential self-disclosure already indicated, which they have attained and upon which their realization of the station of perfection depends. It yields comprehensive knowledge embracing the aspects of all Names, attributes, ranks and considerations, together with a sound conception of the Real in respect of that essential self-disclosure, attained through the most complete witnessing. Thus their answer is not delayed.

Moreover, the perfect ones, and those singular individuals whom God wills, behold the Preserved Tablet, indeed the station of the Pen, indeed the Presence of divine knowledge. They perceive what is destined to occur, since its occurrence has been

known beforehand and is inevitable. They therefore do not ask for something impossible whose existence has not been decreed, nor are their aspirations stirred to seek or will it.

I added “or will it” because there are people upon whose willing things depend for their occurrence, even without their praying or asking the Real to bring them about. For many years I witnessed this in our master—may God sanctify his spirit—in more matters than I can count. He told me that in one of his visions he saw the Prophet, who gave him good tidings and said, “God answers you more swiftly than you call upon Him.”

This station is above that of answered prayers. It is among the distinctive properties of complete compliance, and its station is above the station of compliance. The latter is specifically concerned with what was mentioned earlier: hastening to fulfil ...

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Perfect compliance and the complete human

QNW-WIT248 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...the commands, seeking out what pleases the Real, and discharging His rights to the extent of one's ability. This is indicated in the Prophet's reported answer to his uncle Abū Ṭālib when, seeing how swiftly the Real answered his prayers, he said, “How swiftly your Lord responds to your desire, Muḥammad!” Another version has, “How compliant your Lord is towards you!” The Prophet replied, “And you, uncle: if you obey Him, He will comply with you.”

The station which I have said is above this rests upon the servant's complete fulfilment, through his own reality, of what the Real wills from him by the first, universal will directed towards the perfection of disclosure and self-contemplation. That is what occasions the bringing of the world into existence, and the perfect human being is the particular entity intended by God in himself. Everything else is intended as subordinate to him and on his account, since whatever is indispensable for reaching an intended object is itself intended. This is what I mean by “intended subordinately.”

The perfect human being alone is intended in himself because he is a complete locus for the Real's manifestation. Through him the Real appears in His Essence and all His Names, attributes, rulings and considerations, as He knows Himself through Himself within Himself, including His Names, attributes and the other rulings and considerations just indicated, and the realities of His objects of knowledge within His hidden entities. No alteration is imposed by defective receptivity or a flaw in his mirrorhood that would cause what is reflected to appear otherwise than it is in itself.

One whose condition is such has no will distinct from the Real's will. He is the mirror of his Lord's will and of the other attributes. His prayer is then absorbed into his willing, which does not differ from his Lord's willing, and what he wills occurs, as God says: “Doer of whatever He wills” (Q 85:16).

If one who realizes this prays, he prays in the languages of the worlds and their ranks, since he mirrors them all. If he leaves prayer aside, he does so as a locus of manifestation for the Real, in respect of the one of his two faces which turns towards the divine side and does not differ from Him insofar as He is “Doer of whatever He wills.”

Beyond this station there is no further goal for one who aims, and no ascent to a higher rank or station for one who ascends. Below it is the person who turns towards the Real with complete knowledge and a sound conception, addressed by His words ...

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Unity, multiplicity and complete manifestation

QNW-WIT249 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...“Call upon Me; I shall answer you” (Q 40:60). The Real's report is true. This has become possible for the servant just described, and its result—the answer—necessarily follows, unlike the other people who turn towards Him in the conditions already mentioned.

Know this, and you will attain precious secrets and remarkable kinds of knowledge which thoughts and understandings have never reached, and which fingers have not inscribed with pens. God is the guide.

A noble text. The highest degree of knowledge of a thing—whatever the thing, whoever the knower, and whether the object known is one or many—is attained only through union with the known and the absence of otherness between it and the knower. The cause of ignorance, which prevents complete apprehension, is simply the predominance of that by which each is distinguished from the other. This is an intelligible distance, and distance wherever it occurs prevents the complete apprehension of the distant object. Degrees of knowledge differ according to the predominance of that by which knower and known are one: this is true nearness, removing the separation which is the true distance indicated by the rulings of difference and distinction.

If you witness and taste this through verified unveiling, you will know that the perfection of the Real's knowledge of things arises from His contemplating them within Himself and from the absorption of their multiplicity and otherness in His unity. A thing's being in anything, whether its receptacle is intelligible or formal, occurs and appears according to that within which it is determined and manifested.

We therefore say: the Real knows Himself through Himself, and knows things within Himself by His very knowledge of Himself. Since the divine report states that “God was, and nothing was with Him,” the otherness of things is negated relative to the unity which is their essential receptacle, and the Real's priority in respect of unity is established.

When the multiplicity of things—conceived subsequently, having previously been latent within unity—is distinguished and actually joined with unity, the perfection originally hidden within unity becomes manifest. Thus the door of the perfection of disclosure and self-contemplation, the true intended object, is opened; and the rulings of unity appear in multiplicity …

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Degrees of knowledge and the criteria of complete knowledge

QNW-WIT250 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

…and those of multiplicity in unity. Unity makes multiplicity one, since it becomes a common element among the many things intrinsically distinct from one another. It joins their differentiating features, because it gathers them through itself, as we have said. The many things in turn multiply the One through the determinations which occasion the different appearances of the One: colouring, being coloured, and the differing qualities required by the varied preparednesses of the many recipients of the one self-disclosure. Knowledge of the kinds of appearances and of their necessary rulings is thus renewed. These rulings consist in the effects of some upon others, through establishing and undoing, outwardly and inwardly, above and below, within time and outside time, in affinity and without affinity. All this occurs through the connection established among them by the one existential self-disclosure which gathers their dispersed elements together, as we have said.

Knowledge, delight and felicity, in all their varieties, are according to affinity. Ignorance, torment and wretchedness are according to the strength of the rulings of difference and distinction. Where the rulings of union and distinction are mingled, there are competing powers of predominance. The origin of each collection of these rulings in some form of affinity, and its reference and ground considered as a relation, is what is called a “rank.” Understand.

While I was writing this text, I was told inwardly: the rulings attributed to unity and to the one Real, and expressed as the rulings of necessity, have as their root, from the standpoint of unity, a single ruling: the reality of decree. The measures are the effect of the multiplicities of the objects of knowledge relative to that one ruling, and the appearance of the one existence according to those differentiations: an initial effect, then a second effect within the enumerated things through the return of their effect upon them. Know this and ponder the remarkable matter I have indicated; you will attain precious knowledge. God is the guide.

A noble text clarifying the remaining secrets of the preceding text. The highest degree of knowledge of anything other than the Real is to know it through a knowledge resulting from seeing it completely within the Real's knowledge. This knowledge has two signs.

The first is that the knowledge you have attained makes you independent of returning to examine it repeatedly in search of further knowledge. An increase of knowledge after a claim to prior knowledge arises only from the incompleteness of the first knowledge. Had that knowledge been complete, further increase would have been unnecessary, as is the case with the Real. This depends upon complete cognitive encompassment of the known.

The other sign establishing the attainment and soundness of this knowledge is that its ruling extends over the thing until ...

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Names, states and essential perfection

QNW-WIT251 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...it passes beyond the thing's restriction and reaches the point at which its end is seen to be connected with the Real's absoluteness. Knowledge of the Real is otherwise. It relates to Him only insofar as He is determined in a rank, locus of manifestation, state, aspect or consideration. Whenever He becomes apprehensible to the knower through determination in one of these ways, knowledge of Him appears and something not previously determined becomes determined for that knower from the unrestricted Essence, according to the condition of the recipient of the disclosure at that moment.

Just as human states reach no final limit at which they stop, so the Real's determinations and the diverse ways in which He appears to the human being are without end, in accordance with human states, which are determinations of the unrestricted divine Essence and varieties of its appearances. Elsewhere it has been pointed out that the Names are names of states, and that states succeed one another over the entities, whereas the Real passes through the states, as He says: “Every day

He is upon some affair” (Q 55:29). Understand, and do not interpret this away. Rather, strive first to witness it directly; meanwhile believe and submit, and you will be safe. God grants success.

A majestic text. No existent in existence is described as unrestricted without also possessing an aspect of restriction, even if only through its determination in the understanding of one understander or several. Nor is any existent judged restricted without also having an aspect turned towards the unrestricted. Only one who knows things completely, after knowing the Real and knowing everything that he knows through Him, knows this. Whoever has not tasted this witnessing has not realized knowledge of either the Real or creation.

A text explaining the secret of perfection and greater perfection. The Real possesses an essential perfection and a perfection of the Names whose manifestation depends upon bringing the world into existence. Considered as determinate, both perfections belong to the Names. Every judgment made by a judge concerning something presupposes the determination of its subject within the judge's understanding. Unless the Real's Essence were conceived before Names are attributed to it, and distinguished by its independence of all else in the establishment of its existence, it would not be judged to possess an essential perfection.

Every determination conceived of the Real is undoubtedly a Name of His: for the realized knowers, the Names are simply the Real's determinations. Thus every perfection attributed to Him may, from this standpoint, truly be called a perfection of the Names. But insofar as the arising of His Names from the Presence of His unity is required by His Essence, all the perfections attributed to Him are essential perfections.

Once this is established, we say that whatever possesses this perfection from its own essence is not diminished by accidents ...

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The reality of the Real and modes of transcendence

QNW-WIT252 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...and external concomitants in certain ranks, in the sense that they would impair its perfection. Nor may a deficiency in its perfection be imagined such that those things would complete it. Rather, accidents and concomitants may reveal, in certain ranks, the character of its greater perfection. Among these is the knowledge that this is its condition.

A very noble text. The reality of the Real is the form of His knowledge of Himself insofar as He is determined in His understanding of Himself under a consideration which unifies knowledge, knower and known. His essential attribute, which does not

differ from His Essence, is the oneness of comprehensiveness, beyond which no comprehensiveness, relation or consideration can be conceived. Complete realization of the witnessing and knowledge of this attribute comes only through knowing that the Real, within every determinate thing, admits the judgment that He is determined according to what requires His apprehension there as determinate, while knowing that He is not confined to that determination and that, as He is in Himself, He is undetermined. This is the form of His knowledge of Himself.

He knows His Essence as determined relative to His appearance in determinate things according to their character, and relative to one who witnesses Him only in a locus of manifestation. He also knows Himself as undetermined in Himself at the very moment when determination is predicated of Him because of the limited apprehension of one who apprehends Him only in a locus—whether that locus is considered identical with what appears or other than it.

The reality of creatures is the form of their Lord's knowledge of them. Their essential attribute is poverty which bears the fruit of unrestricted sufficiency—not just any poverty. Understand.

A very noble text. The fruit of rational declarations of transcendence is to distinguish the Real from what is called other than Him through negative attributes, guarding against deficiencies supposed in minds which do not occur in existence. The fruit of revealed declarations of transcendence is to deny a multiplicity of existences and participation in the rank of divinity. Revelation also establishes them while affirming a sharing with the Real in positive attributes, so as to deny resemblance and equality. This is indicated in “God is the best of providers” (Q 62:11), “the best of forgivers” (Q 7:155), “the best of creators” (Q 23:14), “the most merciful of the merciful” (Q 12:92), “God is greater,” and similar expressions.

The people of unveiling declare transcendence by affirming comprehensiveness of the Real without confinement, and by distinguishing the rulings of the Names from one another. Not every ruling may be ascribed to every Name. Rather, among the Names ...

Editorial note

The Qurʾānic reference accompanying “the best of forgivers” is corrected in English to 7:155; the electronic/printed reference reads 7:156. The Arabic quotation is unchanged.

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Knowledge as a mirror of known realities

QNW-WIT253 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

…are those to which certain rulings cannot possibly be ascribed, although those rulings are established for other Names. The same applies to the attributes. Among the fruits of the transcendence known through unveiling is the denial of an “other” while the numerical ruling remains, without positing a deficiency to be denied or conceiving a perfection to be added to the Real by someone's affirmation. Peace.

A noble text. A thing's being in anything is according to its receptacle, whether that receptacle is intelligible or formal. Thus contingent objects of knowledge, considered in the fixed determination and inscription they possess in the Real's knowledge, are described as pre-eternal. Yet whatever is determined in the Real's knowledge is, from another standpoint, not free of the ruling of temporal origination: the world's existence and the knowledge of its inhabitants are originated and receptive, unlike the Real's existence and knowledge. Know this, and God willing you will be guided.

A noble text, among the noblest, most majestic and most comprehensive in gathering the universal roots of divine and cosmic knowledge. The designation “Essence” applies to the Real only in respect of His determination: the determination which, in the understanding of creatures other than the perfect ones, immediately follows the absoluteness whose character is unknown and which has no name. This absoluteness is a negative description of the Essence, conceived as distinct from every determination. The positive, actual reality is the first determination, which intrinsically comprises the essential Names, the Keys to the Unseen. What is designated as the Essence does not differ from its Names in any respect.

The Names, however, differ from and oppose one another, while also being united with one another through the Essence that encompasses them all. Oneness is an attribute of the determination, not of the unrestricted reality that is determined, for the unrestricted has neither name nor attribute. In respect of these Names, considered as not different from the Essence, we say that the Real acts through His Essence. Understand.

The Essence has only one concomitant, differing from it only relatively: knowledge. Unitive oneness is established for the Real in respect of knowledge. Within and through knowledge the rank of divinity and the other ranks and objects of knowledge are determined, for all are inscribed in it. Knowledge is the mirror of the Essence insofar as the Essence comprises the essential Names from which, as explained, it differs in no respect. Knowledge is the origin and wellspring of intelligible multiplicity. I called knowledge a mirror for the known things, and also for the Essence with its essential Names, because …

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The divine Names and the keys of the unseen

QNW-WIT254 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

…under the conceptual distinction of knowledge from the Essence, the Real's determination in His understanding of Himself within Himself is conceived. His essential knowledge is therefore like a mirror for Him.

For this reason we said elsewhere that the reality of the Real is the form of His knowledge of Himself. We also pointed out that whatever appears in a locus differs from that locus in one respect or several, except the Real: He may be identical with what appears and identical with the locus of appearance. Remember this.

The ranks are universal determinations encompassed by the one essential concomitant, knowledge. They are like receptacles for the unrestricted effusion proceeding from the Essence which passes through them, under the consideration that the effusion does not differ from the One who pours it forth, as was indicated concerning the Real's being both locus and manifest reality. They enter into the reality of effecting, not without qualification, but in respect of what I have said about their being like receptacles.

Every rank is an intelligible locus for a collection of rulings of necessity and possibility, branching from the essential Names, the mother divine Names and the subordinate Names which follow them. The ranks have fixed entities in the domain of knowledge and intellection. They have no independent effect, but act through existence. Such also is existence's relation to the ranks: the ranks exercise their effects and manifest their rulings in whatever comes into contact with them and is determined within them, through the modifications of the unrestricted effusion reaching and passing through them.

They are like relative ends in relation to the movement of the essential effusion and existential self-disclosure through the stations and degrees determined between beginninglessness and endlessness, without final goal or resting place. It is thus clear that the ranks gather collections of rulings which settle within them from the Presence of necessity and possibility. They make manifest the results of those conjunctions, but according to their own character, not according to the rulings or the unrestricted effusion as such. Their relation is that of shapes and moulds to whatever takes shape and is moulded through contact with and residence in them. This is their effect. Their entities are fixed, and the results of the rulings are finally referred and attributed to them, since they are the point of emergence and return. Understand.

Know also that the ranks are conceived as arising from one another, as are the Names. Divinity, with its universal Names—the Living, the Knowing, the Willing and the Powerful—is a shadow of the Essence insofar as it intrinsically comprises the Keys to the Unseen. Yet, in the tasting of the perfect ones, there is a subtle difference between divinity and the Essence in this respect: ...

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Essential correspondence with God and among human beings

QNW-WIT255 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...divinity is conceived as distinct from the mother Names just mentioned. The Essence is conceived as distinct from its essential Names only by those veiled from essential self-disclosure. Those who possess that disclosure neither conceive nor witness this kind of distinction, except insofar as they know the knowledge of the veiled. For them, the distinction is what I indicated: the Essence does not differ from its essential Names in any respect, while those Names differ from one another, although they cannot be separated. The Keys also possess differing degrees, some following others, as I pointed out concerning the divine Names in the subordination of the Creator, the Originator, the Giver of Form and the like. Remember this.

A section on connection. The secret of affinities lies in sharing something that removes the rulings of otherness precisely from the aspect which establishes the affinity. The first and highest is intrinsic affinity. Intrinsic affinity between the Real and the human being who is the entity intended in himself is established in two ways.

The first concerns the weakness of the effect of his mirrorhood upon the self-disclosure determined within him: it imparts no character compromising the Real's holiness, apart from the restriction of determination, which does not compromise the Real's greatness, majesty or unity. He is free from most rulings of possibility and properties of intermediaries. From this aspect the degrees of those brought near and of the singular individuals differ before the Real.

The other aspect of affinity with the Real is according to the servant's share in the form of the divine Presence. That share differs with the comprehensiveness within him. Affinity weakens or strengthens according to the narrowness or breadth of the sphere of his comprehensiveness in respect of his receptivity, and his shares accordingly diminish or increase.

One who encompasses the attributes and rulings belonging to necessity and possibility, and whatever of them may actually appear in each age and time, while also possessing affinity in the first respect, has perfection. He is beloved of the Real and intended in himself. In his reality, the isthmus of isthmuses, he mirrors both the

Essence and divinity together with their concomitants. One possessing intrinsic affinity only in the first respect is beloved and brought near, but no more. This has been indicated earlier.

Intrinsic affinity between human beings is also established in two ways, corresponding to the two divine aspects mentioned. The first concerns a sharing of temperament: their temperaments fall …

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Spiritual origins and degrees of equilibrium

QNW-WIT256 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

…within one degree among the degrees of equilibrium encompassed by the entire range of human temperaments, or one person's degree of temperament is adjacent to the other's. This is a great principle in the way of realization, tasted by few. After God's decree and determination, what occasions the determination of human spirits from the spiritual worlds, and their differing degrees of nobility and elevation through few or many intermediaries and the consequent strengthening, multiplication, weakening or reduction of the aspects of possibility, is the temperament which requires the spirit to be determined according to it.

A temperament more closely related to true equilibrium—at the central point of whose circle the souls of the perfect ones are determined—requires reception of a nobler spirit, more highly related to the degree of the higher Intellects and Souls. The further it is from that point of equilibrium, the reverse applies in respect of lower worth and rank.

Know this, and understand what I have said about sharing temperament. Through it, ascend to knowledge of the spiritual affinity proper to the other aspect, resembling the hidden, purely divine intrinsic affinity. If you know this through witnessing or realized understanding, you will see that some spirits' first station of determination is the Preserved Tablet; some begin from the spirituality of the Throne, at the station of Isrāfīl; some from the Footstool, at the station of Mīkāʾīl; and some from the Lote Tree, at the station of Jibrāʾīl.

The order descends until it reaches the lowest heaven, assigned to Ismāʿīl, the chief of its angels—peace upon them all. You will then know that, after God's prior knowledge, care, decree and will, the greatest condition for these differences in the degrees of human spirits is what was mentioned about temperaments and their nearness to, or distance from, the point of true equilibrium. The effect of care and will concerns the excellence of the Lord's fashioning, which is followed by the breathing and determination of the spirit. Understand and remember.

Affinity of rank has several aspects, not only one. One concerns the original sources from which the spirits just mentioned are determined. The source of determination of the highest—the spirits of the perfect ones—is the Mother of the Book. Some are determined in knowledge and existence, united together, from the essence of the Supreme Pen, called the First Intellect and the Universal Spirit. Others begin from the Preserved Tablet; others are Throne-related and Isrāfīlian; others are Mīkāʾīlian, from the Footstool's station and spirituality ...

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Paradisal forms, angelic gifts and divine vision

QNW-WIT257 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...and others are Jibrāʾīlian, from the station of the Lote Tree of the Uttermost Boundary. This continues through the kinds of these spiritual sources down to that assigned to Ismāʿīl, the angel of the lowest heaven, whom the Peripatetic philosophers call the Active Intellect, as was mentioned.

Another aspect concerns their imaginal loci of manifestation. According to all realized knowers, spirits of differing ranks are never without loci in which they are determined and appear. The first loci of human spirits, apart from the perfect ones, belong to the unrestricted imaginal world.

Although imaginative forms arise from the subtle powers of this natural constitution and from its purified and cleansed substances, clothed in spiritual qualities, their attributes and states in Paradise appear according to their spirituality and powers and the properties of their imaginal loci.

The dwellings of the people of Paradise manifest the ranks of their spirits in respect of their stations with the Real and their first imaginal loci. The Prophet indicated this subtly, for example in the reported words, “ʿAlī, your palace in Paradise is opposite mine,” or, in another version, “alongside mine.” He is reported to have said something similar of al-ʿAbbās. Of believers generally he said, “One of you knows the way to his dwelling in Paradise better than to his dwelling in this world.” This arises solely from the ruling of affinity.

The market of Paradise contains beautiful human forms in which its people may choose to clothe themselves. It is one of the streams of the unrestricted imaginal world, the source and wellspring of loci of manifestation. It is the channel of the supply reaching the loci of the spirits of Paradise from the imaginal world, and the origin of their foods, drinks, garments and everything they enjoy in the lands corresponding to the ranks of their deeds, beliefs, characters, attributes and degrees of equilibrium in all these things.

The robes of honour and precious gifts which the angels bring from the Real to the generality of Paradise's inhabitants when carrying them to the Dune of Vision to visit and sit with the Real are manifestations of the rulings of the Names …

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Divine companionship and the freedom of the perfect

QNW-WIT258 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

…and attributes upon which the visitors in reality depend, even if they do not know it. Through these gifts their affinity with the Real is strengthened, and the subtle bonds connecting them to Him are enlivened from the aspect of those Names and attributes which hold the rank of lordship over them.

His instruction to the angels near the end of those meetings, “Return them to their palaces,” points to the rulings of the affinities acquired through those robes and gifts, and to the ending of the rulings of the Names and attributes through which affinity with the Real is established and which bring about their gathering and presence before Him. Whenever the authority of the Names and attributes opposed to those requiring the gathering becomes manifest, the rulings which require distinction appear, and distance and veiling result. Understand.

Their differing ranks while sitting with the Real correspond to their differing ranks with the Real Himself, to the soundness of their beliefs concerning God or of their knowledge and witnessing, and to their earlier preference for the divine side over all else. The duration of the meeting, the differing nobility of the address they receive, and what they understand from it correspond to what we have mentioned: to their presence with what they knew of Him, or their holding Him present according to their belief in Him; to their affinity with Him in respect of the station of the Dune of Vision; and to His self-disclosure proper to them there. Know this.

The condition of the perfect ones—may God benefit us through them—in these and other matters is different. They have passed beyond the Presences of the Names and attributes and their particular self-disclosures into the domain of essential self-disclosure. They are as the Prophet described in the reported saying, “There is a class of the people of Paradise from whom the Lord neither conceals Himself nor veils Himself.”

They are confined neither to Paradise nor to any other world or Presence. As I have indicated elsewhere, Paradise cannot encompass a perfect human being, nor can anything other than Paradise. Although they appear in whatever loci they will, they are, like their Master, free from confinement, restrictions, places and times …

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Prophetic ascents and intermediate realms

QNW-WIT259 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

…rather, they are with Him wherever He is, where there is no “where,” no location, body, distance or veil, no journey for a visit, and no ending imposed by a particular time, Name or attribute.

Understand, strive, and aspire to join them and share in some of their exalted ranks, for God is the patron of beneficence.

As for the affinities established between human beings through the ranks of the intermediate world, the model which indicates their details to someone who has not unveiled or witnessed them is what the Prophet related in the report of the Night Journey: he saw Adam in the lowest heaven, with the dark forms of the fortunate among his descendants on his right and those of the unfortunate on his left. When Adam looked to his right he laughed; when he looked to his left he wept.

This indicates the ranks of the generality of the unfortunate and fortunate. The unfortunate are those for whom the gates of heaven are not opened at death. Their misfortune has differing ranks. The Prophet is reported to have said that some of their spirits are gathered in Barahūt and in the places named in the transmitted wording as “al-Ḥilyatayn, al-Khāsiʾīn and al-Khābitīn” [the readings of these names are uncertain].

The ranks of the unfortunate begin from the concave underside of the lowest heaven, where Adam is, and their lowest ranks are those mentioned in the report. The generality of the fortunate have their intermediate-world ranks in the lowest heaven, in differing degrees encompassed by one rank. The ranks of the elect among the fortunate are those indicated after Adam in the report of the Night Journey: Jesus in the second heaven, Joseph in the third, Idrīs in the fourth, Aaron in the fifth, Moses in the sixth, and Abraham in the seventh—peace upon them all.

Those who share in these prophets' states and inherit from them completely likewise have differing ranks within those heavens. The Prophet's report concerns what he witnessed in one of his Night Journeys: thirty-four ascents are reported of him, their accounts collected and documented by the traditionist Abū Nuʿaym al-Iṣfahānī—may God have mercy upon him.

How could this condition be restricted to these seven prophets alone? The messengers and prophets are plainly numerous, and among them are perfect ones designated by God, such as David, whose vicegerency is explicitly affirmed, and other great prophets and messengers. Where, then, are their intermediate-world ranks determined after death, when there are only …

Editorial note

Several place names in the account of death outside the inhabited region are uncertain in the consulted printing. They are transliterated with an explicit uncertainty marker rather than replaced with guessed modern locations.

Printed p. 260

Conclusion of the preceding text; appended discourse

QNW-WIT260 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

…the higher and lower worlds?

The lower world is the place in which the differing ranks of the unfortunate are determined. It follows that the levels of determination of the prophets, messengers, perfect inheritors and elect among the fortunate after death and before the resurrection are in the heavenly Presences. The reason for the particular account given by the Prophet is what was indicated above: it serves as a model for what has not been individually mentioned. Understand.

His particular report concerning these seven was occasioned at that time by an affinity of attribute, act or state, nothing else. So too with John, who is sometimes with Jesus and sometimes with Aaron: this follows from his sharing with both—peace upon them all. Reflect, and God willing you will be guided.

A very noble text. The Real is pure existence, in which there is no difference. He is one with a true unity, not conceived in opposition to multiplicity. Neither that unity's reality in itself nor its conception in sound, verified knowledge depends upon conceiving an opposite. Rather, it is established through itself and establishes, without itself being established by another. Our expression “unity” serves transcendence and understanding; it does not signify unity as conceived in veiled minds.

Once you know this, we say that, considered in the unity just indicated and in abstraction from loci of manifestation and attributes ascribed to Him through those loci and His appearing in them, He cannot be apprehended, encompassed, known, designated or described.

Whatever is apprehended among concrete entities and witnessed among beings, however a person apprehends it and in whatever Presence the witnessing occurs—apart from apprehension through unveiling of disengaged meanings and realities in the Presence of their unseen—is what I mean by “among concrete entities”: whatever is apprehended in any locus of manifestation. What is thus apprehended is only …

Editorial note

The 2008 editor records that the following discourse was an appended text in the exemplar he copied. Its position in this appendix is therefore a transmitted arrangement, not an independently established authorial sequence. The modern editor’s note is not included in Qūnawī’s running text.

Printed p. 261

Shared existence and the realities known by God

QNW-WIT261 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

…colours, lights and surfaces differing in quality and quantity. Their likenesses appear in the imaginal world connected with the human constitution, or in that which is separate from it in one respect, either as they are externally or with elements which exist externally. The multiplicity of all these is sensible; their unity is intelligible or intuited. All of them are rulings of existence—or call them forms of the relations of His knowledge, or attributes necessarily attached to existence insofar as it is joined to each existent entity through the secret of its manifestation. It appears in, through and to those entities according to their character. However you express it, none of this is existence itself.

Existence is one. It is not apprehended by what is other than it insofar as that other differs from it, as explained earlier: the one as one is not apprehended by the many as many, nor conversely.

Human apprehension is not possible through a person's being one with a true unity like the unity of existence. It is possible through his being a reality qualified by existence and life, through knowledge subsisting in him, through an affinity between him and what he seeks to apprehend, and through the absence of obstacles to apprehension. Whatever he apprehends is therefore apprehended through his multiplicity, not through his oneness. Thus, as such, he cannot apprehend what has no multiplicity at all, for the reason given.

This subtle point contains precious secrets which I have explained more fully in my book *Unveiling the Secret of Jealousy from the Secret of Perplexity*. Further clarification of what we have established will also occur within this book, God willing.

Returning to complete our discussion: in the case of the Real, existence is His very Essence. In everything else it is additional to its reality. The reality of each existent is a relation determined eternally in its Lord's knowledge. In the terminology of the realized people of God it is called a “fixed entity”; others call it “quiddity,” “known nonexistent,” “fixed thing,” and similar names.

From the Real in respect of the unity of His existence only one proceeds, since the one as one cannot manifest or bring into existence more than one. But for us this one is the general existence poured forth upon the entities of generated beings: those already existent and those not yet existent whose existence has been known beforehand. This existence is shared by the Supreme Pen, the first existent, also called the First Intellect, and all other existents. This differs from the account of the discursive philosophers. For the realized knowers there are only the Real and the world; and the world is nothing additional to realities known to God, as ...

Printed p. 262

The cloud and two considerations of existence

QNW-WIT262 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...we indicated earlier, subsequently qualified by existence.

Considered as known, with their forms determined in the Real's eternal, intrinsic knowledge, these realities cannot be made. Otherwise originated things would subsist in the Real's Essence, or He would be a container for another or Himself contained—impossibilities which, together with further difficulties, are evident to the insightful. Understand.

Thus the realized people of unveiling, and also of reflection, do not describe them as made. What is made is existence; what possesses no existence cannot be made. Were it otherwise, eternal knowledge would have an effect in determining its objects eternally within itself, although those objects are not outside their knower. In themselves they are nonexistent, with no establishment except in the knower Himself.

To say they are made would therefore require either that they accompany their knower in existence, or that their knower be a receptacle for an effect of Himself upon Himself and a container for something else. All this is false: it compromises the sheer unity of the Real and entails that the existence poured forth is an accident of already existent things rather than nonexistent ones. This is impossible because it would amount to acquiring what is already acquired, and for other reasons which need not be elaborated.

They are therefore unmade in the respect explained. There are not two existences: existence is one, shared by all of them and received from the Real.

This one existence which accrues to created possibilities does not in reality differ from the hidden existence of the Real, disengaged from entities and loci of manifestation, except through relations and considerations: appearing, determination, multiplication through conjunction, accepting the ruling of being shared, and similar descriptions attaching to it through its relation to loci.

The wellspring of the loci of existence considered in conjunction, the Presence of its self-disclosure and the dwelling of its determination and descent, is the “Cloud” (*‘amā’*) mentioned by the Prophet. It is the station of lordly descent and the source of the essential, all-merciful generosity from the unseen of identity and the veil of the might of “I-ness.” Within this Cloud the rank of the first, unseen, eternal marriage is determined, opening the Presences of the divine Names through eternal essential orientations. We shall soon break the seal of the key to its keys, God willing.

Existence therefore admits two considerations. The first considers it simply as existence ...

Printed p. 263

Unrestricted existence and apparently opposed attributes

QNW-WIT263 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...which is the Real. In this respect, as already indicated, it contains no multiplicity, composition, attribute, description, name, designation, relation or judgment: it is sheer existence.

Our word “existence” serves understanding; it is not a proper name delimiting Him. His Name is His very attribute, His attribute His very Essence. His perfection is His intrinsic existence, established for Him from Himself, not from another. His life and power are His very knowledge, and His eternal knowledge of things is His very knowledge of Himself: He knows Himself through Himself and knows everything by His knowledge of Himself.

In Him diverse things are united, and from Him the many arise, without their containing Him or His containing them, without their bringing Him forth from a preceding hiddenness or His Himself bringing them out and displaying them. His unity is the source of every multiplicity, and His simplicity is the very reality of every composition, at last and at first [the transmitted wording here is difficult]. Everything contradictory in the case of another is established for Him in the most perfect manner. Whoever speaks about Him rather than through Him, denies of Him every ambiguous matter and confines Him within his own apprehension, is mute and silent, ignorant and bewildered, until through Him he sees each opposite within its opposite —indeed, identical with it—while distinguishing between their realities.

His unity is His very multiplicity, His simplicity His very composition, His manifestation His very hiddenness, and His lastness His very firstness. He is not confined within the conceived meaning of unity or existence, nor circumscribed for a witness or within something witnessed. He may be as He has said and appear as He wills, without confinement to absoluteness or restriction. His is the meaning encompassing every letter and the perfection embracing every attribute. Whenever

the beauty hidden from the veiled in something imagined to be blemish or deficiency is laid bare, so that its true attribution to Him is apprehended, the form of perfection is found within it and it is seen as a throne for the disclosure of majesty or beauty.

All Names and attributes are multiple with Him within a unity which is His very reality. He does not transcend what is established for Him, nor is He veiled from what He has manifested to complete [its perfection].

His veil, might, independence and holiness express the distinction of His reality from whatever opposes it, and His lack of dependence upon anything—or His lack of need for anything in the establishment and permanence of His existence. Nothing is realized through itself or through anything else except through Him. Awaken.

From this standpoint, intellects and thoughts do not apprehend Him, and directions and regions do not encompass Him ...

Editorial note

The wording concerning the first/last composition is difficult in the consulted text; the English marks that difficulty rather than silently rewriting the Arabic.

Printed p. 264

Hiddenness, disclosure and divine knowledge

QNW-WIT264 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...nor do inward perceptions and outward eyes encompass His witnessing and knowledge. He transcends formal and intelligible restrictions and is holy beyond accepting any measurement of quantity or quality. He is exalted above the encompassments of intuition, understanding, supposition and knowledge, and concealed by His perfect might from all His creatures: perfect or deficient, those who imagine they turn towards Him and those who turn away.

All the declarations of transcendence made by intellects through thought or insight are negative judgments. They yield no true knowledge and still fall short of what His majesty requires and His holiness and perfection deserve. The origin of His knowledge's relation to the world is His very knowledge of Himself. This relation appears through the appearance of the relations of His knowledge, which are its objects. He knows the unlimited because His knowledge encompasses and because He is the source of everything. He knows His Essence, its concomitant and the concomitant of that concomitant, together and individually, comprehensively and in detail, without end. Whatever He determines, or whose rank He knows to be determined through a condition and cause, He knows with that condition and cause

and its concomitant, if His prior knowledge of it precedes its determination. Otherwise He knows it through Himself, as He wills. No new knowledge arises for Him, however, and no determinate thing or judgment confines Him.

His perfection is through Himself. His existence is actual, not potential, necessary, not possible. He transcends familiar change and origination. Originated things do not contain Him so as to display or preserve Him; He does not create them out of need for another, nor do they constitute Him. Things are connected with Him through what is determined from Him; He is not connected with them insofar as they are distinguished from Him by their multiplicity. Their possession of existence depends upon Him; He does not depend upon them. Through His reality He is independent of everything, and everything depends upon Him for its existence.

As has been said, there is no relation between Him and things except providential care, and no veil except ignorance, confusion and imagination, because of His extreme proximity and nearness and His surpassing might and elevation. His care is in reality the pouring of His existential light upon what is reflected in the mirror of its entity—which is the relation of its being known—and is prepared to receive the ruling of His bringing into existence and manifestation. “Nothing is like Him” from the first aspect; “He is the Hearing, the Seeing” (Q 42:11) from the second.

Whenever He is apprehended or witnessed, speaks or is addressed, it is from behind the veil of His might, in the rank of His self already mentioned, through the relation of His manifestation and the ruling of His self-disclosure at the dwelling of His descent, insofar as His general existence is joined ...

Printed p. 265

The divine Names in manifestation and concealment

QNW-WIT265 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

...to possible things and His light shines upon the entities of existents, and in no other way.

When viewed from this aspect, His existence is determined and restricted by the attributes necessarily attached to each determinate possible entity. In reality these are relations of His knowledge, collectively and individually, together with what follows from those attributes: matters called affairs, properties and accidents; effects following the rulings of the Name “Time,” called times; and also ranks and abodes. This determination and individuation are called “creation” and “other,” whose secret you will shortly understand, God willing.

Every description is then ascribed to Him. He is called by every Name, appears through every designation, accepts every judgment, and is restricted in every place by every designation. He is apprehended by every faculty of perception—sight, hearing, intellect, understanding and other powers and means of apprehension. Remember this.

Know that this occurs through His pervading everything by His essential light, which is holy beyond partition, division or indwelling in spirits and bodies. Understand. Yet all this occurs whenever He loves and however He wills.

At every time and in every state He admits, through His own Essence rather than something additional, both of the universal and opposed judgments just mentioned. He joins every pair of different things: absent and present, outgoing and incoming. If He wills, He appears in every form; if He does not, no form is ascribed to Him.

His determination and individuation through forms, and His qualification by their attributes, do not impair the perfection of His existence, might or holiness. His appearing in things, making them appear, and being determined and restricted through them and their rulings do not contradict His elevation, freedom from restrictions or essential independence of everything described as existent. Rather, He joins realities which resemble and differ from one another so that they are brought together, and those which are other and distinct so that they differ.

Through His existential self-disclosure hidden things appear and blessings descend from the unseen into the witnessed, in respect of His Names “the Expander” and “the Originator.” When the ruling of His descent is withdrawn, existents become hidden and cease to exist through His Names “the Contractor” and “the Restorer.”

When He is concealed by His might, He is Forgiving; when He loves to be known, He draws near and appears in whatever He wills, however He wills, and is Loving. Through love He originates as lover, and love makes Him appear; through it, as lover and beloved, He restores everything into His grasp, subdued beneath the force of His might because of the strength of His action and the weakness of what receives it.

Printed p. 266

Conclusion of the appended discourse

QNW-WIT266 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

The manifestation of His power, the instrument of His wisdom in acting according to His customary way, and the locus where the secret appears of contraction and expansion, origination and concealment, unseen and witnessed, unveiling and the formal, causal veil—through which He performs what has been mentioned, though not without qualification—is His Glorious Throne.

For this reason He said, disclosing the secret of this matter, “For one who has a heart, or gives ear while present” (Q 50:37): “Surely your Lord's grasp is mighty. It is He who originates and restores. He is the Forgiving, the Loving, Lord of the Glorious Throne, Doer of whatever He wills” (Q 85:12–16), in the two ranks of absoluteness and restriction.

His words “Doer of whatever He wills” answer an anticipated question which He knew would arise from a veiled objector.

Printed p. 267

Final appended passage and colophon

QNW-WIT267 · Arabic source · Qūnawī

A noble text, the last of the texts.

Know that the greatest doubts and veils [arise when] the multiplicities occurring in the one existence “necessitate the effects of the fixed entities within it” [the opening construction is textually uncertain], so that one imagines that the entities themselves have appeared in existence and through existence. Only their effects have appeared in existence; the entities themselves have not appeared and never will, for they do not intrinsically demand manifestation.

Whenever a realized knower reports otherwise or ascribes existence and manifestation to them, that report is in the language of certain ranks and relative tastes. Its validity is established relative to a particular station or certain stations, not according to the tasting of the station of perfection.

The definitive text whose ruling is not superseded is what we have stated. The same applies to everything stated in this book: it is the plain truth of how the matter is. What is said elsewhere may be unqualifiedly true, like what we have stated, or true relatively and in connection with a particular station, as indicated earlier.

When what I have explained in this text becomes clear to you, you will know that manifestation belongs to existence, but under the condition of multiplicity together with the effects of the entities within it; and that hiddenness is an essential attribute of the entities, and also of existence insofar as its unity is conceived. The matter turns between manifestation and hiddenness through predominance and subordination: whatever diminishes from the manifest is included in the hidden, and conversely. Relations and attributions are forms of states and rulings arising between ranks: some make others manifest, and some conceal others, according to the predominance and subordination just indicated. Understand.

The book is complete. Praise belongs to God alone, and may God bless our master Muḥammad, his family and companions, and grant them peace.

Editorial note

The opening construction is textually difficult. This appendix reads للوجود (“belongs to existence”), whereas the lemma quoted at commentary p.232 reads في الوجود (“in existence”); the commentary’s gloss then uses للوجود. These internal differences within one printed volume are not independent manuscript variants. The appendix’s colophon does not supply the commentary’s missing final clause.

Textual notes and sources

What has been established

The running Arabic and English cover al-Mahāʾimī's commentary, printed pp.11–232, and Qūnawī's separately printed original, pp.235–267. The copytext is the 2008 edition prepared by Aḥmad Farīd al-Mazīdī, published in Beirut by Dār al-Kutub al-ʿIlmiyya. Its electronic transcription and a scan of the printing have both been consulted. The current coverage ledger distinguishes text coverage, translation review and documented image comparison.

The scan and the electronic transcription represent the same modern edition. Agreement between them can resolve a transcription error; it does not supply independent manuscript attestation. Likewise, the original text printed at the back of the same volume is useful for internal comparison, but does not by itself establish which reading is authorial.

The final commentary sentence

Printed p.232 ends its final explanatory sentence with **فإذا ظهرت آثار الوجود بشرط** and then supplies an end formula. The acquired print image therefore confirms that the interruption is present in the modern printing itself. It is not merely an online extraction failure. The reason for the earlier loss or interruption remains unknown.

The edition leaves this sentence unfinished. It does not complete it from the independently arranged Qūnawī appendix, from doctrinal expectations, or from a conjectural paraphrase. The end formula is recorded without assigning its authorship conclusively to al-Mahāʾimī, an earlier copyist, or an editor.

The final lemma and its explanation also require separate treatment:

Location	Reading in the consulted printing	Treatment
Commentary p.230, beginning of Text Twenty-Two	توجب	Retained in the quoted commentary lemma
Appendix p.267, corresponding opening	يوجب	Retained in Arabic; the difficult opening construction is marked in English
Commentary p.232, quoted lemma	الظهور في الوجود	Rendered as manifestation "in existence"
Commentary p.232, ensuing explanation; appendix p.267	الظهور للوجود	Rendered as manifestation "belonging to existence"

The reading بموجب reported in later reception material is not silently substituted into either printed passage. These are internal or reception comparisons, not a completed manuscript apparatus.

Scan pagination and the two absent leaves

The PDF has 269 images. Its image numbering is not a constant offset from printed pagination. For the commentary, printed pp.11–112 correspond to zero-based Archive leaves 11–112. After printed p.112 the acquired scan proceeds directly to printed p.115. Printed pp.113–114 are absent from that scan, although both occur in the electronic transcription and remain available in this edition.

From printed p.115 onward, the zero-based Archive leaf is the printed number minus two. Thus commentary p.232 is PDF page 231, and appendix p.267 is PDF page 266. The page map records each source page explicitly, including the two absent images. Absence of an image is not reported as absence of the corresponding text.

Separating medieval text from modern editorial notes

Electronic page extraction had sometimes joined the continuation of a modern footnote to the next page's medieval running text. Inspection of the printed rule and page layout resolves several such cases. Examples include commentary pp.19, 211, 215, 224 and 226. Those note continuations are excluded from the authorial Arabic and are not translated as al-Mahā'imī's prose. Conversely, the last authorial line on p.210 had been lost from the extracted body; the scan restores it before the continuation on p.211.

These repairs affect attribution, not merely appearance. A useful edition must distinguish Qūnawī's lemma, al-Mahā'imī's explanation, an authority quoted by the commentator, and the modern editor's apparatus. English speaker labels and topical headings remain editorial aids. They are not additional words attributed to the medieval authors.

Selected translation and reading decisions

Location	Issue	Decision
Commentary p.11	Several grammatically difficult phrases also occur in the print	Preserve the source and mark the difficulty; do not classify every awkward reading as an OCR error

Location	Issue	Decision
Commentary p.12	العقل الملكي in the sequence of intellects	Render contextually as the dispositional intellect, with the technical interpretation documented
Commentary p.15	Active and passive forms of the unvowelled mūjid/mūjad	Distinguish the producer from what is produced, while recording the problematic printed variant
Commentary p.150	The commentator explicitly identifies المظهر as an active participle	Render “manifester,” rather than the different noun “locus of manifestation”
Commentary p.157	Direction of knowing through the Real; the force of اتحاد	Restore the direction of the Arabic construction and the explicit claim of union
Commentary p.172	Vessel and water analogy	Preserve which term the commentator identifies with each side of the analogy
Commentary pp.176–177	The new text begins on p.176; the lemma and commentary use a difficult contrast	Restore the printed boundary and retain the printed tension instead of silently harmonizing it
Commentary p.182	Digital فلك الروح against printed الملك الروح	Follow the inspected print, with the change recorded in the review file
Commentary p.210	Digital العلماء against printed العماء	Restore the printed word in the discussion of the cloud
Commentary p.221	Qur’ānic reference to the testing of those who strive and endure	Correct the English locator to 47:31 and document the source’s reference error
Commentary p.230	Digital تجابيها against printed تجليها	Follow the print
Commentary p.231	Words omitted at the start of the electronic page	Restore the printed continuation; do not silently emend the difficult repeated “existence” later on the page
Appendix p.236	Repeated في نفسه	Retain and mark the repetition
Appendix p.252	“The best of forgivers”	Correct the English Qur’ānic locator to 7:155; preserve the Arabic quotation
Appendix p.259	Uncertain place names in a reported visionary account	Transliterate and mark uncertainty, without supplying guessed locations

Location	Issue	Decision
Appendix p.263	Difficult phrase concerning composition	Mark the difficulty rather than make an unrecorded Arabic emendation

The detailed review files preserve the affected passages and reasons for changes. This table highlights consequential examples; it is not an exhaustive list of every correction.

The appended discourse in Qūnawī’s text

At appendix p.260 the modern editor explains that a following discourse was an appended text in the exemplar from which he copied. The current reader preserves its transmitted placement and records that fact. The layout of the 2008 appendix is not presented as a separately established authorial ordering. The modern editor’s note is summarized in the apparatus, rather than inserted into Qūnawī’s running prose.

The separate appendix’s final colophon is retained on p.267. It does not repair the incomplete final clause of al-Mahā’imī’s commentary on p.232.

Cross-references and further critical work

The concordance identifies shared Arabic wording between the original and commentary. Its current threshold is at least twelve consecutive normalized Arabic words. Diacritics and a small set of orthographic variations are normalized for matching; the displayed Arabic is not normalized by this procedure. Links are textual parallels, not claims that every word of one passage corresponds exactly to every word of the other.

No manuscript images have been collated for this release. Leiden Or.5675 and the Āshtiyānī edition remain independent comparison targets, with their acquisition status recorded in the source register. Until those witnesses are examined, the edition’s full text coverage should not be confused with a completed manuscript-critical establishment of the work.

Primary source access

- 2008 printed scan, Internet Archive
- Public electronic transcription of the same edition
- Page-by-page source map
- Review index
- Exact coverage ledger

Stage 13 continuation, 11 November 2026

The remaining commentary pages 41–60, 94–105 and 125–149 were reviewed against the supplied Arabic. Eighty-five English passage corrections repair omitted arguments, reversed implications, paragraph alignment and substantive metaphysical wording. The Arabic was preserved byte-for-byte at the passage level. Thirty editorial notes and three Text Twelve heading corrections accompany the review. Exact old and new English, reasons, page findings and unresolved readings are preserved in review-stage13/.

All 222 commentary pages have now undergone this review. This does not mean every defective clause is resolved: p.43 passage 1 retains an identified synopsis, and the new notes identify further clauses requiring image or independent-witness comparison. Seven positively documented Stage12 scan checks (pp.21,23,26,27,33,35,40) were omitted from the old aggregate; reconciliation raises the historical commentary scan count from 91 to 98, without claiming new image inspection.

The current source register, page-by-page review record, glossary, historical drafts and downloadable corpus accompany the reader at https://gnamma-research.github.io/booksite/texts/al-mahaimi/mashra-al-khusus/.